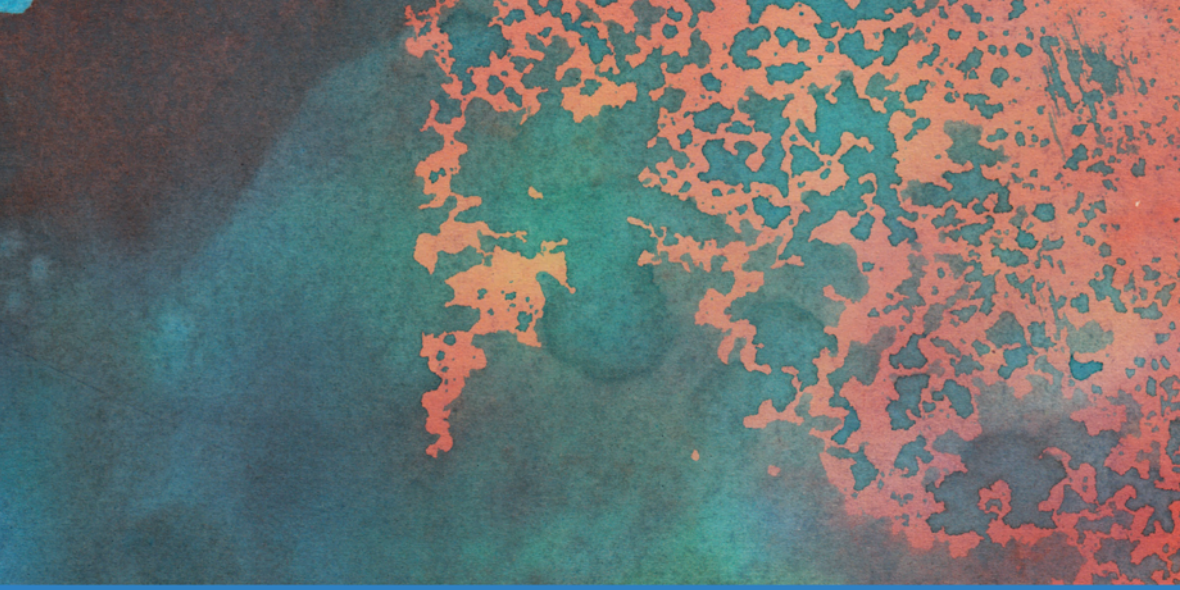
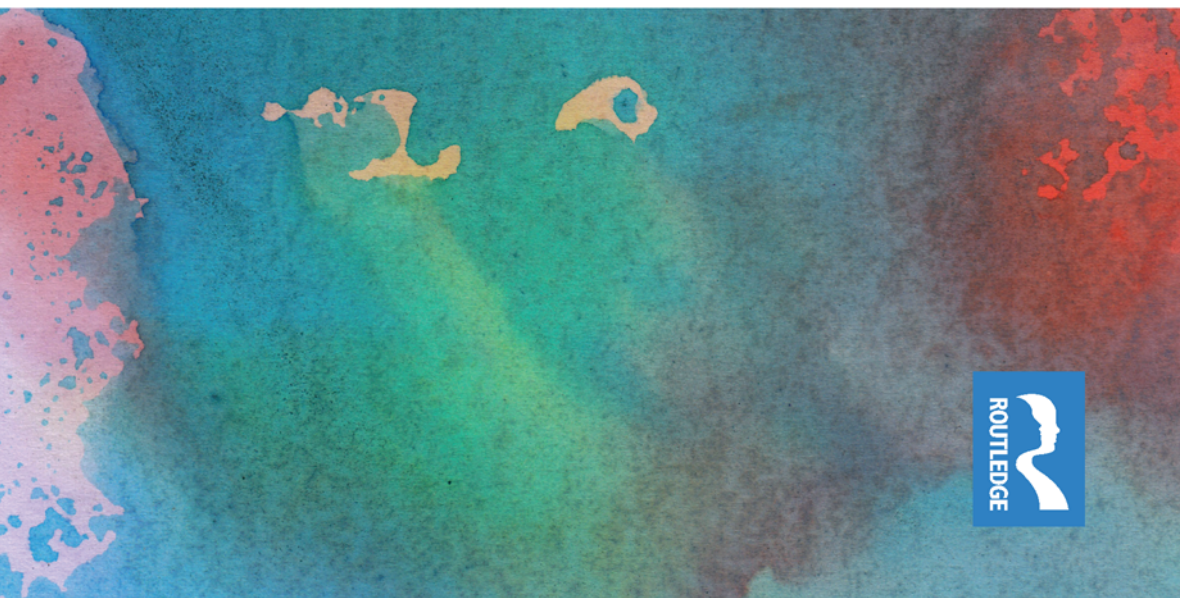


Routledge Studies in African Development

NATIONAL LIBERATION MOVEMENTS AS GOVERNMENT IN AFRICA

Edited by
Redie Bereketeab



National Liberation Movements as Government in Africa

Africa is well known for the production of national liberation movements (NLMs), stemming from a history of exploitation, colonisation and slavery. NLMs are generally characterised by a struggle carried out by or in the name of suppressed people for political, social, cultural, economic, territorial liberation and decolonisation. Dozens of NLMs have ascended to state power in Africa following a successful violent popular struggle either as an outright military victory or a negotiated settlement.

National Liberation Movements as Government in Africa analyses the performance of NLMs after they gain state power. The book tracks the initial promises and guiding principles of NLMs against their actual record in achieving socio-economic development goals such as peace, stability, state building and democratisation. The book explores the various different struggles for liberation, whether against European colonialism, white minority rule, neighbouring countries, or for internal reform or regime change. Bringing together case studies from Somalia, Somaliland, Uganda, Ethiopia, Eritrea, South Sudan, Namibia, Angola, Mozambique, South Africa, Zimbabwe, and Algeria, the book builds a comprehensive analysis of the challenges NLMs face when ascending to state power, and why so many ultimately end in failure.

This is an ideal resource for scholars, policy makers and students with an interest in African development, politics, and security studies.

Redie Bereketeab is Associate Professor of Sociology and Senior Researcher at The Nordic African Institute, Uppsala, Sweden.

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This collection provides a much needed conceptual and comparative analysis of African liberation movements whose struggles against oppression and questionable records as governments remain highly controversial. Wide-ranging and comprehensive, this volume constitutes a landmark in the study of contemporary African politics.

Roger Southall, *Emeritus Professor in Sociology, University of the Witwatersrand, South Africa*

This wide-ranging collection of case-studies takes our knowledge of national liberation movements in power in Africa to a new level and will be required reading for students of African politics.

Chris Saunders, *Emeritus Professor, University of Cape Town, South Africa*



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Edited by
Redie Bereketeab

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Part I

Conceptualisation and performance of liberation movements-cum-governments



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1 Introduction

Understanding national liberation movements

Redie Bereketeab

Introduction

Africa is well known for a phenomenon widely described as the national liberation movement (NLM). This prevalence of NLMs has to do with the continent's unfortunate history of domination, exploitation, colonisation and enslavement by Europeans, and in some cases also by Africans. Usually, NLMs have arisen in response to these misfortunes and many states in Africa achieved independence from colonial domination by waging bloody liberation wars. The characteristic of the NLM, as the name implies, is a struggle carried out by or in the name of oppressed people in quest of political, social, cultural, economic, territorial liberation and decolonisation from European as well as African powers. NLM also connotes fundamental sociopolitical transformation rather than neocolonial or external domination.

The objective of liberation movements could vary widely, ranging from outright political sovereignty to cultural and territorial autonomy within an existing African state. It could thus also aim at changing existing oppressive and exclusionary state structures and achieving equitable representation for pluralist identities. Such initiatives thus aim at systemic reform or regime change. Dozens of NLMs have achieved state power in Africa through violent popular struggles that have culminated in either outright military victory or negotiated settlements following military stalemates.

Many NLMs succeeded in achieving the right of self-determination leading to the formation of sovereign states, while others managed only to bring about political reform within existing state structures. Nevertheless, the record of successful liberation movements turned governments has been less than satisfactory. This is aptly noted by Roger Southall (2013: 1), who has remarked that

> looking back from the early 21st century, it is a widely held view that 'national liberation movements as governments' have proved to be a disappointment not only to their many sympathizers internationally but, above all, to the majority of people over whom they now rule.

Indeed, the impressive successes NLMs registered during the struggle have not been matched by equal success when they assumed government. The process of

post-liberation peace-building, state-building and nation-building as well as democratisation and socioeconomic reconstruction was beset by veritable challenges. It is of course worth noting here that a marked difference could be observed among the various NLMs with regard to these immediate and pressing tasks. Some may have been successful initially, only to succumb to challenges later. They also held on to power for differing lengths of time.

This chapter seeks to provide a succinct exposition of the origin and development of the concept of NLM. The next section grapples with the conceptual foundations of national liberation. This is followed by an exposition of the significance of the naming and designation of movements, for those that fall under the rubric of national liberation enjoy a positive reception, such as international support and legitimacy of their quest of sovereign statehood, while those denied this positive designation are also denied international support and legitimacy, a fate that either delays or completely obstructs their quest for independence. The final section reviews the themes and structure of the book.

Conceptualising national liberation

The general literature on national liberation distinguishes between two broad conceptual categories, namely political and armed liberation movements, the distinction referring to the means they use to achieve their goals. The former category relates to a political form of struggle, the latter to the use of violence to achieve the goal. Although Clausewitz (1997) described war as a political struggle waged by other means, the above distinction has significance. Furthermore, other less substantial distinctions can be made. If a movement is political, the likelihood is high that from the very outset a set of clear principles and programmes are put in place that define the political priority of the movement. In this form of struggle, there seems to be an inherent inevitability that random efforts by a handful of individuals will not yield the needed outcomes (cf., Suttner 2004: 6–7). There is a need for a gestation period pertaining to mobilisation, consciousness raising and organisation to achieve a clear definition of tactics, strategies and ideology in order to ensure participation by the whole or a majority of the population.

On the other hand, if armed struggle precedes political struggle, most probably a developed political programme will not be in place from the outset. This sequence gives priority to military tactics and strategies aimed at developing and expanding combat capability. The primary objective is focused on military operations against enemy forces, to the full or partial exclusion of vital sociopolitical objectives such as mobilising and organising civilians. Essentially, mass mobilisation is deferred. A negative consequence of the absence of an elaborate political programme from the outset is the lack of rules and principles regulating relations between various ethno-linguistic groups, which often leads to division and civil war in the movements even before sovereignty is obtained. This certainly impedes the liberation struggle, since cohesion among combatants as well as relations with the wider civil population depend on clarity of purpose,

programmes, rules and principles. Recruiting the general population into the movement is decisive for the outcome. In other words, a clearly formulated ideology of national liberation is necessary to the success of the NLM. The form of the struggle has profound implications for the character of the political liberation culture and, by extension, to the post-liberation transition, state-building and democratisation process.

Etymologically, it is possible to trace the concept of 'liberation war' as far back as the Napoleonic wars in early nineteenth-century Europe. At this time, the term was associated with the wars undertaken by European states against Napoleon's expansionism with the aim of liberating themselves from imperial domination (Schulze 1996). The concept of *national* liberation was not common at the time, since the notion of nation and nations as socio-political organisations was just emerging. For the first time, though, Austria and Spain adopted the concept of nation to mobilise their citizens against Napoleonic invasion. To give their campaigns a popular character and to ensure total mobilisation, resistance was glorified as being for the people and their fatherland. Nationalism and patriotism were carefully and skilfully aroused and ultimately became a formidable force, positively connoting liberation, national unity and development and driving struggles for those ends.

Since the French Revolution, the concept of nation has become increasingly conspicuous in the vocabulary of social science (Smith 1986: 134). This was an era when people were categorised, identified and included or excluded as nations. Once a people gained recognition as a nation, it became illegal to deny them their right to constitute a sovereign state. Sovereignty became the fulfilment of human destiny, as Hegel put it. Furthermore, it gradually became acceptable, and even garnered international sympathy, for a people recognised as a nation to engage in a national liberation struggle aimed at constituting a sovereign state. People denied that right led bitter struggles to achieve recognition of their nationhood and right to statehood.

Nevertheless, it was in the twentieth century, particularly in the aftermath of the Second World War, that the concept gained widespread usage. This is perhaps due to the new paradigm that became increasingly dominant after the First World War, which was particularly embodied in the Wilsonian doctrine of national self-determination. In 1918, US President Woodrow Wilson (Hutchinson and Smith 1994: 10) advocated that every people be allowed to exercise the right of self-determination that would lead to the emergence of a sovereign nation state. The Treaty of Versailles of 1919 introduced this principle into European politics (Schulze 1996: 277, 280).

The Wilsonian doctrine was a direct assault on entrenched colonial and imperial systems, which yoked heterogeneous ethnic groups into one entity under foreign colonial rule. Now, ethnicity and culture rather than territoriality assumed increased relevance as a benchmark of nationhood. The new doctrine advocated the creation of homogenous entities. It also encouraged in oppressed and colonised peoples an awareness of and desire for national sovereignty. This historic redefinition of the people or the nation, and the recognition of the

natural right of all people to be free, provided a legal instrument to colonised people all over the world. Also significant was the recognition afforded to achieve such freedom through *national liberation struggle*.

It is worth noting that the Wilsonian doctrine was only thought to be valid for European societies, and even within Europe, as Hobsbawm (1990: 32) has written, self-determination applied only to nations considered viable.

> Wilson believed he had discovered an ethical principle for democratic disposition of the European domains of the multi-national empires of Austria-Hungary, Ottoman Turkey, and Czarist Russia. Never imagining that such a principle could find application outside Europe, he was shocked at the parade of would-be nationalities he beckoned from obscurity by his words, many hitherto unbeknownst to him. In subsequent testimony to the Senate Committee on Foreign Relations, he confessed: 'When I gave utterance to those words [that all nations had a right to self-determination], I said them without the knowledge that nationalities existed, which are coming to us day after day.… You do not know and cannot appreciate the anxieties that I have experienced as a result of many millions of people having their hopes raised by what I have said'.
>
> (Young 1993: 19)

The blatant double standard in Wilsonian doctrine was a source of great suffering and anguish for many societies under imperial domination. It took several years before the principle of self-determination as a universal legal and political instrument became generally applicable, and it was only in the late 1950s and early 1960s that Africa began to benefit from the principle of a people's right to self-determination as enshrined in various UN conventions. Gaining self-determination took many struggles and the lives of thousands. The emergence of a pan-African organisation, the Organisation of African Unity (OAU), in 1964 further consolidated the principle.

The fascist government of Salazar in Portugal, supported by the US, UK, and France, refused to accept liberation. Consequently, Angola, Mozambique and Guinea-Bissau were compelled to wage bloody wars against the last Western imperial power (Schmidt 2013: 79–101). In addition, there were those who, because they were not defined as a people, were denied that right. These people included the Eritreans, West Saharans, and South Sudanese (Young 1982). OAU and UN conventions, while recognising the rights of people subjected to European domination, shied away from recognising the right to self-determination of people under African domination. The people of Western Sahara are still victims of this double standard. The politico-legal circumstances of the OAU's establishment conferred undue influence upon some member states so that they held a kind of veto power over the body's becoming involved in defining and resolving national struggles within the continent. Thus, Ethiopia forestalled OAU discussion of the Eritrean question by defining it as a domestic affair, a definition the continental organisation accepted. Morocco also resisted OAU's involvement in the case of

the ex-Spanish colony of Western Sahara. Revolts in Katanga, Biafra, and South Sudan were dubbed secessionist, a description that itself carries negative connotations (cf. Bereketeab 2015). The selective implementation of the right of self-determination thus became a source of both theoretical and empirical controversy.

Petrified by the implications of the separation of Eritrea for the proclaimed sanctity of African colonial borders, OAU member states not only ignored the calls for help of the Eritrean people, but also engaged in a campaign to vilify the liberation struggle (Davidson 1980; Greenfield 1980; Habte Selassie 1989; Markakis 1981). For the OAU, the right to self-determination concerned peoples and nations subjected to white domination. To prevent claims by ethnic or identity groups incorporated within emerging postcolonial states in Africa, the OAU declared the inherited colonial borders sacrosanct (Lemay-Hebert 2009; Makinda 1982; Ndulo 2010; Spears 2004; Temin 2010). This sacrosanctity thus delegitimised many quests for self-determination, since they were perceived as undermining African unity, and not as national liberation movements. One exception was the OAU'S recognition of the right to self-determination of the Saharawi people of Western Sahara under Moroccan domination, although Western powers blocked the materialisation of this self-determination (Iratni 2015). Nevertheless, once the notion of nation that originated in the West gradually assumed universality, the principle of national liberation became a potent political instrument in the service of colonised and marginalised peoples in their quest for liberty.

Names matter

The present section discusses the various names given to different liberation movements and their effect on those movements and seeks to explain the motives and aims of the actor(s) giving those names. The advantage of the designation NLM is its positive connotations leading to automatic political, legal and moral legitimacy and acknowledgement and the increased likelihood of material, political and diplomatic support. NLMs also gain entitlement to membership of regional and international organisations and even benefit from international accords and conventions. Generally, the concept NLM encompasses a variety of organisations of different political and ideological stripe (Suttner 2004). It has also proved to be a very contentious concept within academia, international relations and politics. As is well known, certain movements are designated NLMs by some but not by all. These others may refer to such movements as secessionist, insurgent or guerrilla movements. Still other struggles are framed as civil war. Yet other movements maybe designated as terrorist, as the ANC was by the US Congress, a designation that was not abandoned even when the ANC came to power. All this labelling takes place irrespective of the views and understandings of the subjects themselves: victims are often denied the agency of defining and labelling themselves. Most importantly, why are there all these different names? Is it simple chance or taste or semantics that lead to this diversity? Or are there political and ideological reasons for the

names, with legal consequences? Moreover, why should we be concerned about names and designations? We should because the ambiguity of naming translated into political practice is of great consequence.

There is indeed an intrinsic link between the names given to conflicts or movements and the prospect and means of finding solutions to them. From a normative perspective, the first step in analysing and tackling problematic social phenomena and social action entails social categorisation. The next step may involve value judgement and evaluation. Depending on this judgement, measures may be taken towards resolution or non-resolution. If the value judgement is positive, the measures to find solutions will be positive. Contrariwise, if the value judgement is negative, the measures will either be negative or entirely lacking. In other words, naming and designation can be an act of social legitimation or delegitimation. This, in turn, brings binding entitlements or their absence. Hence, naming and designation are a key concern, and that is why bitter struggles take place between contending forces over them. The concern with names is no less important today, when the world is faced with serious problems of radicalism, extremism and fundamentalism.

Let us now examine the names and designations commonly used in analysing liberation movements. To begin with, Clapham (1998: 1) describes 'guerrilla' as the name given to armed movements that by originating in the countryside and attacking across state frontiers, seek to contest the power of the state, and frequently establish their own rule in territories over which the state has lost control. On the other hand, 'insurgency' is used to describe movements that may not strictly qualify as guerrilla, and lack the ideological and romantic associations that the term 'guerrilla' evokes. Clapham's definition of guerrilla seems to derive from the struggle modality adopted by a specific movement. The generic connotation and differentiation associated with guerrilla movements is their mobility, reflected in their small units and their hit-and-run tactics. Quite often, however, a rural or urban movement may begin as guerrilla and underground but slowly adopt conventional types of warfare (Suttner 2004: 6). Here a slight difference can be observed in the definition of insurgency, however. Campagnon (1998: 74) writes that 'while "guerrilla" designates simply a mode of conducting warfare … "insurgency" refers to a movement launched to overthrow a government or at least to challenge the action of the state'. Thus, the stress is placed on the movement's relationship to the state.

However, this distinction between guerrillas and insurgents seems to focus on the tactics of warfare and the aim of the movement. Guerrilla is simply defined based on tactics, the common characteristic being the hide and ambush mode. The conventional understanding of guerrilla warfare is that a cluster of small, mobile, and malleable groups adopt hit-and-run tactics against a larger army versed in large-scale conventional warfare (Britannica Online Encyclopedia). By contrast, insurgency as defined by Campagnon refers to the goals of the movement – the overthrow of a government. If the aim is merely such overthrow without the movement declaring its social, economic, cultural and political objectives, especially those that will bring self-evident benefit to the

population, the movement will fail to elicit international support and sympathy. Inherent in the definition of insurgency is the notion that the conflict is between groups within the same nation. What pitches them against one another is the desire to appropriate the state. Thus, insurgency is intimately associated with civil war. The normatively sanctioned solution to civil war is peaceful negotiations and compromise within the state's territory, and, where those fail, crushing the insurgents. Civil war is widely and negatively perceived as state-breaking (Ayoob 1996; Nair 1977) rather than as the constructive achievement of people's rights through reform or regime change, a notion discussed elsewhere in this volume. The general perception of liberation struggle is thus depicted as follows:

> Those for whom 'liberation war' extended only to the struggle against white rule could not accord the same status to insurgencies directed against indigenous African regimes, these were instead to be condemned as a threat to the project of African nationalism, and could often plausibly be regarded as exemplifying the evils of 'tribalism' and 'balkanisation', and of 'neo-colonial' interference in the domestic affairs of the continent.
>
> (Clapham 1998: 18)

The problem with such narrow definitions is that they separate movements from their social, cultural and ideological contexts and aims. Instead of reflecting the socioeconomic and politico-cultural objectives and aspirations of the subjects themselves, these definitions often tell us more about the disposition of the definer. By defining a conflict as guerrilla or an insurgency aimed at destabilising an established state, legitimacy is conferred on the claims of the targeted state. This may play into the hands of oppressive states and hamper the achievement of just and permanent solutions. State-centred perceptions and definitions give primacy to the rights of a state to territorial integrity, rather than to the rights of oppressed peoples. This demonstrates the tension between state-centred rights and people-centred rights. The biases of scholarship and definitional meaning, coupled with biases in international relations driven by the politics of geostrategic interests, can have far-reaching, detrimental political and developmental consequences for liberation movements. In short, definitions and naming are more than innocent acts – they reflect embedded ideological and political interests.

Whereas some describe NLMs as irresponsible, disgruntled and pathological, others adopt definitions that capture their popular nature and content as well as their people-oriented aims and their aspirations to ensure national identity and sovereignty. Mona Younis (cited in Suttner 2004: 4) defines NLMs as:

> social movements in amplified form: the disaffected: (those compelled to act) are virtually entire 'nations,' using not merely extra-institutional means but anti-institutional action for a political objective that is nothing short of the elimination of the existing state. The convergence of multiple

> movements of workers, peasants, women, students, professionals, and others produce this collective action on a grand scale. The clarity of the collective grievance renders the convergence of disparate class forces possible, generally over several generations: freedom from domination by a population that sets itself apart on the basis of national identification. Conquest in the name of one nation stimulates an unprecedented convergence of classes within the other.

In short, the main consequences of naming and definition can be summarised thus:

(1) These are conceptual and theoretical tools. In the tradition of Max Weber, it could be said that in a descriptive sense, they facilitate understanding, *verstehen* and interpretation. Nevertheless, names and definitions transcend the descriptive when they subserve a practical political purpose.

(2) They contain normative values that constrain or enable solutions. If a movement is defined as a people's movement, NLM, or as just, etc., it has the potential to achieve legal and international support. This may lead to pressure being exerted on the parties by the international community to find a just and democratic solution to the conflict (e.g. ANC and SWAPO). On the other hand, where a movement is defined as separatist, narrow, chauvinist, terrorist, or as destabilising an established member of the international state system, its chances of international and legal support are negligible (e.g. Eritrean National Liberation Movement, South Sudan (the first civil war), Biafra).

(3) As such, names and definitions imply legal and moral principles by which movements are evaluated internationally in terms of offering or withholding support and sympathy, because they are considered moral and legal or alternatively illegal and immoral.

Finally, a crucial ethical question is who has the right to define and name a NLM. Is it the people who pay with their lives because they believe in what they are doing? Or is it disengaged foreign scholars, equipped with the 'objectivity' derived from their preconceived conceptual and theoretical instruments and questioning the authenticity of the 'subjective' views of the indigenous population? Or is it scholars with affiliations and romantic commitments to certain values and paradigms. Affording due legitimacy to 'subjective' perceptions would be of great ontological and epistemological significance, and would represent a paradigmatic shift in understanding national liberation struggles and in fashioning international responses to them. Bestowing unfettered legitimacy on the subjective conversely may erode territorial integrity and nation-building, leading to perennial conflicts and divisions.

Different response to NLMs may have a great impact on the conduct of the struggle and may determine the movement's post-liberation behaviour and practice. Political culture is the cumulative outcome of lived and perceived experience. Post-liberation leaders are the product of the political culture of the liberation struggle, which may make transition very challenging. Recognition of the NLM during the liberation struggle may contribute to the form and content of the resolution of that conflict. NLMs that enjoyed international recognition

and support were able to reach settlements through negotiation and compromise and this in turn may to a degree have influenced their behaviour and performance after independence. Those struggles settled through outright military victory, following protracted wars, on the other hand, brought bitter memories and disdain for the international system that the combatants felt had betrayed them. Such movements are less inclined to listen to the international system, often to the detriment of post-liberation transformation.

Themes and structure of the book

The central theme of this book is the performance of successful liberation movements once they have achieved state power. It assesses this by examining the record on socioeconomic development; governance; peace, security and stability; human rights; nation- and state-building; honouring promises and meeting citizen expectations; tackling national questions, etc. The book comprises five sub-themes: (1) general conceptualisation and performance of NLMs turned governments; (2) liberation struggles from European colonialism; (3) liberation struggles from white minority rule; (4) liberation struggles from neighbouring countries; and (5) liberation struggles for reform (regime change). The last case is distinguishable in not seeking the creation of a separate state.

These categories of NLM converge in many aspects while simultaneously diverging in others. The NLMs considered converge in being driven by common noble ideals of 'people's war' founded on the liberation movements' claimed or actual politicisation of the masses, peasants, workers, women, youth and professionals, its promotion of revolutionary hopes, and the regular conflation of the struggle against white supremacy and colonialism with a struggle for socialism (Southall 2013: 10). People's war as an emancipatory social project implied overthrowing foreign domination. This was the first step in the emancipatory project, with the second being the building of developed, equitable, peaceful, democratic, participatory and representative nation states. It was these noble ideals that attracted the masses to the ranks of the NLMs. The widespread failure of the transition from the first to the second stage has, however, engendered crisis, disappointment and loss of legitimacy, and can be seen as a failure of political leadership. This crisis of performance during the second stage of the national liberation struggle is the common hallmark of the cases included in this anthology. As an ideal at least, the NLM embodies dreams, aspirations and ambitions of emancipation, development, equity, peace and stability. In its failure to discharge the tasks of the second stage, the NLM has come to embody disappointment, despair, hopelessness and betrayal.

In terms of divergence, the NLM examples studied here demonstrate distinct variability. One variation relates to whether the NLM sought to free the people from European colonial rule or from rule by white settlers. Yet another category arose in the context of European colonialism, but instead of achieving decolonisation it experienced annexation by neighbouring counties. The variability is also evident in the manner and timing of independence from foreign

domination. We see variation in the way in which Anglophone, Francophone, and Lusophone colonies won their independence. Decolonisation of Anglophone colonies was more or less peaceful, and likewise for the Francophone colonies, with some notable exceptions. By contrast, the liberation of Lusophone colonies and the freedom struggle in settler minority states involved bitter and protracted conflict.

Those who gained their independence through decolonisation could be said to have experienced a relatively smooth transition, but those compelled to engage in protracted armed struggle, such as the Portuguese colonies seeking to throw off the yoke of the fascist Salazar, backed by the US, UK, and France, faced more complicated challenges. Those NLMs whose country was annexed by a neighbour had to wage multidimensional struggles – armed, political, legal and moral. The three cases involving annexation (Eritrea, Namibia and Western Sahara) also demonstrated variability. Eritrea was completely denied recognition by the OAU, UN and Western powers, and was forced to wage a bitter 30-year war. Namibia received broad support and recognition, while support for the Western Sahara remained divided, with decisive voices (US, UK, and France) being raised against it. This divergent experience testifies to the inadequacy of and contradictions within the theoretical, legal and political instruments of decolonisation and self-determination. Perhaps this variability also explains the differing degrees of success and failure following the ascendancy to state power.

This book consists of five thematically delineated parts and 16 chapters. These are succinctly described below.

The present chapter has sought to provide a conceptual exposition of the origins and development of the NLM concept of national liberation movement. It has situated the analysis around the notion of liberation and discusses the significance of names.

Chapter 2 explores the cases of several African states, including the self-proclaimed state of Somaliland, but also Angola, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Namibia, Rwanda, Somalia and South Africa and South Sudan, Uganda and Zimbabwe. It argues that (a) there are varieties of liberation movement experiencing different degrees of success and failure during and after the liberation struggle; (b) pre-liberation institutional strength or weakness, capacity to manage transition and structural transformation and ability to mobilise pre-liberation social support base are key considerations; and (c) liberation movement governments are pragmatic and rarely adhere to the ethos and ideologies that galvanised the national liberation struggle.

Chapter 3 argues that seizing political power has been the goal of all liberation movements, and that this in practice means seizing state power, even if the state in question is of colonial origin. In the struggle for state power, liberation movements invoke universal values such as freedom, equality, justice and democracy in order to gain legitimacy and popular support and foster the hope of a better future once they are victorious. When that moment arrives, however, liberation movements tend to cling to power and invoke new values to retain legitimacy, values that often contradict those invoked during the struggle.

Chapter 4 analyses the role and performance of the MPLA government in Angola. Angola was plunged into bloody civil war between the MPLA and UNITA immediately after the Portuguese withdrew, a war that ended only with the death of UNITA's leader. MPLA's record as a ruling party and government is, however, less than satisfactory, in that it has failed to establish a genuinely democratic state. This chapter analyses the challenges of the transition from liberation movement to civic government and to democratic state-building in Angola.

Chapter 5 examines the arduous liberation struggle in Mozambique led by Frelimo. It argues that the art of government has proven to be much more complex than the guerrilla tactics adopted during the liberation struggle. Frelimo had to transform itself from fighting the establishment to being the establishment, including creating and maintaining political order. Frelimo has run a constitutional one-party state and banned the formation of political parties. Marxism-Leninism was seen as the appropriate paradigm for key decisions. Frelimo has also sought to protect, for example, the sacrosanct principle of national unity, which it has defended tooth and nail, not least because it has legitimised the party's power.

Chapter 6 examines the performance of the PAIGC (*Partido Africano para a Independência de Guiné-Bissau e Cabo Verde*) after achieving power. The challenges it has faced in the profound transformation from the 'politics of liberation' to civil governance are discussed. After 42 years of independence, where does Guinea-Bissau stand in terms of governance, state-building, and democracy? How did the agenda of 'revolutionary' nationalism affect the politics of the postcolonial governments?

Chapter 7 seeks to retrace the evolution of the political system put in place in postcolonial Algeria and assess whether it has fulfilled the social contract between rulers and governed, a contract based on trading democracy, individual liberties and a multiparty system in favour of an authoritarian system in which 'socialist democracy' and the 'power of the masses' have dominated political discourse.

Chapter 8 explores the continuity in economic policy since the early 1990s when the ANC came to power in South Africa. It reviews the main deals made by ANC leaders in the first decade of liberation. It also considers the ANC's tendency to resort to older lines of argument, especially classical anti-imperialism in the context of an alliance with the BRICS countries. Whether this neoliberal nationalism can endure or will be challenged from the left will depend on the ability of South Africans to deconstruct the ANC's policy of talking left, walking right.

Chapter 9 argues that ZANU-PF under President Mugabe (Zimbabwe) has failed to deliver on its promises of democracy, good governance, human security, social peace, human rights, human development, social cohesion and social justice. It further argues that to measure the performance of a former liberation movement after achieving power, one must clearly understand the knotty national question that cried out for resolution. The chapter also roots the failure

in a theoretical understanding of the conception, constitution, and configuration of the 'political' (foundational normative principles) and concomitant political practice. The chapter analyses what went wrong and why the ZANU-PF government ended up violent, authoritarian and intolerant, and manifested oligarchic and personality cult tendencies.

Chapter 10 examines the trajectory of SWAPO (Namibia), a former liberation movement that has been the government since independence, thereby exploring the 'limits to liberation' in the political sphere. The party, after more than 20 years of postcolonial government is still largely dominated by the first generation of the liberation struggle's leadership. This has provided for continuity and stability in the institutionalisation of the new state, and allowed for the relatively smooth establishment of a new order. At the same time, it has promoted complacency in combination with a strongly guarded exclusivity, which has in turn encouraged poor political and service delivery.

Chapter 11 seeks to analyse the troubled transition from national liberation movement to civic government in Eritrea. To this end, internal, regional and international factors are interrogated and the challenges of transition in Eritrea are framed within the interplay of the three levels. It concludes that Eritrea's multiple post-liberation challenges can be explained in terms of a liberation political culture that has led to rigid governance structures and intolerant politics, a hostile regional situation and a non-accommodating international environment.

Chapter 12 delves into the proliferation of rebellions in South Sudan. It discusses the origin of autocracy in the former Sudan and its link to rebellions. Also examined is the manipulation of ethnic and religious identity to win or retain power and in the context of armed confrontations. This chapter argues that a major cause of the rebellions is the autocratic way the leaders govern their people, which generates dissent and violent conflict. It concludes that ethnic factionalism has long been exploited by elites to achieve narrow power interests.

Chapter 13 analyses the two liberation movements in Uganda, the National Resistance Movement (NRM) and National Resistance Army (NRA). In its formative stages, NRM/NRA developed the Ten Point political programme as a blueprint for building a new Uganda. The Ten Point programme listed the historical problems that Museveni and his team believed were the main causes of Uganda's ills from the colonial era until the 1980s. Upon their capturing power, a new constitution was promulgated and space was opened up for multiparty politics. Yet since then that constitution has been amended to remove presidential term limits and laws have been enacted that curtail individual rights and freedoms and make it impossible to hold free and fair elections. The rhetoric of the liberation movement has veered completely off course.

Chapter 14 seeks to evaluate the accomplishments and failures of the EPRDF in terms of the major promises it made upon coming to power in Ethiopia. Specifically, it examines the performance of EPRDF in terms of delivering on its promise of transforming the socio-economic and political landscape by dealing with the root causes of poverty, lack of rights, and inequality.

Chapter 15 examines the process in Somaliland that contributed to the consolidation of a democratic de facto state through a combination of locally legitimate meetings and conferences and sometimes enlightened leadership. Essentially, that means looking in detail at the events between 1981, when the SNM was formed in London, and 1993, when the military administration passed the mantle to a civilian government on schedule. The chapter discusses the hybrid governance system and state-building initiatives Somaliland has pursued to generate relative peace, stability and democracy.

Chapter 16, based on extensive interviews and sources never used before, offers a comprehensive reappraisal of the formation, fall and failure of the armed opposition movements in Somalia. This chapter challenges the assumptions that (1) the presence of armed groups pushed Somalia into civil war, and (2) that the war was triggered only by men at arms, and argues that, aside from its rivalries and institutional flaws, the Siad Barre regime set the stage for the conditions that led to the fall of these movements.

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2 Varieties of African liberation movement governments

M.A. Mohamed Salih

Introduction

This chapter responds to the general question of why successful liberation movements often perform abysmally during post-liberation reconstruction. This question has at least two implications for the emergence of liberation movement governments: first, it assigns liberation-specific meaning that does not connote the liberal notion of democracy. Second, post-liberation movement governments are unique types of governments because of their ascendency to power through armed struggle. Therefore, such governments defy conventional notions of transfer of power through party politics and elections or peaceful popular agitation for political change.

The chapter explores 13 African states, including the self-proclaimed state of Somaliland, as well as Angola, Eritrea, Ethiopia, Mozambique, Namibia, Rwanda, Somalia and South Africa and South Sudan, Uganda and Zimbabwe. I argue that: (a) there are varieties of liberation movement with various degrees of success and failure during and after the liberation struggle; (b) pre-liberation institutional strength or weakness, capacity to manage transition and structural transformation and ability to mobilise pre-liberation social base of support are crucial; and (c) liberation movement governments are pragmatic and rarely adhere to the ethos and ideologies that galvanised the national liberation struggle.

The next section of this chapter deals with what is meant by varieties of liberation movement and seeks to conceptualise post-independence liberation movements that have been able to form so-called 'movement governments'. Section three elucidates the liberation movements and their successes during the liberation struggle. Section four explores the liberation movement governments' successes or failures in creating democratic regimes and their commonalities and differences. Section five offers an analysis of relative success and failure in response to economic growth and human security. It is followed by a conclusion.

Varieties of liberation movement

This section attempts to show that there are different types of liberation movement that produce different types of regime in the post-national liberation era

(as explained in the section on regime types) (Gordon 1998; Mohamed Salih 2007; Oloka-Onyango 2004; Ottaway 1999). For example, at a crude level of generalisation, the current governments of Eritrea, Ethiopia, Somalia, South Sudan and the self-proclaimed Republic of Somaliland qualify as movement governments. However, it is important to recognise that the objectives and inspiration for waging the liberation struggle are different, so that struggles can be classified into different types. These are, first, liberation movements that waged their struggle against what is perceived as a form of 'internal colonialism', where the majority is ruled by an authoritarian regime dominated by a hegemonic ethnic, religious or regional elite. Eritrea and South Sudan fall within this description. The Eritrean liberation narrative is framed within the struggle against 'Amhara chauvinism', which had rousing appeal for the masses such as in the Eritrean armed struggle against Emperor Haile Selassie commenced by the Eritrean Liberation Front (ELF) in 1960 and from 1970 until Eritrea's independence in 1993 against the Marxist military regime of Mengisto Haile Mariam, which was championed by the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF). President Isaias Afworki has lead the EPLF and its political wing, the People's Front for Democracy and Justice (PFDJ), since their establishment (Nyaba 1997).

Similarly, the South Sudanese struggle against the political establishment in northern and central Sudan began in 1955, a year before Sudan gained independence. The Addis Ababa Agreement (1972), which accorded South Sudan autonomy within a united Sudan, collapsed in 1983 (Alier 1999; Malwal 1981) when the Sudan People's Liberation Movement/Army (SPLM/A) resumed the liberation struggle under its charismatic leader, the late John Garang (Khalid 1987). This long and daunting struggle culminated in the signing of the Comprehensive Peace Agreement (2005), which paved the way for South Sudan's independence in 2011.

The SPLA/SPLM is a unique movement in that it aspired to liberate both oppressor and oppressed under the banner of a 'New Sudan' before fully creating a sense of South Sudanese nationalism to counteract northern Sudan's hegemony. Unfortunately, the movement was marred by internal division and factionalism and split during 1997 (Nyaba 1997). It was further divided on the eve of independence in 2011. The centralised, undemocratic nature of the movement has given rise to ethno-nationalist movements within South Sudan, with ethnic hostilities and renegade armed groups challenging the government well into independence.

Second, liberation struggles against authoritarian regimes, such as that waged by Ethiopian ethno-nationalist movements, produced a liberation movement government different in structure, ideology and national orientation than the SPLA/SPLM. The Ethiopia People's Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF), the current governing coalition, is certainly unique among liberation movements (Mohamed Salih 2001). I do not wish to rehash the history of the Ethiopian liberation struggle against the imperial and Derg regimes. Suffice it to mention that the struggle against the Derg was waged by ethnic-based

movements such as the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF), Eritrean Liberation Front (ELF), Oromo People's Democratic Organisation (OPDO), Oromo Liberation Front (OLF), Afar Liberation and Western Somalia Liberation Front (WSLF), among others. EPRDF emerged from these movements and other movements (SEPDM – Southern Ethiopian Peoples' Democratic, ANDM – Amhara Nation Democratic Movement and OPDO – Oromo Peoples' Democratic Organisation) with the main objective of creating a broad coalition capable of providing a stable government (Bereketeab 2007, 2009; Berhe 2008; Young 1997). It should therefore come as no surprise that EPRDF responded to the ethnic composition of the liberation movements by crafting a federal political system that has empowered rather than suppressed ethnicity. Ethnic federalism, whether we hate it or like it, has provided a unique system of government in the African context and used ethnicity as an instrument for conflict management and containment of the downside of ethnic cleavages.

Third, there are the various clan-based Somali liberation fronts and movements that fought against and ultimately defeated the authoritarian regime of Siad Barre (1969–91). Among the most important of these movements were the Somali National Movement (SNM), Somali Salvation Democratic Front (SSDF), United Somali Congress (USC) and Somali Democratic Movement (SDM) (Bryden 2004; Renders 2012). I refer to these Somali movements and fronts, with the exception of the SNM, as anarchic movements (Laitin and Samatar 1987; Markakis 1990). Although these movements are clan-based, in reality they are not clan-inspired or clan-dominated. Generally, they were founded on a poorly articulated sense of nationalism that was intended to serve the interests of their leaders and the political elite within their orbit. Once control of the state and its resources came within reach, the unity which underpinned their struggle died away and the movements proved unruly and incapable of putting aside their differences in the interests of the cherished goal of state-building and national development (Renders 2012). Instead, most of the movements that were able to rule as single movements or in coalition with others presided over a collapsed state, which they failed to reconstruct. The current transitional government in Somalia is a construction of the international community and fortunately most Somalis have long parted company with the liberation movements that originated during Siad Barre's regime.

Fourth, I make a distinction between anarchical Somali liberation movements and the Somali National Movement (SNM), which operates in the former British Somaliland, currently the self-proclaimed Republic of Somaliland. SNM's liberation struggle could be described as a double liberation struggle, initially waged as an armed struggle against the Barre regime but now pursued as a peaceful struggle to regain sovereignty in the aftermath of what it believes to be the failure of the Somali unitary state.

In Southern Africa, Angola gained independence from Portugal in 1975 after a liberation struggle waged by the Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola (MPLA), the National Union for the Total Independence of Angola

(UNITA) and the National Front for the Liberation of Angola (FNLA). The MPLA military and socialist regime has ruled Angola uninterruptedly under the leadership of Jose Eduardo dos Santos for almost 40 years. Likewise, Zimbabwe's African National Union-Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF) has ruled Zimbabwe under the leadership of Robert Mugabe since achieving independence from British rule (actually a white-settler secessionist government) in 1980. Despite their return to multiparty democracy in 1992 and 1996 respectively, the governments of Angola and Zimbabwe have since presided over restricted democracies that can be described as severely deficient (Chikhwa 2004; Darnolf and Laakso 2003; Douthall and Melber 2006; Sithole 1997).

Founded in 1962, the Front for the Liberation of Mozambique (Frelimo) led by the late Samora Machel, was united in 1964 with two other liberation fronts and waged a struggle against Portuguese rule until Mozambique gained its independence in 1975. Frelimo soon established Mozambique as a one-party Marxist state – an act that drove the Mozambique National Resistance (Renamo) to cooperate with the South African government in a campaign of destabilisation. Mozambique returned to peace only after Frelimo and Renamo signed the Rome Accord of 1992, which put an end to the civil war and 17 years of single-party rule and heralded the country's return to multiparty democracy. There have been three democratic elections since the initial democratic elections of 1994 (Manning 1998; Newit 1996; Nuvunga 2014; Nuvunga and Mohamed Salih 2011; Obede 2003).

Namibia is currently ruled by the South West African People's Organisation (SWAPO). This evolved in 1960 out of the Ovamboland People's Organisation (OPO), founded in 1957. SWAPO's military wing led the liberation struggle that saw Namibia through to independence in 1990. Multiparty democracy was then established, with SWAPO under the leadership of Sam Nujoma as the dominant party (Bauer 1999, 2001). After long and, at times, acrimonious political debates about whether Sam Nujoma should be allowed to defy the constitution and seek a third term as president, there have been two democratic successions (in 2004 and 2009) (Doorenspleet and Nijzing 2004; Melber 2007).

On gaining independence Angola, Mozambique, Namibia and Zimbabwe inherited multiparty democracies with 'democratic' legislatures or constituent assemblies and interim 'democratic' constitutions. However, some of the decolonisation movements, parties and leaders have continued to govern their countries for decades: Dos Santos (MPLA), Afwerki (Eritrea, EPLF/PFDJ) and Mugabe (Zimbabwe, ZANU-PF). Currently, Mozambique, Angola, South Africa and Namibia are still governed by political parties that fought against colonial rule or apartheid oppression (in the case of South Africa) and in some cases they experienced civil war after independence. All adopted various forms of multiparty democracy at different stages in their political development, but some of these liberation movements have better democratic credentials than others.

Success or failure during the liberation struggle

In this section, I attempt to engage with the assumption that there are varieties of liberation movement with different degrees of success or failure during the liberation struggle and that these achievements and setbacks have had considerable influence on their success or otherwise in creating a post-liberation environment conducive to political and economic development in the post-liberation era.

In assessing their success or failure during the liberation struggle, I use four indicators. First there is the ability to create a broad-based national coalition and a workable national programme for post-liberation development. Here, I refer to two types of coalition. One cements support from the peasantry or pastoralists, who comprise the majority of the population, and their leaders, thereby leveraging secularism over ethnic, clan or religious divisions. The other is based on a cross-section of modern elite coalitions (military, business, technocrats, intelligentsia/educated elite) and has the ability to organise and support national and global networks. The assumption here is that such liberation movements have already begun to think strategically about governing and governance in the post-liberation era.

Second, there is the capacity for service/development delivery in liberated areas. Obviously, the liberation movements' first experience of governing a population under their control occurred during the liberation struggle. Some liberation movements were able to control large territories and millions of people. In a sense, movements such as the EPLF, TPLF and SNM offered themselves as an alternative government in the liberated area and controlled the local government administration, personnel and resources. The assumption here is that the learning and skills gained during the liberation struggle represent valuable leadership experience for the movement.

Third is ability to organise self-governing civilian administration and grassroots organisations in a process leading to the creation of political and economic spaces for citizen participation. Experience has shown that liberation movements that create spaces for citizen participation during the liberation struggle are better equipped to manage the transition from liberation to government. Moreover, there is socialisation in creating a proactive citizenship in service delivery and local development.

Fourth is civil-military autonomy as opposed to military administration of civilian affairs. All the previous factors mentioned above are contingent on whether the movement has been capable of laying the ground for civil rule. It has been noted that militaristic post-liberation movements often have their roots in the armed-struggle experience. The extent to which democratic institutions are developed and democratic values are socially and culturally embedded largely depends on whether the system of rule established in the liberated areas was intended or designed to deliver simultaneously both on the war and political fronts.

All liberation movements have some commonalities and differences in respect to their ability to create a broad-based national coalition and a workable

national programme for post-liberation development. The objectives of the struggle included alternative governments, at a minimum national or democratic governments aiming for self-determination, limited autonomy or self-rule. All in one way or another neutralised their political opponents, sometimes in fierce and bloody confrontations. Some liberation movements have moderated their initial objectives or espoused completely different objectives. For example TPLF retreated from the notion of Greater Tigray and Marxism-Leninism, while the SPLA/SPLM shifted from the New Sudan ideology aimed at liberating the whole of Sudan to independence from Sudan and self-rule for the south.

During their liberation struggles, the EPLF, TPLF and SNM were successful in creating popular and elite coalitions, both nationally and among the diaspora. SNM intellectuals appear to have opened several avenues for critical engagement with the movement, perhaps due to its reconciliatory and accommodating nature. Civil wars followed the independence of Angola, Mozambique and Zimbabwe. In the case of the first two states, they were ended through negotiated settlements, while ZANU-PF set about neutralising the opposition.

Among liberation movements, there are significant capacity differences and varying degrees of success or failure in the delivery of services and development programmes. TPLF and EPLF can be seen as the most successful in this regard, not only through the Relief Society of Tigray (REST) and the Eritrean Relief Agency (ERA), but also in developing capacities that have proven effective in the post-liberation period. The SPLA/SPLM has been less effective in both respects and the South Sudan Relief Association (SSRA) has depended on foreign NGOs for most of its operations and has proven less efficient in developing the capacities needed to offer effective services in liberated areas (Mohamed Salih 1999).

In respect of citizen participation, all liberation movements offered space for citizens for self-governing, local service delivery and development through relief, but in different organisational forms. In the case of the EPLF, citizen participation emulated conventional government structures, giving the impression that once independence was attained, the transformation from liberation movement to government would require only minor adjustments (Bereketeab 2012; Clapham 1998; Hedru 2003; Pool 2001). In the case of TPLF, it depended on grassroots organisations (locally called Tabia and Bito) as institutional frameworks. There were also fears that transforming the TPLF into modern national and local government structures would be daunting, owing to the considerable autonomy exercised by lower units of the administrative system (Mohamed Salih 1999). In Tigray region, the change from the TPLF administrative system to the new federal arrangement was, in fact, swift, but not without initial challenges, as some Bitos felt they were about to transfer hard-won powers to the regional government (Clapham 1998; Young 1997). On the other hand, the one-party government of Eritrea was able to up-scale and utilise the organisational structures inherited from the liberation struggle and transform them into local government entities.

In Southern Africa, the ANC had not liberated or governed any part of South Africa before the collapse of the apartheid regime. This was also largely

true of SWAPO, but to a lesser extent in the cases of MPLA and Frelimo, which formed the national governments after the departure of the Portuguese. By and large, the latter two inherited the colonial administrative structures and operated within them until the end of the civil war, when they were able to introduce various local government and public policy reforms.

The liberation movements in focus have been very successful in pursuing the liberation struggle and in liberating their countries from one or other form of authoritarianism. However, there were varying degrees of success or failure in becoming fully democratic during the liberation struggle. However, some built on traditional democratic institutions in governing liberated areas. Others were not able to liberate parts of their countries and therefore to experiment with self-rule before the liberation struggle ended in the successful ousting of incumbent regimes or in political settlements with other liberation movements.

Success or failure in instilling competitive democracies

Several processes are essential to the post-liberation political settlement. First, there is the creation of a national army and a monopoly over the use of force and coercion to prevent a descent into chaos, as in the case of Somalia and South Sudan. This process often involves demobilising armed groups and rooting out any political entity that uses or threatens force to endanger political stability. Second, there is a need to commence state-building by controlling the existing machinery of government or constituting a new government from the remains of the old regime. Third, it is necessary to create a broad-based coalition, popular and elite and national, committed to a long-term vision of national economic, political and social transformation. Post-liberation governments have in a relatively short period created political regimes comprising a set of institutions and rules of the game that regulate access to, and the use of, positions of public authority in a given society. Holders of principal governmental positions, together with the actors they admit or exclude from access to resources (Guillermo O'Donnell and Philippe Schmitter 1986: 73), possess power and the ability to use it to enhance or undermine human security. Positions of public authority are important because they control access to resources, including public goods. This is the more so because a political regime is broader than government and refers to the rules (formal or not) that govern the interactions of the major actors in the political system (Mainwaring 1992: 296), that link the main political institutions (legislature to the executive, executive to the judiciary, and party system to them all) and that shape the political nature of the ties between citizens and rulers (democratic, oligarchic, totalitarian, etc.) (Cardoso 1979: 38).

Therefore, identifying political regime type is important because it denotes a regime's behaviour, sources of legitimacy (whether the holders of principal positions are elected or selected); and prospects and processes of regime change (through regular and periodic elections, military coups or revolution). From this perspective, regime type holds the key to the characteristics or even the

possibility of transition from one regime to another, for example, from authoritarianism to democracy, or the likelihood of democratic reversal (Mohamed Salih 2014).

A political regime can be defined as a democracy if it fails any of these rules: (1) chief executive is not selected; (2) the legislative is not elected; (3) there are no parties or only one party or the current term in office ended in the establishment of a non-party or one party rule, or the incumbent unconstitutionally closed down the legislature and suspended the rules in their favour; and (4) the 'Type II Error', (Alvarez *et al*. 1996) whereby incumbents have continuously held office by virtue of elections after they have overthrown an elected or military government.

The analysis below expounds on the political regime types of the liberation movement governments under consideration, focusing on whether the political executive and the legislature are elected or selected and whether rule by one party, two parties or a multiparty system is dominant.

Angola and Zimbabwe have dominant party systems and in both countries presidents Dos Santo and Mugabe have ruled uninterruptedly since independence. Eritrea too has been ruled by the same person, President Isaias Afreweki, since independence from Ethiopia in 1993. He is head of state, commander in chief of the armed forces and head of the ruling PFDJ. The main difference between Angola, Zimbabwe and Eritrea is that Eritrea is a one-party state (Bereketeab 2016; Pool 2001).

Ethiopia's regime can be described as prime ministerial, with the prime minister elected by the House of Peoples' Representatives. Since its liberation from the Marxist regime of Mengistu Haile Mariam, Ethiopia has had two prime ministers, Meles Zenawi (1995–2012) and Hailemariam Desalegn, who was re-elected for a five-year term in 2015. The president (*Mulatu Teshome*) has been head of the state since 2013. Elections for Ethiopia's first popularly chosen national parliament and regional legislatures took place in May and June 1995. The EPRDF is the dominant party, having won all elections since 1995, and currently holds more than 99 per cent of the seats in the federal parliamentary assembly.

The regimes in Ethiopia and Rwanda have a few similarities. For example, the political executive and legislature are elected mostly from the ruling EPRDF coalition in the case of Ethiopia and the Rwanda Patriotic Front in the case of Rwanda, which also has a single dominant party system. In both countries, but for different reasons (Rwanda's genocide) (Hintjens 2014; Waugh 2004) there is a coalition of marginalised minorities, and there are high levels of economic growth.

In Uganda, the activities of political parties were severely restricted after the coming to power of the National Resistance Army/Movement (NRA/M) in 1986, and until 2004. A constitutional court ruling and a referendum have since allowed multiparty elections to replace no-party democracy. The formation of civic associations is relatively open and allows for a measure of dissent. The members of the main opposition party, the Forum for Democratic Change (FDC), although allowed to contest the February 2006 presidential and

parliamentary elections, are harassed. A number of them were imprisoned prior to the election, including their leader Dr Kizza Besigye, and the constitution was changed in 2005 to accommodate President Museveni's no term-limit ambition (Mugaju and Oloka-Onyango 2000; Ottaway 1999).

Since the eruption of the civil war and the collapse of the defunct Siad Barre regime, Somalia has had an unelected executive. Various unstable federal transitional governments ruled between 2000 and 2006. The current federal government of Somalia has been internationally recognised with the adoption of the new constitution in August 2012 (Shay 2014). This involves a presidential system, with the president (Sheikh Hassan Mahmoud) as head of government. The cabinet reports to the president through the prime minister (Abdiweli Sheikh Ahmed). The parliament of the federal republic consists of the House of the People and the Upper House. Somalia has a multiparty system without a functioning democracy. The majority of the members of the current federal parliament are drawn from the Tayo Political Party (TPP), Peace and Development Party (PDP), United Somalia Parliamentarians (USP), Justice and Welfare Party (JWP) and Somali Green Party (SGP) (Diriye 2012; Somalia, Government of 2015).

South Sudan's political executive is elected by popular vote. The country adopted a presidential system following its independence from Sudan in 2011. The president (Salva Kiir) is head of government, chair of SPLA/SPLM and commander in chief of the armed forces. South Sudan has a de facto dominant party system under restricted democracy, with the SPLM being the major party.

In South Africa and Namibia, the political executive and legislature are elected in a multiparty democracy with a dominant party system. Both countries have experienced a peaceful succession of governments through democratic elections that have been described as largely free and fair, clinching a majority of the votes.

Obviously, variations in political openness, popular participation and representativeness (elected or selected executive or legislature and the extent of political competition measured by number of political parties allowed to compete in free and fair elections), impact directly on the quality of democracy, the role and ability of the opposition to participate freely and political life generally. Dominant party systems prevail in Ethiopia and South Sudan, although the extent of human, civil and political rights accruing to citizens differs considerably between them. Eritrea is the only country which has adopted a front or a one-party system and even Somalia has more active political parties, civil society and non-governmental organisations than Eritrea.

During the post-liberation period, Ethiopia, Somalia and Somaliland have changed chief political executives (president, prime minister or both) several times, either through election or selection in the case of Ethiopia and Somaliland. Isaias Afrewki has been president of Eritrea since 1991, while President Salva Kiir of South Sudan was selected following the death of John Garang. The current Somali president was selected after internal political wrangling in 2012 (Mohamed Salih 2013).

Countries with long-serving chief political executives have witnessed the continuity of entrenched political elites, which are often oblivious to popular demands for political openness and accuse those opting for change of betraying the liberation struggle, even when the ethos of those struggles was the attainment of democracy and human rights. Such intransigence has resulted in the emergence of three types of opposition: a) democratic opposition operating under democratic rules; b) extra-constitutional opposition that has resorted to armed struggle (Eritrea, Ethiopia, Somalia and South Sudan); c) religious extremist opposition such as Al Shabab promising to 'cleanse' Somalia of Western-styled practices and establish an Islamic state ruled by sharia.

The existence of multiparty democracy and constitutional dispensations have not always guaranteed that citizens can freely form and join organisations. Even though they have adopted multiparty democracy, the liberation movement governments of Angola, Eritrea, Mozambique and Zimbabwe are controlled by a dominant state party. In Angola, the MPLA has controlled the country since 1975. Opposition parties persistently are wrathfully dismissed by MPLA vigilantes, who physically assault their members, including members of parliament (Tvedten 1997).

Namibia fares better as a multiparty democracy. Significant opposition parties such as the Turnhalle Alliance (DTA) and Congress of Democrats (CoD), as long as they operate within the broad constitutional framework, are not subject to severe restrictions (Bauer 1999, 2001; Melber 2007). However, SWAPO's dominance is facilitated by its ongoing nationalistic appeal as the party associated with the liberation struggle. SWAPO is also better organised and financially resourced than other political parties, and enjoys the goodwill of government officials, most of whom were associated with the liberation struggle.

South Africa is an exception. It has a vibrant multiparty democracy and a dominant party state, with the ANC gaining landslide wins in all elections to date. Freedom to form and join organisations is guaranteed by the constitution and practised in fact. Even the National Party (NP), which ruled South Africa under apartheid, continues. In fact, the NP joined the ANC after being heavily defeated in various elections (Mohamed Salih 2007; Southall and Melber 2004).

Ethiopia is similar to Rwanda in that its 1993 constitution permits the formation of political parties. However, the RPF, the liberation movement that ended Hutu hegemony after the 1994 genocide, dominates political life. It banned the Hutu-dominated National Republican Movement for Democracy and Development (MRND), which ruled from 1975 to 1994, because of it close association with the genocide. MRND was also banned from contesting the first multiparty election in 2003. Hutu-dominated trade unions and professional associations are treated with suspicion.

In all liberation movement governments, there are close ties between political party functionaries, the executive and legislature as well as the mass organisations that originated during the liberation struggle. This makes the emergence of strong counter-civic associations extremely difficult, almost impossible. The situation is

worse with regard to the decolonisation movements that continue as one-party states (Eritrea) or have been transformed from one-party states into muted or restricted multiparty democracies (Angola, Mozambique and Zimbabwe). Another inhibiting factor is the strong association between particular ethnic groups and political parties or, rather, liberation movements. A further factor is that for ordinary people, the leaders and movements still occupy a special place in their hearts and minds because of their sacrifices during the bloody liberation struggles. Although this special affinity might be a cause for celebration, it has also encouraged complacency, and in some cases, the leaders have found it difficult to curtail their personal political ambitions and have opted for total control.

Beyond differences in regime type, there lies difference in each regime's political and socioeconomic policies and performance. Many liberation movements qualify as hybrid democracies, with varying degrees of separation between executive and legislature, and most lean strongly towards a dominant party system.

Post-liberation economic growth and human security

This section explores differences in the attainment of economic growth, per capita income and human security. I use these issues to disaggregate a movement government's relative success in achieving a modicum of socioeconomic and political development. These indicators are considered on the basis of independent statistical data published by multilateral organisations in order to minimise the bias inherent in data provided by government or opposition.

There are glaring differences in economic growth among liberation movement governments. Table 2.1 shows that some countries have enjoyed sustained growth over a decade, while others have experienced temporarily sharp declines, only to rebound in record time.

Table 2.1 Annual GDP annual growth, 2004–14

Country	*2000*	*2004*	*2006*	*2008*	*2010*	*2012*	*2014*
Angola	3	11	21	14	3	8	4
Eritrea	–3	1	2	7	2	–	–
Ethiopia	6	11	10	8	1	–	–
Mozambique	1	6	7	7	7	–	–
Namibia	3	7	6	5	4	–	–
Rwanda	8	9	7	9	7	–	–
Somalia	–	2.1	3.8	1.8	–	–	–
South Africa	4	6	3	2	2	–	–
South Sudan	–	–	4.4	–53.3	–36	–	–
Uganda	1	11	6	3	5	–	–
Zimbabwe	–3	–3	11	11	3	–	–

Source: World Bank Statistics: http://data.worldbank.org/

Note
Data for South Sudan and Somalia should be treated with caution. Table 2.1 is based on World Macroeconomic Research dataset: http://kushnirs.org/macroeconomics/index.html

Table 2.1 shows that Ethiopia, Uganda and South Sudan have made the most gains. It is ironic that Somalia has registered higher economic growth than Eritrea, whose economy plummeted by 10 per cent in 2008. South Sudan's economy registered minus 53.3 per cent due to the shutdown of oil exports in 2012. Ethiopia and Uganda are the only countries not to have experienced negative growth over the last 10 years, although Uganda has experienced sporadic conflict with the Lord's Resistance Army during this period. None of the Southern Africa liberation movement governments (Angola, Mozambique, Namibia and Rwanda and South Africa) has experienced negative growth rates, with the exception of Zimbabwe.

The Eritrea–Ethiopia war had a prolonged negative impact on the Eritrean economy, while Ethiopia's economy recovered in a relatively short period. Eritrea's defence and general government expenditure rose to about 63.8 per cent of GDP in 2000, leaving meagre resources for other public sector expenditures, including development (Human Development Report 2013, Table 6, page 165). Eritrea experienced its highest growth rate (7 per cent) for decades in 2012 due to the commencement of gold and silver mining, cement production in Massawa and diaspora remittances. By contrast, Ethiopia soon recovered from the effects of the war and topped the rest of Africa in economic growth (ibid.).

Despite considerable growth in Ethiopia and Uganda over the past decade, Africa still ranks very low in the Human Development Index (HDI), which measures life expectancy, educational enrolment and adult literacy and standard of living (measured by purchasing power parity and per capita income). Human security and human development are intertwined and the HDI and Multidimensional Poverty Index (MDPI) are pertinent if partial indices of human security. Noting that human development index (HDI) is a composite measure of three dimensions of human development: living long healthy life, knowledge and decent standard of living. All three aspects of HDI (living long and healthy life, and education attainments with implications for improved standard of living) correlate directly to HDI concerns in a quantitative manner. On this basis, Eritrea scores poorly. For example, Ethiopia ranked 173 and Eritrea 181 out of the countries, measured and relatively Ethiopia has improved slightly in rank from 174 to 173. The Human Security Index includes indicators such as the economy, health, education, environment, personal and community security. This allows us to compare post-liberation movement governments. Table 2.2 shows the nine African countries ruled by liberation movement governments, and their human security performance. The lower the ranking, the more insecure the population of the country.

In short, Somalia, Eritrea and South Sudan are the most human insecure among liberation movement governments. They also, along with Ethiopia, have comparable human health insecurity scores. While Somalia and Eritrea ranked high in political, economic and food insecurity, they are better off in health security than some other politically more stable countries, such as Mozambique and Angola. Political insecurity is particularly high in Eritrea (lack of political openness and forcible conscription) and Somalia (due to the activities of

Table 2.2 Human Insecurity Index ranking

Country	*Economic*	*Food*	*Health*	*Environment*	*Personal & community*	*Political*	*Human Insecurity Index*	*Rank*
Somalia	90	72.92	48.3	87	100	100	90	1
Eritrea	79.4	90.63	19.69	83.75	61.04	88.75	79.2	2
Ethiopia	77.61	82.48	45.53	60.14	38.14	68.88	78.02	6
South Sudan	73.35	60.35	48.23	24.42	78.92	66	73.51	8
Angola	.95	75.19	87.43	26.78	40.47	49.75	71.29	10
Mozambique	75.11	59.82	95.24	41.72	25.02	35.25	69.51	12
Uganda	67.65	32.42	77.32	33.17	72.49	43	68.23	14
Rwanda	68.64	60.8	63.99	28.35	30.69	45	62.25	19
Namibia	43.07	40.63	59.55	22.07	12.83	17.57	41.0	66
South Africa	33.85	11.46	21.65	12.05	31.6	39.0	31.24	85

Source: Extracted from Werthes, Heaven and Vollnhals 2012: 57–62.

jihadist Islamist groups). South Africa and Namibia have the lowest human insecurity among liberation movement governments, but both have more advanced economies and considerable mineral wealth.

Conclusions

The chapter has demonstrated that: (a) there are varieties of liberation movements with various degrees of success and failure during and after the liberation struggle; (b) pre-liberation institutional strengths or weaknesses are important as is the capacity to manage transition and structural transformation and the ability to mobilise pre-liberation bases of social support; and (c) liberation movement governments are pragmatic and rarely adhere to the ethos and ideologies that galvanised the national liberation struggle. Thus, designating all liberation movement policy and practice in political and economic fields as successes or failures ignores the fact that they are different and should be compared and contrasted in the manner this chapter has attempted to explain.

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3 Liberation movements and the 'democratic deficit'

John Markakis

> Revolutions rise to power on the strength of an idea, and end when the only idea left is to stay in power.
>
> (Anonymous)

Introduction

As the struggle began for the liberation of Africa from imperialism, Kwame Nkrumah succinctly defined the goal and aspirations it gave rise to in one sentence: 'Seek ye first the political kingdom', he said paraphrasing the Bible, 'and all else shall be added unto it'. Seizing political power has been the goal of all liberation movements ever since, and because the site of political power is the state, liberation movements aim to seize state power, even if the state in question is of colonial origin.

In the struggle for such power, liberation movements invoke universal values such as freedom, equality, justice and democracy in order to gain legitimacy and popular support, and foster the hope of a better future once they win the struggle. When that moment comes, however, liberation movements tend to cling to power and invoke new values to retain legitimacy, values that more often than not contradict those they invoked during the struggle. In the final analysis, loss of legitimacy does not loosen their grip on the state, and they readily resort to force to remain in power.

Such behaviour has led to widespread popular disappointment and criticism from intellectuals. The reasons for the first are obvious and genuine, the standpoint of the latter is itself open to criticism on two grounds. First, the record of liberation movements in power is viewed through the prism of 'democratisation', an alien ideological construct arbitrarily imposed on Africans. Second, the assessment of a given regime's 'democratic deficit' depends to a considerable extent on the regime's political relationship with Western powers.

The past

Seizing state power proved easier for the first generation of Africa's rulers than applying it to satisfy peoples' aspirations. The newly independent African states

were burdened with ready-made constitutions, replicas of the British and French models that made not the slightest concession to Africa's reality. Foisted on Africa by departing colonial officialdom, these caricatures deservedly had a very short life. The first generation of Africa's political leaders soon discarded them and sought to devise their own solutions to the immense problems of governance they faced. Among them, African socialism and Pan Africanism gained early political currency, and the one-party system was tried for a time. They did not work, and in the 1970s and 1980s most African states came under politically sterile military rule.

This was the time when a new generation of liberation movements came of age in every region of Africa. In South and West Africa it was the sequel of the struggle against colonialism, directed against white settler regimes, and adapted to guerrilla warfare (Mozambique, South Africa, Zimbabwe, Namibia, Angola, Guinea-Bissau). Half a dozen liberation movements came to power as the result of these struggles. The acceptance of the colonial geopolitical map in Africa agreed by the OAU in 1963 and consecrated by the UN ensured that all liberation movements adhered to this principle.

In sharp contrast to the example set by the rest of Africa, the refusal of the people in the Horn of Africa to accept the colonial map gave rise to multiple, simultaneous liberation struggles that have yet to run their full course. The struggle to revise the map in this region has gone through two contrasting phases. The first witnessed the reduction of political units created by the imperialist intrusion and Ethiopia's concomitant expansion, as the three large states – Ethiopia, Sudan, Somalia – incorporated the three small units – Eritrea, Somaliland, South Sudan – left adrift by the receding imperialist tide: the Djibouti enclave survived by remaining a French colony for two more decades. This phase saw the number of states in the Horn reduced from seven to four.

The second phase saw the fragmentation of Ethiopia, Sudan and Somalia, and the detachment and independence of the territories incorporated in the first phase: Eritrea and Southern Sudan de jure, Somaliland de facto. Fragmentation increased the number of states in the Horn from four to seven, and liberation movements came to power in Eritrea, South Sudan and Somaliland. Interestingly, this signalled the restoration of the colonial map after decades of struggle.

As the remnants of imperialism were being cleared from the continent, a different type of liberation struggle appeared. Militant opposition to oppression and misrule by African regimes gave rise to movements of liberation in many parts of Africa. Not all of them were successful, but several succeeded in capturing state power (Rwanda, Congo, Uganda, Ethiopia), while the struggle in Somalia continues. The rise of opposition to domestic oppression and misrule revived popular aspirations for meaningful change on the continent, including freedom, development and democracy. They were boosted in the late 1980s, when the US identified the 'democratic deficit' as the main obstacle to development, and began to promote 'democratisation' aggressively, offering economic and political inducement.

The present

Given the extravagant expectations raised in the struggle, it was inevitable that the performance of liberation movements in power would prove disappointing. The conclusion drawn by one observer expresses this feeling:

> Sobering post-colonial realities have not matched the expectations of those who considered the fight against colonialism as the fight for the implementation of positive values and norms linked to enhanced economic equality, civil and human rights, democracy and other individual freedoms.
>
> (Melber n.d.)

The failure to eliminate the 'democratic deficit' is the most obvious reason for disappointment and is one that has drawn much comment and analysis by observers. Almost unanimously they focus on the role of the so-called 'legacies', that is the experiences that shaped the character of the movements and determine their performance in power. Shedding these 'legacies' (Clapham 2012: 5 calls them 'mentalities') in order to adapt to a radically different political system, such as liberal democracy, is a test most of them are deemed to have failed.

Furthermore, these 'mentalities' put liberation regimes in direct opposition to 'democratisation'. 'The very process of struggling for liberation especially by resort to force or arms may generate political practices that prefigure undemocratic outcomes in the wake of revolutionary success' (Leys and Saul 1994: 146).

> The liberation movements have taken the militarised, disciplined and unity-centred necessities of fighting guerrilla wars, or running organisations in exile under the threat of infiltration, splits and assassination into government with them, giving them an uncompromising approach to political pluralism and national opposition. They treat plurality more as a threat to unity and spoils of the struggle, than as part of the nature of plural politics and a free society.
>
> (Somerville 2013)

As Clapham concludes, 'it becomes all too easy to view the legacies of the struggle not as a blessing but as a curse' (2012: 5). Roger Southall (2013) has drawn up a detailed indictment along these lines of liberation movements in Southern Africa.

The assumption that 'legacies' act as constraints that impede the transition to democratic outcomes evades the question of whether there is a will to adapt to a system that may, sooner or later, deprive these movements of power. The overwhelming evidence shows that in almost all instances the answer is negative. There is just a single instance, Somaliland, where a successful liberation movement has not clung to power. In all other instances, liberation movements claim legitimacy to govern drawn from the struggle itself, a claim people tacitly tend to accept initially. For this reason, liberation regimes strive to keep the

memory of the struggle alive, in fact to merge it with the country's past and its future. The history taught in Angolan schools is the history of the MPLA, as the country's flag and national anthem are the MPLA's. In Ethiopia the Ethiopian Peoples Revolutionary Democratic party (EPRDF) changed the country's flag. The autobiography of Sam Nujoma (2001), longtime leader of SWAPO, is treated as official history of Namibia. In Eritrea, the liberation movement concocted the history of an Eritrean nation.

Liberation regimes are prone to regard the legitimacy deriving from the struggle as open ended. 'In governmental office, liberation movements tend to mark the "end of history". Any political alternative that does not emerge within them is not acceptable' (Melber, n.d.: 43). This is bound to be contested sooner or later by others. First among the latter are rival movements involved in the struggle for liberation. In nearly all instances, liberation struggles were also bloody civil wars between rival movements – Eritrea, Ethiopia, Somalia, Uganda, Mozambique, Zimbabwe, Angola – for predominance. These internecine conflicts were eventually won by the more powerful movement that captured state power, but did not quite eliminate its rivals or their claims. Active or latent, they remained a threat, and were the first target of political exclusion by liberation regimes, which outlawed their rivals from participation in the political process.

The next target of systematic exclusion was political organisations that predated the struggle and still enjoyed a degree of popular support in the country. They were dealt with by being accused of collaboration with the regime that was just overthrown, or with demands that they join a 'front' led by the liberation regime. In many instances, political activity was banned for a long time, save for the ruling movement itself, which used this time to infiltrate the state administration and forge a party-state merger that could easily deflect the challenges of 'democratisation'. 'Elections in Angola were postponed time and time again … using the delay to extend control over the electoral process to guarantee the MPLA victory' (Melber n.d.).

The usual method of merging party and state is to saturate the administration from top to bottom with party members, simply by requiring civil servants to join the ruling party. This ensures the decision-making process functions more or less smoothly, and the regime has recourse to state resources with which to face political opposition. These include the military and security apparatus that is used as a last resort. Another path to political entrenchment is the accumulation of profit-making enterprises – whether state-owned or private – by the ruling party, which are exploited by officials for personal gain and political expediency. The mineral and energy sectors are prime targets. Angola is perhaps the most egregious example.

As pressure to eliminate the 'democratic deficit' mounted in the late 1980s, nearly every incumbent regime in Africa was swept into the 'third democratisation wave'. The exception was Eritrea, where the liberation regime refused to even go through the motions, when doing so became the political fashion everywhere else.

Uganda is a typical case. Upon coming to power in 1986, the National Resistance Movement (NRM) made a clean sweep of pre-existing political parties, blaming them for the country's blood-stained recent history, and political activity was banned for 19 years. A constitution proclaimed in 1995 outlawed political parties, save for the NRM, on the grounds that it is a movement and not a party. The policy of exclusion was called 'no party politics', and it was not until 2005 that political parties were allowed to organise, nominate candidates and contest elections: some 30 parties were registered then. By this time, the party–state merger had consolidated the NRM's hegemony in the political sphere, and while elections subsequently proved lively events, they did not threaten the movement's monopoly of state power.

The most convincing 'democratisation' performance was staged by the EPRDF in Ethiopia, the result of meticulous planning prior to its assuming power in Addis Ababa. The EPRDF is the creation of the Tigray Peoples Liberation Front (TPLF), which led the assault that toppled the military regime in 1991. The TPLF represents the Tigray, a small ethnic group in northern Ethiopia. Given its limited constituency, it was imperative for the TPLF to form an alliance with other ethnic groups, and the EPRDF was put together before the capture of the state. Democratisation was not a priority for the rebels, whose avowed ideological preference was Marxism-Leninism. They experienced a forced conversion on the road to power when they sought the blessing of the United States. Washington wanted to ensure the EPRDF understood the rules of the game, and made them an offer they couldn't refuse. 'No democracy, no money', was the stark choice Herman Cohen, US Assistant Secretary of State for African Affairs, reportedly put to them.

The seizure of power was followed by the introduction of an interim political formula devised by the EPRDF that proposed federalism as the solution to the multiple conflicts that were tearing the country apart. All aspiring political actors had to accept this formula in order to participate in the political process. This served to exclude political groups that existed before the advent of the EPRDF, and were now opposed to the formula and its claim to dominance. Several other organisations accepted the formula in principle and were included in the transitional government. At the same time, new, ethnically based political organisations were encouraged and proliferated in the 1990s. A few opposed the EPRDF, most were absorbed by it.

This period of political pluralism did not last long. The regime made no secret of its opposition 'democratisation'. 'Liberal democracy has no place in Ethiopia', Meles Zenawi, the late EPRDF leader, once declared. Instead, the regime promoted what it called 'popular democracy', a concept harking back to its Marxist 'legacy'. The EPRDF made free use of state resources and administrative control of the political process to restrict the political space, forcing most rival political actors out of the arena, some to resume the low-intensity conflicts that continue in the periphery of the state.

A few managed to survive and contest elections without making significant gains, until an opportune alliance of opposition parties in 2005 caught the

regime off guard and scored an apparent upset, at least in the urban sector, forcing the EPRDF to play its trump card, force. A state of emergency was declared, a couple of hundred protesters were shot dead and many more wounded, opposition leaders were arrested, tried for treason and sentenced to death. They avoided this fate by begging for pardon and went into exile. The EPRDF won the following two elections with no less than 100 per cent scores, winning praise from US President Barack Obama for being 'democratically elected'.

Obama's statement raises two questions: First, what is the meaning of 'democratisation' in the African context; and second, how do its foreign promoters perceive its implementation on the continent? The evidence so far shows the answers lie not in the meaning or implementation of this much-abused concept, but in the relationship between its promoters and African regimes. Generally, the former are quite willing to take periodic theatrical performances of democracy, namely elections, at face value provided the regime enjoys client status. Mild criticism is limited to the annual US Department of State Human Rights Reports. By contrast, regimes that reject client status are pilloried. The regime in Eritrea that has not bothered even to go through the motions is a case in point.

Material development and social welfare are among the hopes raised during the struggle. In this respect, the record of liberation movements in office is mixed. In most cases a degree of economic and social development has taken place over time. Of course, that is the case throughout the continent regardless of the nature of the regime. In Ethiopia, the EPRDF has played a leading role in promoting record growth. By contrast, in Zimbabwe the regime demolished a flourishing economy, while the regime policies in Eritrea stifled economic growth, causing a mass exodus of youth from the country.

The embrace of the free market is the twin of 'democratisation' and the condition African states are obliged to accept in order to qualify for client status – Eritrea, once more, is the exception to the rule. This condition puts underdeveloped economies under the sway of international capital with well-known consequences: loss of autonomy to plan development policy, and loss of power to defend national resources, including capital and labour, from intense exploitation. An associated consequence is the rise of corruption and embezzlement of national wealth in which regimes are heavily involved. The record of liberation regimes in all these respects is impressive. In some instances – Angola, Eritrea, Burundi, Zimbabwe, Uganda, Mozambique, Ethiopia – corruption has reached spectacular levels. According to the Transparency International Corruption Perception Index for 2010–2012, these countries score 166, 161, 159, 156, 142, 110 respectively out of 175, the global record.

Yet another malignant consequence is the economic and social inequality associated with the free market. Here, the record of some states ruled by liberation movements is impressive. South Africa is perhaps the most unequal society in the world. In Angola, whose economy, fuelled by oil, gas, diamonds and ample agricultural land, grew at the rate of 11 per cent annually in 2002–2010,

outpacing China, embezzlement by the ruling elite is incalculable: an IMF report mentions a missing US$39 billion. Isabela dos Santos, the daughter of its long-time ruler, Edward dos Santos, is reportedly the richest woman in Africa. The capital Luanda is the most expensive city in the world, yet half the population live on US$2 a day. MPLA President Dos Santos has ruled Angola for 36 years (the constitution adopted in 2010 allows him to stay on for another 13 years) as both state president and head of government. He puts himself up for election as the '*candidato do povo*' ('candidate of the poor').

A striking feature of liberation regimes is continuity in power of movements and leaders. No liberation movement has been removed from power through elections, and only one, that in Guinea-Bissau, was removed by force. Only one of them, the EPRDF in Ethiopia is led by a newcomer, due to the death from physical causes of its original leader, Meles Zenawi. Model constitutions drafted during high tide of 'democratisation' are routinely amended 'by popular demand' to allow incumbents additional terms of office.

Conclusion

In the political history of independent Africa, liberation regimes have proven to be the most durable form of government. So far, efforts to place them under the spotlight of political analysis, or to assess their performance in government, have been hopelessly distorted because, as is the case with the rest of Africa, they are perceived through the prism of 'democratisation', the hegemonic paradigm of 'political science' that has not the slightest relevance to African reality. As a result, the political experience of Africa in the past three-quarters of a century, lived behind the façade of 'democratisation', is treated as a type of political pathology, because it does not conform to an imagined, alien ideal. 'At the end of the day, liberation without democracy is still less than liberation' (Melber, n.d.) is a common verdict. It's a rare observer who argues, as Dorman (2005: 4) did, for the need to 'unpack some of the ideological baggage that surrounds governments of former guerrillas, to interrogate their relations with civilians, former allies and former enemies, and *to make sense of the politics in these countries*' (emphasis added).

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Part II

Liberation struggles against European colonisation



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4 The MPLA government and its post-liberation record in Angola

Paulo Ingles

Introduction

After 40 years of independence and more than 50 years after the beginning of the insurgency against its colonisers, Angola still lacks the benefits of full citizenship implicit in the promises of the nationalist discourse. That discourse was set up with the promise of, briefly, retrieving the dignity of Angolans as persons and the fulfilment of citizenship. Apart from external influences, it seems that anti-colonialism arose due to a lack of the advantages associated with modernity among the majority of the population and propagated, paradoxically, by the colonial administration. It seems that nationalism arose as some kind of political ideology through which the native political elite would engage in getting the power of the state through political independence and thereby introduce political and social reforms. These elites adopted from Marxist ideology the universal language that provided, as Elísio Macamo put it, the coherence and consistency required by a political narrative (Macamo 2016). If political independence was thought by nationalists a precondition of achieving the promises of nationalism, 40 years later the outcomes are still a cause of concern. Many accounts and explanations have been put forward within various disciplines to explain the gap between such promises and the modest outcomes (Chabal and Vidal 2007; Messiant 2007; Oliveira 2015; Schubert 2014).

The decline of nationalist enthusiasm was analysed as early as the 1970s and 1980s, mainly from within political science and development studies: the governance and political economy of developing countries were placed under rigorous scrutiny. It was claimed that even though there was political independence, the new states did not have the instruments to develop a sustainable economy because these were in the hands of the former colonisers at the centre of the world economy. This claim was part of the *world system theory* formulated by Wallerstein (2004). After making a clear distinction between strong states at the centre of the world economy and weak states, he asserts:

> The very weak states, which contain a disproportionate share of peripheral production processes, are usually unable to do very much to affect the axial

> division of labor, and in effect are largely forced to accept the lot that has been given them.
>
> (Wallerstein 2004: 28–9)

The dependency theory under which the marginal condition of African economies was studied in the 1970s and 1980s tried to extend its analysis to the world of politics: 'weak' political action was seen as a consequence of weak economic performance. The late 1980s and early 1990s were considered a period of African transition from a single-party system to a more democratic multiparty system, and international agencies and the international community were expecting positive results in terms of social and economic transformation. Researchers, however, have pointed out that economic development and the transition from single-party or military regime to a type of liberal democracy would be long and complex and not a simple issue of formal procedural change such as the introduction of elections. Patrick Chabal and Jean-Pascal Daloz, for example, suggested that among the constraints to change in Africa was a sort of structural disorder whereby the political sphere and private issues were conflated. The absence of the political as a separate field of action was due, in part, to generalised and vertical corruption, which perverted institutions and, hence, all sectors of society. However, such disorder is functional, they argue, because it makes the continent work (Chabal and Deloz 1999). Jean-François Médard (1991, 1989) follows the same reasoning. Africans appropriated the model of the state as a way of organising society along the lines of patronage and patrimonialism in order to exercise political power. These perspectives have attracted many critical remarks, some of which have been accepted by authors like Chabal himself (see Chabal 2009).

In the following, I focus on the constitution of the political leadership and, by extension, the political culture in Angola. Political culture is the embodiment of practices which comprise political decision-making, state administration and the public sphere. However, I use political culture in the sense that Elísio Macamo uses it concerning the Mozambican case: 'a way of doing politics that draws from historically constituted notions of power and authority that spell out the conditions under which power can be exercised while at the same time lending legitimacy to the forms which it takes' (2016: 3). For the purpose of this chapter, I extend the notion of political culture beyond the conditions under which power is exercised to include the way power has been contested.

One crucial aspect of conflict is violence – both symbolic and physical, used not only against the enemy, but also against followers. Violence, which includes physical elimination, worked as a device to limit and occasionally suppress political competition. Thus, internal debates and critical opinions were limited and the cohesion of the group strengthened the loyalty to the leader and the president's inner circle. This may have mystified the leader, but group cohesion may also have been understood as a resource and as a weapon against the enemy, as the accumulation of intangible capital like the capacity to influence decisions or to represent the group to outsiders. But it could also be converted into force,

enabling the leader to control and punish those accused of wrongdoing and to marginalise and expel them from the party. The greater the number of members loyal to the leader, the greater his capacity to influence individuals and use power in specific situations. Power is referred to here in the sense used by Max Weber: it involves social relationships (domination) and needs legitimacy in the sense of acceptability, but also an apparatus through which it can be exercised (Weber 1948). The context of nationalist struggle created the narrative which justified the specific exercise of power: power was an instrument, a means to achieve independence; the nationalist movement as an institution was the micro-space in which power was exercised.

The core of my argument is that the continual use of violence as a way to exercise control over a group during the anti-colonial war and, later, as a means to exercise political power, has shaped the political culture. I argue that the kind of political leadership that emerges when violence is persistently used to achieve political control hardly enables a transition to democratic forms of organising society. The point is that a political culture involving a considerable weight of authority, whose existence depends on physical and symbolic coercion, leaves little space for political competition. The chapter explores the conditions under which such authority emerges, what kind of legitimacy is required and how it fits in with or runs the bureaucratic apparatus.

On the origin of Angolan nationalism: seeking legitimacy by rewriting the past

In 1982, Mário Pinto de Andrade, an Angolan social scientist, revealed during an interview, and for the first time after almost three decades, where and when the MPLA[1] was founded. That revelation seemed to be of marginal importance in the midst of the other issues of the time. In 1982, Angola was facing one of the harshest and longest civil wars on the continent, involving the MPLA government and UNITA.[2] When the interviewer asked Andrade to confirm that the MPLA was founded at a congress in Luanda on 10 December 1956, he replied that neither date nor place were correct:

> It is necessary to note first of all that at that time we were not writing history, we were engaged in political struggle, it was within this context that it was necessary to replace for what it was told until now.
>
> (Andrade and Messiant 1999: 186)

But later he added with a touch of irony that 'it wasn't a lie, but it was not … the truth at all' (Andrade and Messiant 1999: 186). Why did the party claim over many years that the MPLA was founded in Luanda in 1956, and not in Conakry, where Angolans were exiled at the time, in 1960? The main reason according to Andrade, and confirmed by further research (see Pacheco 1997), was the rivalry with other nationalist movements, especially the UPA,[3] which later became FNLA. FNLA was founded at the end of the 1950s by different

groups and associations based in northern Angola and linked with the former province of Bas-Congo (Democratic Republic of Congo). FNLA claimed precedence over MPLA in terms of its foundation, and it claimed to be a proper Angolan nationalist movement in terms of its roots. Thus, to gain legitimacy among Angolans and abroad, FNLA claimed that the MPLA was a party founded by the sons of settlers, i.e. Congolese citizens. The MPLA, on the other hand, accused the FNLA of being clannish, Congolese and not interested in the liberation of Angola as a unique territory but only in the restoration of the former Kingdom of Kongo, from which some FNLA members claimed descent. Claiming 1956 as the MPLA's year of foundation and Luanda as the site of that foundation was part of a political battle: it sought to show that MPLA was founded before 1958, the alleged year of FNLA's foundation, and in Luanda, the main city of Angola, instead of in a distant country unknown to Angolans. Andrade confirmed that 'saying that MPLA existed before and was a very serious organisation in Angola was a matter of life and death. I contributed, it is true, to making it believable' (Andrade and Messiant 1999: 186).

Apart from MPLA and FNLA, the main force in the struggle against Portuguese colonialism was UNITA, founded in 1966. Its first leader, Jonas Savimbi, was a senior member of the FNLA and later left the party to found his own. One reason he put forward for this was FNLA's alleged clannishness and its failure to defend the interests of all Angolans, but only of a small portion of them, those living in the north.

The three movements claimed to be the real representatives of the Angolan people, and all attempted to gain popular sympathy by using inflamed discourse based on strongly nationalist and anti-colonial propaganda. However, even though they faced a common enemy – colonialism – they considered each other competitors from the beginnings of the struggle and, later, when the struggle was at an advanced stage, became each other's enemies. The first task for all the movements was to gain legitimacy among the people as nationalist fighters, as well as international support. In order to augment their internal acceptance, they aimed to recruit especially young people as guerrillas and provide food to the villages. They also aimed at logistical and diplomatic support for confronting colonialism in international arenas and at securing military equipment for the guerrillas.

Anti-colonialism not only took the form of military confrontation, but also aimed at constructing an alternative history of Angolan society in order to convince people of the advantages of political independence. Each movement sought a proper language through which it could give consistency and coherence to its claims. MPLA seemed to find it in Marxism. It cast its struggle not only in terms of political freedom, but also of the elimination of all kinds of social and economic division through a socialist state. So while Marxism-Leninism fed the MPLA's struggle in ideological terms, socialism was the state model to be pursued to achieve such a utopian postcolonial society. Thus, colonialism was interpreted as an instrument of imperialism by which people were subjected to political, economic and cultural oppression and exploitation.

Political independence was the essential first stage in constructing an alternative society. According to MPLA, the war was anti-colonial but also anti-capitalist and anti-imperialist. MPLA would accept the allegedly modern condition of Angola built during colonisation, but intended to correct the systemic barriers that allowed for the reproduction of social inequalities. There was always a tension between whether the changes would be brought about through revolutionary or reformist action. We will see below how these two approaches to change created the tensions and conditions under which different kinds of leadership would emerge.

FNLA had the same diagnosis of colonialism even though it saw colonialists as invaders. Colonialism had attempted to destroy the ancient Kingdom of Kongo which, according to the movement, was not completely destroyed, but persisted in the traditions of the people. Anti-colonialism would be a way to restore a people's sense of dignity as expressed through their traditional habits. These habits were maintained, despite the Protestant efforts at acculturation. Beyond that, religion gave the FNLA some language with which to configure its political discourse by drawing from religious metaphors such as the Promised Land or attributing to its leader characteristics similar to those of biblical figures. The tension in FNLA was between those who valued modern aspects of Angola stemming from colonialism, and others who saw such aspects as a main cause of Angola's backwardness, which was considered not only the outcome of economic exploitation, but also of cultural exclusion. Thus, the dichotomy was perceived not as between oppressor and oppressed – the MPLA perspective – but rather between invader and natives. Anti-colonialism was seen as a precondition of restoring native power. The FNLA borrowed its anti-colonial discourse from negritude and persistently affirmed the value of black or African culture and identity.

UNITA, like the MPLA, believed in a modern Angola, but like FNLA saw the impact of such modernisation as the impoverishment of Angolans, especially the peasants. Thus, UNITA adapted Maoism as its ideology to construct an anti-colonial discourse and as a model for organising revolutionary action. For UNITA, colonialism was also a system of exploitation, as the MPLA and – slightly – the FNLA believed. UNITA highlighted the dichotomy between cities and villages: cities were modern and wealthy but corrupt and somehow racist, while villages, although poor and exploited, were where traditions were kept alive. The revolution was intended to balance this dichotomy.

The three nationalist movements shared the idea of anti-colonialism, even though they gave different interpretations of it. They also shared the idea that the social structure of colonial society was based on a racial hierarchy, which had to be dismantled, and that this could only occur through political independence. However, these common views were not enough for common ground to be established for fighting colonialism, nor trigger a discussion about the political system to be implemented in postcolonial Angola. Rather, the three movements got into a fierce fight, which had a clear impact on the propaganda discourse, as we will see below, and on the definition of loyalty. Being

nationalist went beyond being anti-colonialist, it also meant sharing a group or party's vision of colonialism and how it should be fought. With regard to this, while the nationalist movements were seeking legitimacy through discourse, propaganda and action, they had to reinvent the history of the movement, as the revelation of Mário Pinto de Andrade has shown, and the context in which each movement emerged. The attempts of each to reinvent its own history as part of a consistent and coherent legitimating discourse has precluded the possibility of a *Basiserzählung* (Trotha 2004), a basic narrative. The impulse to construct a unique history and put the movement on an appropriate path required strong leadership – not in the sense of a political programme, but rather in the sense of building a disciplined group. It was in this context that violence was useful.

Inventing the enemy

As Mário Pinto de Andrade notes in his interview, arguing that MPLA was founded two years before FNLA was a matter of life and death. Apart from the dramatic nature of the assertion, it shows the importance of the narrative about origin and it equates legitimacy with a certain version of history. It also shows the importance of a group and its structure. Important elements in the constitution of a group are not only the convictions of its members, but also the social boundaries between 'us' and 'them'. Seen from the outside, boundaries may internally reinforce the convergence and adherence of a group's members. With regard to the nationalist movements, the process of delineating social boundaries was not linked to best ideas or practice, but to historical redescription and the history of the others is always described systematically in an opposing way. Thus FNLA described MPLA members as 'sons of the colonisers', thereby portraying themselves as the natives. MPLA members were viewed as mulattos (i.e. coloured people) and whites, while FNLA members considered themselves to be African natives, i.e. blacks. UNITA was described by MPLA as a puppet movement created by the Portuguese to destroy nationalism; MPLA painted FNLA as clannish, strangers (Congolese) and racist; UNITA, for its part, described FNLA as clannish and corrupt, and the MPLA as bourgeois, corrupt and *crioulos* (i.e. former slave traders). For FNLA, MPLA was communist and aiming to establish a dictatorship in postcolonial Angola, thereby eliminating religion and private property; for MPLA, FNLA was an instrument of imperialism and would be dominated by a puppet president, like Mobutu of the Democratic Republic of Congo.

These descriptions would have been understandable in the context of struggle if they had been only for propaganda purposes and political disputation. However, since they were relayed by means of sophisticated tools such as radio, pamphlets and manuals, they had more serious implications. The movements were also military organisations, with certain territories under their control and with their own flags, hymns and small departments, which functioned as ministries. Thus, followers of other movements were not only ideological adversaries

but were also perceived as enemies. Those who crossed into a base or territory under the control of another movement could face jail, other punishment or even execution. Hence, constructing the enemy was part of the process of legitimating a national movement (Meneses 2015).

From political leader to 'driver' of the people: the constitution of authority

Returning to the Andrade interview, a curious fact is that he gave it in Paris in 1982, and not in Luanda, as he was in exile at the time. He was the founder and first president of the MPLA and, with other colleagues, had written the MPLA's first statutes. At the time, Agostinho Neto, a popular poet and leading nationalist who would become the next president of the MPLA and the first president of Angola, was imprisoned in Portugal. The group around Andrade set up the movement in Guinea-Conakry and, later, in Léopoldville (now Kinshasa). But why did Andrade step down from the presidency to be replaced by Neto? One of the reasons, according to Andrade, was that he preferred diplomacy and to make MPLA known in other African countries and in Europe. Another reason, which is more relevant to our argument, is linked to the conflict with FNLA: the leader of FNLA, Holden Roberto, had claimed that MPLA members were mulattos (sons of Portuguese, but popularly perceived to be an insult) (Bender 1978), and many members of the MPLA board were coloured people, including Andrade himself. This criticism struck home in the MPLA, and prompted the party's decision to choose 'blacks' for the party leadership. It was in this context that Neto, himself a black, was appointed party leader. The third reason was that the movement concluded that it would be impossible to negotiate a peaceful independence process with the Portuguese, who insisted that Angola would continue to be a Portuguese province – and not a colony. Military pressure on the Portuguese became the only option. Thus, the MPLA leader would not only have to be a political authority collaborating with advisors and taking decisions on the movement's path ahead through open discussion and public debate, but also the one who mobilised the masses. The charisma, tenacity and courage of the leader would become crucial in the context of guerrilla warfare – not only against the Portuguese but also against the other movements. Concerning MPLA and FNLA, and later also UNITA, as the movements became more militarised and politically complex, political power became more centralised in the leader. Party loyalty was not associated with political ideas, images of the country or moral principles, but with the ideas, emotions and visions of the leader. The leader came not only to symbolise each movement, but was also identified with the movement itself.

This process was complex. One factor was the polarisation and radicalisation of the different movements, which obliged every individual to identify with one of them. The second phenomenon was that being committed to a nationalist movement implied dependency on the movement for survival: the movement provided food and housing, and some members received scholarships to study or

work abroad. Any dissidence had consequences, including being politically, socially and economically frozen out. In addition, there were emotional costs: one would experience exclusion and marginalisation. Some dissidents who had lived in the bush or in exile could not return to Angola, because they might be viewed by the Portuguese authorities as terrorists, while others feared punishment by former fellow party members after independence. Thus, loyalty was more complex than simply deciding to adhere or not to a political movement. Another important element was the use of violence and punishment. There were trials, revolutionary courts and military courts. During the guerrilla struggle, almost everyone was considered a member of the military and subject to martial law. Some trials were arbitrary, with the party president having the authority to exculpate some and pronounce others guilty. This prerogative reinforced the president's power within the movement, but also instilled discipline and strengthened control.

A case of dissidence

When one MPLA leader was killed because he had criticised the party's president, Agostinho Neto, many MPLA members abandoned the frontlines of the movement, went into exile or crossed over to FNLA (Rocha 2003). Andrade was among those who left the MPLA's party leadership, and Viriato da Cruz, general secretary of the party, joined the FNLA. A few years later, members of the MPLA, mainly intellectuals and officials, spoke out against the extensive power of the president and the personalisation of power. Following this decision, they decided to create their own group within the movement as a space to debate especially the process of decision-making. Before doing so, to ensure that members would not be punished and killed, they asked the movement for physical protection. The group challenged the president to permit more debate and political discussion. Its members felt there needed to be more checks and balances on the president's power, and the group thought that a congress could be a forum for open discussion. However, challenging the authority of the president was interpreted as betrayal, and members of this group – many of them founders of the MPLA – were excluded from the party. After independence, some were jailed and tortured, and others went into exile. Mário Pinto de Andrade had been among those challenging the president. Even though Andrade had founded the MPLA and fought against colonialism, he eventually died in exile. He returned to Angola only to be buried at his birthplace.

Authority, bureaucracy and legitimation

Colonisation came to an end in the spring of 1974 when the Portuguese government was overthrown in an army coup. The new authorities decided to decolonise Portugal's colonies and, to stop the war and hand over political power, concluded the Alvor Accord with the three movements in January 1975. The agreement stated that independence would be proclaimed on 11 November

1975 and that a month prior to this, a parliament would be constituted by means of elections. Meanwhile, a transitional government was set up. It included members of all the movements, but was headed by a Portuguese commissioner.

Even though the Portuguese were to retain military control of Luanda, all movements retained their armed branches and, as independence approached, tensions between them escalated and there were soon violent confrontations. By June 1974, the idea of an election had been practically discarded, especially by the MPLA and FNLA, which engaged in urban war apparently to take control of Luanda before independence in order to be handed power by the Portuguese and to enhance internal and external legitimacy. To this end, both movements activated external allies: the MPLA sought support from Cuba, the FNLA approached Mobutu of the Democratic Republic of Congo, and UNITA asked South Africa for support. Strengthened by Cuban support, and to a lesser extent also by Portuguese assistance, MPLA managed to seize power and dislodge the other movements. Nonetheless, each movement proclaimed independence on its own, but only the independence proclaimed by MPLA was recognised by foreign countries. The FNLA disappeared as a liberation movement, and its leaders went into exile. UNITA, however, transformed itself into a guerrilla movement and fought against the government, with the war ending only in 2002.

Meanwhile, MPLA declared a dictatorial regime in order to transform Angola into a Marxist-Leninist socialist state. The suppression of basic rights and limitations on freedom in Angola were fairly typical of any dictatorship. We need not go into the details of how these rights were suppressed and by what means. We should rather try to analyse the constitution of authority in the context of the bureaucratic apparatus and how this authority gained legitimacy.

Authoritarianism and bureaucracy

We have outlined the conditions that facilitated the emergence of leadership in the struggle for independence and the creation, through the exercise of power, of a specific kind of leader. However, this leader was described in the context of a nationalist movement where the scope for formal or informal political participation was narrow. Political participation can be understood as the compromises people achieve through debate, suggestion, criticisms and evaluations in a political process such as the struggle for independence. We have already seen that both military and political aspects of the liberation struggle were strictly centralised. After independence, when the nationalist movement transformed itself into a ruling party, there were two forms of political participation. One was by influencing decision-making via an assembly representing the people wherein suggestions, criticisms and evaluations could be formulated. The other might take the form of a mechanism whereby political representatives could explain and justify decisions, especially after something goes wrong. But where the people are not allowed to participate in political decision-making, then one

is looking at an authoritarian regime wherein all decision-making is centralised in the hands of one person or of a small group.

However, there is another aspect of political participation and this relates to how policies are implemented. In this regard, and following the scheme outlined by Macamo and Neubert (2002: 56), there are two possible ways of implementing policies. One is by means of what they call a Weberian-type bureaucracy: 'A Weberian-type bureaucracy under the rule of law is based on a strong administration which implements decisions taken by local political decision-makers. The implementation process is regulated by rules and laws embedded in a general constitution' (Macamo and Neubert 2002: 57). This means that the presence of an authority is almost indispensable to the process of implementing laws. However, this project does not imply liberal democracy, since it can be present in authoritarian regimes. The second mode of implementation is what they describe as arbitrary: 'where administration does not follow strict rules. All decisions are single-case matters as a result of the arbitrariness of the authority in power' (Macamo and Neubert 2002: 56). Unlike the first one, in the arbitrary mode the persons in power come first. Therefore, implementation of all policies, even those decided after technical discussion, depend on the persons who hold the power.

To summarise the scheme regarding political participation in decision-making, a regime can be authoritarian when there is no political participation; or, when there is political participation, it can be participatory-democratic, regardless of whether the decision-making arises from a liberal or a popular democracy. Regarding policy implementation, this can be by a Weberian-type bureaucracy which is impersonal, follows strict rules and runs independently of the political authority behind it. Second, there is the arbitrary mode of implementation when the administration does not work according to the law but depends on the direct interference of a political authority. The authors of the scheme combined these elements and developed a typology of political systems with four possible variations. In this chapter we can't explore all the aspects of the typology. Instead, we use the outline to explore the relationship between authority and bureaucracy, specifically how the kind of authority in the ruling system impacts on the way policies are implemented.

From authoritarian state under the rule of law to command state

As noted above, the Angolan regime is authoritarian in terms of political participation. Political decisions were made by the Political Bureau of the party, even though there were national and provincial assemblies. Concerning the mode of implementing policies, two aspects should be mentioned: during the early years – from 1975 to 1977 or a bit later – the regime was close to the Weberian-type of bureaucracy in an authoritarian state but under the rule of law. Some of these laws were, evidently, 'revolutionary laws', but were followed fairly strictly. Where the government in place had not passed specific laws or

decrees, the administration reverted – paradoxically – to colonial laws. This was a 'mixed' system because of the interference by political authorities in the bureaucracy. For this reason, it was arguably an arbitrary mode of implementing policies. At that time, the new government did not yet have complete control of the bureaucratic machine, and many officials had worked in the administration before independence and maintained some of the routines after independence, except where political prudence was required. Things changed in 1977 due to the reconfiguration of political authority.

After UNITA and FNLA were expelled from the cities and almost disappeared from the political scene, tensions mounted within MPLA seriously threatening its internal cohesion. Partly, this was due to ideology: even though MPLA was Marxist-Leninist, there existed opposing ideological tendencies within the party. One group claimed that the revolution had not been sufficiently radical, because some colonial structures persisted and the social hierarchy was still racialised. The other group, congregated around the president, Agostinho Neto, comprised many coloured people and whites, who claimed they were more skilled on account of discriminatory policies under the colonial administration. This tension was translated into a political dispute and later into violent conflict. The first group was accused by the second of having plotted a coup d'état on 27 May 1977. In reaction, the president's group used state security forces to imprison, torture and kill more than 10,000 people, most of them civilians, and the country experienced almost a state of terror. A consequence of these purges was the extension of the party's and the president's power into every level of official life in order to forestall any political threat to their authority. Many institutions in the society – companies, schools, associations, radio stations or newspapers – were either nationalised or prohibited. The consequence for the bureaucracy was that the mode of implementing policies became more arbitrary. All levels of administration ceased to be based on laws or decrees, but became personal in that implementation of decisions now depended on the permission of a central authority. This political turn of events paralysed or deeply complicated bureaucratic procedures. Not only did the law cease to be the sole reference for the public administration, but it was replaced by the word of the chief. Soon after, communications between the central power and local public administration stopped because there was no more common ground. The major interest of the political authority was not the correct implementation of policy according to political decisions, but rather the prevention through the administration of any kind of political competition or opposition. Evidently, this trend has adversely impacted any transition to democracy.

Authority, democracy and clientelism

From 1976 to 2002, Angola witnessed civil war between the MPLA government and the UNITA guerrilla movement. Until 1989–90, the war was influenced by the Cold War. However, after the fall of the Berlin Wall, a reconfiguration of

power occurred in the region. The strength of MPLA and UNITA, especially of their leaderships, lay in their armies, as well as their allies and the population at large. But how would a democratic transition interfere with the leadership? In other words, would the political culture allow for political transition?

During the war, UNITA transformed itself from a nationalist movement into political structure and an almost conventional army and created within Angola a sort of parallel state. The post-war transition would mean dismantling its war machine and creating space for political participation. Such a transformation would imply changing the pattern of political leadership from military to civilian. The MPLA government, on the other hand, developed a patronage system. Government authoritarianism was not enough to maintain control over every corner of the administration and over minor leaders. Violence, at least physical violence, was no longer a regular instrument for exercising political power. Thus, the leader of the party (i.e. the head of the state) developed a scheme by which he could maintain his political leadership by distributing benefits to his supporters, what Chabal and Deloz call a clientelistic network (Chabal and Deloz 1999; Elwert 2001). In fact, it is a kind of exchange, involving, say, a ministry, a senior position in the public administration or a leading position in a public company in exchange for loyalty. The networking extended to high-ranking army and police officials. Any change to the political system would have to accommodate such practices, and this could, more than the lack of political will, constrain any transition to democracy (Neubert 1999).

Conclusion

Currently, Angola faces difficulties in its political and economic system. The economic challenges are quite similar to those of other countries reliant on the sale of oil and other natural resources on the global commodity market. The political challenge, however, is linked to the specificity of political leadership. I have argued that the conditions under which nationalist leaderships emerged have influenced their way of exercising power: it is commitment to a leader rather than to a political project that has generated a particular political culture. Violence and other forms of coercion were the means by which a boundary between 'us' and 'them' was devised and authority was constituted. This kind of authority maintained itself when the nationalist movement became the ruling party. However, former rivalries and disputes over political power led to political confrontation within the ruling party. The results of such confrontations intensified the authoritarianism, but also changed the way of implementing policies. This was no longer done through a bureaucratic apparatus but as an instrument of political control. This has constrained participation by citizens in political decisions, and led the bureaucratic system to fall apart. Deficiencies in water supplies, electricity, health services, housing, employment, among others, seem to be more due to political constraints than to the absence of policies. On the other hand, this political system is linked less to the cultural characteristics of a society than to the conditions under which power is exercised, and these can be historicised.

Notes

1 Popular Movement for the Liberation of Angola. It was one of the major nationalist movements in Angola and, after independence, became the party of government. It has been ruling the country ever since.
2 National Union for the Total Independence of Angola. It was the third nationalist movement and founded in 1966. After independence it became a guerrilla movement and fought against the MPLA government until 2002. It is currently a political party and has seats in the Angolan parliament.
3 Union of the People of Angola, which later became FNLA, National Front for the Liberation of Angola.

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5 From former liberation movement to four decades in government

The maintenance of the Frelimo state

Adriano Nuvunga

Origins, liberation struggle and national independence

Official historiography indicates that the Mozambique Liberation Front, Frente de Libertação de Moçambique (Frelimo) was founded in Dar-es-Salaam, Tanzania, in 1962,[1] when, under the influence of Ghana's Kwame Nkrumah, Tanzania's Julius Nyerere and the Conference of Nationalist Organisations of Portuguese Colonies (CONCP), three regionally based nationalist movements, the Mozambican African National Union (Manu),[2] the National Democratic Union of Mozambique (Udenamo)[3] and the National African Union of Independent Mozambique (Unami)[4] merged into one broad-based nationalist movement with the intention of liberating the land and the people from Portuguese colonial rule (Frelimo 1980).

However, scholars (De Brito 2009; Opello Jr 1975) question the notion of a merger of the organisations on the grounds that soon after it had taken place their leaders abandoned Frelimo and attempted to relaunch their former organisations. In fact, prior to the start of the liberation struggle, according to these scholars (De Brito 1987; Opello Jr 1975), there was conflict surrounding Frelimo's origins, characterised by exclusions, expulsions and revolts in the initial stages as leaders of the different groups competed for control of the party and for positions of power. For instance, not only were Manu's Matthew Mmole and Lawrence Millinga not elected to the central committee, they were actually expelled from Frelimo in 1962.

In the beginning, the major cleavage was between two groups. On the one hand, there were the semi-educated *assimilados*,[5] predominantly from ethnolinguistic groups located in the current northern provinces of Niassa and Cabo Delgado (bordering on Tanzania and Malawi), with Lazaro Nkavandame, from a relatively rich Makonde rural family (Oppelo Jr 1975), as the prominent political figure. The other group comprised highly educated *mestiços* (people of mixed European and African descent) and *assimilados*, largely from ethnolinguistic groups located in the southern provinces of Gaza, Maputo and, partly, Inhambane, with Eduardo Mondlane as the prominent political figure. Mondlane was a scholar, the only Mozambican with a PhD at the time, and a UN official based in New York.

Following revolts[6] within Frelimo in Tanzania, a second congress was held, amid tensions, in 1968 in Matchedje, Niassa, in the hinterland of northern Mozambique. Mondlane was elected president and Urias Simango vice-president. Having failed to have the venue for the congress moved to Tanzania, where he enjoyed popular support, Lazaro Nkavandame boycotted it, thereby paving the way for strengthening the Mondlane faction. Nkavandame was later declared *persona non grata* by the Tanzanian government and ordered to leave the country.

Following the assassination of Mondlane in February 1969, a triumvirate was formed, to be known as the presidential council. Its members were Simango (from the central part of what is today Sofala province, with Beira as the capital city), Marcelino dos Santos (a *mestiço* from Lumbo) and Samora Machel (a military commander from the southern province of Gaza). Two months later, in April 1969, the central committee assembled for its longest meeting – 11 days – at the Nachingwea (Tanzania) base to discuss the leadership of the movement. With Nkavandame out of the picture and Simango believed to have been connected to Mondlane's assassination, Machel emerged as president and Dos Santos as vice-president of the nationalist movement. The focus of the cleavage thus shifted from north/south to south/north-centre.

This exacerbated the tensions within the movement (Opello Jr 1975) and different leaders attempted either to revive their old movements or to create new ones. However, these movements had no real political support and presence apart from the Comité Rovolucionario de Moçambique (Coremo), based in Lusaka (Newitt 1995), which was headed by Adelino Gwambe and later joined by Urias Simango. Internationally, this movement was linked to South Africa's Pan Africanist Congress (PAC) and Angola's União Nacional para a Independência Total de Angola (UNITA) (Poppe 2009). However, as a result of the tumultuous and violent internal politics that dominated Frelimo in the early 1960s, the successful elite faction, the south/north alliance, formed a political leadership that was 'fairly cohesive, firmly bound together and somehow immune to outside influence' (Sitoe 2004: 50), and able to lead the liberation struggle towards eventual independence.

At the time of its formation, it was not clear that Frelimo would opt for armed struggle; while some thought it inevitable, others favoured a political campaign. Even among the former, however, there were divisions about tactics, with some favouring the type of urban rebellion that had proven effective in Algeria, and others favouring a popular rebellion in the form of a guerrilla movement (De Brito 1987; Opello Jr 1975; Poppe 2009).

With only 250 trained combatants, Frelimo, claiming a popular mandate and defining the liberation struggle as the struggle between the oppressed working classes of Mozambique and the oppressor class, colonial or traditional (Opello Jr 1975; Poppe 2009), launched the armed struggle on 25 September 1964 with an attack on the Chai military base in the northern province of Cabo Delgado.

After 10 years, the 25 April 1974 coup d'état in Portugal smoothed the way for negotiations over the political independence of Mozambique. The Lusaka

Agreement, signed by Frelimo and the Portuguese government on 7 September 1974, some five months after the coup, provided for a 12-month transitional government. Appealing for pluralism a few weeks later, the coup leaders who had left or been expelled from Frelimo formed a political coalition, the National Coalition Party, Partido de Coligação Nacional (PCN) with the intention of participating in the process of national independence. The majority group within the PCN was the Comité Rovolucionario de Mocambique (Coremo), headed by Adelino Gwambe and Urias Simango. The PCN also included the Grupo Unido de Moçambique (Gumo), led by Joana Simião, and Unipomo, led by Lazaro Nkavandame. However, continental organisations such as the Organisation of African Unity (OAU) and, importantly, the Portuguese government, recognised Frelimo as the only representative of the Mozambican people (Cahen 1998; De Brito 1987; Jossias 2007; Poppe 2009; Serra 1993) and the Lusaka Agreement did not provide for elections before independence. Accordingly, on 25 June 1975 the Frelimo president, Samora Machel, proclaimed the total independence of Mozambique, ending five centuries of Portuguese rule.

Frelimo as government

Amid enormous popular euphoria over independence, power was transferred to Frelimo, which moved proudly to create a state out of the colonial territory. According to the 1975 Constitution, the objectives of the newly independent state were:

i elimination of structures of oppression (colonial and traditional);
ii strengthening popular democracy;
iii construction of an independent economy and promotion of cultural and social progress;
iv defence and consolidation of national unity; and
v setting up cooperatives and establishing friendly relations with other peoples and states in the continued struggle against colonialism and imperialism.

But the art of government proved to be much more challenging than the guerrilla tactics of the liberation struggle. Frelimo had to transform itself from fighting the establishment to being the establishment with the task of creating and maintaining political order.

From nationalist movement to one-party state

Consistent with its history, and perhaps as a legal response to those political groups that wanted to participate in the new political process, Frelimo created and ran a constitutional one-party state, banning the formation of political parties. Signs of political repression could no longer be disguised, for example, when the leaders of PCN were arrested and sent to re-education camps in Niassa

(Fauvet 1984). In 1975, prior to independence, these leaders were presented to the media as prisoners at Nachingwea base (Poppe 2009). Only four months after independence, in October 1975, the Frelimo government created the Serviço Nacional de Segurança Popular (SNASP), the secret police tasked with detecting and neutralising all forms of subversion and sabotage against the state. At the same time, re-education camps were established, citizens were obliged to carry an identity card and permission to travel from one district to another was formalised. On the first anniversary of independence in 1976, President Samora Machel declared that within a few months opposition to Frelimo would be eliminated (Poppe 2009).

Two years later, thousands had been arrested and sent to re-education camps and Frelimo had been transformed from a nationalist movement into a political party; had formally adopted Marxist-Leninist ideology at its third congress, held in 1977; and had monopolised the name and history of the liberation struggle. Ideologically, it intended to end the exploitation of 'man by man' and to create a '*homem novo*', a new man (De Brito 2010; Francisco 2009; Newitt 1995), and to become a transformational force that would shape the '*sociedade nova*', the new society (Poppe 2009). Frelimo's leading role in society was shaped by its victory in the 10-year liberation struggle and particularly by the proclamation of independence in 1975 (De Brito 1988, 2009; Sitoe 2004; Lundin 1995). In other words, it was moulded, on the one hand, in the context of liberating the 'land' and 'the people' from colonial rule and on the other by being the 'state builder' in the vanguard of the revolution.

It took its aim of creating a new man and new society to the extreme, since, like any other former liberation movement turned ruling party, it not only felt it had 'won the right to govern the state through sacrifice and military victory' but that that this right 'also imbue[d] [its] state reform project' (Dorman 2006: 1097). So, stimulated by its Marxist-Leninist ideology and rhetoric, Frelimo embarked on the creation of a state that was rejected by some communities as being at odds with their core values, which included ethnicity, chieftaincy and/or traditional authorities – seen by Frelimo as a remnant of feudalism. To this end, Frelimo implemented somewhat aggressive policies: coercive communal villages, state farms, a rigid social organisation (Cahen 1998; De Brito 1991; Newitt 1995), the abolition of tribes and the replacement of the traditional authority structure with *grupos dinamisadores* (dynamising groups).

It also went on to thwart all forms of autonomous political and social organisation, replacing them with satellite organisations of the party, in particular democratic mass organisations such as the Organisação da Mulher Moçambicana – OMM (Organisation of Mozambican Women), Organisação da Juventude Moçambicana – OJM (Mozambican Youth Organisation), Organisação dos Trabalhadores Moçambicanos – OTM (Mozambican Workers' Organisation), the Organisação Nacional dos Professores – ONP (National Teachers' Organisation) and the Organisação Nacional dos Jornalistas – ONJ (National Organisation of Journalists) (Adalima 2009; Poppe 2009).

The result was a state that was not dissimilar in nature to the colonial regime (Sitoe 2004). The driver was perhaps not only the vanguardism and Marxism-Leninism but the concrete challenges Frelimo faced in maintaining the political order it had created. Alternatively, Marxism-Leninism was a suitable paradigm for interpreting and carrying out the key decisions Frelimo had made and felt it must protect, for example, the sacrosanct principle of national unity, which it defended tooth and nail because it legitimised the party's power.

Crises in post-independence Frelimo

Frelimo's prolonged rule was not without power-threatening crises. The first was the formation of the Resistencia Nacional Mocambicana (Renamo) rebel movement in 1977, two years after independence. Renamo was initially backed by the Rhodesian regime, then, after Zimbabwe's independence in 1980, much more vigorously by the South African apartheid regime. However, scholars (Cahen 1998; De Brito 2009) suggest that what started as an external aggression evolved into civil war in about the mid-1980s.

> It is evidently impossible to define a precise date for the passage from a war of aggression to an atypical civil war … it seems clear the process of transformation took place between 1982 and 1985, the period when the war extended to the entire country.
>
> (Cahen 1998: 11)

The fact that all Renamo leaders came from the central region of the country exacerbated the south/centre cleavage, which, to-date, shapes voter behaviour (De Brito 1995; Lundin 1995; de Tollenaere 2004).

Not only did Frelimo initially fail to defeat the rebel movement, within a few years Renamo had spread across the country, placing the Frelimo project of building a new society and new men 'under fire', to use Joseph Hanlon's expression. This was a considerable crisis, but the second, and perhaps more salient one, was negotiating with what Machel called the boar, the *javalis*, although there were no direct negotiations with Renamo. Indeed, the negotiations were held with the South African regime in an effort to stop it from providing material support to the rebel movement in exchange for the Mozambican government's neutrality towards the African National Congress (ANC), to which it had been offering logistical support. These negotiations, which led to the Nkomati Accord, reflect the Mozambican government's difficulty in recognising the rebel movement as a relevant actor in the country's political process and not just the instrument of externally supported political and economic destabilisation (Mazula 1995). Signing the accord meant, in part, establishing a pact with the alleged bosses of the rebel movement as a way of 'destroying the root cause of the evil' from within (Della Rocca 1998). In much the same way, the amnesties granted to Renamo guerrillas by the Mozambican authorities were a way of integrating Renamo into state structures, but without recognising the

rebel movement as representing the aspirations of a portion of the Mozambican population. This also meant the implicit recognition that the long-proclaimed national unity, *unidade nacional*, resulting from the fusion of Manu, Udenamo and Unami did not include all spheres of society.

The next crisis was the shift from a centrally planned economy to a market economy. As a result of Mozambique's rejection as a member of the Council for Mutual Economic Assistance, the hope of aid from the Soviet bloc faded and, in 1984, the government had to start negotiations with the West in search of help for an economy largely paralysed by civil war and a prolonged drought. The aid that was provided was conditional on the establishment of a Structural Adjustment Programme, which was implemented from 1987 with the support of the Bretton Woods Institutions, paving the way for economic reforms. The other aspect of the second crisis was political reform – the 1990 democratic transition, with the then People's Assembly enacting the country's first multiparty constitution.

This meant letting go of the idea of homogenisation and introducing the 'unity in diversity', *unidade na diversisidade*, principle, a serious decision that involved Frelimo's acceptance that it could no longer claim to be the 'embodiment of the national will'. The move was preceded by an announcement at the party's fifth congress, in 1989, that it was abandoning Marxism-Leninism – the cause to which the country's late president, Samora Machel, who had earlier been killed in a plane crash, had devoted much of his political life.

Although the 1990 constitution promoted political liberalisation, eliminating the ban on the formation and membership of political parties, guaranteeing political and civil rights and, in particular, establishing elections as the mechanism for winning and legitimising political power, the war did not end. This led to the third crisis: direct negotiations between the Frelimo government Renamo, in which Frelimo worked on finding a formula to end the civil war while at the same time defending the political and state power it had consolidated since independence. This had been the main theme of the fifth Frelimo congress in 1989, which had again proposed an amnesty for Renamo guerrillas, a kind of integration.

While preparing for the negotiations in Nairobi the same year, Frelimo presented what it called a 'basis to assist positive dialogue with the *armed bandits*'. This was a 12-point document that, essentially, stated that the rebel movement should recognise the state created and governed by Frelimo, its organisation and legality, and that there should be an immediate ceasefire. In its turn, Renamo demanded official government recognition. In point 5 of the 16-point document setting out the terms of the peace negotiations, Renamo described itself as 'an active political force on the Mozambican political scene' and maintained that 'any peaceful solution must take into account this reality'. In short, just as Renamo did not recognise the legitimacy and sovereignty of the government of Mozambique, the government did not recognise Renamo as a political movement.

It was necessary that the Frelimo government be recognised by the rebels. In the words of Armando Guebuza, head of the Mozambican delegation to the

1990–92 Rome peace negotiations that culminated in the *Acordo General de Paz*, the General Peace Accord, signed in Rome on 4 October 1992:

> the government of Mozambique is a Frelimo government, the party that achieved independence.… This state organised itself and we are an internationally recognised state. There is a state that has institutions and laws. The negotiations underline an abnormal moment in the country but they cannot call into question the state or the legitimacy of its institutions and laws. The laws that we are handing to Renamo cannot be discussed because they are legitimate.
>
> (Della Rocca 1998: 152)

Over the negotiating table in Rome, Frelimo reluctantly recognised the former rebel movement as an 'important' actor in the Mozambican political process. The recognition was a nod to the international community because in its 'rhetoric and above all, in its political practices and *habitus*, it accorded Renamo no political legitimacy whatsoever … Renamo remained a group of fringe elements, illiterates, assassins, and monkeys' (Cahen 1998: 5).

The fourth crisis related to the justification of Frelimo's overnight change of attitude towards the economy and business. Under the highly principled and heavy-handed leadership of Machel, who had argued that 'power holders should be the first in consenting to sacrifices and the last in enjoying benefits', Frelimo elites were committed to building socialism through collective means of production. After Machel's death, and in the context of the subsequent economic reforms, privatisation was used for elite self-enrichment. This move was epitomised by the statement of one of Frelimo's heroic figures and founding fathers, Alberto Chipande, who repeatedly stated, '*lutamos pela Liberdade e portanto temos o doreito a enriquecer*' ['we fought for liberty and thus we have the right to become rich'] (Weimer, Macuane and Buur 2012: 32). So, the once wholehearted proponents of Marxist-Leninist socialist principles became the kings of Mozambique's 'jungle capitalism' (Bowen 1992) or 'savage capitalism' (Hanlon 2009) as 'born again private sector entrepreneurs' (Fauré and Médard 2000).

The fifth crisis was that Renamo almost won the second presidential election in 1999. Frelimo had not only retained power without challenge throughout the two years of democratic transition (1992–94), it also won the first democratic elections in October 1994. In 1999, however, there was an upset. Not only was there only a marginal difference between the number of votes for the two presidential candidates – Frelimo's Joaquim Chissano and Renamo's Afonso Dhlakama – astonishingly the number of votes excluded from the final count as being invalid was equal to the difference between the two candidates.[7] Thus Chissano won a problematic and somewhat fraudulent electoral victory (De Brito 2008; Hanlon and Fox 2006; Nuvunga 2005; Rønning 2011). This was a major crisis that might have spelt the end of Frelimo's 'historic mission'.

Despite the acrimony that surrounded the election, Frelimo survived, but it made important changes. Power was transferred from the reformist, technocratic

and state-centred President Joaquim Chissano to the party-centred and heavy-handed leadership of President Armando Guebuza, who revitalised and reorganised the party, restored the founding history of the nationalist movement to give direction to the party, increased salaries to party personnel and, when he became president of the republic in 2005, brought back the subservience of the state to the party. So while President Chissano had rolled back the party from the state, President Guebuza not only further entrenched the party in the state, he put it in the driving seat. The results are evident: from almost losing power in the 1999 election, Frelimo won solid electoral victories in 2004, 2009 and 2014. Clearly, crises and strategic responses to those crises have been part and parcel of Frelimo's dominance since it came into being in the 1960s.

Electoral triumphs

Using Mohamed Salih's nuanced conception (Salih 2003) of political parties as a point of departure, namely that they are instruments of collective human action and creatures of political elites – either politicians trying to control governments or government elites trying to control the masses – Frelimo is a successful party. In fact, 53 years after its formation as a liberation movement, it remains the dominant political organisation in the country, and represents a rare case of an African political party that has managed not only to survive the political transition from one-partyism to multiparty competition, but also to remain in power (Carbone 2005; Nuvunga 2014; Nuvunga and Salih 2010, 2013).

The second paragraph of the preamble to the statutes approved by the 10th congress presents Frelimo as pursuing another major objective of the liberation struggle, economic independence. This is clearly a Marxist historicist interpretation of today's Frelimo in light of the liberation struggle. At independence in 1975, the population numbered 10 million people, 90 per cent of whom were illiterate, with only 2 per cent in formal jobs and about 85 per cent peasants. Forty years after independence, International Monetary Fund (IMF) statistics show that in 2013 Mozambique's GDP was $15.33 billion, with a GDP growth rate of 7 per cent.

The proportion of the population considered to be below the poverty line is 54.7 per cent; 35 per cent of the rural population has access to water; life expectancy is 50 years; illiteracy has been reduced to 48 per cent, with the net enrolment rate for primary education at 81.3 per cent, and the proportion of girls in primary education having increased from 33 per cent at independence to 47.2 per cent in 2009. Child mortality rates dropped from 147 to 124 per 1,000 live births between 1997 and 2004, while the mortality rate of children under five decreased from 219 to 178 per 1,000 live births in the same period and maternal mortality has gradually declined from 1,000 deaths per 100,000 births in the 1990s to 408 in 2003.

This is an outstanding achievement in a country that had experienced a devastating 16-year civil war. However, Mozambique's economy has not undergone

significant structural change: it remains a subsistence agricultural economy. The country was shocked when the 2013 Human Development Index (HDI) showed that only two countries, Niger and the Democratic Republic of Congo, scored worse.

Frelimo's retention of land as state property at the disposal of rural communities gives the party extra credibility among these communities even as it argues that economic liberty is gradually being attained because of the party's policies. So, taking into consideration the fact that Frelimo only began to normalise the economy after the peace agreement that ended the civil war (which Frelimo continues to call the destabilisation war) was signed in 1992, Mozambique can be considered a successful country (Hanlon 2004) and Frelimo a successful party. Frelimo not only reformed the state, it reformed itself to fit into the multiparty era. National sovereignty, the rule of law and national unity are intact and there has been no democratic reversal in the two decades of multiparty politics. All these aspects create the goodwill that results in Frelimo's retention of power.

However, other equally important aspects account for the party's prolonged rule. One of these is party unity. Although there are disputes and there is friction among longstanding Frelimo members, the party remains united. Frelimo's early days were dominated by acrimonious internal conflicts over control of the then liberation movement, but since the revolutionary faction took control of the party at the second party congress in 1968, the party's leadership has remained united, despite some serious incidents, for instance, the alleged attempted coup attributed to the then head of the army and founding member of Frelimo, Sebastião Mabote, early in the 1990s. As De Renzio and Hanlon (2009: 252) have stressed, '[g]roups and factions form and shift according to the issue at hand, but differences are largely argued out within the party. There are no expulsions or splits, and all factions remain inside the party'. This is an important change from the trend within Frelimo in the early 1960s.

Although the nucleus of original Frelimo members (most of them bound by the history of the liberation struggle) may play an important role in party cohesion, pragmatic aspects also play a part. One of these is that the party's members evidently understand that breakaways would weaken the party, leading to its collapse. Others are family ties through marriage and, importantly, patronage. Indeed, contrary to the situation in the 1960s, when there were few prestigious positions on offer, a factor that partly contributed to internal conflicts, with the state under its control Frelimo now has plenty of such positions, both national and international, in which to place different groups, thereby significantly reducing internal tensions. In fact, in the ministry of state administration there is a department dedicated to handling the issues of former government members.

The narrow boundary between Frelimo and the state machinery is a decisive aspect. Legally, the 1990 constitution envisaged separation between party and state and professionalisation of the civil service. Consistent with this, concrete signs of Frelimo's presence in the state machinery, for instance, its flags, party and ideological departments in organigrams, party documentation, and party

personnel on the civil service payroll, were rolled back, but, at odds with a meritocratic system, the state machinery remains highly acquiescent to Frelimo. Rønning (2011: 5) observes that in reality 'the "separation" of state and party has strengthened Frelimo's influence over the state'. The *Country Report of the African Peer Review Mechanism* (2010: 103) describes a 'conflation of party into state':

> [T]he CRM was inundated with reports that Frelimo cells or units exist in all public institutions, where they operate with official sanction. Indeed, members are permitted to suspend work in order to attend party meetings when these are scheduled in working hours.… Compulsory deductions are made from workers' salaries for the benefit of Frelimo when authorized by the relevant party organs.

Thus, Mozambique represents a typical case of a politically controlled state bureaucracy, which views its main mandate as defence of the dominant party's political agenda. While there is no evidence as to how effective the Frelimo party cells in the state machinery are, the broad acquiescence of this machinery in relation to Frelimo turns the state into the logistical base for the party's political and electoral activities. For example, the planning and finance directorate of Inhambane province published a tender notice in the daily pro-government paper *Notícias* in May 2008 for the provision of campaign material (8,000 T-shirts and 10,000 pennants) for Frelimo. Frelimo deploys cadres to ensure that the state machinery is put at the service of the party, with civil servants in managerial positions doing the party's work not only to maintain their positions but because they believe that their positions depend on Frelimo remaining in power. Frelimo's strong organisational capacity is embedded not only in the legacy of the one-party state but also, and importantly, in the acquiescence of the state machinery to the party, in relation to logistical matters and to information that is made available to the party and the fact that the party's political and electoral objectives become policy priorities at provincial and district levels.

President Guebuza indicated in his speech after the promulgation of the electoral results by the constitutional council on 30 December 2014 that he was impressed by the fact that ministers, national directors and permanent secretaries had left the comfort of their homes in cities and spent 45 days in rural villages campaigning for Frelimo. These high-level politicians and civil servants used not only state resources but the powers of the state for Frelimo's benefit, meaning that Frelimo's much-vaunted party machinery is, in fact, state machinery.

Another factor contributing to Frelimo's retention of power is that its name continues to resonate with a significant portion of the population as synonymous with the liberation struggle, which has been astutely turned into what Melber (2009: 451) has termed 'a myth … and permanent institution'. Frelimo uses this association to claim, as it did in the 2004 and 2009 elections, that its victory is a national imperative. It also uses what Dorman (2006: 1092) calls the

'exclusionary language of (former) liberation movements' to, as Warner (1998) terms it, demonise the opposition.

As an institution, Frelimo is far more important than its leader of the moment. Politically, there are robust internal mechanisms for accountability. Two important instances illustrate this. First, after the 1999 presidential election, when President Chissano almost lost to Renamo's Afonso Dhlakama because of rampant corruption, a state lethargy and a dwindling ability to mobilise voters, President Chissano was told at the 2002 party congress not to stand in 2004, despite the fact that he had the right to one more term and wanted to assert that right. However, he accepted the party's decision and the then head of Frelimo's bench in parliament, Armando Guebuza, was elected the party's candidate and made general secretary of the party in order to have a platform from which to prepare for the presidential race. Ten years later, Guebuza, who had served his two terms, was hoping for a third by means of a constitutional amendment. This could easily have been achieved by Frelimo, since it has a sufficient majority in parliament. An ad hoc parliamentary committee for constitutional revision was formed and given a considerable budget. Media and civil society showed no sympathy for the move but more persuasive were the objections from within the party, which effectively put paid to the plan.

The fact that Frelimo is a well-resourced party is another important factor. Its business and financial arm, the SPI Gestão e Investimentos Lda, established in 1992, controls several companies and lucrative businesses, including state concessions, so that in the event of a loss of power, the party would retain a position of strength from which to contest the next elections, with a chance of returning to power. This money not only enables it to pay good salaries to its personnel throughout the country, it also funds internal organisational needs, including training.

Frelimo also benefits from its international relations. Throughout the liberation struggle, it received generous support from a diverse group of states and international organisations. To begin with, Ghana's Nkrumah and Tanzania's Nyerere were instrumental in its formation. At the beginning of the struggle, military training and weapons were initially provided by Algeria and later by Egypt, Somalia, Ghana and Guinea. However, the bulk of the support came from the socialist countries, the USSR and China. After independence and throughout the socialist era these two countries remained Frelimo's major allies, but it also managed to get support from the Scandinavian countries, Italy, the Netherlands and East Germany.

Regionally, as a response to South Africa's regional hegemony, Mozambique actively participated in the creation of the Southern African Development Cooperation Conference (SADCC) (1980–93), which later became the Southern African Development Conference (SADC), a politically driven response and 'defensive mechanism' formed by the frontline states, *Países da Linha da Frente*, namely Angola, Mozambique, Botswana, Tanzania and Zambia, and later joined and led by Zimbabwe.

Having played an important role in the struggle for independence by the Zimbabwe African National Union (ZANU), the ANC and the South West African People's Organisation (SWAPO), Frelimo solidified relations with Zimbabwe, South Africa and Namibia. So, regionally, it harvests considerable political support from relationships that date back to the liberation struggle. At the continental level, Frelimo received much political support from the then Organisation of African Unity. Moreover, good and long-lasting relations with Western international organisations and political parties have resulted in significant aid to Frelimo and the state before, throughout and after the civil war. All in all, Frelimo benefits from external relations built not only on the legacy of the liberation struggle but also on post-independence pragmatism, specifically its policy of neutrality in international affairs.

The seeds of prolonged rule have been and are being planted not only through the accumulation of money, but also through education. Since Frelimo's early days, education has been a central issue, with the organisation nurturing education in the liberated areas, *zonas libertadas*, of Cabo Delgado, Niassa and Tete, as well as in its camps in Tanzania as it prepared cadres for the challenges of post-liberation rule. After a long period of inactivity, a decade ago Frelimo revived the idea of Frelimo schools, creating private secondary schools in each province. These schools have the same curriculum as normal private schools, licensed by the ministry of education, but teachers are selected according to their political affiliation. Recently, Frelimo has set up its own private university, the Universidade Nachingwea, named after the historic military base at the time of the liberation struggle. This university offers the same courses as any other private university but, while its stated aim is increasing the supply of skilled labour in the country, it is believed its graduates will receive privileged treatment as applicants for employment in state institutions. Whether these schools and university will prolong Frelimo's rule for many more years remains to be seen, but Sara Rich Dorman (2006) contends that because of the inevitable passing of the founding fathers and historic members, who know and understand the hierarchy and respect party discipline, post-liberation governments come with an inbuilt 'expiry date'.

Conclusion

Frelimo's prolonged rule can be attributed to its success as a party. Having faced power- threatening crises, it has had the courage to make the changes necessary to save the state it created out of the territory it liberated. The first major steps towards its maintenance of power and its abandonment of Marxism-Leninism were the economic and political reforms of the mid-1980s. Subsequent talks with the former rebel movement (Frelimo's de facto abandonment of the negation of pluralism that had characterised it throughout the one-party era) were also part of the formula to save the political order it had built, though not before it had monopolised the name and history of the liberation struggle, and built the basis of the state during the one-party era.

Without necessarily abandoning the exclusionary logic towards the opposition and critics, which is inherent in former liberation movements, Frelimo adhered to the principles of multiparty competition and its prolonged rule has been secured through relatively democratic elections. Considering its non-democratic roots and its claim to be the embodiment of the national will, its respect for the constitution has further helped to make Frelimo a party popular with the people.

Given its objectives after independence and a 16-year civil war, Frelimo has done well politically and socioeconomically. While its founding fathers and historic members unilaterally privatised businesses soon after the death of President Samora Machel, there is still some sense of historic mission to improve the living standards of the people, particularly those in rural areas. The reaffirmation in the party's statutes that the next major goal is economic development attests to this and, importantly, links the current Frelimo with the once principled former liberation movement.

The image of internal unity presented to the public, and the institutional mechanisms for internal democracy and the internal checks and balances, inspire confidence in the people Frelimo governs. However, it is its control of the state that – in biasing the civil service towards Frelimo, keeping tensions within the party at bay and in turning state machinery into the logistical base for its political and electoral agenda – ensures Frelimo's prolonged rule.

Notes

1 Its first congress, named the congress of unity, *congresso da unidade*, was held between 23 and 28 September 1962 in Dar-es-Salam, Tanzania.
2 Manu, led by Mattew Mole and Lawrence Milingo Malinga, was a movement formed essentially by Makonde migrants in Kenya and Tanzania. It was the only movement that operated within the colony – other movements operated from overseas. The Mueda massacre in June 1960 targeted a crowd of Manu supporters who had gathered in front of the administrator's office to submit a petition demanding independence (Newitt 1995: 450).
3 Udenamo's founders were Mozambican emigrants living in the former Southern Rhodesia (Zimbabwe), most of whom were from the former colonial districts of Manica and Sofala. However, its president, Adelino Gwambe, was born in Inhambane, southern Mozambique, and worked in Beira, the old capital of Manica and Sofala district, before emigrating to Southern Rhodesia.
4 Unami, led by Balthazar da Costa Changonga from the then district of Tete, was formed in 1961 in Malawi, mainly by natives of the same district.
5 Assimilated status was theoretically to be granted upon application to any African who demonstrated that he was 18, employed, and able to read, write and speak Portuguese (Opello Jr 1975: 69).
6 The first revolt occurred at the Mozambique Institute in Dar-es-Salaam in March 1968, with students refusing to combine educational training with military activity. The second occurred in May 1968, when a group of Makonde marched on the Frelimo office in Dar-es-Salaam, resulting in the closure of Frelimo offices by the Tanzanian police. The third occurred a few days after the second, when some 20 men armed with pangas again invaded the Frelimo office, resulting in one death and five people injured (Opello Jr 1975).
7 Chissano won 52 per cent of the vote and Dlhakama 48 per cent (Nuvunga and Salih 2010), with some 300,000 votes invalidated.

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6 From Cabral's liberation movement to power struggle and ideological erosion

The decline of PAIGC in Guinea-Bissau

Birgit Embaló

> The problem of the nature of the state created after independence is perhaps the secret of the failure of African independence.
>
> (Amílcar Cabral: 'Connecting the Struggles')

Introduction

The aim of this chapter is to examine the performance of PAIGC (*Partido Africano para a Independência de Guiné-Bissau e Cabo Verde*) after achieving state power. The challenges liberation movements face when they have to go beyond the 'politics of liberation'[1] and undergo a profound transformation to civil governance will be discussed based on the case of Guinea-Bissau. Forty-two years after independence, where does Guinea-Bissau stand in terms of governance, state-building and democracy? How did the agenda of 'revolutionary' nationalism work itself out in the politics of the postcolonial governments?

Previous analysis of African liberation movements has shown that this transformation process is often characterised by great difficulties. The performance of liberation movements as government bodies does not correspond to the idealised images of the political order they have been portraying. Instead, most end up installing one party and authoritarian regimes (cf. Melber 2003: xiv–xv; Southall 2013: 1).

PAIGC and the struggle for national liberation

Founded clandestinely in 1956 and led by members of the Crioulo elite, it was not until the end of 1961 that PAIGC opted for armed struggle. By 1965, the liberation movement controlled about 50 per cent of the countryside with about one-third of the population and by the end of the 1960s about two-thirds of the national territory and 50 per cent of the population was under its control (Lobban and Mendy 1997: 251–53).

The 'liberated zones' formed the basis for the political, educational and health infrastructures built up by PAIGC. Moreover, within those zones a system of people's stores providing basic commercial barter exchanges was

introduced. Medical and educational services were enlarged and further consolidated in the late 1960s. FARP (People's Revolutionary Armed Forces) was created in 1964 and subjected to strict political control by the Political Bureau. PAIGC was recognised as the only legitimate liberation movement by socialist and north European countries, the Vatican (1970) and finally the United Nations (1972) (as against rival organisations such as FLING).

Amílcar Cabral's vision of nation- and state-building

The political and military organisation and the social, educational and economic infrastructure installed by PAIGC, rudimentary though it was, has been interpreted as the essence of independent Guinea-Bissau (see Chabal 1983/2002: 1956–57, Davidson 1981: 85). The postcolonial order envisaged by Cabral was based on social justice and equal distribution of wealth, and primarily built on modernised agriculture as adapted to Guinean reality. Visiting the liberated areas in 1970, Swedish political scientist Lars Rudebeck noted: 'There can be no doubt that the PAIGC today is a revolutionary movement building a new society with broad popular support, and a small but well-organized people's army' (Rudebeck 1972: 4–5). Other analysts adopted a more critical stance, arguing that the structures established in liberated zones were created out of sheer necessity to support the armed struggle, and were not primarily intended to serve as structures beyond liberation from colonialism (Dhada 1993: 131–38). However, a UN special mission visited the liberated areas in April 1972 and praised the efforts of the PAIGC in health and education (see UN 1972). The status of women had also improved in terms of active female participation in social and political life.[2]

Cabral was convinced the colonial system had to be destroyed and its very structures not carried over into the postcolonial era (Cabral 1973: 83). A complete system change had to be initiated by creating the nucleus of a new state of Guinea-Bissau through armed, political and cultural struggle in the liberated areas. Institution-building with and for the people in those areas during the armed struggle, not in a distant future after independence, was Cabral's practical answer to the question of how these new embryonic instruments would unfold and function in a participatory bottom-up approach (Gibson 2013: 25). Examples of this model of people's power ('revolutionary democracy') were the local governance structures and social programmes that were instituted: village committees, people's courts, agricultural production, women's empowerment and education and health.[3] The barter system was intended to de-link the liberated areas from the colonially dominated economy. Armed militants were taught farming techniques to improve local food production for the benefit of peasants and militants (Cabral 1973: 84; Chabal 1983/2002: 110–13; Gibson 2013: 19).

Of particular importance was the educational system that the PAIGC initiated in the form of village and pilot schools (Chabal 1983/2002: 115–18). Village elementary schools were a favourite target of Portuguese bombing. Heavily dependent on foreign aid and suffering from a shortage of materials and

qualified staff, such schools were, nevertheless, crucial to nurturing the political consciousness of the children and young people about their living conditions and about PAIGC values and to teach to a level of knowledge sufficient for making societal progress possible (Chabal 1983/2002: 115–17).

The village committee, comprising five villagers, two of them women, was meant as a basic organisational unit and representation of the state at the local level. It was undoubtedly the most important element in the political organisation of the liberated areas, guaranteeing the participation of the village population in the war effort and organisationally integrating local governance. The number of effective village committees was quite considerable. 'It is probably here that Cabral was able to evolve the most original and effective solutions to the question of political mobilisation and participation' (Chabal 1983/2002: 109).

The political participation of ordinary people was made possible, even before independence, through the first elections that took place in the liberated zones in 1972. They paved the way for the first historic meeting of the *Assembleia Nacional Popular* (National Popular Assembly) on 23–24 September 1973, culminating in the declaration of independence (Lobban and Mendy 1997: 254–55).

Cabral was deeply concerned about the unity of the leading ranks of the PAIGC, mainly urban-based intellectuals, many of them of Cape Verdean origin, and the peasantry (see Amado 2011: 376–77). He believed that unity was possible between the party leadership, rooted in the petit bourgeoisie but freeing itself of narrow class interests and perspectives, and the pauperised rural people, who, through political education, could become real actors in the liberation struggle. In 'The Weapon of Theory' (a speech delivered in Havana 1966), Cabral underlined that the petit bourgeoisie party leadership, although struggling for national independence, might well betray the social revolution in the future (Cabral 1969: 110). At this point, the PAIGC leader already recognised that the greatest threat to liberation could come from leading figures within the movement.

Obviously, these internal threats proved too strong, for Cabral was assassinated on 20 January 1973 as part of a plot against revolutionary thinking. This episode reflected the inner tensions and ideological divisions within PAIGC, particularly over the dominance of the Cape Verdean leadership and possible unity between the islands and Guinea-Bissau. Violence and radical persecution were the only answers of the militarised party towards its enemies. Many political dissidents from the 'nationalist' PAIGC wing were killed without proof of individual complicity in Cabral's assassination.

Although a severe setback for PAIGC, the premature loss of Cabral did not result in the breaking up of the liberation movement. On the contrary, with the launching of Operation Amilcar Cabral and the seizure of the Portuguese fortress of Guiledje in March 1973, the liberation movement demonstrated its determination to fight until final victory. On the eve of independence, significant progress had been made in the liberated areas in terms of education, health and political participation, notwithstanding the war circumstances and the limited resources at hand.[4] However, Cabral's vision of collective farming

and agricultural cooperatives did not materialise. Subsistence agricultural production persisted and the failure to bring about change was seen by Cabral as a fundamental failure of political mobilisation (cf. Chabal 1983/2002: 110–14).

The state-in-the-making in the liberated territories was not fully consolidated or mature enough to rise to the many political, administrative and economic challenges facing postcolonial nation- and state-building.

PAIGC in power (1973–94)

Consolidation of the nation state

Article 4 of the first constitution of Guinea-Bissau confirmed that power should emanate from the (working) masses in strict collaboration with the ruling PAIGC party. However, de facto this transfer of power to the people never happened, even in the period of democratisation after 1994. PAIGC remained the leading force in society and the highest expression of the sovereign will of the people. The party represented a higher political authority than the elected National Popular Assembly, the supposedly paramount state organ. Party dominance was assured by the personal union of party and state leadership positions (Rudebeck 1974: 150ff). Party and state fused into the 'one-party state' without any firewall between party, executive power, the legislative sphere and public institutions.

At independence, the circumstances were too complex to allow for the transfer of the political model in the liberated areas to the whole nation. Even though PAIGC had moved forward after the assassination of Cabral, there were much deeper challenges, namely the capacity of the collective party leadership to provide ideological and practical guidance on the unfolding revolutionary process and post-independence state-building (Manji and Fletcher 2013: 10). The party lacked the intellectual resources to reflect on the nature of the colonial state and on how the postcolonial state should differ from it.

Once in power, PAIGC faced overwhelming and critical challenges: consolidation of the nation state within the colonial borders as well as state-building and economic development from within. Especially in terms of its operating structure, political relationships similar to the previous system were retained: i.e. power relations were fundamentally asymmetrical, with marked contrasts between power-holders and subordinates. Aspects of the colonial system were reproduced in the struggle for their abolition and subsequently in the governance concepts applied in the postcolonial conditions (cf. Melber 2002: 5).

The party took over and adapted structures left behind by the Portuguese instead of implementing the 1973 constitution, which had envisioned the creation of a democratic, decentralised people's state (Galli 1987: 53). The social consensus established during the armed struggle and the moral values it generated could not withstand the transformation of PAIGC into the executive authority of the state. Certainly, there were also objective conditions hampering Cabral's political vision from becoming reality.

The transfer of almost all personnel and operations to Bissau after independence delinked PAIGC's revolutionary leadership from its rural base. Leading PAIGC officials and fighters who came to the capital after independence focused on improving their personal and party status, instead of living up to Cabral's example of human decency and defending his political principles. PAIGC cadres were preoccupied with the attractions of city life and with factional and interpersonal conflicts in the party and military. These developments marked the death blow to Cabral's vision of a participatory and socialist popular democracy.

From a pragmatic standpoint, there was no other option to PAIGC's decision to take over Bissau as capital. Bissau had a fairly large population of about 100,000, and almost all experienced administrative personnel were concentrated there. All significant economic installations and transport and communication facilities were located in and around the capital. However, the decision to maintain Bissau as capital[5] was also taken in the interests of PAIGC survival. The power vacuum left by the departing Portuguese had to be filled. Massive concentration of the PAIGC and governing bodies in Bissau offered the best underpinning of the party's claims to be the sole representative of the Bissau-Guinean people as against rival 'liberation movements'.

PAIGC faced serious problems in running the state, as there were very few fighters and war commanders qualified for their new tasks. Without previous governance experience, the party had to rely on what was left of the colonial bureaucracy, specifically its middle and minor civil servants, to discharge administrative responsibilities effectively. These civil servants belonged mainly to the urban Crioulo class, among which most of the leading party figures also originated. Thus PAIGC perpetuated colonial centralism and served foremost the interests of the Crioulo elite of Bissau (see Lopes 1982: 20–55).

From the early days of the liberation struggle, there had been tension between the military and political command structure.[6] The foundation and evolution of the state of Guinea-Bissau was strongly linked to FARP, the military structure of the one-party state regime. In the early stages of nation-building, the submission of the military to civilian authorities was not on the party's agenda: everyone considered himself a politician and FARP became part of the governing body (Embaló 2012: 60). To be a good fighter or a high-level official in FARP was even an important prerequisite for promotion into political office.

During the first years of independence and during the regime of President Vieira, the military participated directly in political power, holding important positions in the legislative and executive branches. There was no clear distinction between the exercise of military and political power. Liberation fighters viewed themselves as the sole legitimate candidates for state office and resources. Their claim to power was apparently permanent, not only because of the rightness of their cause but also because of their peculiar and legitimate entitlement to it (cf. Clapham 2012: 6). Even now, decades after independence, war veterans base their claims to pension benefits on the sacrifices they made during the liberation war.

The struggle for national liberation had united the people of Guinea-Bissau across tribal lines and ethnic differences. Liberation became the founding myth of the new nation state and a central strand in its identity. To become more robust and durable, that initial unity would have had to go much further in: (a) weakening ethnic boundaries and integrating different ethnically based local cultures and perceptions of political order and; (b) bringing the propagated values of the new nation state, namely social justice, equal distribution of wealth and human dignity – and an end to exploitation – to the rural majority.

PAIGC was uncompromising in its approach to internal plurality. Any opposition or dissent was considered hostile and critics were branded as enemies of the people and the national interest. The latter served to justify all kinds of authoritarian practice. Identification with one's homeland was denied to so-called 'enemies' of independence. They were treated as a threat to unity, not as an integral part of a plural politics. There was no attempt to bring them into the national family or to achieve national reconciliation. On the contrary, commanders of Portugal's colonial troops were persecuted and some were killed. Traditional authorities who had collaborated with the colonial state (mainly Fula and Manjaco) were collectively accused of treason and conspiracy and many were publicly executed, without regard for their individual cases. There thus ensued 'a long chain of retaliatory violence, vengeance and counter-vengeance' (Von di Paz 2010: 36) which hardened the divisions among Bissau-Guineans.

Socioeconomic development

Portuguese colonialism had left Guinea-Bissau destitute, for it had neither modern agriculture nor a modern industrial sector. From the early days of independence, the state apparatus was seen as the only modern economic sector, and therefore considered an attractive source of jobs.

Reflecting the colonial ideology of superiority, modernisation and progress, 'development' in PAIGC's vision had to be brought from the urban centres to the *djinte de matu* (bush people) in the countryside (Galli 1987: 133). Unlike Cabral's vision of an adapted and integrative approach to agriculture development, development was thought of in purely economic terms as modernisation of agriculture and industrialisation, thereby mimicking concepts privileged by development agencies at that time. The peasants of the liberation war, a major pillar in Cabral's liberation ideology, were completely neglected in this development scenario.

Investments made by PAIGC and its development policy were not adjusted to the needs of the dominant agriculture sector and its transformation from subsistence to market-oriented production that would induce growth and later larger-scale modernisation (Schiefer 1986: 179–81). Economic development under President Luíz Cabral followed the pattern of a socialist planned economy through monopolisation of trade in primary products. Strict controls were placed on internal and external trade, resulting in low prices for local agricultural goods, little if any sustainable rural development and massive food imports.

Political power and political participation

PAIGC wanted to induce change through the political and ideological mobilisation of the people. The educational system and the village committees were among the most important mechanisms and dynamic institutions on the local level (Aaby 1978: 13). The party expected to integrate the rural population, local social and political interest groups, traditional leaders and village elders as well as veterans in villages who were unrecognised for their national contributions. Apparently, however, from the beginning PAIGC was unable to bring these diverse groups and people together in the Guinean nation-building project. With political power centralised in the hands of a small Crioulo faction in Bissau, PAIGC failed to institute a social and political system clearly oriented towards the poor majority and failed to narrow the enormous social and economic gap between the two groups. This tendency was aggravated by PAIGC's economic policies, which neglected peasant needs and production structures.

In many regions, village committees had become fairly well accepted as local representatives of the state. Concentrating power, party cadres and capacities in Bissau resulted in the disintegration of the party and state organisation in rural areas. The village committees were now at the bottom of a 'pyramidal state structure in which their main function was to transmit directives from above' (Galli 1987: 3). Two large and important rural groups were excluded from political decision-making, social influence and the nation-building project. The Balanta of the south, who had massively supported the liberation army and had made the most sacrifices during the liberation war, were barely honoured by the PAIGC, instead being looked upon as simple rice cultivators and 'peasants of the bush' (Van der Drift 2000: 161–64). The Fula were widely excluded from participation in the making of an independent Guinea-Bissau as some of their leading families had collaborated openly with the colonial military and administration (Carvalho 2005: 164).

Increasingly hierarchical party and state structures and the exclusion of peasants from development resulted in the gradual distancing of that population group from the one-party state in Bissau. Only a few postcolonial village committees worked effectively as the bridging institution between state and rural society,[7] while local leadership continued to be a decisive sociopolitical force in rural society, within or parallel to the village committees.

Urban social and political forces, with PAIGC at the forefront, dismissed these manifestations of local identity. The culture and social organisation of rural communities did not fit in easily with the ideals of equity, education and freedom PAIGC was proclaiming. The party considered these institutions as expressions of 'tribalism' and neglected them (Carvalho 2005: 162). PAIGC did not abide by the understanding of Cabral, who had stressed 'the need for a detailed and careful analysis of cultural differences between and within ethnic groups, linking the failure to grasp these with the political mistakes committed by so many nationalist movements in Africa' (Chabal 1983/2002: 184).

Political mass participation was ensured through socialist-style mass organisations, such as JAAC (Amilcar Cabral African Youth), OPAD (Organisation of the Pioneers of Abel Djassi) and the National Workers' Trade Union (UNTG), the latter firmly integrated into the party. The mass organisation of women, UDEMU, had mobilised women during the liberation struggle and continued to be an instrument of the party's socialist ideology. The mass organisations followed a strict top-down approach and were first and foremost instruments by which the party could exercise control over the population.

With independence, mass education (see Embaló 2008: 117–20) was pursued, with schools being opened in city neighbourhoods and central villages with the aim of gradually providing equal access to primary and secondary schools nationwide. An educational revolution started, nourished by the political will to leave behind the colonial past and establish new paradigms in education. However, PAIGC took on a commitment that exceeded its capacity, given the poor educational structures left by the colonial state (the only secondary school at that time being in Bissau). PAIGC was in no position to respond to the new challenges, especially given the alarming lack of professors and school infrastructure. Socialist propaganda and revolutionary education concepts came to eclipse the financial and human capacity of the state to build schools everywhere in the country.

Military coup of Nino Vieira and personalisation of power

As soon as the external enemy (colonialism) was defeated, internal cleavages and rivalry over top leadership positions in PAIGC began to dominate the political arena. Power struggles among the new political and administrative cadres over state resources and potential sources of income emerged right from the start of the postcolonial era in Guinea-Bissau (Mendes de Carvalho 2009: 2–3). This prepared the ground for the neopatrimonial governance system that emerged over time.

The economic situation in Guinea-Bissau had badly deteriorated by 1980. There was socialist propaganda, mass organisations and school indoctrination, but there was no socialist redistribution of wealth. The first years of independence had already witnessed a widening gap between the rich elite from the upper echelons of the party and *praça* and a generally impoverished population (Vigh 2006: 44–45). The discrepancy between a governing elite living in ostentatious luxury and a population deprived of even basic goods was completely unacceptable, given the innumerable sacrifices so many people had made in the national liberation struggle. The one-party state proved totally incapable of resolving the population's main problems, including in 1980 a rice crisis and food shortages, particularly in the cities.

Ideological divisions in PAIGC between the Cape Verde faction and the Guinean nationalist faction over the ties between the two countries, as well as discontent in the armed forces over a new promotion system resulted in a military coup against President Cabral in 1980, led by the famous war

commander João Bernado (Nino) Vieira.[8] Claiming to 'bring back the party to the revolutionary line' (*movemento reajustador*), Nino Vieira began to govern the country in authoritarian style. This first coup resulted in the direct occupation of the presidency, the highest office, by a military leader. A revolutionary council, comprised predominantly of loyal Balanta and Papel officers (Nino himself being Papel) was established as the highest governing body. The guidance of the ruling PAIGC was not questioned, but the military gained 'a much more significant political role than it had enjoyed under the previous regime' (Forrest 1992: 58).

President Vieira consolidated his power within the party, the army and the state by various means. He cut the strong links to Cape Verde and put a definite end to the 'bi-nationalist' project. His widespread popularity and legitimacy among soldiers helped him to manage the urgent political and economic demands of the army for some time, and he did not open up high party and government posts to Balanta officers, who had for long expected such rewards (see Forrest 1992: 60–61). In view of the deteriorating economic conditions, various coup attempts ensued between 1982 and 1987 (see Nóbrega 2003: 232–53). Adopting an attitude of zero tolerance, Vieira used these episodes as a pretext to eliminate his (supposed) political enemies, foremost Balanta, one by one and faction by faction.[9]

By the mid-1980s, President Vieira exerted significant control over government and party. All national power was concentrated in the office of the president, who became head of a state council that was directly appointed and controlled by him. This phase was characterised by increased personalisation of power at the expense of party decision-making (Forrest 1992: 60–61). Vieira further consolidated his personal power within the army, party and state by building patronage networks financed by the privatisation and embezzlement of state resources and based on oscillating alliances between military and civil political actors. The president managed to impose himself on all conflicting constellations, whether of an inter-elite nature or involving civil and military rivals. He provided a model for Guinean leaders of how to accumulate power and enrich oneself based on creating and interacting with neopatrimonial networks of dependents.

Following the kingship model of African agricultural societies, President Vieira implemented a system for the central redistribution of (state) resources (see Schiefer 2002: 61). Wrapped in socialist rhetoric, his appropriation of such resources was chiefly directed at increasing personal wealth and power, not the benefit of those most in need. De facto President Vieira built up patronage networks for the defence of his personal political and economic interests, based on support by friendly officers. This neopatrimonial model appears to have been the central power mechanism of the ruling elite of Guinea-Bissau and enabled it to dominate key state functions.

The economic liberalisation of the second half of the 1980s, imposed by the World Bank and IMF, strengthened the urban elites by concentrating wealth in their hands. Privatised commercial farms (*pontas*) belonging to this elite, which

had close ties with the government, received substantial international grants. Having already brought the army under his control, President Vieira strengthened his ties with the urban Crioulo class that most benefited from economic liberalisation[10] by further promoting them into higher echelons of the military and into top positions within the PAIGC leadership (see Djalo 2000: 30). In so doing, Nino Vieira reinforced his patronage networks, that is, 'systems based on personalized structures of authority where patron-client relationships operate behind a façade of ostensibly rational state bureaucracy' (Taylor and Williams 2008: 137). The president also reached out to traditional authorities in the countryside, rehabilitating and integrating them into his networks.[11]

Democratic openings and civil war (1991–99)

Political openings in the early 1990s did not develop from within Bissau-Guinean society because of the regime's violence and intimidation: instead it was brought about by pressure from international donors. Before that time, opposition groups could only operate from abroad.[12] The constitution was changed in May 1991 to allow for political pluralism and freedom of expression and association. Article IV, which had defined the PAIGC as the sole political movement, was repealed, marking the end of one-party rule. Although now officially separated from PAIGC, the armed forces were not depoliticised or seriously reformed.

Political liberation was largely orchestrated by the political elite, particularly the president and PAIGC, which was not genuinely interested in pluralistic change and tried to manipulate the democratisation process in its own interests (Ostheimer 1999: 36). After the democratic opening-up, political parties mushroomed in Guinea-Bissau, as in many other African countries, with little to distinguish parties in ideological terms and programmes beyond a common 'development' discourse. These parties were and are largely unable to articulate the demands of the population (Chabal 1996: 65). The National Front for the Liberation of Guinea (FLNG) and the Resistance of Guinea-Bissau – Movement of Bafata (RGB-MB) were the only ones not founded by PAIGC dissidents. Most of the other parties were created by younger PAIGC members who wished to democratise the movement from within but faced resistance from an older generation intent on defending its privileges and position.

PAIGC could maintain a position of superiority and was in effect the only party with the membership and infrastructure to campaign nationwide in the first elections of 1994 (Ostheimer 1999: 47, 92). However, it failed to carry out the *structural transition* towards internal democratisation and political dialogue within its ranks. Competition among different groups and increasing factionalism were and still are the most obvious result of the 'new era of freedom'. Personal differences among PAIGC senior officials increasingly overshadowed the first democratic period in Guinea-Bissau (1994–98). The main split within PAIGC was between those who favoured Nino and those who did not. No consensus was possible, thereby allowing President Vieira to continue with his authoritarian rule.

In these first years, the democratic transformation of the political system in Guinea-Bissau was purely a formal process and did not translate into all-encompassing and genuine democratisation with broad mass support (Cardoso 2001: 241–46). The outbreak of war in 1998–99 relates directly to the incapacity of the ruling party to transform itself into a responsible democratic body. Neglect of the economic needs of the army, culminating in the dismissal of the army chief (Ansumané Mané) by President Vieira over accusations of illegal weapon trafficking with Casamance rebels, triggered the '7 June War' in 1998. These events in Guinea-Bissau show how democratisation may reinforce or escalate conflicts, if it does keep pace with the capacity of institutions to absorb conflict.

Belated democratisation and PAIGC's inner decline (2000–15)

Postwar elections held on 28 November 1999 brought victory to the main opposition parties, PRS (Party of Social Renovation) and RGB-BM. Finally, the 25 years of PAIGC rule was broken and the election opened a new era of democratic rule in Guinea-Bissau. Subsequently, on 16 January 2000, PRS candidate Kumba Yalá, supported by large numbers of the people of Guinea-Bissau eager to break with the past, won the presidential election.

However, the population rapidly became dissatisfied as the country fell back into severe economic and political crises. Kumba Yalá's prime ministers and governments changed continuously, and the public administration and army were paralysed, since salaries for public servants and soldiers went unpaid for months. In November 2002, Yalá dissolved parliament and governed by presidential decree, and in 2003 he thrice postponed legislative elections. The weakness of the democratic institutions and the continuing fragmentation of the opposition parties helped Yalá stay in power, despite his incapacity to rule (Embaló 2012: 16–17; Frempong 2005: 15). Not surprisingly, by September 2003 the grievances had escalated to the point where the government was toppled by the military (Embaló 2012: 16–17). After this disastrous PRS interlude, PAIGC won back power in the elections of 2004.

Various parliamentary elections (1999–2000, 2004, 2008, 2014) have been concluded successfully thanks to massive technical and financial support from the international community and a fully responsive electorate. Despite the establishment of legitimate governments and institutions, the ruling elite – largely represented by or closely linked with PAIGC – has failed to produce stable governments, a reform agenda that would allow for profound reconciliation, true political and institutional rebuilding and viable socioeconomic development. Elections have served the elites primarily in creating an impression of sufficient legitimacy to attract more development funds.

How is it possible that 20 years after the first multiparty democratic elections, after a civil war that left thousands dead, after two military coups in 2003 and 2012 and various failed military interventions, the former sole party is still the

major political force in the country, dominating executive and legislative power, domestic politics and the country's economy? And this is so even though, political analysts argue, the country slides into profound crisis whenever PAIGC has an absolute majority, as the greatest difficulty for PAIGC seems to be the management of victory after successful election campaigns (*Gazeta de Notícias* 2015).

The political system of Guinea-Bissau is characterised by belated institutional democratisation. After 30 years of formally implementing democracy in Guinea-Bissau, no progress towards substantive democracy has been achieved. Elections have not been accompanied by the institutionalisation and national appropriation of democratic values, norms and rules. The incomplete democratic transition from one-party rule to multiparty pluralism has resulted in a minimal, formal democratic system. Strong democratic institutions and political parties that could bring the people and state nearer to democracy are lacking. Guinea-Bissau is trapped in meeting electoral obligations but largely failing to move beyond democratic procedure. Democratic institution-building is still at an initial stage and often a merely formal response to the concepts and norms of democracy and the rule of law.

Given the country's dysfunctional political system, PAIGC is still the dominant ruling party. There are roughly 40 opposition parties, but they have not brought about more democracy, as most of them are small and have no grassroots foundations, and none has the capacity to strongly challenge the government (Voz di Paz 2010: 34). Most parties are in practice just an apparatus and framework for achieving the objectives of particular interest groups, and lack coherence, a programmatic approach and cohesive internal discipline (Ostheimer 2001: 2–3). Moreover, opposition parties are unable or unwilling to unite to form a common front against the dominant PAIGC (see Chabal 1996; Rudebeck 2001).

President Vieira was re-elected president in 2005. This sounds like a paradox, but his re-election is the most significant reflection of belated democratisation in Guinea-Bissau. Desperately seeking political stability, the electorate was mainly motivated by illusions of an allegedly brighter past. People voted for PAIGC in 2004 and for the ousted former president in 2005 in the absence of any credible democratic alternative. Thus, voters further cemented and legitimised the hegemony of PAIGC and Vieira through the ballot box. Vieira was able to drive out Prime Minister Carlos Gomes Junior, responsible for the confiscation of Vieira's assets after the war, and put three different prime ministers in office in quick succession. Slow but steady corrosion of PAIGC, further internal party struggles and factionalism characterise this period, which also saw alliances between members of the PRS and pro-Vieira PAIGC dissidents.

Democratic credibility has been lost in the so-called democratisation of Guinea-Bissau due to constant intra- and inter-party quarrels between PAIGC and opposition parties and in parliament. President Vieira was assassinated in March 2009, and none of the presidents or prime ministers that came to power after 2008 had the capacity to induce substantial change in the party and political system. Despite PAIGC's persistently poor performance, the electorate,

deeply concerned about the chronic instability of Guinea-Bissau, has continued to vote in favour of the party (in 2004, 2008 and 2014) and its prime ministerial candidates. Carlos Gomes Junior (2008) and Domingos Simão Pereira (2014) were both perceived as relatively strong and reliable politicians by the time of their election. Obviously, clear mandates and clear majorities that allow governing without coalition partners are still seen as the solution to the country's ongoing disarray.

Rather than governing in the interests of the population at large, PAIGC spurs on a patronage system linked to Bissau's tiny commercial class. While the rural population continues to survive by traditional subsistence farming, the state has become a purely self-serving entity. A mix of formality and informality has been institutionalised throughout the state, with PAIGC having the lion's share of ministers, government officials, senior civil servants, etc. Formal and informal structures reinforce one another and the distinction between the public and private sphere is blurred. People in power abuse public resources, services and property for personal gain, and state institutions have lost credibility, responsibility and accountability. Continuous crisis and conflict in Guinea-Bissau, particularly within PAIGC, are related to the persistence of these elite neopatrimonial networks grounded in the party and state structures.

PAIGC's leadership struggles and factionalism continue to be the most important threat to the democratic political culture and impede the inner reform of the party. Because PAIGC was so hegemonic at independence, the political culture within the party has been replicated in all state structures. In almost every PAIGC government, conflict between president and prime minister dominates politics. PAIGC often seems to be a conglomerate of rival leaders and divergent factions, lacking a common ideology and unifying political principles (Clapham 2012: 6). It is doubtful that PAIGC is more than a tactical electoral alliance. Internal tensions may erupt at any time, since factional competition, inner fragmentation and ideological erosion are ongoing. This process may even escalate into open conflict among the PAIGC leadership and the formation of new parliamentary majorities with other parties.

However, since the inception of democracy, PAIGC has sought to avoid losing power. No matter how much the party's legitimacy and governance capacity have deteriorated, its leaders employ a range of (often repressive) measures to cling to power. PAIGC also still appropriates the symbols of national unity for its own purposes: for instance, the national flag is the party emblem. This is clearly a relic of the one-party-state system. Beyond that, belated party formation and a superficial understanding of the essence of multiparty democracy has helped PAIGC to dominate the political scene in almost every way. There is no reason to presume this will change in the near future.

Conclusion

The liberation movement was meant to institutionalise participatory (or revolutionary) democracy after capturing state power, but PAIGC did not undergo the

necessary historical transformation when the focus shifted to postcolonial nation-building and tackling underdevelopment, poverty, exploitation, etc. Political immaturity combined with lack of vision and an immense sense of entitlement characterised the party, which repeatedly fell back on evoking images of the glorious liberation struggle and the victory over colonialism. These images served as a pretext for PAIGC to stay in power seemingly forever, regardless of major performance and capacity shortfalls.

The PAIGC leadership style and governance structures have inhibited the emergence of a democratic political culture and institutions. Following the democratic opening up, the political and military elite has exploited the formal democratic system, its mechanisms and institutions in order to legitimise and sustain its power. The smallness of the ruling elite, linked by family and ethnic ties, and its constant reconfiguration through quickly shifting alliances have worked against the formation of larger political interest groups or true parties to create a national consensus about key questions. Conflicts within the political class of Guinea-Bissau 'are fought for a change within the agents holding positions of power rather than a change of the actual socio-political structure of power' (Vigh 2006: 70). The party is needed for accessing the centre of power and key state resources through formal and informal channels in order to keep the lucrative neopatrimonial networks running that are the main sources of personal enrichment for the tiny elite. Over time, the state has been divided among those people in need of the hegemonic PAIGC to shield them in their acts of corruption, robbery of public goods and 'criminalisation' of the state.

Cultivating the myth of the party of the liberators (*partido dos libertadores*) comes nowhere close to meeting Cabral's definition of liberation as an 'act of culture' and is even more impropriate for establishing democratic governance patterns. PAIGC has failed to develop a specific political and ideological framework that would allow for reaching beyond 'national liberation' by democratising the party from within and enabling the emergence of a patriotic national elite. On the contrary, PAIGC seems unable to replace the long-faded liberation project with a new one.

As of this writing, in January 2016, four factions are fighting for the leadership of PAIGC. None wants to leave the party. There should be no illusion about the decline and erosion of PAIGC or the fragility of the party system in Guinea-Bissau. Although it has a comfortable majority of over 60 per cent in the legislature, PAIGC is literarily breaking apart and collapsing. Recently, the government's main programme was rejected by the opposition plus 15 PAIGC members.

In closing, I turn to the Crioulo expression used in seeking hope: '*Cabral ka muri*!' (Cabral did not die!).

Notes

1 PAIGC saw national liberation as its minimum goal, whereas the broader and more comprehensive goal was liberation from the underdevelopment and neglect experienced under colonialism (Rudebeck 1974: 82).

2 See Urdang: Women participated in the liberation struggle as teachers, clinic directors, members of village committees, food providers and political commissioners.
3 Cabral 1973: 84; Chabal, 1983/2002: 110ff. The development of basic medical infrastructure by PAIGC was intended for liberation fighters and rural population alike.
4 I do not agree with Dhada (1993: 135–37), who argues that all the aspects of statehood-building were focused on the armed struggle and the pragmatic needs of the liberation war, and that the elections in the liberated areas were organised to convince the UN of the legitimacy of the PAIGC as sole national movement.
5 Cabral had proposed establishing the eastern town of Boé as the capital as a means of decentralisation and breaking with the colonial past.
6 For Cabral, the political education of freedom fighters was more important than their military qualification. In 1964, the PAIGC congress of Cassaca put an end to military attacks that had been carried out without political authorisation by clearly subjecting the military branch of the liberation movement to the PAIGC political bureau (Chabal 2002: 62, 77–82).
7 Village committees in the Gabu region were often regarded as alien institutions; in Balanta and Mandjaco villages local authority remained mainly in the hands of village-preferred leaders; in the Oio region and in the south the village committees were clearly dominated by leading local representatives and ruling clans (see Forrest 2003: 208–10; Frauenlob: 103–7; Rudebeck 1988: 210; Schiefer 2002: 115).
8 President Luíz Cabral promoted trusted soldiers close to him into the officer ranks. Balanta liberation fighters demanded to be compensated for their sacrifices with higher positions and better payment and supported Nino Vieira against President Cabral.
9 The politically motivated ethnic cleansing of the Balanta elite in 1985 caused ethnic withdrawal, the self-perception of the Balanta as victims and the cultivation of hatred.
10 As in other African countries, economic liberalisation had mainly negative impacts on the rural population, poor city dwellers, civil servants and the military (Cardoso 1996).
11 Under Nino Vieira, there was some ideological shift towards 'authentic Guinean culture' (Fernandes: 46; Jao: 129), but it was only with democratisation that the *régulo* system was partly re-established (Frauenlob: 80).
12 The 'Movimento de Bafata' of Fernando Gomes had been operating from Lisbon since the late 1980s.

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7 From anticolonial liberation movement to ruling party

The FLN in Algeria

Yahia H. Zoubir

Introduction

'Authoritarian developmentalist regimes' in Africa have often ended in failure, sometimes with disastrous long-term consequences. By the end of the 1980s, it had become increasingly apparent that national liberation movements that had succeeded in defeating colonial rulers and seizing power had not only failed in the modernising tasks they pledged to undertake, but, contrary to predictions, had, through their rule, led to impoverishment of the middle class and pauperisation of the masses in whose name they had fought.

Undeniably, some of these dictatorships achieved significant industrialisation and even modernisation, yet this relative success and the initial euphoria have been overshadowed by the widespread corruption, injustice, arbitrary power, nepotism and clientelism that have pervaded these states since independence. The long-held assumption that central planning under an authoritarian regime was the best path to rapid economic growth has been shattered in the face of the harsh realities resulting from two or three decades of such development. Furthermore, the conviction that countries with just one strong party were in a better position to modernise society has been disproved by the catastrophic results of such political systems.

The consequences of such development strategies – or rather of the way in which they have been executed – are dreadful. In addition to serious economic crises (inflation, astronomical international debt, high unemployment, etc.) authoritarian regimes have faced a crisis of credibility, legitimacy and identity. Power has been centralised in the hands of petit bourgeois elites, which have maintained their position through sheer force, corruption, clientelism, neopatrimonialism and almost absolute dictatorship. In the process, they have squandered the initial mobilising capacity of the liberation movement and failed to satisfy the ever-increasing demands of their populations. The successful populist discourse of the past has lost all credibility when confronted with these gloomy realities. Even if many of these regimes are still in power, the tacit social contract established after independence has lost legitimacy and dashed the hopes it generated. The petit bourgeois elite, no matter what its revolutionary credentials, has proven incapable of bringing about either capitalist economic development or revolutionary social transformation (Sharabi 1988: 9).

Unquestionably, the fragility of the authoritarian state in Africa had become visible by the 1980s. This weakness was demonstrated by the forceful new opposition to the single party rule by a multitude of social groups, especially radical Islamist organisations, and by the inability of these regimes to find viable political formulae to overcome the multi-dimensional crises, most of them the result of their inept rule. Although the impasse these regimes often faced both domestically and externally compelled them to introduce some degree of liberalisation and even democratisation, they have continued to cling to power without, however, improving socioeconomic conditions or instituting good governance, let alone democratic rule.

Numerous considerations have induced the former national liberation movements turned (single) ruling parties to embark on certain reforms. First, most of the states they rule continue to face daunting socioeconomic challenges, which have often caused violent upheavals against the regimes and/or ethnic conflict. While such cyclical unrest has given rise to selective democratic reforms, these party-regimes have not fundamentally changed power structures in their polities. Second, and more importantly, the failure to transform their societies by those parties that had gained legitimacy in the liberation struggle has undermined their authority to rule and even their *raison d'être*, compelling them to resort to repression and deception. When their survival is at stake, the ruling elites initiate timid political measures, whose underlying objective is not democratising the polity, but simply curbing social and political opposition. This explains the recurring upheavals aimed at removing inefficient and despotic rulers. In 1988, Algeria experienced probably one of the most consequential uprisings in Africa, and yet the postcolonial system the Front de Libération Nationale (FLN) put in place in 1962 remains virtually intact, its failures and obsolescence notwithstanding.

From national liberation movement to ruling party

Of all the national liberation movements in Africa, FLN probably resonated most among peoples under colonial rule across the globe. On 1 November 1954, the newly created FLN, which emerged following a split in the nationalist movement (Harbi 2003) that had first emerged in the 1920s (Kaddache 1993),[1] launched the Algerian war of liberation against French occupation (Horne 1987). The FLN and its armed wing, the National Liberation Army (ALN), fought a bloody, eight-year war against a very strong enemy, ultimately achieving the country's independence in July 1962. The war of liberation has had a lasting impact on the country's national identity and concrete consequences for the shape of post-independence Algerian politics.

FLN proclaimed that the objective of the struggle against France's colonial rule and settler colonisation was 'the restoration of the Algerian state, sovereign, democratic, and social, within the framework of the principles of Islam' and 'the preservation of fundamental freedoms, without distinction of race or religion' (Appel au peuple algérien 1954). FLN revolutionaries decided that

until independence was achieved, all existing political parties, such as the Democratic Union for the Algerian Manifesto (UDMA), the Algerian Communist Party (PCA) and the influential Association of Algerian Muslim Ulema (religious scholars), were to dissolve themselves and submit to the authority of the FLN: their integration into FLN would be not as parties but as individuals without affiliation to their parties of origin. In other words, FLN was a nationalist political party with hegemonic status and ambitions. Throughout the war (1954–62), FLN, which stressed that it was leading a democratic and popular revolution, called on Algerians to make sacrifices and repeated its promises of creating a democratic, egalitarian society in which justice would prevail. The promise to erect a democratic and social republic was reiterated at FLN's Soummam Congress in 1956 and, again, on the eve of independence in 1962, at the Tripoli Congress: 'The democratic spirit cannot be purely theoretical speculation. It must be embedded in well-defined state institutions and in all sectors of the country's social life' (Projet de Programme pour la réalisation de la révolution démocratique populaire 1962). The latter congress called for the creation of a modern state built on 'democratic, anti-imperialist and anti-feudal' foundations and 'a democratic party', FLN, capable of carrying out this task. Despite all the references to democracy and democratic principles, Algeria's new rulers established an authoritarian regime, which permitted no party other than FLN.

This chapter seeks to retrace the evolution of the political system put in place in postcolonial Algeria and assess whether it has fulfilled the social contract between rulers and governed, a contract based on trading democracy and a multiparty political system for socialist 'democratic' development and transition to a modern polity. The main argument is that the new rulers have built an authoritarian system in which 'socialist democracy' and 'power of the masses' has dominated political discourse, but which denied individual liberties in the name of socialist/collective freedom. The system, despite the vicissitudes it has experienced over more than 50 years, has remained intact: it has relied until today on the military (its backbone), the FLN party and the high administration to repress opposition. The main question is whether FLN succeeded in building the modern, democratic and socialist republic its leaders committed to. The chapter therefore will: (1) discuss the nature of the political system instituted after independence; (2) socioeconomic and political continuity and change since independence; (3) the obsolescence, inflexibility and failings of the system; and, (4) future prospects of the political system.

Algerian political system: one party – or military rule?

In Algeria, the postcolonial state became the locus of power and privilege immediately after independence. The new bureaucracy, whose members owed their positions to allegiance to patrons rather than to any degree of competence, symbolised the hypertrophy of the superstructure. Moreover, the postcolonial state purposely precluded the emergence of an autonomous civil society. Instead, the regime sought to establish total control over society. Power and control,

rather than the exercise of politics, dominated the system. In other words, the regime aimed at extinguishing genuine political participation while using a populist discourse that glorified the masses. In many ways, the petit bourgeoisie, which made up the bureaucracy, became the exclusive repository of the post-colonial state. Clans and clienteles were established within the structures of the authoritarian state. This was done secretly in order to preserve a monolithic appearance. The contradictions inherited from the wartime period were infused into the state. The political system established at the end of the war of independence reflected the nationalist movement's narrow and exclusive focus on independence, thereby failing to produce a mobilising social programme for the post-independence era. The masses, whose support for FLN/ALN was critical to their success during the war of liberation, were progressively excluded from political life, except in the FLN-controlled 'mass organisations'. FLN, whose claim to authority rested almost solely on historic rather than democratic legitimacy, was proclaimed the only lawful party (Ahdjoudj 1990: 18). Gradually, FLN lost the moral force it had enjoyed during the war. The FLN party, made up of opportunists and clients, enjoyed little trust among the masses, and its ideological influence remained limited, especially among the middle class and intellectuals. Instead, FLN, which became the appendage of the various clans in power, provided its members with access to privileges not available to most Algerians.

From the beginning, the regime, whose members saw democracy as regressive, decadent and a threat to national unity, repudiated the establishment of a multiparty democracy. The regime blocked the emergence of autonomous organisations, including trade unions. Only mass organisations affiliated to FLN were allowed to operate. The regime made great efforts to mobilise the population through the single party and these mass organisations. But, because of the military and peasant nature of the revolution, FLN, which had since its inception ostracised autonomous social groups, adopted a policy of using the new classes (intelligentsia, business class and workers) for its own ends, and forced them to play subordinate roles only. Obviously, in such a system all segments of society became (and were seen as) mere appendages of the state, and personal loyalties and patron-client relations were substituted for political and ideological commitments, and the economy itself was subordinated to political rule. Thus, the fragility, and at times total marginalisation, of the business class facilitated the transformation of the petit bourgeoisie into a state bourgeoisie.

Algeria's new rulers failed to erect a truly modern state for a number of reasons: 'privatisation' of the nascent state and its militarisation by rural and bureaucratic forces; factionalism, clientelism and regionalism; extreme government secrecy and suspicion vis-à-vis the masses and intellectuals; idealisation of violence and force as the basis of power; religion as the source of integration; negation of political and cultural pluralism; and sheer authoritarianism. In other words, 'although étatistes [statists], the FLN elite failed to build a modern state; instead, they produced a "political machinery"' (Harbi 1993: 199). Except for the formation of two opposition parties, the Party of the Socialist Revolution

(PRS) and the Front of Socialist Forces, both splinters from the FLN, resistance to the state remained weak for the first decade of independence. Struggles among clans within the state characterised the Algerian political system.

Undoubtedly, this system was determined by the nature of the nationalist movement that shaped the men and women who eventually held the destiny of the country in their hands. The creation of a strong state and of a nation suffered from the absence of both during the period of French colonisation after 1830. The nationalist movement's populist vision, which assimilated state and a *pouvoir central fort* [strong central power], rested on a conception of the organic solidarity of the community, rather than on the more modern notion of a state based upon external norms and a contract. The fact that Algeria's history has been characterised by the absence of a social pact helps to explain the necessity felt by the builders of the Algerian political system to achieve social cohesion through authoritarian means, as well as the emergence of religion as a substitute for citizenship. One can only concur with the historian Mohammed Harbi that Algerian

> nationalism served as a vehicle for a communitarian, not a social project. The contact with colonisation was favourable to the emergence of a civil society. But the development of a civil society has been equally thwarted by everlasting traditional solidarities and by a political culture founded on the pre-eminence of the community.
>
> (Harbi 1993: 36)

The party, the armed forces and the high bureaucracy constituted the three pillars of the political system. But of the three, the military was, and remains, the most organised and most influential. Indeed, soon after independence, the Algerian military was converted from an anti-colonial guerrilla force (ALN) into a modern, professional institution (National Popular Army, ANP) (Zartman 1973). The military has ever since been closely linked to political power. This occurred despite the principle adopted at the 1956 Soummam Congress stipulating the primacy of political/civilian institutions. At the time of that congress, its initiator, Ramdane Abane, already held the view that ALN should be transformed into a modern army with a unified command (Yefsah 1993: 79). This transformation was made the more critical by the heterogeneity of the recruits in the armed forces, which included barely educated war veterans (*Mujahidin*), former officers and NCOs in the French army who eventually joined the war against France, the external army (based in neighbouring Morocco and Tunisia) and new recruits from all over the country.

The military in independent Algeria was entrusted with promoting the 'national campaign for the construction of the new revolutionary and socialist society' (Ottaway 1970: 197). The armed forces saw themselves as 'guardians of the revolution'. In many ways, the military corresponded to Eric Nordlinger's 'praetorian rulers' (Nordlinger 1977: 26ff), but the Algerian model was of the progressive or, one might say, populist type. The Algerian armed forces sought

to bring about socioeconomic change that would improve the conditions of the lower classes, the main victims of the war of liberation and the primary base of support for the regime. Objectively, the regime, especially under Houari Boumedienne (1965–78), achieved substantial socioeconomic development, in which the military took an active part (construction of schools, highways and dams; erection of 'socialist villages'; organisation of literacy campaigns throughout the country). Without the military's backing, President Boumedienne could not have carried out his development policies. Clearly, the military, i.e. the high command and the intelligence services – albeit it in the shadows – dominated the authoritarian system and were at the forefront of the nation- and state-building project, which took precedence over all other considerations.

Despite the weight of the military and the intelligence services (known as Military Security, SM before their restructuring in 1987) – which 'constituted a real parallel political system'[2] – (Bennoune and El Kenz 1990: 273) in the political system and in economic structures, the military entrusted civilian authorities with political power. Those military officers who served in the government were progressively converted to civilian life. By the mid-1970s, most of them had either retired or taken up other positions in the bureaucracy and party. This is why it has always been difficult to characterise Algeria's government as a military regime, for 'the army does not rule', at least not directly, and 'knows its own substantive limitations, and it knows that if it were to start ruling, it would cease being an army' (Zartman 1987: 22) It is, therefore, more appropriate to describe Algeria as having 'an apparatchik government – a government of managers of both military and civilian background, richly experienced in the manoeuverings and manipulations of bureaucratic politics, but unfamiliar with the popularity contests and programmatic debates of electoral politics' (ibid.).

However, the military remains, in spite of the changes that have been taking place since 2013, unmistakably the guardian of the regime, the instrument of power. If the military has never been implicated directly in government affairs, it has been precisely to maintain the unity of its ranks (Bennoune and El Kenz 1990: 269). This is also the reason Colonel Boumedienne, who seized power in June 1965, made sure that the FLN never emerged as a solid force capable of counterbalancing the power of the military. Retired or active military officers were represented at all levels of FLN to ensure that it never threatened military hegemony. For his part, the president could not act against the force from which he had emerged and which helped him consolidate his own power. In saying that the military remained united, I do not suggest there has been no factionalism in the ranks. Indeed, despite its preoccupation with unity inherited from the nationalist movement, factionalism has permeated the military: at least some military leaders have been caught up in clan and clientelist relations based on regional and/or economic interests (Harbi 1993). Nonetheless, ANP has remained the only state institution that developed as a truly national entity, i.e. one which for the most part rose above clientelism and factionalism. What must be emphasised here is that far from being an instrument of the FLN state, the reverse was closer to the truth: the FLN state was under the control of the ANP,

or at least its most influential leaders. FLN's role in the political system has often been exaggerated: indeed, until at least the 1988 uprising, the FLN never ruled post-independence Algeria, but has to this day been an instrument in the hands of the military force.

Assuming that postcolonial Algeria was justified in erecting an authoritarian system in order to lay the foundations of a strong state with enduring institutions capable of addressing the human security of its citizens, then the legitimate question is whether Algeria's rulers succeeded in achieving this objective. Has the social contract between citizens, who gave up their freedoms, and authoritarian rulers, who pledged to carry out the task of development as a tradeoff, materialised? Have the FLN-ANP, intelligence services and bureaucracy been able to create a modern society 53 years after independence from colonial rule? The answer would appear to be in the negative, or at best mixed, but in order to address this question more authoritatively, a cursory review of the development policies of successive regimes is needed.

Algeria's developmentalist state

Boumedienne, who came to power in a coup, perfected the authoritarian system his predecessor, Ahmed Ben Bella had established (1962–65). The new ruler sought to legitimise his rule through the redistribution of wealth derived from hydrocarbon revenues, which also served to finance the new development strategy. In order to end Algeria's underdevelopment as rapidly as possible, the regime launched an 'industrialising industries' initiative based on a widely acclaimed theory developed by the French economist Gérard Destanne de Bernis. Soon after the coup, authorities began structural reforms aimed at erecting 'a strong state'. New codes of the commune in 1967 and of the *Willaya* [departments] in 1969 redefined the administrative units of the country and their socioeconomic functions. The main focus, however, was on economic development through planning, in order to secure for Algeria national self-sufficiency. State-owned enterprises in mining, hydrocarbons, banking, insurance, iron, steel and construction materials served as the vehicle for this industrialisation initiative. To this end, the state nationalised a number of foreign assets. The provision of free healthcare and free education allowed the regime to enjoy a great degree of stability, except for a coup attempt in 1967.

As seen earlier, the military played an important role in the new strategy. In the period 1962–65, Ben Bella had sought the predominance of party over state institutions: Boumedienne reversed this relationship, thus making the FLN subordinate to the army. In other words, the single party system was a myth since Boumedienne had little consideration for the party. He felt that the military, the best organised state institution and the least prone to factionalism, should be the pillar on which his policies rested. He understood that 'the armed forces are the shield and the spearhead that protect the [socialist] Revolution against its domestic and external enemies' (Mameri 1993). His view was that should the army be opposed to the ideological orientation of the regime; no one could

stop the latter's overthrow. The integration of the armed forces into the party must be seen in this context. Not only did Boumedienne rely on the armed forces, but he also called upon the intelligence services to ensure that no serious opposition to the regime could emerge.

Boumedienne's authoritarian system reached its limits in 1974–75, when strains within the ruling bloc (Naïr 1982: 22)[3] became apparent over the lack of success in various sectors of the economy and the regime's obvious lack of legitimacy. Boumedienne became more aware of the shortcomings of the Algerian 'socialist' development strategy, which, despite substantial improvement in the population's standards of living, had increased social inequalities instead of narrowing them. He also recognised that discontent would continue unabated. Lacking democratic channels, Algerians adopted attitudes of apathy toward politics and the populist discourse. The main expression of their discontent was not only political indifference but also passive resistance in the form of strikes (although illegal in the public sector), absenteeism and sabotage.

The institutionalisation process under Boumedienne culminated in the adoption of a new constitution in November 1976. This consecrated presidentialism as the hallmark of the Algerian political system and the pre-eminence of state and government over all other institutions. (Stora 1994: 33). The party would play a leading role only insofar as state cadres were members of the party. An FLN-dominated legislature was put in place, but clearly its role was limited. At that juncture, the regime could have made the transition to democracy, for, as students of transition note,

> the most favourable occasions for attempting liberalisation come at periods of widely accepted success of the authoritarian regime, including a high economic conjuncture, in which the soft-liners hope that the regime's effectiveness will be transferred into popular support for the regime during the transition.
>
> (O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986: 16)

However, opposition to such liberalisation is inevitable since:

> if things are going well, and no important crises … are foreseen, why decide on changes that will inevitably introduce new actors and uncertainties, however tightly liberalisation may be controlled by the regime? Why risk the 'achievements of the regime' for the sake of the fuzzy long-term advantages advocated by the soft-liners?
>
> (O'Donnell and Schmitter 1986: 16)

Regardless of Boumedienne's intentions and those of all the presidents who succeeded him (Bendjedid, Kafi, Zeroual, and Bouteflika), opposition to democracy has remained a sine qua non for the cohesion of the group in power, notwithstanding the introduction of a multiparty system. The pseudo-liberalisation put in place after the 1988 riots proved to be a scheme to divide the opposition and

co-opt political parties, providing them with the illusion of participating in a democratic polity. This explains why the 'democratic transition' in Algeria has remained at a standstill: on 16 October 2015, the director of the Bouteflika's cabinet and head of the pro-government National Rally for Democracy (RND) declared publicly that the transition had already been achieved in 1992–95 and that establishing an 'anarchic democracy' was unacceptable (Amir 2015). The *raison d'être* of the system has been preservation of the interests of the groups in power and those of their respective clienteles.

Authoritarian rule without development

The Promethean system instituted during Boumedienne's populist rule was coming under great stress by the end of the 1970s: in spite of the existence of state-owned enterprises, Algeria remained a rentier state, with the main revenues derived from the sale of hydrocarbons. In spite of state largesse, the population's grievances grew and, besides, most people were angered at the FLN regime's complete domination of state and society and its repression of any opposition. Meanwhile, state-led economic development failed, with inflation and unemployment beginning to mount as the government was forced to cut back on the welfare state and pursue economic liberalisation policies. A scarcity of affordable housing, as well as of food and medicine, also faced the country. Corruption, incompetence and nepotism permeated the economy and the political sphere. Finally, while many Algerians' grievances were economic, others criticised the regime for its secularism and demanded Islamisation of the public sphere. Once again, the contradictions within the nationalist movement resurfaced: centralisation and repression did not mute the underlying demands of the various societal groups.

Under the Bendjedid regime (1978–92), which succeeded Boumedienne's, the political system remained practically intact, even if the new president ousted several important personalities from the heights of power. An anti-corruption campaign and various changes announced by the regime served to eliminate from office personalities or clans that had fallen out of favour, and to co-opt individuals who had not been sufficiently rewarded by the previous regime (Chalabi 1989: 44). Bendjedid's rule witnessed the revenge of factions opposed to Boumedienne's statist policies and to his 'industrialist technocrats' (Harbi 1992: 136). The new incumbents in power made timely alliances to eliminate individuals who threatened their power, and elevated to new positions those who supported the new bloc. However, there was no radical rupture with the past, and the birth of a civil society continued to be delayed, despite initial promises of liberalisation. The regime remained hostile to the emergence of an independent intelligentsia and repressed any form of organised dissent. A coalition of bureaucrats, petit bourgeois, elements of the military and landowners provided the social basis of the new regime. The level of corruption far exceeded that under Boumedienne.

The economy was the only sector that witnessed major changes under the new regime. Given the new bloc's bias toward the private sector, Bendjedid

appointed individuals to dismantle the state-owned enterprises and restructure the public sector. Members of the private sector, especially those with access to the political leadership, were offered a greater role in both agriculture and industry. The state's hydrocarbon revenues were reallocated towards the service sector and consumption to the detriment of productive activities. The new reforms consisted mainly of rehabilitating the (non-productive) private sector and encouraging it to play a greater role in the economy. In addition to fiscal and financial incentives, private enterprises were offered bank loans and tax exemptions in many areas.

Yet, despite seeming moves towards economic liberalisation, Bendjedid's regime remained authoritarian. The FLN party, although not the real holder of power, did nonetheless acquire many new prerogatives and was converted into a quasi-totalitarian machine. It was entrusted with stifling the regime's opponents (principally leftists, cultural activists, some Islamists and union leaders). The party also increased its control over all mass organisations, using articles 120 and 121 of the FLN Statutes, which barred non-FLN individuals from holding office in such organisations. As a close observer of the Algerian political scene has noted, 'In the absence of social hegemony, Algeria was subjected to the political hegemony of the party, combined with the power of the military' (Leca 1990: 18). The regime did not tolerate opposition and used repression whenever necessary against artists, independent unions, Berber militants, human rights activists and radical Islamists. However, the regime was increasingly concerned about the cyclical riots that erupted throughout the country. Limited though these were, they forced the regime to introduce in 1987 some timid liberal legislation, which allowed for the emergence of civic associations for, for instance, consumer rights and cultural interests (Zoubir 1999). The regime even recognised a new Algerian Human Rights League, although two other civic associations were denied legal status. Of course, the FLN-dominated National Popular Assembly opposed such openings and a mini-struggle ensued between those who sought a degree of liberalisation – but not real democratisation – and those who opposed it.

The economic reforms introduced in the 1980s worsened the condition of the masses, especially industrial workers, who lost some of the social benefits they had secured under the previous regime. Subsequent to the dismantling of the state-owned enterprises, unemployment grew; the regime cut food subsidies and deregulated the price of agricultural produce, leading to a rise in the cost of living, especially for the urban poor. Reforms to the education and health sectors resulted in the emergence of additional networks of privilege (e.g. selective schooling system and private hospitals), thus alienating large sections of Algerian society. In short, economic liberalisation benefited mostly the friends, relatives and clients of those in power. The way in which liberalisation was carried out 'led ineluctably to corruption, a phenomenon which has seized the entire social body and generated in it an ethical malaise which has led to generalized cynicism and fed … sermons in the mosques and reactions of religious fundamentalism' (El Kenz 1989). Clientelist networks

multiplied in spectacular fashion and grew stronger. '*Affairisme*' and the informal sector became widespread, and a parallel economy, known as *trabendo*,[4] was instituted.

During Bendjedid's presidency, political opposition, albeit unorganised, grew stronger. Lacking democratic channels to express their demands and grievances, dissident groups organised protests which were severely repressed by the authorities. Ultimately, the 1988 uprising (Algeria's 'Arab Spring') compelled the regime to open up the political system and institute a modicum of political liberalisation. A key reform was the legalisation of new political parties. This step ushered in a multiparty system, theoretically terminating the FLN's hegemony and making the FLN *un parti comme les autres* ('a party like any other'). The regime hoped this would provide a sufficient façade of democracy to rekindle the legitimacy it had long lost. None of the newly created parties, the rulers were convinced, would be able to amass sufficient support to truly challenge the military-backed FLN, a miscalculation it came to regret. A radical, catch-all Islamist party, the Islamic Salvation Front (FIS), attracted a considerable following and was poised to seize power through clean elections. Instead, the military-civilian establishment cancelled the electoral process and banned FIS. The military declared a state of emergency, which was not lifted until February 2011, after the Arab uprisings swept through the region. From 1991 until 2000, the incumbent rulers fought for their survival in a gory quasi-civil war. Tens of thousands of Algerians lost their lives, and the country suffered the massive destruction of infrastructure and factories. The 'Red Decade' highlighted the utter failure of the FLN regime to govern legitimately: it maintained power through sheer force, resulting in the public perception that it was no better than colonial rule.

The 'democratic' transition under Bouteflika: a few steps forward, many backward

In the new millennium, Algeria began to emerge from a decade of instability. President Bouteflika, brought to power by the military – the election having followed the same pattern of rigging that continues to this day – had solid credentials, such as having served as Boumedienne's foreign minister during the golden age of Algeria's foreign policy (Zoubir 2004, 2015). Bouteflika's major challenges were to bring about political stability, re-establish security in the country, revamp the economy and break Algeria's international isolation. He introduced an amnesty law that protected both security forces and jihadists. The law protected individuals against legal proceedings, reduced existing sentences, allowed for probation or the annulment of civic rights rather than prison sentences, and so forth, all at the discretion of the authorities.

After an absence of two decades, Bouteflika returned to the country with the vision he had inherited from the previous governments in which he served as foreign minister (1963–78). Instead of introducing the long hoped for democratic reforms, he took steps to consolidate his presidency for life. The Algerian

constitution of 1996 limited presidential mandates to two terms: in 2008, Bouteflika introduced amendments, adopted overwhelmingly by a completely co-opted parliament in November 2008, which removed the presidential term limit (Aghrout and Zoubir 2009). This allowed Bouteflika to run for and win another term in April 2009 and a fourth in 2014 despite his age, poor health and the mixed results of his presidency. Given the means at his disposal and the support of the parties that dominate parliament, no one doubted his victory. Bouteflika has generally used the FLN-dominated parliament, a quasi-illegitimate institution (since candidates are co-opted and elections are rigged), as a rubber stamp for his policies. Still, to ensure support for the constitutional revisions and his candidacy for a third term, parliamentary deputies, and later governors (*Wally*) and high government officials, received a 300 per cent salary increase two months prior to the election, even though their salaries and benefits were already considerable compared to those of the average citizen. Political parties – secular and religious – exist, but, strangely, they have no aspiration to accede to power. They are content with having representatives in the parliament partly because a portion of their salaries go into the parties' funds. The majority of Algerians have lost hope of seeing political parties play a consequential role in politics or bringing about any real change: the low participation in the 10 May 2012 legislative election illustrates (and confirms) the pessimism about the political system and its capacity to effect transformation (Zoubir and Aghrout 2012). Furthermore, Bouteflika has succeeded in taming civil society and tolerating only those associations that support his policies (Aghrout and Zoubir 2015).

Bouteflika, the Presidential Clan, and the problematic of transition

Since Bouteflika has come to power, he and his cohorts have conveyed the impression that should they leave power, the country would either fall into the hands of some undefined forces (neocolonialism!) or would once again face civil war. The determination of Algeria's rulers to remain in power has resulted in whimsical statements about the future of the country without them. While his supporters argue that 'it is not Bouteflika who needs Algeria, but it is Algeria which needs Bouteflika', this fanciful discourse, far from reflecting genuine support for the president and his allegedly superior credentials, in fact highlights several paramount issues: the unrelenting crisis in the political system and the inability of the rulers to inaugurate an authentic transition from authoritarianism to a more democratic polity or at least to lay the foundations of good governance (Zoubir 2013). Bouteflika and the so-called 'revolutionary family', made up of the parties and organisations gathered around FLN, consider themselves to be the force that secured the country's independence and, as such, to be entitled to rule the country until their deaths, omitting to mention the sacrifices of ordinary individuals and freedom fighters in the national independence struggle. The postcolonial

'aristocracy' refuses to hand over power to new generations and has blatantly failed to promote a productive economic system, depending instead on oil rents, which they can use as a legitimising tool to maintain their rule.

Upon his return from France following his hospitalisation, Bouteflika – some might say his clan – appointed to key positions individuals who are very close to him and made important changes within the military hierarchy and within the powerful intelligence service, the Department of Research and Security (DRS), which lost a few of its traditional prerogatives and saw the removal of its all-powerful head, Maj. Gen. Mohamed Mediène, better known as 'Tewfik'. The objective was to provide Bouteflika with undivided power and to consolidate the presidential dictatorship he has been building since first coming to power in 1999. As a matter of fact, many of the previous prerogatives of the DRS have now come under the direct control of the presidency.

Having established the hegemony of the presidency, Bouteflika secured his unabashed re-election on 17 April 2014. He could not even run his campaign – his Prime Minister Abdelmalek Sellal and other ministers campaigned on his behalf – and has rarely been seen since his return from France. While the opposition parties condemned the re-election as a breach of the constitution, on the grounds the president cannot perform his duties, the divisions among them and the absence of constituents in a depoliticised society provoked mere contempt from the regime, which accused them of being anti-nationalistic groups seeking to destabilise the country.

Conclusion

The Algerian regime under Bouteflika's rule has been able to maintain itself in power thanks to hydrocarbon revenues which it uses to silence social discontent and to co-opt divided challengers. These are often former members of the regime and do not enjoy the trust of an alienated population, particularly the youth, who have no faith in an old-guard and its supporters, often accused of having betrayed the ideals of the war of national liberation.

The incumbent regime sees the current stability of the country, unlike that of the post-Arab spring countries, as everlasting. Indeed, officials hold up the menace of destabilisation should Bouteflika and his cohorts leave office by referring ad nauseam to the situation in Libya and Syria, arguing that Algeria is a democratic country whose spring was in 1988.[5] Probably recognising its lack of domestic legitimacy, the regime believes it enjoys broad international support for its role in regional antiterrorism.

Currently, the '*pouvoirs occultes*'[6] are searching for a successor to Bouteflika, one who will safeguard the enormous benefits that have cumulated before and since Bouteflika was brought to power. While the Algerian population has succumbed to the 'stability' trope and is satisfied that some socioeconomic grievances are being addressed, the big drop in the oil price has already begun to alarm the regime and jeopardise rent redistribution, one of the bases of its shallow legitimacy, with possibly unforeseen consequences.

Notes

1 The nationalist movement emerged as a result of the oppression of the Muslim population considered as second-class French subjects who had been denied their basic rights since the country invasion in 1830. While Algerians opposed armed resistance soon after the invasion, nationalist movement began to form around 1910.
2 For a detailed analysis of the role of the military intelligence in the Algerian political system, see Harbi (1995); Harbi argues that the SM constituted a 'state within the state' and was feared, because of its autonomy and power, even by the military hierarchy.
3 I borrowed the notion of 'bloc in power' from Naïr (1982: 22). Naïr applies the Gramscian approach to his study of the Algerian political system. Sultanism is also used to analyse the Algerian system; see, for instance, Leca and Vatin (1979). Addi (1994) applies S. Eisenstadt's (1973) theory of neopatrimonialism.
4 *Trabendo* refers to illegal imports of foreign goods unavailable in the country and their resale at higher prices at home; it is part of an impressive informal economy outside the productive sector. Individuals overseeing such a market made huge fortunes. Their connections with the Algerian bureaucracy are certain. Today, although the imports of goods is much easier than in the past, the informal trade activities have become more sophisticated and continue to involve dignitaries of the regime.
5 This is based on the author's interviews with high-level officials and press reports in Algeria.
6 According to former Prime Minister Mouloud Hamrouche (in 1995), real power in Algeria is exercised by the 'pouvoir' and by the government. Although the military has a say in the appointment of senior officials, it has no control over their activities. In other words, they rule with no accountability and when they fail, the military is blamed for it. The government and the central and local administration make up the 'pouvoir'; the clans are located within those institutions. The clans operate outside the military, even though members of the military, as individuals, might belong to one of the clans. However, there is no link between the army, as an institution, and the clans. The problem, of course, is that a centre of power, that is a centre of decision, does not exist. The true powers in Algeria are hidden powers (*pouvoirs occultes*). The analysis he provided in 1995 remains valid up to this day.

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Part III

Liberation struggles against white minority rule



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8 The African National Congress

From liberation movement to neoliberal state manager

Patrick Bond

Introduction

The most vital reminder of how the exercise of power by national liberation movements contradicts their former ideals is the durability of radical, often anti-imperialist narratives in times of political panic. It is then that the shrillest manifestations of liberatory rhetoric arise, attempting to disguise how the spoils of liberation are being devoured by corrupting neo-colonial forces both within and without the nation. It is then that the party must remind the society of the times it was profoundly rooted within the urgent drive to liberate a country from wide varieties of colonial repression. It is then, too, that international threats are conjured up (sometimes conjoined with ethnic fear-mongering), so as to distract attention from the party's immediate failings. South Africa boasts amongst the world's most vivid examples of this tendency, which can be termed 'talk left, walk right' (Bond 2006). The more the African National Congress (ANC) is threatened as the ruling party, the more this populist tendency will be given voice, just at the time when genuinely destructive neo-colonial forces – especially those in the financial markets insisting on fiscal austerity – amplify the society's already extreme contradictions.

In 2016, the ANC had governed South Africa for 22 years, after the movement's unbanning in 1990 was achieved through exceptional protest and coordinated international solidarity. Economic, political, cultural, social, environmental and other policy changes adopted during the 1990s were profound in many respects, especially in terms of the ANC's most celebrated success: one-person one-vote in a unitary state, the primary goal of liberation. But the socioeconomic grievances of the vast majority soon became profound and unresolvable. One 2015 estimate by the University of Cape Town's main poverty research unit puts the poverty rate among 55 million South Africans at 63 per cent, despite one-third of the population receiving a monthly state welfare grant. (In 1994, most poverty estimates were below 50 per cent.) The unemployment rate had soared during the 1990s from 16 per cent to nearly 30 per cent (not counting people who gave up looking for work, which easily adds another 10 per cent), as trade liberalisation and imported capital goods replaced local labour-intensive production with imports and machines. The inequality rate in 1994 was measured by an income

Gini coefficient at around 0.65 and had risen to 0.77 by 2014, the world's highest among major countries (Bond 2015).

Yet in electoral terms, the ANC retained enormous, consistent popular support – a three-fifths to two-thirds share of the national voting electorate in nine contests between 1994 and 2014 thanks to loyalty based in part on its prestige as a liberation movement and in part on subsequent patronage. Its ability to recover revolutionary rhetoric was one factor in keeping its troops aligned after 2002 against not only the traditional enemies of 'imperialism' and white racism, but also against new 'ultra-left' forces threatening stability. Jacob Zuma, the ANC leader elected in late 2007, along with other leaders of the same generation, such as Secretary-General Gwede Mantashe, needed to – and usually could – draw upon both the elite's modernising, neoliberal management of these contradictions, and the old populist traditions of the ANC 'big tent' politics. One of the main vehicles for the party's durability was what became known as 'tenderpreneurship', a vast web of state contracts given to cronies.

What is remarkable in this context, as the rest of this chapter argues, is how much continuity has been achieved in terms of neoliberal public policy since the early 1990s, notwithstanding all the contingencies of intra-ANC political manoeuvring, including the dramatic 2007–08 leadership change (Saul and Bond 2014; Bond 2014). After a brief survey of ANC history next, the main neoliberal deals done by ANC leaders in the first decade of liberation are reviewed, followed by an assessment of the internal and external political forces, including new black business elites. In the subsequent section, the ANC's social welfare policies are considered, and found to be tokenistic. Finally, we consider the tendency of the contemporary ANC to resort to older lines of nationalist narrative, especially classical anti-imperialism in the context of an alliance with BRICS countries under similar stresses. Whether this style of reproducing neoliberal nationalism can proceed without loss of power (as for example, Zimbabwe's Robert Mugabe showed for decades), or instead a successful challenge from the left arises, will hinge on how well South African society can deconstruct the ANC's talk left, walk right combination.

ANC's historical trajectory

Books about the ANC's liberation history, strategy, tactics and alliances have proliferated (Dubow 2000; Ellis 2012; Holland 1989; Johns and Davis 1991; Lissoni *et al.* 2011; Lodge 1983; McKinley 1997; Meli 1988; Roux 1964; Walshe 1970). The ANC was founded in 1912 as a gathering of educated male professionals (the main leader John Dube had a divinity degree from a small US liberal arts college) aiming for slightly better treatment during the height of colonial power. For several decades, using entirely mild-mannered tactics, they received very little from the white establishment. It was only in the 1950s, with the rise of the ANC's Youth League led by Nelson Mandela, that a more militant version of nationalism arose. The party still aimed at furthering the cause of black Africans but gradually found common cause with the South

African Indian Congress (whose roots go back to Mahatma Gandhi's 1894 Natal Indian Congress), the Coloured People's Congress and even progressive whites in the Congress of Democrats. In addition, white Communists built up strong relations with the ANC, to the extent that by the time the 1955 Freedom Charter was compiled from thousands of grassroots inputs after a national mass meeting in Kliptown, Soweto, authorship was led by a group that included Rusty Bernstein and Ben Turok. Its most controversial clause is that 'The mineral wealth beneath the soil, the Banks and monopoly industry shall be transferred to the ownership of the people as a whole'.

By the early 1960s, along with the breakaway Pan Africanist Congress (PAC) – ever suspicious of white influence over the ANC – the liberation movements turned away from mass marches and civil disobedience to armed struggle. After the 1960 Sharpeville Massacre of PAC members who burned their passbooks, when police shot 69 activists dead, the forces of liberation began to turn from protest to sabotage. Some high-profile ANC activists, including Nobel Peace Prize laureate Albert Luthuli, opposed the armed struggle, but they were in the minority of the leadership. Then in 1962, Mandela was captured by the white apartheid state thanks to assistance from the US Central Intelligence Agency (CIA); he was released only in February 1990. The movement turned resolutely to armed struggle and developed underground cells, but in 1963 the ANC's top leadership layers were imprisoned.

The power of internal apartheid repression proved overwhelming, so most of the surviving cadres went into exile. By the time of the 1968 ANC congress in Morogoro, Tanzania, the movement had solidified its relations with likeminded international liberation movements, and shifted its membership rules so as to allow not just black Africans but committed South Africans of any race to become members. The ANC's ability to draw on Soviet and Scandinavian material support, its backing by most member states of the Organisation of African Unity, as well as its mobilisation of popular solidarity in the West and Global South meant that the apartheid regime had become isolated by the 1980s. The armed struggle was sporadic, however, and many attacks by the apartheid regime within the region, 'Askari' infiltrators and internal disciplinary crises beset the ANC's Mkhonto we Sizwe army. The movement could claim only a few symbolic attacks within South Africa, and the apartheid state used the armed struggle and its Soviet backers as an excuse for extreme militarisation. Mandela was denounced as a terrorist in the official West and indeed from 1962 to 2008 was on the US State Department's official terrorist list, taken off only when a law to that effect was passed by Congress, but many others in the ANC remain subject to intense interrogation as an aftermath of Cold War hostility to the Soviet Union's revolutionary Third World allies.

Meanwhile within South Africa during the 1970s and 1980s, the danger for ANC nationalism was its potential eclipse by various sectoral and identity movements that were experiencing direct apartheid repression. As popular protest rose from Durban in 1973 (with port labour strikes), Soweto in 1976 (as high school students rejected tuition in the Afrikaans language), across the country in the

form of Black Consciousness (BC) militancy (e.g. in the brief rise of the Azanian People's Organisation), and through community uprisings from the late 1970s, the ANC faced a dilemma. On the one hand its underground cadres worked diligently to influence the new movements, and, on the other, Congress movement ideologues occasionally resorted to smear campaigns against some of those sociopolitical forces – such as the 'workerist' Federation of South African Trade Unions (Fosatu, labelled by exiled Communist trade unionists as 'yellow', i.e. too close to business), as well as the BC movement and the exiled PAC – that it could not immediately control. As BC began to ebb in ideological power, first the United Democratic Front of more than 1,000 civil society groups formed in 1983 and then the Congress of SA Trade Unions (Cosatu) shook off its predecessor Fosatu's critique of ANC 'populism' upon its founding in 1985, as mineworker and South African Communist Party (SACP) influence prevailed. Then leftists within community movements were marginalised during the 1984–86 uprisings, and even the mainstream faith movements began to informally ally with the Congress tradition, even though the ANC only renounced the armed struggle in 1990. The ANC's alliances with the SACP (Ellis and Sechaba 1992) and Cosatu (Baskin 1991) were fraught with difficulty, but Cosatu firmly endorsed the ANC when it was unbanned. From 1991 onwards, the 'Alliance' endured, even when stressed, such as when in 2013 the largest trade union in Africa (the metalworkers) seized upon the ANC's conservative bias to split away from the Alliance, resulting in their 2014 expulsion from Cosatu.

As the ANC gained internal hegemony over the anti-apartheid forces during the 1980s, the movement also took advantage of a weakened apartheid economy and, as a result of combined internal and external pressures, forged new alliances with big capital en route to taking state power. Most importantly, it was possible for the ANC and its allies to 'make South Africa ungovernable' from the mid-1980s by using mass action. In this process, classically nationalist politics were relatively unhindered by distractions of class, gender, faith, identity, ethnicity, geography (e.g. urban or rural) and sexual preference. (By the early 1990s, the varieties of other political agendas would all be satisfied to some extent within the ANC Big Tent, and the constitution would provide strong supporting measures for reproductive rights, gay marriage and the civil and political rights of disenfranchised people, with the ANC generally offering its majority consent to a nominally liberal political system.) The formula for a long period of nationalist rule was thus established and a formidable vote-gathering machine was constructed. Part of that formula entailed an open critique of 'imperialism' from within the core of the ANC leadership, while at the same time, the ANC's top layer of state rulers – especially in the neoliberal bloc – also worked closely with Western institutions and governments on a variety of global, continental and national initiatives (Bond 2003, 2006).

That process, in turn, was partly a function of the international strategy adopted to bring down apartheid: economic sanctions. At the most critical juncture, in August 1985, international banks fled South Africa thanks mainly to President P.W. Botha's aggressive resistance to reform in his Rubicon Speech.

The mix of local and global pressure became acute. In September 1985, ANC exiled leader Oliver Tambo received a high-profile visit from white South African business elites in Zambia, and many more 'talks about talks' in subsequent months ensured that a smooth transition process would transpire based on social democratic aspirations but neoliberal principles. By the time Mandela began negotiating from his prison during the late 1980s, the Soviet Union had faded as an ANC ally. The onset of global financial power within a neoliberal 'New World Order' dominated from Washington was well recognised, especially by ANC cadres who had spent the 1980s witnessing one African country after another conceding to World Bank and International Monetary Fund (IMF) structural adjustment programmes.

After the February 1990 unbanning of the liberation movements, the ANC's leadership was consolidated in a 1991 conference that made Mandela the party president and Cyril Ramaphosa the general secretary (he had served as the mineworkers' union leader over the prior decade). In different ways, both succumbed to the so-called Faustian Pact with big business – local and global – that catalysed South Africa's neoliberal era (Bond 2014; Kasrils 2013). In 1994, Ramaphosa found himself sidelined within the ANC by more skilled forces loyal to Thabo Mbeki, and after leading the drafting of the final constitution in 1996, he retreated into big business and soon became one of the two richest black South Africans. Mbeki became the anointed successor to Mandela, and indeed served the first government of Mandela (1994–99) as a de facto prime minister. In 1999, Mbeki became state president and served until a palace coup in September 2008, considered revenge for his firing of the then Deputy President Zuma in 2005. That decision followed a close Zuma ally's conviction on corruption charges involving a bribe arranged for Zuma ($33,000 a year) from a French arms company, and was followed by the national prosecutor's collection of 783 counts of corruption. These hung over Zuma's head until they were mysteriously dropped in April 2009, on the eve of the ANC's re-election, on grounds that chief investigator Leonard McCarthy (who later became the main World Bank corruption-buster) had illegally conspired against Zuma. Over the prior seven months, an interim president, Kgalema Motlanthe, was in place until Zuma's rule began in May 2009.

There are many accounts of the way the ANC managed its internal transition from liberation movement to ruling party (Bond 2014; Booysen 2011, 2015; Gumede 2007; Marais 2011; Saul and Bond 2014; Southall 2013; Terreblanche 2012). The pages that follow offer an analysis of the ANC's transitional process – from liberation movement to neoliberal government – using the two foundational characteristics of political economy, capital accumulation and class struggle.

Faustian pacts and black bourgeoisie

Zuma's reign has been hampered by economic stagnation, the roots of which can be traced to decisions made by ANC leaders in the 1990s without meaningful input from the party's majority, who still aspired to the Freedom Charter,

which, as noted earlier, promised that 'The mineral wealth beneath the soil, the Banks and monopoly industry shall be transferred to the ownership of the people as a whole'. The Reconstruction and Development Plan also had wide-ranging strategies for transformation that were ignored (Bond and Khosa 1999). In contrast, a listing of the dozen most damaging 1990s Faustian Pacts between the ANC and capital (to quote former Intelligence Minister Ronnie Kasrils, 2013) includes:

- repayment of the US$25 billion apartheid-era foreign debt, which denied Mandela money to pay for the basic needs of apartheid's victims (October 1993);
- giving the South African Reserve Bank formal independence in the constitution, which resulted in the insulation of the central bank's officials from democratic accountability, leading to high interest rates and the deregulation of exchange controls (November 1993);
- borrowing $850 million from the IMF, with tough conditions that included rapid scrapping of import surcharges that had protected local industries, state spending cuts, lower public sector salaries and a decrease in wages across the board (December 1993);
- joining the World Trade Organisation on adverse terms, as a 'transitional', not developing, economy, in turn destroying many clothing, textiles, appliance and other labour-intensive firms (June 1994);
- lowering primary corporate taxes from 48 per cent to 29 per cent and maintaining countless white people's and corporate privileges (1994–99);
- adopting a neoliberal macroeconomic policy, which not only failed on its own terms, but also caused developmental austerity (June 1996);
- privatising parts of the state, such as Telkom, the state-owned telecommunications company (1997);
- approving the 'demutualisation' of the two mega-insurers Old Mutual and Sanlam, which represented the privatisation of historic mutual wealth for current share owners (1998); and
- permitting most of South Africa's 10 biggest companies to move their headquarters and primary listings abroad, leading to permanent balance of payments deficits and corporate disloyalty to the society (1999).

The personalities who accomplished this rapid shift of capital accumulation from an internal to an external orientation were mostly ANC political intellectuals whose trajectory was not dissimilar from leaders of the US Democratic Party, British Labour Party and most European social democratic parties. Aside from the interlocutors from the old white Nationalist Party who smoothed the transition (especially F.W. de Klerk, Barend du Plessis, Chris Stals and Derek Keys), the ANC's neoliberal leadership faction during the post-apartheid era consisted mainly of Mbeki; finance ministers Trevor Manuel (1996–2009), Pravin Gordhan (2009–14 and 2016) and Nhlanhla Nene (2014–15); central bank governors Tito Mboweni (1999–2009), Gill Marcus (2009–14) and Lesetja

Kganyago (2009–16); Deputy President Ramaphosa (2014–16) as well as a few other major figures (e.g. Trade and Public Enterprises Minister Alec Erwin, who was in the cabinet from 1996 to 2008, Justice and Mining Minister Penuell Maduna from 1996–2004; Treasury Director-General Maria Ramos from 1996–2003; and numerous behind-the-scenes bureaucrats). Some had an uneasy relationship with the dominant white business bloc, but many of these men and women readily circulated into financial institutions and mining houses before or after their state service: Rothschild (Manuel), Goldman Sachs (Mboweni), Allan Gray Investment (Nene), ABSA Bank (Marcus, Ramos), Shanduka/Lonmin/Standard Bank (Ramaphosa), AngloPlats (Valli Moosa) and BHP Billiton (Xolani Mkhwanazi).

In the Zuma era, since 2008, this bloc is typically distinguished from the more explicitly corrupt 'state capture' ministers and bureaucrats associated with the Gupta family and other tenderpreneurs (e.g. in KwaZulu-Natal, notoriously corrupt construction families like the Mpisanes and Singhs, who continue to bid successfully for major state projects) (Desai and Bond 2017). Having arrived in South Africa from India with a small investment fund just as apartheid was falling, three Gupta brothers soon accumulated such power and wealth that, it is widely alleged, they could regularly manipulate Zuma. (A similar function was played by the Shaik family prior to 2005, when one brother was jailed for facilitating Zuma's corruption.) This was in part possible through patronage connections to Zuma's son and nephew, and to other crucial Gupta allies, including the leaders of the ANC's Youth League (Collen Maine) and Women's League (*Bathabile Dlamini*). Gupta allies hold high-ranking positions in parastatal agencies, and it is generally understood that in the second half of 2015 the brothers instructed Zuma whom he should appoint as ministers to lead mining (Mosebenzi Zwane) and finance (Des van Rooyen).

Upon the financial markets' fright at the latter incident, when more than $50 billion quickly fled the country in mid-December 2015, the neoliberal bloc rebelled at the firing of Nene. Ramos and two other bankers met the ANC Treasurer (Zweli Mkhize) and there was also Chinese pressure (due to a large loss of share value in Standard Bank, which is 20 per cent Beijing-owned), and Van Rooyen was shifted to the local government ministry within four days. Gordhan moved back to finance to stem the haemorrhaging, but 2016 was characterised by severe tensions as Gordhan slowed the pace of Zuma's patronage politics. Ramos ended ABSA's relations with the Guptas in December 2015, as did the three other main banks and leading accounting firm KPMG a few months later after another revelation of a finance ministry takeover gambit, thus threatening the liquidity and staff payment systems for the Gupta mining, media and IT empire. Several of the Guptas then left Johannesburg for Dubai, but one brother also promised to return to a new base in Durban. The Gupta corruption scandals were far-reaching and reminded the society of how corrosive state-capital relations could be.

Indeed, two April–May 2016 court cases were lost by Zuma: first against his personal enrichment in constructing a rural palace at Nkandla with state funds

(of $15 million), and second in the revocation of the 'irrational' prosecutorial dismissal of 783 corruption charges against him in 2009, just prior to his taking the presidency. Yet it would not be forgotten that capitalist corruption of the ANC became much more serious from the late 1990s, when a $5 billion deal to buy sophisticated weaponry from Germany, Britain, Spain and Sweden implicated even some of the country's senior neoliberals (including Mbeki and Erwin).

The shifting and apparently fickle character of the ruling elite's configuration should not disguise a more durable trend among ANC leaders: these power blocs evolved over time because the accumulation of capital as a motive for wielding ANC policy power became strongest as the Black Economic Empowerment (BEE) 'tenderpreneurship' strategy began to reach its limits. This occurred only once Mbeki committed forcefully to what he termed in 1999 'the formation of a black capitalist class, a black bourgeoisie', using a required minimum black shareholding (around 25 per cent of each major firm) through which transfer of shares to explicit new owners was mandated. This transfer was often accomplished through unsatisfactory debt/equity deals from which the new owners regularly cashed out, leaving the white firms frustrated at needing to subsidise another new black co-owner.

For instance, in the case of the platinum mining house Lonmin, Ramaphosa's 9 per cent ownership brought with it multiple disasters, including the 2012 Marikana Massacre of striking workers, which was catalysed by Ramaphosa's urgent emails to the police minister (Saul and Bond 2014), followed by the 2015 refusal of his former company Shanduka to continue propping up the same firm in a new share issue once it shed more than 99 per cent of its London share value. *Vice* news revealed that in 2015, the British army visited Lonmin to 'devise a medium term strategy, with concrete deliverables, for the party [ANC] to retain power at the next general election', an extraordinarily blunt reflection of the link between imperial power and their local allies in Pretoria (Miller 2016).

The enforced share transfer requirement followed the mid-1998 financial catastrophe in which a prior model for black ownership of previously white business – vast debt loads on the expectation that stock market prices would continue rising through the 1990s – imploded, leaving many of the first-generation black empowerment schemes bankrupt. Those schemes reflected the idea put forward by Mbeki's deputy president, Phumzile Mlambo-Nguka (2005–08), in 1998 when she was Erwin's deputy minister of trade and industry: 'Blacks should not be ashamed to be *filthy rich*'. But the realisation that only a handful of black billionaires had emerged from the ANC's attempted corporate redistribution strategy led to periodic calls for 'broad-based' BEE during the 2000s. Still, these never shifted ownership, much less control relations. The billionaires mostly had embarrassingly conspicuous consumption habits that left them indistinguishable in lifestyle from the country's most hedonistic whites. The ANC's official spokesperson, Smuts Ngonyama (1998–2008), had in 2007 confirmed the sentiment of get-rich-quick access to state tenders when remarking, 'I didn't

join the struggle to be *poor*'. He later quit the ANC when Mbeki was fired to join an opposition party, but rejoined in 2014 and immediately became ambassador to Spain.

Internecine political party competition

Some of the personality foibles discussed above are important because they set the stage for the Mbeki-Zuma power transfer. Zuma's campaign for the presidency in 2007 in part reflected the Alliance's centre-left anger at Mbeki's arrogance, neoliberalism and AIDS policies, but also included a lobby of black entrepreneurs (like Tokyo Sexwale) who had not sufficiently prospered during the Mbeki years. Within the ANC, such internecine squabbles and personal splintering began soon after 1994, reflecting how populist politicians stray from the tent due to particular circumstances. One case was the popular leader Bantu Holomisa, who set up the United Democratic Movement – a party which regularly won just 2 per cent of the vote – after losing a mid-1990s battle against a corrupt elder minister (Stella Sigcau).

Then in 2008, the centrist Congress of the People party emerged when two ANC leaders (Mbhazima Shilowa and Mosiuoa Lekota) became infuriated at Mbeki's ouster. They won an impressive 7.4 per cent of the 2009 vote (30 seats in parliament), but the party soon melted down in an internecine power struggle between the two, and in the 2014 election only won 0.7 per cent (three seats). In 2013, the next breakaway was by Julius Malema and the ANC Youth League's radical leadership, after ANC official Ramaphosa disciplined the youngsters for numerous insults to the older elites, including a call for mining nationalisation that Ramaphosa was intent on suppressing. Malema survived his own corruption and tax trials (suggesting that the state's prosecuting power would be shamelessly used against Zuma's opponents), and his Economic Freedom Fighters (EFF) won 6.4 per cent of the 2014 national vote and in subsequent years played an exceptionally disruptive role in parliament. Their 'pay back the money' (for Nkandla) and '#ZuptasMustFall' insults became not just national memes but also found expression in court battles that they and the centre-right opposition party, the Democratic Alliance (DA), began to win on a regular basis, demonstrating the continuing independence of the judiciary.

Prior to a leftist movement consolidation anticipated in 2019, the main electoral challenge to ANC power would be the ever-reformulating DA, which remained committed to both political liberalism and economic neoliberalism. It rose dramatically in support from 1994 (1.4 per cent) to 1999 (9.6), 2004 (12.4), 2009 (16.7) and 2014 (22.2). Yet because of its white roots, this bloc – which initially included the apartheid regime's National Party (winner of 20 per cent of the vote in the 1994 election, albeit with sufficient massaging of the numbers to cast doubt, and then by 2004 so reduced in support that it folded) – was so widely discredited in the eyes of the majority that even when under talented black leadership from 2015, the DA found it difficult to challenge the ANC outside its main power base, the Western Cape. There, the party's support from

the majority demographic of Coloured and white voters meant not only DA leadership of the province after 1994 but that even in the city of Cape Town (with a large Xhosa-speaking population), the ANC lost municipal power to the DA in 2006, following a two-day electricity black-out.

That exception aside (as well as the Zulu-nationalist Inkatha Freedom Party's brief leadership of the KwaZulu-Natal provincial government from 1994–99), the huge majorities won by the ANC in national and provincial polls from 1994–2014 gave its rulers sufficient power to make and implement policy. Yet as remarked by one of the main insider-commentators on the transition, Alan Hirsch (2005: 22), 'because the ANC was confident of electoral success for at least 10 to 15 years, reaping the liberation political dividend, it did not feel forced to introduce risky, populist economic or fiscal policies to retain electoral support'. By 2016, the main reason to avoid expansive social spending was fear of a credit ratings agency downgrade. The combination of arrogance and fealty to global finance, within a neoliberal global policy milieu and with rapid class formation undermining the ANC's former liberatory orientation, permitted the party to fulfil its 1955 Freedom Charter and 1994 Reconstruction and Development Programme mandates only partially, with a watered-down set of policies that are best described as 'tokenistic'.

Social democratic ideals, neoliberal realities

The immediate post-apartheid era should have been the period when the ANC most decisively established a generous welfare state. A dozen Faustian pacts and other socioeconomic policies had the opposite effect, rendering social democratic policies impotent (Bond 2014b). The word tokenistic applies well, suggesting that after 1994, the extension of apartheid-era social policy – which had been limited to white, Indian and Coloured South Africans – was pursued in a manner that stressed 'width not depth' and fell far short of potential resource allocation.

To illustrate, state welfare grants suffered cut-backs – e.g. in 1996, a 26 per cent reduction in the main child support grant (from $37 to $27 per month) – even while many more people gained access. The number of South Africans receiving monthly grants soared from fewer than three million in 1994 to 17 million two decades later (out of 55 million residents). By 2016, following substantial currency depreciation, monthly grants were only $23 per month (far lower than required to support a poor child under the age of 18). In addition, there was an $85 per month pension for retirees over 60 years and the disabled. In all cases, these were means-tested, although the treasury promised to shift from means-tested administration to universal access for old-age pensions as a strategy to avoid distorting savings incentives for elderly people, but the move has been repeatedly delayed.

Still, social grant provision remains a logical component of a neoliberal policy repertoire, as Susan Booysen (2011: 15) argues, because it is part of the ruling party's 'political regeneration … the ANC-in-government is the

dispenser, the patron that ensures social grants and other benefits. This is recognised as the 'ANC doing good'. A related philosophical feature of the ANC's neoliberal approach to social policy is decentralisation, which means the transfer of responsibilities to lower levels of government *without the requisite financial resources to deliver services*, also known as 'unfunded mandates'.

This was just one of the ways that the commodification of services led to social unrest in the form of service delivery protests, by some measures reaching thousands per year (Bond 2014b). Others related to water and sanitation, because by 2003 the country's leading water official, Mike Muller (2004), admitted that '275,000 of all households attributed [water supply] interruptions to cut-offs for non-payment', which extrapolates to in excess of 1.5 million people affected that year alone. In 1999, the World Bank had claimed that its water advisor's 1995 pricing recommendations were 'instrumental in facilitating a radical revision in South Africa's approach to bulk water management' (Bond 2014), a revision of the 1994 Reconstruction and Development Programme 'lifeline' water supply mandate (Bond and Khosa 1999). By the time that mandate was finally honoured by Water Minister Ronnie Kasrils in 2001, the commercialisation instinct was already thoroughly accepted by municipalities. As a result, the right to water ended up either being sabotaged or delivered in a tokenistic way, i.e. free for merely the first six kilolitres/household/month (kl/hh/m). To illustrate, in Durban – the main site of Free Basic Water pilot-exploration starting in 1998 – the overall cost of water ended up doubling for poor households because of a huge price increase in the second bloc (the city soon had the second-highest price among its South African peers for 6–10 kl/hh/m). For poor people, this led to consumption cuts by a third in the subsequent six years, from 22 kl/hh/m to 15 (Bond 2014).

The worst services disconnection rate was for fixed telephone lines, where, of 13 million people connected for the first time, 10 million were cut off by 2000, as prices per call soared. This was due to the partial privatisation of state phone company Telkom that resulted in the demise of internal cross-subsidies, as new Texan and Malaysian investors attempted to maximise profits at the expense of poor-customer retention during the late 1990s. Electricity also experienced exceptional price increases – more than 400 per cent from 2007 to 2014 – which in turn led to many more disconnections and a turn back from clean power to dirty sources of household energy. The essence of the Free Basic Services, as with so many other aspects of ANC social policy, was tokenism (Bond 2014).

Radical rhetoric and rising resistance

The adverse policies for the country's majority, as explained above, were not accidents. Nor were they necessary concessions to economic reality, because enormous surpluses were certainly produced in post-apartheid South Africa, but these trickled upwards and outwards instead of across and downwards. For example, the country's stock of what is sometimes called natural capital (mineral wealth) rose as the commodity price index soared from 2002 to 2011.

South Africa has what is considered to be the world's greatest mineral resource endowment, valued at peak by Citi Group at $2.5 trillion (Mala 2012). But because of lax regulation, the mainly foreign-owned mines and smelters were stripped, with the Washington NGO Global Financial Integrity (2015) naming South Africa the country seventh most prone to Illicit Financial Flows (in absolute terms, and higher in relative terms), with an average of nearly $21 billion in annual losses over the 2004–13 decade.

The corporate propensity to misinvoice, transfer price or simply evade taxes was one reason that Johannesburg's commercial elite was in 2014 considered the most corrupt capitalist class on earth, according to the business consultancy PricewaterhouseCoopers (PwC). Drawing on its survey, *The Sunday Times* labelled South African management 'the world leader in money-laundering, bribery and corruption, procurement fraud, asset misappropriation, and cybercrime', with 77 per cent of all internal fraud committed by senior and middle management (Hosken 2014). Two years later, the same PwC (2016) report also had South African corporations in the world-leading position on corruption, just ahead of the French and Kenyan bourgeoisie. This may help explain SA's 2013 rating as the third most profitable country for corporations among major economies, according to the IMF (2013). Even if some in the ANC objected, the permission the local capitalist class needed to remove this wealth abroad and, at home, to wage class war was regularly given by the state. The most extreme form was at Marikana, where Lonmin required police intervention against wildcat strikers in 2012 at the same time as it was transfer-pricing vast profits to a Bermuda 'marketing' company.

To disguise the ANC's service to global capitalism, an anti-imperialist rhetoric can be extremely useful. This was evident especially when in May 2016 there were revelations about how the CIA had assisted the apartheid state in Nelson Mandela's 1962 arrest and 27-year jail term. Chief foreign policy spokesperson Clayson Monyela quickly assured Washington that 'from government's point of view, our relations with the United States are strong, they're warm, and cordial'. Monyela was replying to the charge that the CIA 'never stopped operating here', made by ANC spokesperson Zizi Kodwa: 'It is still happening now – the CIA is still collaborating with those who want regime change' (Voice of America 2016). Among those, according to the State Security Agency and Deputy Defence Minister Kebby Maphatsoe in 2014–15, was the 'CIA agent' Thuli Madonsela. In reality, she was the country's Public Protector and in that capacity, the main state official regularly in intense conflict with Zuma, including over his home subsidy repayment (South African Press Association 2015). Maphatsoe continued in 2016 to fear 'the foreign intelligence community's plan to have a regime change in South Africa' (Stone 2016). ANC Secretary-General Gwede Mantashe had, four months earlier, warned of a potential Washington-sponsored coup: 'We are aware of the programme that takes young people to the United States for six weeks then brings them back and plants them everywhere in the campuses' (he was referring to Barack Obama's Mandela Washington Fellowship internships).

Conclusion

This 'talk left' was apparently deemed necessary to disguise a 'walk right'. It was not the only potential course, for the ANC government could have mustered political will to restore exchange controls to prevent capital flight, and then address the vast socioeconomic injustices. State spending in relation to GDP has stayed in the 22–29 per cent range since 1994, far lower than in typical European social democracies, and than in Brazil and Russia. The sum of state social spending by the South African government was so limited that in relation to GDP, only four of the world's 40 largest economies had a lower ratio (South Korea, Mexico, China and India – all of which had much lower Gini coefficients) (Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development 2011). The ANC government walked rightwards in 2016 – by imposing real budget cuts on state welfare spending, including central-municipal transfers and housing – but talked left about its revolutionary heritage and the threat from imperialist powers.

It may be that these manoeuvres ultimately will be considered self-defeating. The anger of the country's working class was ranked the highest among 140 countries by the World Economic Forum (2015) in its 2012–15 surveys. Protest rates included more than 2,000 'violent' uprisings annually, according to the police (Bond 2014). In addition to radical urban social movements, which had been protesting vigorously since the late 1990s, a new left party was elected to parliament with 6 per cent of the vote in 2014: the EFF. At that point, the continent's largest trade union – the National Union of Metalworkers of SA (Numsa) – was breaking away from the formal Alliance that conjoined the more conservative, pro-government Cosatu, SACP and ANC (Bond 2014). On May Day 2016, the drive to found a new socialist workers' federation was announced by unions representing nearly a million workers. Both the objective and subjective conditions necessary for a left challenge to the ANC's power appeared to be ripening. The ANC's neoliberal nationalism and welfare tokenism could lead to a new liberatory movement taking its place, and confusing talk-left, walk-right rhetoric would only slow that process marginally.

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9 ZANU-PF in power in Zimbabwe, 1980–2013

Towards explaining why former liberation movements fail as governments

Sabelo J. Ndlovu-Gatsheni

Introduction

The Zimbabwe African National Union-Patriotic Front (ZANU-PF) has been in power since 1980, and Zimbabweans have known only President Robert Mugabe as their leader since that date. However, ZANU-PF as a governing party has not lived up to the expectations of the people of Zimbabwe, who were at the time emerging from an era of abusive colonial government. The chapter posits that as a national liberation movement, ZANU-PF under President Mugabe was expected to deliver democracy, good governance, human security, social peace, human rights, human development, social cohesion and social justice after ascending to state power as part of the resolution of the national question that provoked the liberation struggle. It also posits that to measure the performance of a former liberation movement after ascending to power, it is important to clearly understand the intractable national question that cried out for resolution.

Thus, this chapter focuses on the national question, delineating its core lineages and highlighting its shifting character across time. Without this exercise, it is very difficult to critically assess the ideals, promises and dreams of the liberation struggle against which ZANU-PF's postcolonial performance as government is to be measured. The first section articulates a theoretical framework to enable a deeper understanding of the postcolonial performance of ZANU-PF as well as facilitating scientific explanation of what, fundamentally, went wrong in Zimbabwe. The theoretical framework is grounded in understanding the conception, constitution and configuration of 'the political' (concept and foundational normative principles) and concomitant political practice. The second section provides a generic definition of the national question and highlights the importance of taking into account historical, contextual and epochal shifts as well as contestations to understanding what constituted the national question. The third section assesses the performance of ZANU-PF as governing party. In the conclusion, the overshadowing of the national question by destructive factionalism in both ruling and opposition parties is highlighted. The conclusion also underscores the fact that the fundamental problem facing Zimbabwe is that of the constitution of

'the political' in terms of the 'will to power', thereby producing political practices that privilege struggles for state power rather than service to the people.

Constitution of the 'political' and crisis of governance

In her book *On the Political* (2005), leading political theorist Chantal Mouffe defines 'the political' as a domain of political philosophy and political theory dealing with norms, values, ideologies, ethics and humanism. Understood in this sense, 'the political' has to do with the 'ontological' questions, with the very way in which society is constituted. It is different from 'politics', which is the domain of political science, dealing with empirical aspects and pitched at the 'ontic' level – that is, a set of practices and institutions through which order is created, or the organisation of human coexistence in the context of conflict cascading from the political (Mouffe 2005: 8). Western political philosophy and political theory deriving from Plato, Machiavelli, Hobbes, Nietzsche, Clausewitz, and many others articulated 'the political' as fundamentally constituted by the 'will to power', as a 'paradigm of war' and a 'paradigm of difference' (see, for example, Hobbes 2010; Machiavelli 1992; Nietzsche 1968).

The reduction of 'the political' to the 'will to power' constituted the original corruption of the political and the distortion of its noble vocation and essential function (Dussel 2008: 3). This corruption deriving from what Dussel terms the 'fetishism of power' involving the rearticulation of the original vocation of politics, namely the 'will to live' as the 'will to power' (Dussel 2008: 3). In Dussel's philosophy of liberation, 'politics is above all that action that aspires towards the advancement of the life of the community, of the people, of humanity' (Dussel 2008: 61), but in the corruption of 'the political', the 'will to live' is 'negated by the Will-to-Power' of the powerful (Dussel 2008: 78).

For Dussel: 'Politics, as consensual and feasible Will-to-Live, should attempt through all means to allow all members to live, to live well, and to increase the quality of their lives' (Dussel 2008: 85). Put in simpler terms, the corruption of 'the political' takes the format of distortion, if not destruction, of the ethical, positive, progressive, emancipatory/liberatory and humanist vocation of politics. This is followed by 'the fetishism of power', in which a political leader becomes 'the centre or source of political power', rather than the political community defined as the people/citizens. Dussel elaborates on the corruption of power:

> This *corruption*, moreover, is double: it corrupts the governors who believe themselves to be the sovereign centre of power, and it corrupts the political community that allows itself (consents) to become *servile* rather than be an *actor* in the construction of the political (actions, institutions, principles).
>
> (Dussel 2008: 4)

Under corrupted 'political' power is simply exercised as domination and exploitation of ordinary citizens. The consequence is that people *survive* rather than *live*, and each day is about avoiding and postponing death. This situation

arises when 'power qua service' (exercise of power in the service of the political community) has been allowed to die (Dussel 2008: 130). When 'the political' is corrupted, power is understood as a 'thing, an object at hand, or a well-bound package' that has to be conquered, taken and then retained by all means necessary (Dussel 2008: 131). In this conception of 'the political', a political party becomes a simple 'electoral machine' used to 'conquer' and 'retain power'.

It is also in this context that politics is reduced to a narrow and violent road leading to the state house. A politics that is preoccupied with taking control of already corrupted institutions underpinned by 'fetishised power' structures will not benefit the political community/people/citizens/humanity but will result in what Frantz Fanon (1968) termed 'repetition without change' born of a flawed national consciousness that produces a skewed definition of the national question.

This conception of 'the political' has dominated the modern world since its birth 500 years ago. It has been naturalised and routinised by political philosophers and political theorists and reproduced across the human globe. The national liberation movements that were heavily interpellated by the immanent logic of colonialism could not escape this conception of 'the political'. Even their understanding of the national question and its resolution was hostage to dominant Eurocentric ideas. This is why Ramon Grosfoguel has no kind words for nationalism as a liberatory force:

> Nationalism provides Eurocentric solutions to a Eurocentric global problem. It reproduces an internal coloniality of power within each nation-state and reifies the nation-state as the privileged location of social struggle.… Struggles above and below the nation-state are not considered in nationalist political strategies. Moreover, nationalist responses to global capitalism reinforce the nation-state as the political institutional form par excellence of the modern/colonial/capitalist/patriarchal world-system. In this sense, nationalism is complicit with Eurocentric thinking and political structures.
>
> (Grosfoguel 2011: 18)

This argument explains why African nationalism has failed to escape the reproduction of racism, tribalism, sexism, patriarchy, repression, oppression, exploitation and all the other negatives of colonialism.

The national question

The Nigerian historian J. F. Ade Ajayi (2000: 239) made this challenging observation: 'Nowhere is nationalism and nation-states ready-made. It is a plant that can grow if properly nurtured and tended; if not it can be choked by greed and injustice'. The Tanzanian scholar Issa G. Shivji (2003: 8) lamented how 'nation-building turns into state-building. Nation is substituted by party and party by leader, the father of the nation. The National Question is reduced to a race question or ethnic question or cultural question'. These two interventions

speak to the postcolonial nation-state as a human invention that needed to be not only constructed and nurtured but also to the need to be on constant guard against negative forces bent on hijacking and redefining this product of the human mind, collective efforts, struggles and sacrifices, in the process conflating nation with state, party with the state, leader with party, and consequently producing uncaring dictatorial regimes dominated by personality cults, greed and injustice.

Once this situation is allowed, the national question undergoes a terribly skewed interpretation that reduces it to a race, ethnic, cultural or a simple colonial problem. The democratic and human rights aspects of the national question fall by the wayside as 'the will to power' takes precedence over everything else. The definition and understanding of the national question by the political elites is always informed by the 'will to power'. The Zimbabwe national question is not free of this definition and understanding. It is as complex as in any other postcolonial society and not easy to define. This is partly because the national question is an all-encompassing 'code word' for multifaceted struggles for liberation and multiple and contested quests for freedom (Ajayi 2000: 217). At the centre of any national question are vaguely defined 'national interests' that are open to various interpretations and manipulations. At the heart of the national question is the complex project of the social constitution/self-definition of a people involving construction of a myth of foundation, national identity and national history, otherwise known as *nation-building* (Ndlovu-Gatsheni 2009; Ndlovu-Gatsheni and Ndhlovu 2013; Raftopoulos and Mlambo 2009). It also entails the drive to construct a political constitution, otherwise known as *constitution-making/making of the basic law* to give political existence to a people and govern coexistence of individuals and groups within a nation state.

The constitution also gives life to the legitimate means and methods of accessing power (elections), acceptable modes of political practice and exercising power (governance and legitimacy), and rules for sharing power (separation of powers / devolution / decentralisation). These power issues constitute what is known as *state-making*, which sometimes degenerates into personal power consolidation. But the constitution also governs the modalities of accessing, owning, controlling, managing and distributing resources, otherwise known as *development*. This is why Rivkin (1969: 156) noted that 'nation-building and economic development … are twin goals and intimately related tasks, sharing many of the same problems, confronting many of the same challenges, and interrelating at many levels of public policy and practice'.

On the defence front, the national question speaks to safeguarding sovereignty and territorial integrity. Blessing-Miles Tendi's book *Making History in Mugabe's Zimbabwe: Politics, Intellectuals and the Media* (2010) highlights how questions of race, land, patriotism and sovereignty have constituted President Mugabe's and ZANU-PF's definition of the national question since the beginning of 2000s. These issues constituted what Terence Ranger termed a 'patriotic history', which was ranged against Western neo-imperialism (Ranger 2003).

Tendi elaborated on the concept of patriotic history and how it was used by ZANU-PF:

> Patriotic History asserts the centrality of Zimbabwe's radical revolutionary tradition and it is premised on four themes: land; race; a dichotomy between 'sell-outs' and 'patriots'; and the rejection of Western interference based on what are perceived as 'Western ideals' such as human rights.
>
> (Tendi 2010: 1)

What needs to be emphasised is that definition of the national question must take into account history, national context, global setting and epochal changes. As such, the national question cannot be understood as a static monologue, and that ordinarily consensus is often sought in understanding the national question. This question, in the words of Ajayi (2000: 218), assumes the status of 'perennial debate' on how to order relations between diverse people and ensure they have the 'same rights and privileges; … access to power and [an] equitable share of national resources'. The debate is inherently ongoing because citizens have to constantly evaluate whether nation and state are on the correct course, carrying them into a better future; whether governance institutions are still adequate to facilitating human progress and whether those in power still exercise it according to the social contract with the people.

Some broad lineages of the Zimbabwean national question are paradoxically interlocked. In the 1960s, the Zimbabwean national question emerged as a 'colonial question'. This is well documented in early nationalist literature such as Sithole's *African Nationalism* (1959); Shamuyarira's *Crisis in Rhodesia* (1965); Mlambo's, *Rhodesia: The Struggle for a Birth Right* (1972); and Dumbutshena's *Zimbabwe Tragedy* (1975). Sithole eloquently argued that African nationalism was against European domination, but not against the 'white man'. He elaborated that the basic elements of African nationalism included the

> African's desire to participate fully in the central government of the country; … for economic justice that recognizes … 'equal pay for equal work' regardless of the colours of the skin; … to have full political rights in his own country; his dislike for being treated as a stranger in the land of his birth; his dislike for the laws of the country that prescribe for him a permanent position of inferiority.
>
> (Sithole 1959: 37)

The first mass nationalist movement, the Southern Rhodesia African National Congress (SRANC) formed in 1957, tried to define the national question in its statement of principles:

> Its aim is the NATIONAL UNITY of all inhabitants of the country in true partnership regardless of race, colour and creed. It stands for a complete integrated society, equality of opportunity in every sphere and the social,

> economic and political advancement of all. It regards these objectives as the essential foundation of that partnership between people of all races without which there can be no peaceful progress in this country.
>
> Congress affirms complete loyalty to the Crown as the symbol of national unity. It is not a racial movement. It is equally opposed to tribalism and racialism. It welcomes all of any race who are in sympathy with the aims and are prepared to fulfill the conditions of membership. It recognizes the rights of all who are citizens of the country, whether African, European, Coloured or Asian, to retain permanently the fullest citizenship. It believes that this country can only advance through non-racial thinking and acting, and that an integrated society provides the only alternative to tribalism and racialism.
>
> (Southern Rhodesia African National Congress 1957: 3)

Despite these moderate demands, the Rhodesian colonial state reacted harshly by banning the party, arresting its leaders and imprisoning them in 1959. This harsh treatment resulted in radicalisation of African nationalist demands. For example, the National Democratic Party (NDP) that succeeded the SRANC defined itself as 'a political party initiated and led by Africans' dedicated to 'the struggle for, and attainment of freedom for African people of Southern Rhodesia' (Samkange 1979: 21). Unlike SRANC, NDP demanded 'one man one vote' as a solution to the 'Rhodesia problem', while at the same time committing itself to 'working in conjunction with other freedom organisations in Africa for the establishment and maintenance of democracy in Africa and the achievement of Pan-Africanism' (Samkange 1979: 21). The Zimbabwe African People's Union (ZAPU) and the Zimbabwe African National Union (ZANU) that succeeded NDP committed themselves to fight for 'one man one vote as the basis of government' and to unite African people against colonialism and imperialism as forms of oppression. In its policy statement of 21 August 1963, ZANU committed itself to building 'the ZANU state' and made the following promises, which encapsulated its conception and understanding of the national question:

> a ZANU will establish a nationalist, democratic, socialist and Pan-Africanist republic within the fraternity of African states and the British Commonwealth of Nations.
> b The only form of franchise that the ZANU Republic will recognize is one based on 'one man one vote'.
> c In the organisation of the ZANU state the principles of the rule of law and separation of powers shall be strictly adhered to.
> d The ZANU republic shall be a unitary and indivisible state.
> e The ZANU republic shall be based on the principles of non-racialism.
>
> (Zimbabwe African National Union 1979: 65)

At its inaugural congress on 12–13 May 1964 in Gwelo (now Gweru), founder president Reverend Ndabaningi Sithole asserted that 'ZANU … stands for

democracy, socialism, nationalism, one man one vote, freedom, Pan-Africanism, non-racialism and republicanism' (Sithole 1979: 57). What is intriguing is the use of the term 'the ZANU state'. Does it mean that from as early as the 1960s, party and state were conflated? If so, then it is not surprising that at the end of the liberation struggle the postcolonial nation state was born as a 'party state' and a 'party nation', to borrow the words of Norma Kriger (2003).

The adoption of the armed liberation struggle further radicalised conceptions of the national question. With the adoption of Marxism-Leninism-Maoism-Castroism, anti-racism and 'one man one vote' were no longer the only key issues. The land question and radical transformation of society along socialist lines became a prominent part of the anti-colonial liberation struggle. No longer was full participation in the central government desired, rather the colonial state had to be destroyed and a new egalitarian socialist state built on its ashes (Ranger 1980: 71). The nationalist movements, particularly ZANU, worked actively to cast itself as carrier of the burden of history, and consistently linked its struggle to the primary resistance of the 1890s, thus claiming as ordained heir to be blessed by the oracular messages of spirit mediums such as Nehanda and Kaguvi (Chitando 2002, 2005; Ranger 1977). This connection is well articulated in David Lan's *Guns and Rain: Guerrillas and Spirit Mediums in Zimbabwe* (1985).

ZANU was combining Marxist-Leninist ideas of vanguardism with claims of oracular blessing to position itself as the most enlightened and legitimate embodiment, representative, articulator, interpreter and promulgator of the national question (Martin and Johnson 1981). *Chimurenga*, interpreted as violent nationalist revolution, became the solution to the multifaceted national question (Ndlovu-Gatsheni 2012). In short, the act of spearheading the armed anti-colonial liberation struggle was used by ZANU to claim the right to define and interpret the national question. Rosa Luxemburg (1976: 141) once posed the question: 'Does there exist one political party which would not claim that it alone, among all others, truly expresses the will of the "nation," whereas all other parties give perverted and false expressions of the national will?'

Right up to the Lancaster House negotiations of 1979, liberation movements and 'nationalist' elites were involved in serious and even violent competition over whose movement represented the 'will of the nation', defined as the oppressed and colonised black people of Zimbabwe. The political campaigns during the 1980 elections were partly about who represented the nation's will. ZANU-PF's electoral success in 1980 reinforced its belief that it was the only authentic voice of the people. At the end of the 1990s and during the 2000s, contestations over who represented the 'will of the nation' returned to the national agenda with renewed importance.

ZANU-PF's performance in government

With the achievement of political independence, the national question, from being a colonial question, became one of nation-building and state-making.

Anti-colonial nationalism had to be transformed into a new national patriotism (Kaunda 1975). Such unions of convenience as the Patriotic Front (PF) of 1976 did not have the potential to translate anti-colonial nationalism into post-colonial national patriotism.[1] Unity, or the lack of it, has haunted the liberation movements and the postcolonial nation state in equal measure.

Unity as a concept was used with reference to black people, whereas an unwritten policy of reconciliation was proclaimed in 1980 as part of a project to allay the fears of whites. There was no policy on black unity, but this was desperately needed for the postcolonial nation and state to emerge. The armed forces had to be integrated into the Zimbabwe National Army (ZNA) (Musemwa 1995); the success of the coalition government depended on the unity of political elites; black people had to be united if a new nation was to be born. Zimbabwe, like other postcolonial societies, was constituted by a kaleidoscope of ethnic and racial groups, and ethnicity had always worked against unity in the past. Trying to impose national unity by force of arms resulted in the commission of atrocities in Matebeleland and the Midlands regions two years into independence (CCJP and LRF 1997).

Lack of unity had implications for economic development as well. Between 1982 and 1987, efforts were made to deal with the so-called 'dissident' problem, which in reality meant military conquest of Matebeleland and the Midlands regions, where the opposition ZAPU continued to enjoy support. Only the signing of the unity accord on 22 December 1987 brought to an end the low intensity war that had cost the lives of over 20,000 Ndebele-speaking civilians. But the post-1980 national question also entailed deracialisation and Africanisation as a marker of the achievement of political independence. More importantly, the new government had to begin to deliver services and development in fulfilment of liberation war promises. People expected a better economic and social life as well as a democratic environment different from what they endured under the colonial regime. From the people's perspective, the national question could be rendered as:

- Ending poverty and underdevelopment imposed on the African people during 90 years of colonial rule;
- Bridging the gap between the poor, formerly colonised and the rich, mainly the former colonisers, in terms of equitable wealth redistribution, increased income and greater opportunities. This entailed deracialisation of the patterns of ownership of productive property;
- Ensuring economic growth and sustainable development; and
- Entrenching democracy and ensuring greater participation by the people in the system of governance.

While there were indeed commendable efforts to deliver education and health services, there was more continuity in terms of the politics of repression and authoritarianism. This is why Mandaza (1986) characterised the Zimbabwean state in the 1980s as a 'schizophrenic'. While trying to uplift previously

impoverished black people, the same state tended to repress them politically. The first decade of independence was the most progressive in terms of service delivery, yet the Willowgate Scar Scandal,[2] indicated where the country was going. The ZANU-PF political elite, which had presented itself as socialist and concerned with the welfare of the people, had begun to 'chew' the Leadership Code. Colonial primitive accumulation was succeeded by black primitive accumulation. James Muzondidya's conclusion on the postcolonial project is correct:

> While at independence in 1980, the ZANU-PF government committed itself to establishing a more cohesive nation-state based on democracy, reconciliation, social justice and equality, and tried to transform and democratize the structure of governance in urban and rural areas through decentralization of powers and resources to local authorities, its post-colonial project of building a just, equitable and non-racial society was not achieved in the 1980s and the foundation for a truly democratic order was not laid.
>
> (Muzondidya 2011: 8)

What was laid was an authoritarian political system carried over from the Rhodesian Front by ZANU-PF, but hidden behind a façade of constitutional democracy (Ncube 1991). The introduction of an executive presidency marked the beginning of Zimbabwe's overt descent into authoritarianism and open corruption: the Lancaster House constitution began to undergo constant amendment; the Leadership Code was abandoned; and a drive towards a one-party state was forcefully attempted. In addition, an Economic Structural Adjustment Programme (ESAP) was introduced, despite opposition from workers, students and progressive intellectuals. All these developments were taking place in the absence of a credible opposition, since ZAPU had been swallowed up in 1987. While the Zimbabwe Unity Movement (ZUM) under Edgar Tekere managed to mobilise people against the one-party state, it soon fizzled out after the 1990 elections. Emergent political formations such as the Zimbabwe Union of Democrats (ZUD) under Margaret Dongo, United Parties (UP) under Bishop Abel Muzorewa and others failed to challenge ZANU-PF effectively. Fortunately, civil society formations such as the Zimbabwe Congress of Trade Unions (ZCTU), Zimbabwe National Association of Student Unions (ZINASU) and the National Constitutional Assembly (NCA) became more vocal and tried to fill the void (Raftopoulos 2001).

It was during this period that President Mugabe decided to coopt the increasingly vocal and critical war veterans, who for many years had been neglected, and awarded them lump sums of Z$50,000 as compensation for their sacrifices during the liberation struggle. Soon after, Mugabe decided to send the Zimbabwean military to the Democratic Republic of Congo to support the failing (and unelected) regime of Laurent Kabila. These two decisions were made when the national economy was failing and ordinary people were hard hit by ESAP (Mlambo 1997). Thus, the origins of Zimbabwe's economic collapse are traceable to this period, although they had even deeper roots in the untransformed

colonial economy. The Zimbabwean national currency plummeted and inflation increased. Apathy during elections indicated that ZANU-PF was losing popularity.

But without a credible opposition, ZANU-PF continued to dominate politically and even became complacent. However, despite its attempts to use violence and other means to penetrate, control and dominate society, it failed to establish its hegemony over the population. As noted by Muzondidya (2009: 200):

> Throughout the 1980s and early 1990s, the government struggled to impose itself and its political ideals on the nation. Its power continued to be challenged by a number of groups and individuals who felt excluded from both the national project of development and the structures of political and economic power. Such challenges ensured that there were always spaces in which the state's unpopular policies could be questioned, and that democratic tendencies were able to coexist, however uneasily.

The national question began to be articulated in terms of constitutionalism, with the NCA and other civil society organisations demanding a new people-driven constitution to replace the much-amended Lancaster House constitution. The principle of separation of powers was heavily compromised by a powerful and interventionist executive arm of government and the rule of law was under threat. Globally, a discourse on democracy and human rights cascaded down from the shift from the Cold War to neoliberalism. At the continental level, the 1990s witnessed a 'third wave of democracy' that swept away some of the longstanding dictatorial regimes and one-party regimes (Huntington 1993). It was during this period that Francis Fukuyama resurrected the Hegelian idea of the 'end of history and the last man' in his celebration of the triumph of neoliberal ideology (Fukuyama 1992). It was, therefore, not surprising that the 1990s were dominated by a new articulation of the national question in terms of democratisation and human rights discourse. ZANU-PF had allowed both these aspects of the national question to slide off the national radar screen as it pushed for greater regime security at whatever cost. Increasingly, democracy and human rights began to be castigated as alien ideas.

The formation of the Movement for Democratic Change (MDC) in September 1999 was a culmination of these democratic and human rights demands and reflected the realisation that Zimbabwe needed a strong opposition with the potential to unseat ZANU-PF. MDC was further emboldened by the defeat of the ZANU-PF sponsored 'yes vote' in the referendum of February 2000 on the constitution. The late 1990s had also witnessed increasing demands by landless peasants, war veterans and the emerging black bourgeois, which had organised themselves into bodies such as the Affirmative Action Group (AAG), for increased black embourgeoisement. This meant increased access to economic sectors still dominated by the white minority. ZANU-PF was thus under pressure to deliver on land on one hand and on democracy

and human rights on the other. Increasingly, at the beginning of the 2000s, ZANU-PF used historic land grievances and memories of the liberation struggle as an effective political tool to regain popularity, particularly among rural people, who had experienced the guerrilla war directly and were still desperate for land.

Meanwhile, MDC was pushing for democracy and human rights, and criticised ZANU-PF's nationalist discourse as 'top-down, centralized, always trapped in a time warp' and its governance as being 'based on patronage and cronyism' (Tsvangirai 2000). ZANU-PF responded by mobilising its structures of violence and even bragged of its violent history, in the process inviting regular military forces and militias to defend the partisan regime. In this context, the commanders of the armed forces expressed open support for Mugabe during the presidential campaign. Morgan Tsvangirai on 28 December 2005 wrote a letter to President Mugabe, copied to the chairman of the African Union (AU), the UN Secretary-General and the chairman of the Southern African Development Community (SADC), complaining of how the defence forces and police were being mobilised and used as 'combative political units of your party ZANU-PF' in violation of the Defence Act, Police Act and the national constitution (Tsvangirai 2005; Ndlovu-Gatsheni 2006).

This type of politics placed political violence and repression at the centre of the national debate. These issues had haunted postcolonial Zimbabwe since Operation Gukurahundi in the 1980s, and were resurfacing in the early 2000s to engulf the rest of the country. The question of violence became linked with the question of political legitimacy, with ZANU-PF being accused of rigging elections. Violence reached its zenith during the presidential run-off of June 2008, from which Tsvangirai was eventually forced to withdraw (Masunungure 2009: 79). Throughout the post-2000 period, ZANU-PF also used land redistribution as the main deliverable and central leitmotif of the *Third Chimurenga* (Mugabe 2001). Raftopoulos summarises the core issues well:

> From the late 1990s Zimbabwe entered a period that has come to be known generally as the 'Crisis in Zimbabwe'. This upheaval consisted of a combination of political and economic decline that, while it had its origins in the long-term structural economic and political legacies of colonial rule as well as the political legacies of African nationalist politics, exploded onto the scene in the face of a major threat to the political future of the ruling party, ZANU (PF). The crisis became manifest in multiple ways: confrontations over land and property rights; contestations over the history and meanings of nationalism and citizenship; the emergence of critical civil society organisations campaigning around trade union, human rights and constitutional questions; the restructuring of the state in more authoritarian forms; the broader pan-African and anti-imperialist meanings of the struggle in Zimbabwe; the cultural representations of the crisis in Zimbabwean literature; and the role of Robert Mugabe.
>
> (Raftopoulos 2009: 201–2)

It was during this period that the Zimbabwean national question assumed international proportions, with sanctions being imposed and external mediation taking place. The national question also took on deeply humanitarian dimensions, including lack of food and health problems, not least cholera outbreaks. With the physical beating of MDC and civic leaders, including Tsvangirai, on 11 March 2007, external pressure for the resolution of the Zimbabwean crisis escalated and South Africa was mandated to lead the mediation. This initiative produced the Global Political Agreement of 2008 and the Inclusive Government of February 2009. Raftopoulos's *The Hard Road to Reform: The Politics of Zimbabwe's Global Political Agreement* (2013) provides the most comprehensive analysis of the period from 2009 to 2012. As the title of the book conveys, democratic reform was the main issue facing the Inclusive Government, along with attempts to stabilise the troubled economy. At the same time, political elites within the MDC factions and ZANU-PF became engaged in contestation over control of the state, while also remaining on a political campaign footing. Masunungure and Shumba (2012: xiv) capture this Inclusive Government episode thus:

> Two sets of opposing forces are locked in a bitter and protracted contest for supremacy. These are the old guard regime forces (which have historically held power) personified by incumbent President Mugabe and his Zimbabwe African Union Patriotic Front … party on the one hand, and, on the other, the two formations of the Movement for Democratic Change … which until the Inclusive Government … have historically been out of power. Until 2008, the former had ruled Zimbabwe as a dominant and de facto one-party regime, resisting any changes that threatened its continued prolongation in power and the perquisites of that power brings. The two MDC formations have been fighting for change for over a decade, with Morgan Tsvangirai personifying their epic struggle.

As noted by Raftopoulos (2013: xv), the national question became entangled in 'conflicting notions of change' itself. To ZANU-PF, the main problem with the Inclusive Government was the continuation of sanctions, whereas for the MDC formations, the emphasis was on internal democratic reform and delivery of a people-driven new constitution. The constitution-making process became another area of struggle among the three political parties and was used as a dress-rehearsal for the elections. The smaller MDC-N pushed for devolution of power, which became its main campaign slogan during the July 2013 elections. The 31 July 2013 elections marked the triumph of ZANU-PF over its adversaries. What ZANU-PF had been struggling to achieve was sustainable economic recovery and full recognition by the international community. This is why Raftopoulos has argued that:

> The mixed policy messaging of the Mugabe regime can be attributed both to the challenges of seeking fuller international re-engagement while holding on to its empowerment programme, and the tensions within

> ZANU-PF about how to proceed with such a re-engagement. The tropes of sovereignty, liberation history, regional solidarity and empowerment have been integral to ZANU-PF political imaginary and 'language of stateness,' in both the party's 'practical language of governance' and the 'symbolic language of authority'. However, the exposure of the limits of the state's capacity to effect its indigenisation programme has led to the dual strategy of seeking a rapprochement with the West, while promising to export the Zimbabwean model to the SADC region.
>
> (Raftopoulos 2014)

The Zimbabwean minister of finance and economic planning, Patrick Chinamasa, has been clear about Zimbabwe's drive towards re-engagement with the international community by stating that the country is open for foreign direct investment from all over the world:

> Let the message go out loud and clear that Zimbabwe is ready to reintegrate into the global economy. Zimbabwe is looking for new friendships; new opportunities while consolidating old ones. We are looking for mutual beneficial economic relationships not confrontation. We are too small a country to pursue a policy of confrontation.
>
> (Chinamasa 2014: 3)

One can only regret that the same message of non-confrontation was not delivered to the local civil society organisations and non-governmental organisations (NGOs) that were at the forefront of the struggle for regime change.

Conclusion: Redefinition of the national question beyond 2013

To Brian Raftopoulos,

> the events of 31 July 2013 represented not simply a return to certain continuities of ZANU(PF) rule, but also a reconstitution of the political terrain in Zimbabwe, particularly around the immediate future of opposition politics in the country, and the possible implication of the Zimbabwean experience for regional politics.
>
> (2014b: 972)

According to Raftopoulos, the post-31 July 2013 marked 'the end of era', and his position is that:

> It is fair to conclude that the politics of political and civic opposition that emerged in the late 1990s and continued through the first 13 years of the 2000s has come to an end it its current form. The political and economic conditions that gave rise to its emergence have changed substantially and

> the social forces that have emerged … pose new challenges for party and civic organisation and mobilisation.
>
> (Raftopoulos 2014b: 986)

If one articulates the national question from the perspective of the opposition MDC and allied civil society organisations and NGOs, one can agree with Raftopoulos that the elections took place when the democracy and human rights discourses that emerged at the end of the Cold War, but had their roots in the unfolding of neoliberalism and the Washington Consensus, had lost their popularity. But one wonders whether if one articulates the national question from the ZANU-PF perspective, the political change brought about by those elections amounted to a restoration of the national liberation Pan-Africanist, anti-colonial, anti-imperial, and anti-West discourse in Zimbabwe to the extent that even the newest political formation, the National Constitutional Assembly launched in September 2013, articulated its ideological orientation in those terms.

This claim should not be misread to mean that the past 13 years or so of struggle for democracy and human rights did not alter the political landscape such that a return to pre-2000 and pre-2009 modes of governance and political practice by ZANU-PF was almost impossible. As Raftopoulos (2010) has argued, 'a passive revolution' in the Gramscian sense has taken place. At the same time, committed cadres of ZANU-PF like George Charamba did not fail to recognise the triumph of the Nationalist-Pan-Africanist discourse and its adoption by the opposition. He noted:

> A new sensitivity is gaining currency in the opposition. There is a quest for new forms of opposing but without descending into the reflex of negativism, of automatic contrarieties. The likes of Lovemore Madhuku, shoots of this new opposition, now realize that durable opposition can only be premised on a reverent embrace of politics and values of liberation, something the two MDCs rejected.
>
> (Manheru 2013)

The end of the democracy and human rights discourse as the ideology of the opposition MDC was also highlighted by Ncube. To him, the outcome of 2013 elections marked the 'end of an era for human rights discourse':

> The strategy of the previous opposition to discredit the ZANU-PF regime's legitimacy in nearly every post-2000 election carried weight because of the latter's complicity in human rights abuses and violations. The peacefulness of the 2013 elections and the absence of gross human rights abuses by ZANU-PF not only during these elections but since the formation of the coalition government in 2009 seem to have diminished the effectiveness of the rights-based discourse as a tool to make morally and politically based demands of or claims against the state.
>
> (Ncube 2013: 100–1)

The other major shift after the elections happened at the regional, continental and to some extent international level. SADC and the AU were able to disengage from their decade-long preoccupation with the legitimacy crisis in Zimbabwe, with the SADC election observation mission not only endorsing the election outcome but declaring that 'a new chapter in the … consolidation of democracy in the Republic of Zimbabwe [had] been opened' (SADC Election Observer Mission 2013).

What Zimbabwe has failed to achieve is the reorientation of 'the political' from the 'will to power' to a new 'will to live' that privileges the people. The drive for a new constitution after the end of the 1990s, and further boosted during the Inclusive Government, was one indication of the quest to rebuild the foundations of 'the political' in Zimbabwe. Now Zimbabwe has a new constitution, although perhaps not the one those fighting for democracy expected. One challenge has been to breathe life into it and to ensure that those who govern do so in compliance with it.

This is one area where civil society has a leading role to play. ZANU-PF gained full legitimacy after winning the 31 July 2013 elections and the region and continent have fully re-embraced the ZANU-PF government. Zimbabwe is the current SADC chair and is actively involved at the leadership level of the AU, all indications of acceptance. Only the United States, the European Union, Britain and other Western states have not fully embraced the ZANU-PF government, but the hostility has de-escalated since 31 July 2013.

What is the stance of locally based civil society organisations and their funding agencies on this changed reality? Ideally, they should engage with the legitimate government of Zimbabwe without losing their role as the conscience of society. The question of political values is another major area open to civil society in pushing for a national development plan to carry Zimbabweans into the future. This point was clearly made by veteran nationalist and ZAPU president Dumiso Dabengwa (2011: 2):

> I am under no illusion this time around that simply changing the colour of the oppressor like we did when we removed Smith and put a black Mugabe in power or simply replacing an 87-year president with a much younger one will do the magic. *We need to change the system first and foremost, more than we just need to change the person.*

To Dabengwa (2011: 2), 'the national question that has bothered each one of us is how do we transform Zimbabwe from a pseudo-democracy to a real democratic nation-state'. Without radical change to the conception, constitution and configuration of 'the political', which has a profound effect on Zimbabwe's political practices, we will be left with a pseudo-democracy backed by a façade of constitutionalism.

Notes

1 The PF was imposed on ZAPU and ZANU by the leaders of the frontline states and the Organisation of African Unity's liberation committee.
2 This involved the illegal resale of vehicles by government officials.

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Part IV

Liberation struggles against annexation by neighbouring countries



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10 Struggle mentality versus democracy

The case of SWAPO of Namibia[1]

Henning Melber

Introduction

Each decolonisation process can claim a degree of uniqueness, based on the historical features of the particular society and its social forces. One should therefore abstain from premature generalisation. There are certain common features, however, shared among the following liberation movements: the Zimbabwe African National Union (ZANU), the South West African People's Organisation (SWAPO) of Namibia[2] and the African National Congress of South Africa (ANC). In the process of decolonisation, all of them attained decisive political power and placed the 'party machinery' at the centre of the emerging system of governance. The emphasis on free elections and an agreed constitutional framework for an orderly transition and transfer of political power to the erstwhile liberation movements of Zimbabwe (1980), Namibia (1990) and South Africa (1994) suggests similarities in terms of shaping the postcolonial environment (cf. Southall 2013). In all these cases, their legitimacy is based on the claim to represent the majority of the people. At the same time, however, the democratic notion is also contested territory. Postcolonial policies in these countries have at times revealed a lack of commitment to democratic principles and/or practices. The movements' fight against unjust systems of oppression rooted in totalitarian rule by racist white minority regimes did not prevent them from falling prey themselves to undemocratic practices deployed against dissenting forces.

As a long-time South African ANC activist suggests, liberation movements represented a distinct notion of family. There was a general suppression of 'the personal' in favour of 'the collective'. Individual judgment (and thereby autonomy) was substituted by the collective decisions of the leadership. Such 'warrior culture … militarist tradition', according to him, 'entailed not only heroic acts but also many cases of abuse and power' (Suttner 2008: 119). As he further observes, this type of applied 'patriotic history' defiantly refuses to acknowledge any meaningful and legitimate opposition and equates the liberation movement with the emerging nation. The dominant narrative is

> a language of unity and a language that tends to represent the unified people as embodied in the liberation movement organisation and then

> equates them with the people as a whole.…In a sense the liberation movement depicts itself as a proto-state.
>
> (Suttner 2006: 24, original emphasis)

This chapter examines the trajectory of SWAPO from former liberation movement to being the sole government since independence, thereby exploring the 'limits to liberation' (Melber 2003a) in the political sphere.

Patriotic history and paternal nation-building

A new political elite operating from the commanding heights of the state induced a dominant public discourse about postcolonial Namibian society (cf. Melber 2003b). It cultivated selective narratives and memories related to the anti-colonial struggle to establish an exclusive legitimacy under the sole authority of one particular set of social forces. The glorification of resistance and its sacrifices served as the cradle for the identity of the new Namibian nation. This had a lasting impact on an already deep-rooted mindset in postcolonial society, as evidenced by the national anthem, which begins: 'Namibia, land of the brave, freedom fight we have won, glory to the bravery, whose blood watered our freedom'. Although inclusivity was claimed, by implication the historical narrative was based on the exclusivity of those declared to be liberators.

National public holidays were monopolised by SWAPO. Although 10 December was originally celebrated as 'Human Rights Day', in the Namibian context this date conjures up the memory of violent oppression in 1959, when police opened fire on demonstrators protesting against the planned forcible removal of black urban residents from the 'old location' in Windhoek to the new township of Katutura, killing 11 of them. It has been renamed the 'Day of Namibian Women' in accordance with a decision by the SWAPO majority in parliament. Each year on 4 May 'Cassinga Day' is celebrated as a public holiday to commemorate the biggest single massacre of refugees in exile, while 26 August remains 'Heroes Day' to memorialise the sacrifices made during the struggle. The UN had earlier dubbed this holiday 'Namibia Day' to commemorate the beginnings of the armed struggle in Omgulumbashe in northern Namibian.[3] Since independence, a memorial has been erected there and on Heroes Day 2013 a statute of Sam Nujoma, the first president of SWAPO and of Namibia, was unveiled there. Now in his mid-80s, Nujoma attended the ceremony in military combat dress.

The war memorial constructed in Omgulumbashe was complemented by a Heroes' Acre in the mountains to the south of the capital Windhoek, designed and constructed by the same North Korean contractor. The triumphant images displayed there:

> clearly embody the vision of victors who lay claim, in Walter Benjamin's words, to the heritage 'of all who have ever prevailed before'. However, in so doing they not only deny the existence of actual cleavages, including the

> social realignments that have occurred after independence with the rise of a black elite. By glossing over social contradictions, these winners of the entire process also acknowledge symbolically their cross-over on the side of domination.
>
> (Kössler 2007: 370)

This North Korean company has also designed and built a military museum in Okahandja and an independence museum in Windhoek. Critics dubbed the latter a 'coffee machine' because of its architectural features. Opened on Independence Day 2014, the history displays have been strongly criticised for their omissions, flaws, distortions and even outright manipulations.

The Namibian policy arena and its symbolic configuration in the public sphere reflect the preferences of a former liberation movement that was content to seize political control and establish its own elite politics within overall socioeconomic structures existing at independence. The catchwords of 'national reconciliation' and 'affirmative action' did not contradict one another. They were two reference points within a status quo-oriented policy of cooption and integration into existing class and property relations. Affirmative action was mainly applied to gain comparative advantage by occupying new higher positions in the state and administration, thereby securing access to further influence and privilege. This approach served the class interests of a new elite in the making, which benefited from its closeness to the party as the centre of political power. Consequently, in contrast to the militant rhetoric, substantial aspects of socioeconomic transformation remained untouched or underwent at best cosmetic change (cf. Melber 2007).

In the absence of credible political alternatives, SWAPO managed to entrench its political dominance by obtaining an ever-higher proportion of votes in a basically legitimate way (Table 10.1).

The absolute majority obtained during the UN-supervised elections of 1989 was only the prelude to the further consolidation of power. The far-reaching mandate obtained after the first parliamentary elections in the sovereign Namibian state in November 1994 encouraged the misperception that the government is supposed to serve the party and that the state is the property of government, and hence owned by the party. The two-thirds majority allowed the party to initiate its first amendment of the country's constitution in 1998. Despite objections from most other political parties, SWAPO's representatives in both the National Assembly and the National Council adopted the constitutional modification that allowed its president a third term as head of state. From a formal point of view, this far-reaching policy intervention was legitimate and based on a mandate secured through a general election. It was also considered as welcome continuity even among some of those not in favour of SWAPO's dominance, who argued that under President Nujoma democracy had prevailed. Yet such a seemingly pragmatic argument could also be interpreted to indicate that Namibia had not yet managed to establish a sustainable democracy, which would require 'the consolidation of institutional, social and legal frameworks which make the process of open

Table 10.1 Parliamentary Election Results 1989–2009 for Bigger Parties (*total votes and per cent*)

Party	*1989*	*1994*	*1999*	*2004*	*2009*	*2014*
SWAPO	384,567 56.9%	361,800 73.89%	408,174 76.15%	620,609 75.83%	602,580 74.29%	715,026 80.01%
DTA	191,532 28.34%	101,748 20.78%	50,824 9.48%	42,070 5.14%	25,393 3.13%	42,933 4.8%
UDF	37,874 5.6%	13,309 2.72%	15,685 2.93%	30,355 3.71%	19,489 2.40%	18,945 2.12%
CoD	– –	– –	53,289 9.94%	59,464 7.27%	5,375 0.66%	3,402 0.38%
RDP	–	– –	– –	– –	90,556 11.16%	31,372 3.51%

Source: The figures are compiled from official data released by the directorate of elections. The Democratic Turnhalle Alliance (DTA) was an anti-SWAPO alliance of parties that had prior to independence been willing to serve as a so-called interim government in collaboration with South Africa. The United Democratic Front (UDF) is an ethnic-regional party mainly drawing on support from the Damara-speaking community. The Congress of Democrats (CoD) and the Rally for Democracy and Progress (RDP) were new parties formed by SWAPO dissidents.

political communication independent of the persons who happen to be in power' (Abbink 2000: 7). Viewing the head of the party and state as the ultimate guarantor of more or less acceptable continuity suggests, rather, support for the 'big man syndrome', which is anything but democratic.

According to an empirical survey undertaken a decade after independence among 1,000 persons over 18 and residing in 10 of the country's 13 regions, Namibian democracy (and by implication social stability) was deeply and confidently associated with SWAPO as the exclusive agent for liberation, and even more so with the person of the first president of the republic. The outstanding legitimacy of the president and his image as 'father of the nation' were to a large extent personalised. The initial stages of Namibia's democracy therefore did benefit from trust in the political leadership. This trust in the person of the president, which is difficult to disentangle from trust in the state, allowed for the consolidation of a political culture within democratically defined rules. Hence identification with the ruling party can hardly be distinguished from satisfaction with democracy:

> It is generally hard to know which came first: trust in particular state institutions or satisfaction with democracy. But even if the relationship is reciprocal, it points to the centrality of core political values – like trust in government – in the syndrome of democratic culture.
>
> (Bratton and Mattes 2001a: 468)

Based on experiences during the first decade of independence it could therefore be concluded that the scope of Namibian democracy very much depended

on the attitudes and practices of both SWAPO party office bearers in general and the head of state in particular. Their practice of and respect for democratic rules of the game could have had a decisively positive impact upon the future prospects of a democratic political culture among the majority of the Namibian population. At the same time, however, these same players eroded the very concept and meaning of democracy by statements that revealed an attitude of placing their own organisation above accountability or loyalty to normative principles vested in the constitution (Melber 2000). While national reconciliation was much trumpeted, it stopped short of reconciliation with SWAPO's own victims in exile, but rather took the form of a kind of elite pact combined with the concept of affirmative action, translated into privileges for comrades. A SWAPO media statement 'on the so-called detainee issue', published in response to revelations of the movement's human rights violations in exile in a book by a German pastor (Groth 1995), and the subsequent discussions, showed a degree of disrespect towards the marginalised who were seeking justice and redress. The party argued it could not 'allow this country to be made ungovernable and be turned into a chaotic and lawless society by irresponsible, unpatriotic elements and foreign remainents (sic) of fascism and apartheid' (SWAPO Party 1996: 1). Using similar rhetoric, other initiatives seen as challenging the dominant party were belittled or ridiculed.

Already in the mid-1990s, it was noted that as a legacy of both colonialism and the struggle against foreign rule, a 'psychosis of fear is permeating the entire Namibian society' (Diescho 1996: 16). A culture of silence, whereby 'good patriots' don't criticise, had become part of Namibia's political reality. One prominent Namibian businessmen observed in the mid-1990s that neither churches nor private sector 'are, in fact, sufficiently aware of their duty and still less it seems willing to do their duty of speaking up on matters appertaining to maintenance and preservation of moral, ethical and social values and standards' (Pupkewitz 1996: 81).

After a decade of independence, Namibia's political culture displayed some disturbing features. A survey conducted in six African countries by the Southern African Democracy Barometer ranked Namibia last in terms of public awareness of democracy (Mattes *et al.* 2000). A summary of the report concluded, with reference to Namibia and Nigeria, that 'the consolidation of democracy is a distant prospect in both these countries' (Bratton and Mattes 2001b: 120). The Helen Suzman Foundation, in its survey of six Southern African states during the late 1990s, found that Namibia was the only country in which a defeat of the leading party would not be accepted by a large majority (Johnson 1998). Another survey of Namibians aged 18 to 32 concluded: 'Namibia does not have sufficient young Democrats to make the consolidation of democracy a foregone conclusion' (Keulder and Spilker 2002: 28).

It would, however, be too one-sided, 'to lay the burden of democracy on only the Government itself' (Boer 2004: 8). Given the relatively high degree of press freedom and the impressive number of independent and politically alert print media, the lack of critical public discourse is as much due to the failure of the

opposition parties and other civil society actors. There is a sufficient arena for articulating dissenting views – although at times at the risk of loss of personal material security. Given the dependence of many citizens on employment by state agencies or related institutions under the political influence of the new elite, individual articulation of dissent at times puts jobs at risk. These bread-and-butter concerns are a major impediment to strengthening a civil society opposed to the hegemonic power structure in place and may contribute to 'the very familiar African scenario of politicised ethnic identities, monocratic and highly-personalised rule with no or very little opposition from the private sphere and a large-scale disengagement of a disillusioned citizenry from the political arena' (Keulder 1996: 88).

Authoritarian state and mindset: democracy under siege

In response to the establishment in 1998 of the Congress of Democrats (CoD) as a new political party by former higher-ranking SWAPO cadres objecting to the lack of internal democracy, the SWAPO election manifesto of 1999 denounced any political opposition by making a mockery of the very same democratic notion it based its legitimacy upon. It declared that 'saving democracy, or more appropriately saving the opposition', was 'the latest version of Europe's burden to civilise the natives' (SWAPO Party/Department of Information and Publicity 1999: 24). Loyalty to Namibia was equated with loyalty to SWAPO and its policies, and there was a failure to differentiate between formal democratic legitimacy (through the number of votes obtained in a free and fair election) and the moral and ethical dimensions and responsibilities of such legitimacy. As a result, and as noted about political culture elsewhere in African societies, 'the state often uses democracy to perpetuate hegemony rather than to advance rights, liberty and democracy. The adoption of non-democratic measures is often justified against the backdrop of achieving 'national' objectives through a democratic mandate' (Salih 2000: 24).

Ever since independence, election results have supported the ruling party's understanding that state assets are useful instruments at the disposal of those holding political power. The way in which party office bearers as public servants abused their access to state-owned facilities during the election campaigns confirmed the existence of the misperception that equated party with government and government with state. The dominance and control asserted by SWAPO over the state and its administration seems to be of greater interest to the party than the legitimacy of its mandate from citizens, including dissenting citizens. As a Namibian scholar observed:

> SWAPO has shown over the years a desire to establish a permanent relationship with the state machinery in order to protect itself, and thereby entrenching its hegemony in the allocation of resources. As a consequence of the fused party-state apparatus, it has become the norm for ministers, who are also party leaders, to use officialdom for party-dom, if one could use such a word.… The

> monopolistic party has reduced the formal institutional processes of government to a mere appendix at the whim of a factional political elite.
>
> (Hengari 2008: 4)

State facilities and public property were used for party propaganda purposes. The same is partly true of the way in which SWAPO has mobilised voters ever since being in government, as it 'often fails to differentiate between its existence as a party and as the government when listing its achievements' (Boer 2005: 53). It even goes a step further by simply refusing to be measured against other parties. When in 2004 party representatives were approached to offer their views on the economic policies being pursued, 'the ruling Swapo party decided not to participate arguing that this research project was designed to help opposition parties' (Sherbourne 2004: 2). In SWAPO's view, information about any other party is considered undue interference in state affairs.

While CoD emerged from the 1999 elections as the official opposition, it never managed to make inroads into SWAPO's support base. In 2008, it imploded over power struggles and fights over resources. The Rally for Democracy and Progress (RDP) emerged as the temporary substitute in 2007 as a result of an earlier internal SWAPO power struggle over the succession to Sam Nujoma as presidential candidate (cf. Melber 2006). Given the RDP leaders' links with parts of SWAPO's regional stronghold in the north, the party was originally considered a serious challenge, prompting an aggressive SWAPO response. RDP was denounced as a collection of traitors, agents of imperialism and remotely controlled pawns seeking regime change. The heavy-handed responses of higher SWAPO officials and local grassroots activists contributed to a climate of repression hitherto unknown. A witch-hunt for so-called hibernators, suspected RDP moles intent on undermining SWAPO structures from within was initiated, and scarred the public discourse for years.

On various occasions, the right to campaign freely was denied RDP activists. They were accused of provoking SWAPO supporters in their local strongholds by merely daring to be visible. Properly registered public political rallies were prevented from taking place on the grounds that this was SWAPO territory. The annual report released in August 2008 by a UN committee in compliance with the Convention on the Elimination of all Forms of Racial Discrimination (CERD), reminded 'the state party that the exercise of the right to freedom of opinion and expression carries special duties and responsibilities' and observed that hate speech, mostly by politicians, remained all too pervasive (quoted in Maletsky 2008).

The degree of polarisation was illustrated spectacularly during a SWAPO Youth League political rally on 18 October 2008, when the league's president demanded that all high-ranking positions in the state apparatus and state-owned enterprises be exclusively filled with reliable party members. He stated: 'We have a political religion called Swapo and the political heaven is Swapo, and the political hell is where all the other political parties are'. The leader of an attending delegation from the ANC Youth League demanded with reference to opposition parties: 'Destroy these political cockroaches, they are in your

kitchen' (quoted in Weidlich 2008). A political analyst not surprisingly observed that 'Swapo leaders and other political party leaders breed prejudice, intolerance, and the types of reactions that are becoming the order of the day in the body politic of the nation' (Diescho 2008).

Among those given to such polemical militancy was Hage Geingob, who succeeded President Pohamba as head of state on 21 March 2015. Addressing a political rally in mid-November 2009, he dismissed the opposition parties as 'fake' and alleged that their leaders suffered from a 'Savimbi syndrome', adding ominously that 'the moment Savimbi died, there was peace in Angola' (quoted in Cloete 2009). Despite public criticism of this outburst, he proclaimed at a rally the weekend before the elections that 'international observers and "cry babies" should not describe the final victory of his party during the forthcoming elections as undemocratic and intolerant towards opposition parties' (quoted in Special Correspondent 2009).

In fact, SWAPO never really had to be afraid of any serious political challenge. CoD and RDP, comprising members with 'struggle credentials' who had previously held political office in SWAPO, did represent a new element in domestic politics and certainly provoked, as we have seen, extreme criticism by SWAPO, but did not succeed in weakening electoral support for the ruling party. The composition and relative strength of the opposition parties has varied since 1994, but their share of the vote has never exceeded 25 per cent, and declined to 20 per cent in 2014, with 19 out of 96 seats in the newly expanded National Assembly (until then counting 72 elected members) shared between nine parties, while SWAPO holds 77 seats.

The pluralistic, multiparty character of Namibia's political system obscures the lack of substantive political-ideological difference among the major parties (cf. Hunter 2005). Observers therefore tend to agree that post-independence Namibian democracy bears all the hallmarks of a dominant party system. For some, 'Namibia is clearly a dominant party state' (Bauer and Keulder 2010: 222), while others refer to an 'established dominant-party system' (Du Pisani and Lindeke 2009a: 1) and to 'a multiparty democracy with a dominant party and a weak, fragmented opposition' (Du Pisani and Lindeke, 2009b: 30) or a 'successful one-party dominant state system' (Lindeke 2009: 1). There are also concerns that 'problems with institutionalising a viable multiparty political system in Namibia are exacerbated by the move towards a one-party dominant state' (Kaapama *et al*. 2007: 60).

Based on the liberation gospel and subsequent expressions of patriotic history, SWAPO acted as the sole liberator of the Namibian people and is largely respected and recognised as such by the overwhelming majority of people. The resulting legitimacy has persisted even when the first generation of 'born frees' began to cast their votes at polling stations. And despite SWAPO's overwhelming dominance, the multiplicity of smaller parties was visible proof of Namibia's relative success, at least on the surface, as a multiparty democracy. Yet, as Lindeke and Shejavali observe (2007: 12) 'it remains difficult to know whether this [successful performance] is the result of democracy, SWAPO

leadership and ideas, or the more general Namibian conditions that prevail in this particular historical setting'. As another observer with intimate knowledge concluded: 'the supply of democracy in Namibia seems to outstrip the demand for it' (Du Pisani 2009: 19).

In light of the above, the actual policy adopted and implemented by SWAPO as former liberation movement turned government has strong elements of what might be labelled democratic or competitive authoritarianism. The electoral dominance as 'a near permanent feature of the post-apartheid political landscape', leads to the question: 'To what extent can a constitutional regime with free and fair elections be regarded as a consolidated social democracy if one party is guaranteed a comfortable majority in apparent perpetuity?' (Du Pisani 2013: 133). A closer examination of the political culture under the SWAPO government suggests that 'doubts remain regarding … [the] extent [to which] the party has managed to overcome its legacy as liberation army' (Elischer 2013: 136).

The contrast between compliance with formal criteria and actual practice is reflected in the fact that Namibia regularly ranks among the best African countries for 'good governance' based on indicators such as press freedom, civil liberties, independent judiciary, regular and relatively free and fair elections, etc. However, an attempt to classify and evaluate multiparty systems concludes that they should 'be moderately fragmented in order to ensure both stable government and relatively strong opposition'. This 'excludes one-party dominance *and* marginalisation of opposition (either in terms of weak or highly-fragmented representation of opposition parties in the legislature)' (Basedau 2007: 116 and 117). One-party dominance is further rated as 'super dominance' if at least a two-thirds majority is obtained in two successive elections. According to this classification, SWAPO enjoys 'super-super dominance' in Namibia.

In this 'SWAPO Kingdom' (Elischer 2013: 17), the most important political contestations seem to take the form of intra-party competition. Decisions within the party over succession and senior-level replacements are also relevant to governance issues and state policies. Could one therefore argue that internal party democracy might compensate for the absence of, or replace, the pluralist character required in a democratic society. The answer is, however, disappointing: the party's 'relationship with intra-party democracy is complicated at best' (Elischer 2013: 136) and the 'democratic stock' is 'extremely low' (Giollabhuí 2011: 594). A comparative analysis of ANC and SWAPO candidate selection for the party lists for parliamentary elections in 2004 revealed that SWAPO members and their congress delegates – in sharp contrast to their ANC counterparts – 'played second fiddle to a relatively small coterie of party notables, including the powerful party leader'. The contest over the party list at the congress in 2004, resulting ultimately in the defection of the losing group and the establishment of a new party, was 'deeply undemocratic' (Giollabhuí 2011: 595; see also Melber 2006 and Elischer 2013: 127ff). The battle over the succession of the first president also underlined the point that 'succession is not democratisation' (Levitsky and Way 2002: 59). The party leadership proper exercises control, not the MPs, who as ministers or deputy ministers are not really tasked with controlling the executive and are

actually in large part identical with the party leadership (Melber 2005). This is a leadership that, despite some retirements and fall-outs over a quarter of a century of independence, is still largely drawn from the 'struggle generation', suggesting very limited upward mobility within the party.

Democratic authoritarianism or authoritarian democracy?

Namibia fully embraces in its normative framework the legal elements of a democratic state: universal suffrage, regular elections, legal guarantees for national civil and human rights, the right to associate and organise as well as legal protection against the arbitrary exercise of power. Several examples, however, illustrate how these formal and legal aspects of the democratic state are at times ignored or bypassed. Informal and shadow networks controlled by the liberation party and its 'party machine', but working through the state apparatus, are used to promote personal gain but also to curtail opposition by skewing the playing field. This can take the form of authoritarian governance and control, which can be classified as structural violence.

The equation that the party is the government and the government is the state – and is so for the rest of time – is deeply embedded in the minds of SWAPO's leaders and rank and file. Addressing the annual congress of the party's youth league in 2010, the former head of state Sam Nujoma ended his speech with the appeal:

> As Namibian youth, and as Africans, you must therefore be on the full alert and remain vigilant against deceptive attempts by opportunists and unpatriotic elements that attempt to divide you. As the future leaders of our country, you should act with dedication and commitment; to always promote the interests of the SWAPO Party and the national interests before your own. It is only through that manner that the SWAPO Party will grow from strength to strength and continues to rule Namibia for the next ONE THOUSAND YEARS.
>
> (Nujoma 2010, original capitalisation)

In light of such attitudes, it is no exaggeration to describe democracy in Namibia as 'unfinished business' (Sims and Koep 2012). The enduring dominance of certain political parties can be explained by 'the fact that they continue to be associated with important historical legacies, that they are well organized and deeply rooted political movements, and that they successfully manage leadership change and succession' (Doorenspleet and Nijzink 2013: 202). SWAPO scores remarkably well in all three categories. Transforming the liberation movement into a party, which after more than 20 years of postcolonial governance is still largely dominated and controlled by the first generation of liberation struggle leadership, is no minor achievement. Moreover, SWAPO's continuity has been a welcome stabilising factor in the institutionalisation of the new state, and allowed for the relatively

smooth establishment of a new order. But all of this has come at a price, for this experience has promoted complacency in combination with a proclaimed and strongly guarded exclusivity, and encouraged a lack of delivery.

> The symbolic narrative continues to supersede considerations of uneven delivery in a number of policy domains, and as such resembles a 'founding myth' in terms of which the Party and the post-apartheid State share a moral and historical assignation. The dominant party not only enjoys a discursive hegemony over the recent political history of the country, but its narrative connects powerfully to the ushering in of a new political order; the democratic regime of independent Namibia.
>
> (Du Pisani 2013: 136)

While political parties are instrumental organisations and indispensable to democratic development and modern politics, analyses on the limits of liberation show that parties which fought liberation wars against settler colonies in Southern Africa have tended to emulate their colonial foes once in power and to continue to use structural violence as a means of governance. It can be maintained that 'in the case of victorious liberation movements … "violent actors" are the ones in power and their continuous ability to mobilise means of violence beyond any constitutional restrictions is an integral part of "the system"' (Mehler 2007: 196). Recourse to violence is not eliminated as a variable in political practice. It remains a residual category that can be mobilised as an integral part of the 'struggle mentality' which survives in the sublime underbelly of a liberation movement as government. This form of governance cultivates a patriotic history based on the narrative that the dominant party achieved victory through the barrel of a gun and remains the 'sole and authentic representative of the Namibian people'.

The particular tension produced by this notion of legitimacy is the more marked when there is an absence of strong adherence to truly democratic practices and forms of governance. This tension is not unique to Namibia or the sub-region, but in this country it has produced specific legitimacies and heroic narratives seeking to camouflage and justify hegemonic rule. This has led to the constant and overt use of structural violence against those that challenge the liberation party's legitimacy. The underlying understanding is that seizing political power after a long struggle signals 'the end of history', inasmuch as any future policy shifts merely reflect the changing power structures within the governing parties. A general, almost logical corollary of this claim to exclusivity and entitlement is the intolerance of diversity. This can be traced back to the liberation struggles, when the parties were movements with quite diverse members, but enforced conformity by suppressing differences and arguing that unity was necessary for nation-building once independence was achieved. Thus, for liberation parties, used to operating underground and demanding strict discipline and absolute loyalty, non-conformity, diversity and even mild criticism was seen as betrayal of the 'family' and as strictly punishable. The persistence of

these practices and attitudes has further weakened already weak opposition parties, who increasingly resemble the liberation parties in the sense of waiting to take over the reins of government and pursue a similar system of political dominance. As a result, they fail to convince the electorate that they are credible alternatives in support of whom it is worth running the risk of being branded an 'unpatriotic traitor', 'dissident' or 'neo-imperialist lackey'.

Namibia offers a wide range of evidence that testifies to the hypothesis that:

> The most durable party-based regimes are those that are organized around non-material sources of cohesion, such as ideology, ethnicity, or bonds of solidarity rooted in a shared experience of violent struggle. In particular, parties whose origins lie in war, violent anti-colonial struggle, revolution, or counter-insurgency are more likely to survive economic crisis, leadership succession, and opposition challenges without suffering debilitating effects.
>
> (Levitsky and Way 2010: 3)

As the authors conclude: 'revolutionary or liberation struggles also tend to produce a generation of leaders … that possesses the necessary legitimacy to impose discipline during crises'. Hence, 'new ruling parties that emerged from violent struggle, such as SWAPO in Namibia … appear to be more durable' (Levitsky and Way 2010: 44 and 45). It is therefore no surprise that in the absence of credible alternatives, and in the spirit of the 'struggle days' and one of its most popular slogans ('SWAPO is the nation and the nation is SWAPO'), the former liberation movement turned party remains largely identified with the nation, and the nation remains largely identified with SWAPO.

It is important, however, to also emphasise that while some authoritarian regimes do not meet all the criteria for full democratic governance, they may at the same time fall short of full-scale authoritarianism. Despite at times manipulating or bypassing democratic rules, SWAPO is 'unable to eliminate them or reduce them to a mere façade' (Levitsky and Way 2010: 53). Notwithstanding these caveats, those exercising political hegemony and control in Namibia are in a position to tolerate formal democracy as the only game in town without risking the continuance of their firmly entrenched rule.

Notes

1 This chapter is an updated summary of chapters 2 to 4 in Melber (2014). These offer more detail and further references. I thank the Cultural Foundation of Social Integration Centre of Excellence at the University of Konstanz for hosting me as a guest researcher at the Konstanz Institute for Advanced Study during February and March 2015, which allowed me to compile this text.

2 SWAPO transformed itself after Independence into a political party, and changed its name to Swapo Party. For the sake of consistency, this chapter refers to SWAPO throughout, unless otherwise quoted.

3 The spelling of the place has been changed to Omugulu-gwoombashe, but the old name is still in use.

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11 Problems of transition to civic governance in Eritrea

Redie Bereketeab

Introduction

Modern Eritrea is a creation of Italian colonialism (1890–1941). It experienced domination and resistance over a stretch of 100 years that ended in 1991. This history of Eritrea is characterised by betrayal, neglect and distortion that left a deep mark on the social psychology of Eritreans (Iyob 1995; Wrong 2005; Yohannes 1991). The sense of victimhood, which the betrayal generated, also fostered a resilience embodied in a state of mind favouring unity and cohesion: 'We could only survive as a nation in our unity'. The demise of Italian colonial rule failed to lead to decolonisation. Instead, dictated by the geostrategic interests of the US, Eritrea was joined with Ethiopia by means of a UN-sponsored federation in 1952 (Habte Selassie 1989; Yohannes 1991). This was the first betrayal. Emperor Haile Selassie abrogated the federation in 1962, a second betrayal, forcing Eritreans to wage a uniquely protracted national liberation struggle. After 30 years of ferocious fighting, and in the face of international neglect, Eritrea gained its independence in 1991.

The post-liberation transition to civil governance and state-building, however, faced formidable challenges. Indeed, the post-liberation state was soon plunged into crisis induced by external and internal factors. The second war with Ethiopia (1998–2000) brought to an end the only years of peace and stability Eritrea has ever seen. The war ended with the Algiers Final Agreement. Fourteen years later, at the time of writing, this final and binding agreement awaits implementation, resulting in a state of 'no war, no peace' between the two countries. This situation is the result of international appeasement of Ethiopia, another betrayal of Eritrea. This state of no war, no peace, coupled with the legacy of a liberation political culture, has produced a crisis of transition and transformation in Eritrea.

This chapter seeks to analyse the challenges of the transition from revolutionary national liberation movement to civil state government. To establish cause-effect relationships, three levels are interrogated: (1) the internal; (2) regional; and (3) the international. The rationale for this approach lies in the analytical assumption that national political leaders are embedded, created and recreated within a national, regional and international political context.

A second contention is that in a closely connected globalised world, there is no single causal factor. The internal level alludes to the domestic process of transition and its difficulties. Two periods are distinguished, 1991–97, prior to the outbreak of renewed fighting with Ethiopia, and post-1997, the wartime and postwar era. This distinction is of great significance in understanding post-liberation transition and transformation. The regional level relates to the political climate that existed when Eritrea emerged as a sovereign state, a climate that might certainly affect the transition process, state performance, and the way in which the state shaped its regional and international relations. The international level refers to the treatment of national governments and the impact of international policies and interventions on the design of domestic policies, strategies and development plans. With regard to Eritrea, international relations are characterised by a history of betrayal and neglect stretching over several decades and culminating in the failure to implement the International Court of Arbitration boundary decision and the imposition of sanctions that affect the country's post-liberation trajectory (Bereketeab 2013; Muller 2007).

In the following sections of this chapter the internal dimensions of the pre-war period and of the later period are dealt with. The aim is to examine internal factors enabling and/or hampering transition from liberation political culture to civic post-liberation culture. Section four deals with the regional dimensions and section five the international. They are followed by the conclusion.

Internal dimensions (1991–97): liberation political culture

Legacy of liberation political culture

A special political culture was fostered during the liberation struggle, and this was carried over into the post-liberation state-building and transformation period. This legacy very much proved to be a hurdle in the post-liberation transition and transformation process (Bereketeab 2007). The hallmarks of the liberation political culture were and are: (1) secrecy; (2) strong centralisation; (3) very hierarchical structures; and (4) insistence on loyalty (Connell 1993; Pool 2001; Wolde Giorgis 2014). This political culture was also embedded in the political, administrative and organisational principle of democratic centralism, which presupposes complete obedience by citizens. It is based on military values, with commands being implemented first and questions being asked only afterwards. Certainly, such values were necessary for the survival and success of the liberation struggle. Since the liberation movement was internationally ignored and isolated, it had no option but to depend on its own resources, chief among these being the small population of Eritrea acting in unison as one fighting force. Both from below (individuals joining the struggle) and from above, in a programmatic and socialising endeavour, the liberation fronts made the utmost efforts to forge a unifying revolutionary political culture that would secure victory. Gradually, a consensus was created around a political culture that, in the end, no one thought to question as a prerequisite for survival (Pool 2001). Accordingly, a miniature, compact

'politico-military society' was created in the field (Bereketeab 2007: 399). This society possessed distinctive and idiosyncratic characteristics that became hurdles to successful socio-political integration post-liberation.

The continuation of the liberation political culture into the post-liberation period promoted rigidity instead of innovation. EPLF (Eritrean People's Liberation Front) became the ruling party and attempted to reshape society in its liberation-era political image. As David Pool (2001: 159), notes: 'Instead of Eritrea remaking the EPLF, the EPLF had been vigorous in remaking Eritrea in its image'. The success of EPLF during the liberation struggle was in part attributed to its ability to engage the civilian population in the struggle. It demonstrated great success in mobilising and organising civilians inside the country and in the diaspora. It also demonstrated an extraordinary capacity to deliver services to the population in liberated areas and thereby enhance its legitimacy (Connell 1993; Davidson, Cliffe and Habte Selassie 1980; Pool 2001).

Post-independence governance is also a replication of the liberation-era style. The state system is highly centralised around the presidential office and a hierarchical administration that descends down to the village level (Bereketeab 2007, 2009). As in the liberation struggle, demands are placed on officials and citizens to show loyalty, make sacrifices and behave as a collectivity. An example of the demand of sacrifices was the instruction that liberation fighters forgo payment for their services for two years (1991–93), an instruction that was not well received. Another example of the sacrifices demanded of citizens was the open-ended prolongation of the period of national service following the second war with Ethiopia. As the liberators had sacrificed their lives without expectation of reimbursement, so the youths of the national service era are expected to do likewise, hence their designation as '*warsay*', inheritors. In short, Eritrea was turned into a society of sacrifices.

In terms of state power, EPLF/PFDJ (People's Front for Democracy and Justice) made it clear from the outset that it would not be so generous as to allow other parties to share in it. The various factions of the ELF (Eritrean Liberation Front), EPLF's historical rivals, were told that their individual members would be welcome to join the ruling party but that the factions would not be allowed to return to the country as an organised political force. This stemmed from the perception that these factions were a veritable threat to post-liberation state-building and national unity. Three reasons have been advanced for the unwillingness to permit the return of the ELF groups: (1) the bloody civil wars (1972–74, 1980–81), whose outbreak EPLF attributed to the reactionary ELF leadership; (2) fear of exposing the post-liberation polity to sectarian and religious conflict (Said 2002); (3) and their historical tendency to dominate power (Mengisteab and Yohaness 2005; Wolde Giorgis 2014). The general thinking was 'we and only we can do it'.

Briefly, it can be concluded that the liberation political culture proved to be a veritable obstacle in the transition to post-liberation civil life and culture. The price of the failure of the transition was evidenced by developments during the second period (post-1997).

Setting priorities

As soon as they had assumed state power, the leaders of the liberation movement, like their predecessors, the nationalist leaders in the immediate aftermath of decolonisation of Africa in the 1960s, defined as their central priorities state-building, nation-building, socioeconomic development and national unity (MacroPolicy 1994; National Charter 1994). These narrowly defined priorities demonstrated not only a strictly revolutionary social engineering project but also a rejection of liberal state-building priorities. All of the priorities adopted represent collective values, which were deemed to be sacrosanct, while liberal desiderata such as multiparty democracy, rule of law, constitutionalism, human and individual rights, etc. were to be subordinated to them. The people's army was to play a key role. To this day, the people's army has not been transformed into a professional military institution. Instead it includes the national service draftees and forms the backbone of the PFDJ government's post-liberation project to reconstruct the nation. Dependence on the people's army also underscores the emphasis placed on self-reliance. Adherence to self-reliance has put the government on a collision course with donors and the West and had dire consequences, for the West has construed this emphasis as isolationism and rejection of aid.

The redrawing of the country into new six administrative zones (*zoba*s) that cut across 'natural' ethnic boundaries was designed to help achieve one of the priority objectives, notably, nation-building, by undermining ethno-linguistic and religious distractions and cleavages in society (Bereketeab 2012), such diversity being seen as a possible hindrance to nation-building and in need of proper management. The chosen state is to rest on secular, modernist norms that do not provide space for parochial and regressive political, cultural and institutional tendencies (MacroPolicy 1994; National Charter 1994).

Governance

The persistence of the liberation-era political culture coupled with the preference for a governance system based on revolutionary legitimacy and performance meant that meritocracy and bureaucratic credentials, as benchmarks for appointment to office, were replaced by political loyalty (Bereketeab 2009; Habte Selassie 2003). The liberation army was transformed into a people's army and tasked with defending the country and actively participating in the political, social, cultural and socioeconomic reconstruction of the war-torn society. National service, introduced in 1994, was also an integral part of the notion of a people's army for such an army, by its very nature, is to serve the people and not to expect rewards. This explains why national service draftees are unpaid or receive only nominal payment.

From the very outset, the national liberation movement dominated the political and economic sectors. The economy was to be mixed, with public and private spheres coexisting in harmony. Parastatal and state-owned companies

became not only active in the economy but were also strategic economic institutions. The private sector was unable, in practice, to compete with the public sector, whose grip on the economy tightened even further following the second war with Ethiopia. When it became clear, because of the war, that the private sector could not cope and that external investment was not forthcoming, the government had no choice but to depend on the public sector to meet societal needs.

Politically, the EPLF/PFDJ defined itself as a broad movement or front, a definition that has had far-reaching consequences. For instance, a front presumably incorporates different politico-ideological tendencies and interests, thereby making redundant the establishment of a pluralist polity, particularly a liberal democratic one. The PFDJ government did not shy away from criticism of liberal democracy, and declared it would follow a democratic path that was context-based and relevant to the history, culture and experience of Eritrean society,

> Our understanding of democracy should emphasize its content rather than its external manifestations. In the context of our society, democracy is dependent not on the number of political parties and on regular elections, but on the actual participation of people in the decision-making process at community and national level. What is being questioned here is not political parties as a manifestation of political pluralism with rights to organisation and free expression, and elections. Rather, it is the equating of democracy [with] the elections. This kind of interpretation is wrong and dangerous. This is because it has been established from the experiences of several countries that the existence of several political parties and organized elections alone do not guarantee the existence of a truly democratic system. If we look at the experience of some African countries, political parties dominated by the interests of an e1ite are imposed from above.
>
> (National Charter 1994: 15)

It therefore opted for guided democracy. Critics interpreted this choice as a deliberate act to impede implementation of full liberal democracy (Mengisteab and Yohannes 2005; Wolde Giorgis 2014). In hindsight, the strategy of guided democracy, however, represented a missed opportunity compared with what was to come. Following the outbreak of the second war with Ethiopia, the possibility of using guided democracy as a stepping stone in the further development of the political order became even less viable.

The strategy of guided democracy precluded the operation of political parties other than EPLF/PFDJ. Only civil society organisations affiliated with EPLF/PFDJ were allowed to operate, and these were organisations that tended to practise self-censorship so as not to antagonise the regime. Lacking the critical voices of a political opposition, trade unions or civil society associations, the polity ended up autocratic. Later, moreover, the regional and international realms turned hostile, accentuating this trend.

The transition from national liberation revolutionary governance to civil governance was therefore seriously impeded. Some have seen the halting transition as cautious pragmatism (Iyob 1997), while others see it as tragedy (Mengisteab and Yohannes 2005). Yet particularly in the first period, there were several positive developments.

Positive developments

The first of these positive developments was holding a referendum to determine the future of the country. More than 98 per cent of Eritreans expressed a wish for independence, which Eritrea formally achieved in 1993. Thereafter, from 10 to 16 February 1994, EPLF convened its third conference. Held in the town of Naqfa, the conference adopted a National Charter wherein the political, economic, cultural, diplomatic and foreign relations strategies that would guide post-liberation reconstruction were elaborated. It was also on this occasion that EPLF changed its name to PFDJ and the country was restructured into new administrative regions (MacroPolicy 1994; National Charter 1994). A constitution commission, headed by a prominent lawyer, was established to draft a constitution. To this end, the commission organised public seminars inside and outside the country and organised a symposium attended by several international experts. The draft constitution was endorsed in May 1997, but by 2003 (Habte Selassie 2003) was still awaiting implementation, still by 2016 is also awaiting implementation. In his Independence Day speech in May 2015, President Isaias Afewerki announced that a further commission had been set up to draft a new constitution, thereby implying that the 1997 constitution was dead. Notwithstanding this reversal, all these measures can be seen as milestones on the road to institutionalisation. However, this progress stalled more generally with the outbreak of the second war.

In foreign policy also, Eritrea steadily worked to integrate itself into the world system (Mengisteab 2009; Muller 2007). It established good relations with the EU, US and individual states, although this success soon faded (Mengisteab 2009; Reid 2009: 21). It also joined the regional organisation, Inter-Governmental Authority on Development (IGAD), but suspended its membership in 2008, accusing the body of becoming a rubber stamp for Ethiopia. In the social sphere, even in the post-1998 period, tangible improvements were achieved. Literacy improved from 23 per cent in 1991 to 52.6 per cent in 2005 (UN 2013: 14). Life expectancy and child mortality also showed considerable improvements from 92 per 1,000 in 1991 to 37 per 1,000 in 2012 (UN 2014: 9). Indeed, the UN declared Eritrea to be one of the few countries that had achieved the Millennium Development Goals in education and health (UN 2013). Press freedom also improved, at least until private newspapers were closed in 2001. The outbreak of the second war with Ethiopia proved a watershed, with many of the positive developments being reversed (see below).

Internal dimension, second period (post-1997)

The outbreak of the second war with Ethiopia in 1998 had a calamitous effect on Eritrea in a number of areas. In addition to the colossal human and material costs, it also generated a serious rift within the leadership of the ruling party and the government. Senior officials in the PFDJ and government began to question Eritrea's performance, particularly during the May–June 2000 Ethiopian assault (Berlin Marlin Manifesto 2000). These rifts culminated in a leadership crisis in 2001. Often such shocks to a political system provide an opportunity for change, but in this case the opportunity was squandered. The crisis could have served two purposes. The first would have been to open up the political space. Until then, EPLF/PFDJ had been perceived as a monolithic organisation, led by a tightly structured hierarchical leadership. Second, Eritrea could have responded to Western demands for formal liberal democracy, at least in the electoral sense, although neoliberal democratisation and state-building may not have been the right answer. Most importantly, it would have prompted a further transition towards a civil political culture, with non-liberators being welcomed into the polity.

Without doubt, the devastating outcome of the May–June 2000 Ethiopian assault generated a shock wave within the PFDJ leadership and shattered its monolithic image. A group of senior party and government officials began to question the leadership style of the president. Groups that came to be known as G-11 and G-15 demanded: (1) a proper inquiry into the debacle during the war with Ethiopia; (2) the convening of a PFDJ congress; and (3) national elections (Berlin Manifesto 2000). The dissidents, in interviews with a private newspaper, accused the president of harbouring authoritarian tendencies. Under normal circumstances, these demands would not have been controversial, but the differences between G-15 and the president and his supporters continued to deepen. In September 2001, security forces struck back, arresting the G-15 members and journalists and closing private newspapers. These senior officials were accused of defeatism and treason and of conspiring to force the resignation of the president and surrender of Eritrea to the UN. Although the government had been able to check its opponents, the crisis grew deeper.

The country was placed under a state of emergency. National service had first been introduced in 1994 and was supposed to last 18 months, but was now converted into an open-ended programme. In 2002 in a related move, a decree was issued introducing the *Warsay-Yekealo* development programme, with a particular focus on postwar rehabilitation and reconstruction. The sole dependence on the *Warsay-Yekealo* development programme to revitalise the economy had the contrary effect, for not only did the indefinite national service deprive the nation of its most productive labour force but it also eventually gave rise to mass flight by youths from the country.

National institutions virtually stopped functioning. The legislative body had its final meeting in 2002, the ratified constitution was never implemented, the legal system became dysfunctional, and basic political, human and civil rights were curtailed. Increasingly, state power was concentrated in the executive branch, particularly in the president and presidential office.

Regional level

At the time that Eritrea became an independent state, the region was already afflicted with festering conflicts. Ethiopia had yet to recover from several decades of civil war; Somalia was in disarray following the fall of Siad Barre; and Sudan was immersed in perennial wars in which centrifugal forces challenged the legitimacy of the postcolonial state. It was not long, therefore, before Eritrea became embroiled in these intra-state and inter-state conflicts (Woodward 2013). Its relations with neighbouring countries were from the outset fraught. The ambitions of the National Islamic Front (NIF) in Sudan to export its Islamic revolution to neighbouring countries led it to support Eritrean jihadist movements (Woodward 2013: 161). Consequently, the Eritrean government severed diplomatic relations with Sudan and began to support the Sudanese opposition. Regional opposition to NIF ambitions gave rise to the creation of a US-backed alliance of frontline states (Uganda, Ethiopia and Eritrea) to oppose the government in Khartoum (Mengisteab 2009; Muller 2007: 32). Later, however, Eritrea was ostracised for inciting conflicts with its neighbours. Furthermore, in 1994 Eritrea, in this case supported by Ethiopia, had also engaged in a brief war with Yemen over several islands in the Red Sea. The Eritrea-Yemen dispute was ultimately resolved through the International Court of Arbitration (Johnson 2000).

The conflict that had the furthest reaching consequences for the transition process in Eritrea, however, was the 1998–2000 war with Ethiopia. On the surface, this second war between the two countries was a border dispute. At a deeper level, however, the conflict related to the very fact of the independence of Eritrea. To this day, most Ethiopians resent Eritrea's independence, some even referring to it as unfinished business (Jacquin-Berdal and Plaut 2004), since it entailed loss of an outlet to the sea. The Ethiopian refusal to accept and implement the EEBC (Eritrean-Ethiopian Border Commission) decision must be understood in light of that loss of access.

Ethiopia's refusal to accept the EEBC verdict led to a no-war, no-peace situation, which led in turn to proxy wars that, *inter alia*, spilled over into Somalia (Muller 2016: 4). The stalemate also gave rise to a host of difficulties in Eritrea, not least the introduction of indefinite national service for the entire youth of the country and the requirement that they be on a perpetual state of alert. As already noted, this situation led to the large-scale flight from the country of this cohort.

Ethiopia also made persistent threats to depose the Eritrean government:

> Ethiopia will continue to work to force the regime to change its policies or failing that it will be prepared to change the government itself through any means at its disposal. The government of Ethiopia is willing to support and work with any Eritrean organisation.
>
> (MoFA n.d.)

Furthermore, there were also occasional military engagements between the two countries, particularly near Badime. The latest serious incident took place in

June 2016. These actions by Ethiopia are claimed to have been induced by Eritrea's support for Ethiopian opposition groups, although Ethiopia was also supporting Eritrean opposition groups, thereby casting doubt on the legitimacy of its accusations.

In 2008, a sudden conflict broke out between Djibouti and Eritrea that surprised many. The previous year the two countries had been working to open a connecting highway and to boost economic cooperation. Soon rumours began to circulate that the conflict was related to the Eritrea-Ethiopia conflict. Indeed, certain sources allege that Ethiopia asked the US to pressure the government of Djibouti to sever its ties with Eritrea. In this regard, it is worth recalling that Djibouti hosts the only real US military base in Africa (Englebert and Dunn 2013: 351) and is highly dependent on American economic support. Moreover, Ethiopia is an important ally of the US in the global war on terror. Thus, it is not too far-fetched to suggest that Ethiopia may have urged the US government to persuade Djibouti to sever relations with Eritrea as part of its own strategy to isolate Eritrea. And Eritrea's isolation in the world and preoccupation with an existential threat from its powerful neighbour presented Djibouti with an ideal opportunity to settle its lingering border disputes with Eritrea.

Eritrean-IGAD relations took an abrupt turn for the worse following Ethiopia's invasion of Somalia in December 2006, an action that IGAD lent legitimacy to by endorsing it. In 2007, Eritrea suspended its membership of IGAD on the grounds that the regional organisation was subservient to Ethiopia (Andemariam 2015; Woodward 2013a: 146). When, later, Eritrea tried to reactivate its membership, its request was blocked by Ethiopia. IGAD was also the main conduit by which Ethiopia secured UN sanctions against Eritrea: the formal request to enact these sanctions was tabled by IGAD in the African Union, which in turn relayed the request to the UN.

International level

Eritreans have always been disappointed in and suspicious of the role of the international community in terms of its involvement or non-involvement in their national affairs. This attitude stems from the long history of betrayal and neglect stretching over more than 60 years. Recent betrayals include the abdication of the international community's responsibilities arising from their role as witnesses and guarantors of the Algiers Agreement. When the border commission announced its verdict in April 2002, it was rejected by Ethiopia, and the main international actors looked the other way for geostrategic reasons. The US administration is not willing to put pressure on a strategic ally in the war on terror in the Horn of Africa, and thus ignored and even undermined the final and binding verdict of the International Court of Arbitration. Several US officials attempted to influence the UN body to push for dialogue between Eritrea and Ethiopia, which Ethiopia demanded as a condition of implementing the verdict. Eritrea, on the other hand, rejected dialogue ahead of implementation, seeing this as a potentially prejudicial ruse to open up the final agreement.

Assistant Secretary of State for African Affairs Jandayi Frazer, for instance, in 2006 visited Badime, the flashpoint in the second Eritrean-Ethiopian war, which had been awarded to Eritrea but which Ethiopia refused to hand over, and proposed that the village's residents hold a referendum to determine which way they wanted to go (Woldemariam and Yohannes 2007). Moreover, Frazer, who was part of George W. Bush's administration, made concerted efforts to change the verdict in such a way as to address Ethiopia's needs. All this was in contravention of the spirit and letter of the Algiers Agreement, which had, in fact, been drafted by US officials (Bolton 2007). When this failed, Eritrea was subjected to a campaign of demonisation alleging that was supporting terrorism and was destabilising the region. Indeed, Frazer threatened to place Eritrea on the list of states sponsoring terrorism.

Eventually, in 2009 the US ambassador to the UN, Susan Rice, succeeded in persuading the UN Security Council to impose sanctions on Eritrea. Widely seen as championed by the US and Ethiopia, Security Council Resolution 1907 (2009) imposed an arms embargo, travel restrictions and froze the assets of Eritrea's political and military leaders (UNSC 2009). In 2011, Resolution 2023 was passed accusing Eritrea of supporting various opposition groups in the region. In order to avoid charges of imperialist intervention, the US encouraged an African state, Uganda, which was then on the Security Council, to table the motion. Rice convinced President Museveni that if the proposal came from an African country and was supported by the African Union, the Security Council would more readily endorse it. She could then claim that it was African countries who wanted to punish Eritrea (Bereketeab 2013).

In 2015, in a pattern that was beginning to seem familiar, Djibouti and Somalia were encouraged to make accusations in the UN of grave human rights violations by Eritrea. Subsequently, the UN decided to create a commission of inquiry tasked with investigating Eritrea's human rights record (Muller 2016: 6). The commission's report alleges that Eritrea is guilty of grave human rights violations that may amount to crimes against humanity (UNGA 2015). The commission's methods of gathering information were highly questionable – its sole sources being Eritrean asylum seekers, disaffected ex-officials, opposition groups in the diaspora, countries in conflict with Eritrea (Djibouti and Ethiopia) – leaving the body vulnerable to accusations of being politically motivated. Not only were these sources likely to be unreliable, but their testimony cannot be verified, because it was given anonymously (Muller 2016). In short, the commission's whole procedure undermines the credibility and integrity of UN offices and organs.

Eritrea is nicknamed the North Korea of Africa, a secretive state, hermetically sealed and isolated from Western media (Myers 2010), activists, human rights organisations, as well as scholars both Western and Eritrean (Connell 2015; Plaut 2014). The question here is whether Eritrea is isolating itself or being isolated by West. The record shows that the Western world, particularly the US, driven by its geostrategic interests, has systematically worked to isolate and undermine a state perceived as non-biddable. The policy of isolation is intended to force Eritrea[1] to change its policies, and in some circles the

concerted demonisation of Eritrea is also intended to promote regime change. The notion of liberal regime change gained momentum after the declaration of what is commonly known as the George Bush Doctrine. This has two main components, pre-emptive action and regime change (Council on Foreign Relations 2004; Daalder 2002; Dresner 2009). The former relates to taking action before the perceived enemy attacks, while the latter refers to deposing a government seen to deviate from prescribed neoliberal Western norms and values.

The definition of liberal values as universal, and the insistence that non-Western societies are blank sheets on which Western values and norms are to be inscribed, reveals a one-size-fits-all model of development, a relic of modernisation theory. This understanding fails to consider the consequences of these crusading campaigns on non-Western societies. The implications are not only ideological, but also practical. Those not found amenable to the neoliberal revolution (Harrison 2010) are punished in various ways that may lead to their eventual destruction. Indeed, the underlying message is surrender or perish.

Conclusion

This chapter has sought to analyse the challenges of transition from national liberation movement to civil governance in Eritrea. Essentially, the transition requires a transformation of political culture. The chapter contends that a toxic marriage of liberation political culture and regional and international structures and actors has made the transition painful. It is possible to distinguish two periods, 1991–97 and post-1997, each with its own peculiarities. This distinction helps us to understand why, following the second war between Eritrea and Ethiopia, circumstances began rapidly to deteriorate. The second war marked an important watershed in the transition.

Not only did the conflict complicate regional and international relations, but also the domestic priority became national survival. This in turn necessitated draconian measures, including clamping down on dissent, closing private newspapers, suspending the constitution and instituting indefinite national service. All this led to economic and political hardship as well as mass exodus. In terms of regional issues, despite the formal ending of the war, a no war, no peace situation has taken hold, with Ethiopia rejecting the boundary commission decision and bent on bringing about the collapse of the Eritrean government. Ethiopia has made concerted efforts to isolate Eritrea economically, politically, diplomatically and militarily, for instance through IGAD and by means of UN sanctions. The failure to resolve the Ethio-Eritrean conflict has had spill-over effects in the region that have affected Somalia, Djibouti–Eritrea relations and even states outside the Horn of Africa across the Red Sea.

Third, there is the international factor, largely characterised by the failure of the international community to live up to its responsibilities as guarantors and witnesses of the Algiers Agreement or in upholding the International Court of Arbitration verdict. These failings have not only complicated the domestic situation in Eritrea, but also the regional situation. Above all, they have adversely affected Eritrea's relations with the Western world, leading to sanctions.

Note

1 Interviews with the European Union (EU) and German ambassadors to Eritrea, 2 December and 3 December 2015 respectively in Asmara.

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12 Understanding rebellion in South Sudan

Leben Nelson Moro

Introduction

There are only a few armed rebellions against an established state that succeeded in winning independence for the rebels. The rebellion led by the Eritrean People's Liberation Front was one of them, while the other rebellion that achieved the same feat in the Horn of Africa was that involving the Sudan People's Liberation Movement/Army (SPLM/A). Under its founding leader, the late Dr John Garang de Mabior, the SPLM/A fought for a united 'New Sudan', but negotiated the 2005 Comprehensive Peace Agreement (CPA) with the regime of President Omar al-Bashir, which included the right to self-determination for the people of Southern Sudan (Moro 2014). When they voted between 9 and 15 January 2011, Southern Sudanese overwhelmingly chose independence, which was declared on 9 July 2011.

Independence has not brought about the expected peace and development, however. The newborn Republic of South Sudan has instead faced armed rebellions and associated humanitarian crises. It is argued that the SPLM/A evolved in an autocratic political climate, in which personal rule was often violently challenged, and its key leaders continued to pursue autocracy after taking over the leadership of the new country, in the process fomenting dissent that led to more uprisings.

To a great extent, the actions of the ex-rebel leaders were no different from those of the Arab and Muslim elites who misruled the former Sudan[1] for many decades. Grievances that were bottled up so that independence could be achieved now came to the fore. According to Amir Idris:

> Historically the political unity of the South was forged as a result of the northern hegemony and domination during the long decades of civil war. Therefore, it was a reaction to external oppression rather than a product of an internal process of political inclusion and accommodation.
>
> (Idris 2013: 123)

Once external oppression was a thing of the past, former rebel leaders turned on each other, rupturing the unity of the SPLM. Indeed, a keen observer predicted

that 'the day to decide which group will dominate the SPLM, or whether the organisation will divide into two or more groups, is assuredly coming closer, and the outcome cannot be easily predicted' (Young 2008: 170). Ultimately, it broke into three groups, the SPLM-In Government (SPLM-IG), SPLM-In Opposition (SPLM-IO) and SPLM-Former Detainees (SPLM-FD).

The crises that led to the split began as a contest over the leadership of the SPLM. In 2012, Dr Riek Machar 'declared his intention to contest … the Chairmanship of the SPLM' (Nyaba 2013: 4). In July 2013, President Salva Kiir dismissed him as vice president along with the rest of the cabinet. Subsequently, divisions within the party deepened as Salva Kiir tried to push through amendments to key founding documents with the aim of securing for himself another term as party chairman.

On the night of 15 December 2013, Dinka[2] members of the presidential guard (or Tiger Battalion) fought with their Nuer colleagues in the Al Gaida Barracks in Juba, and engulfed other military installations in the city. The SPLA split into two, one faction supporting Salva Kiir, who is a Dinka from the Greater Bahr el Ghazal region, and the other siding with Riek Machar, a Nuer. No doubt ethnicity was manipulated by these former rebel leaders with a view to holding on to, or gaining, power. On the following day, Salva Kiir, wearing a military uniform, announced to the press that a military coup, planned by Riek Machar, had been thwarted. Subsequently, 11 prominent SPLM leaders were put behind bars, but Riek Machar evaded capture and emerged as the leader of an armed rebel group, SPLM/A-In Opposition. He claimed that allegations about a coup story were baseless and were only meant to cover up suppression of dissent and calls for reform of the SPLM (BBC 2014).

Within a few days, the violence spread to Unity, Upper Nile and Jonglei states. Thousands of civilians, particularly ethnic Nuer, were killed by security forces or were forced to flee their homes, with some taking refuge in the UN Mission in South Sudan's bases (UNMISS 2014). According to Peter Nyaba, the presidential guards, the majority of them Dinka from Greater Bahr el Ghazal, were responsible for killing these civilians on the assumption that they supported Riek Machar (Nyaba 2013).

Also, Dinka civilians were targeted by armed Nuer in suspected reprisal attacks. Apparently, the massacres of Nuer civilians in Juba motivated Nuer youth, organised as the so-called White Army, to fight the government and target Dinka civilians because they belonged to the same ethnic group as Salva Kiir. The White Army and SPLA deserters headed towards Juba to end Salva Kiir's rule, but his regime was rescued by Ugandan soldiers despatched by President Yoweri Museveni. During the third anniversary celebrations of independence, Salva Kiir proclaimed that these troops would not leave 'until we feel that our institutions are secure from any attack' (Manyang 2014: 2).

Meanwhile the humanitarian toll in the country continues to mount. Thousands of people have been killed, more than 1.5 million have fled their homes and millions have faced food shortages. Poignantly, on 25 July 2014, the UN Security Council described food insecurity in the country as the 'worst in the world'

(IRIN 2014). On the economic front, the country is in dire straits. While presenting the 2014/2015 budget on 25 June 2014, Aggrey Tisa Sabuni, the then minister of finance, said that the crises had 'severely impacted on economic activity' (Sabuni 2014). For instance, oil flows had been halted in Unity State.

This chapter delves into the reasons for the proliferation of rebellions in South Sudan. The next section discusses the origins of autocracy in the former Sudan and their links to rebellions. It discusses the manipulation of identity, especially ethnic and religious, as a means to win or retain power and in the context of armed confrontation. Section three analyses the rise of the SPLM/A, the autocratic leadership of John Garang and the rebellions he had to confront, and the CPA. Section four discusses the first rebellion, the Anyanya rebellion, the different leadership styles of key rebel leaders and the Addis Ababa Peace Agreement of 1972, which ushered in a democratic and accountable governance system, probably because that system was not dominated by former rebel leaders. The last section concludes the paper.

Autocratic leadership and rebellion

The key malaise in the three-year-old South Sudan, autocratic leadership, is the same disease that afflicted the former Sudan and subsequently brought about its demise. In reality, many African countries have grappled with, or are coping with this problem. As Bratton and van de Walle point out, 'the interaction between the "big man" and his extended retinue defines African politics, from the reaches of the presidential palace to the humblest village assembly' (Bratton and van der Walle 1994: 459). These 'big men' have not brought economic development to their countries but instead have brought political instability (Blackings 2014: 3). Moreover, as Blackings argues, regimes marked by party pluralism and tolerance of opposition views – like that in Botswana – are the exception rather than the rule in Africa (Blackings 2014: 3).

In most cases, the 'big men' mismanaged diversity, a key characteristic of most African countries, imperilling their own countries and in some cases their own hold on power. One of the outcomes of their misrule is that elites from certain clan, ethnic, tribal and religious groups dominated governance structures, while others were politically marginalised (Abdulkadir 2012: 57). In some instances, marginalised individuals or groups resorted to violence so as to improve their lot. Ironically, where the marginalised succeeded in wresting power from their oppressors, they often perpetuated or reinstituted the very structures they opposed, spawning new rebellions in turn.

The former Sudan had this experience. Since gaining independence in 1956, it has been ruled by several autocrats with a military background, the longest serving of whom, President Omar al-Bashir, oversaw the disintegration of the country on 9 July 2011. These former Sudanese 'big men' manipulated identity, particularly ethnicity and religion, to maintain a small group of elites, who identified themselves as Muslim and Arab, in a privileged position, while the majority of people were excluded from meaningful participation in the affairs of their homeland

(Moro 2014). In fact, the Islamic and Arab-dominated state relegated Southern Sudanese, who self-identified as black Africans, 'into the status of second class citizens without equal rights to those who were considered Arab and Muslim from the North' (Idris 2013: 133). Like other marginalised Sudanese, the Southern Sudanese rebelled several times against their inferior status.

Second (or SPLM/A) war and comprehensive peace agreement

President Omar al-Bashir came to power in a coup in 1989 against a democratically elected government in the context of the former Sudan's second armed rebellion. The drift into this round of fighting began in the early 1980s, mainly in response to the dictatorial rule of President Jaafar Nimeiri (1969–85). According to Lam Akol, disillusionment with Nimeiri was so widespread that armed groups, some of them made up of veterans from the first war, the Anyanya fighters, gathered in Ethiopia in 1983 to plot rebellion against the country's Muslim and Arab-dominated regime (Akol 2001). They failed to choose a leader and became bogged down in infighting that left many people dead or displaced. This bloodletting was 'over power and the top position in the movement' (Akol 2001: 203).

Like the 'big men' in Khartoum, the leaders of the SPLM/A were themselves 'big men' who did not hesitate to use violence against anybody, including their own people, who challenged them. Indeed, the SPLM/A grew out of the authoritarian former Sudanese political culture, and shared many of the characteristics of the regimes that ruled the country. De Waal points out that the 'Sudanese governance has long been neo-patrimonial, a lesser-noticed feature of Sudanese rebellions, including the SPLM/A, has been that they share many of the same characteristics' (De Waal 2014: 348). In this kind of system, the leader maintains authority through patronage (Bratton and van der Walle 1994) and may also frequently resort to violence to retain or acquire power.

Ultimately, Garang triumphed over other contenders for power in the SPLM/A because of the military backing of the then Ethiopian president, Mengistu Haile Mariam, whose regime was battling rebels backed by Jaafar Nimeiri's government. Garang was a veteran of the first rebellion, a former colonel in the Sudanese army, and the holder of a doctorate from a US university. Contrary to majority opinion in Southern Sudan, he called for a united 'New Sudan' in which marginalised Sudanese could participate as equal citizens. According to him, marginalised people 'should unite to challenge the minority, elitist, Muslim-Arab hegemony at the core of the country that had dominated Sudan under successive regimes since independence' (Woodward 1996: 51).

Garang's victory, however, would have significant future implications. First, the intervention by a shaky Ethiopian regime in the rebellion in pursuit of its own interests made another round of fighting among Southern rebels likely when the political situation changed. Second, the bitter infighting among Southern rebels intensified the politicisation of ethnicity since Garang was Dinka, while many of his defeated opponents were Nuer. And third, the struggle

also had ideological dimensions as the defeated rebels were interested in independence for Southern Sudan and not a united 'New Sudan'. Indeed, Garang boasted that the first shots fired by the rebel movement were at separatists (Akol 2001: 203). It is possible, however, that some people, especially the Nuer, may have thought the shots were aimed at their ethnic group.

Exploiting the deep ethnic tensions in Southern Sudan, the Nimeiri regime recruited Nuer fighters into the government army. According to Mohamed Salih, the result was that Nimeiri took 'the whole country back to an age before colonialism and resurrected inter-tribal warfare, but now with modern weapons' (Salih 1985: 170). Southerners who needed guns to fight the SPLA had a willing supplier in the government army.

After Nimeiri was overthrown in 1985 by the military, the political manipulation of identity was pursued with renewed determination by Omar al-Bashir, an Islamic fundamentalist who had at one point played host to the late Osama bin Ladin and other Islamic terrorists. The war against the SPLA was rebranded as a *jihad* against infidels, who included Muslims at odds with al-Bashir's version of Islam. Malwal accurately explained how northern elites resorted to Arabism and Islamic fundamentalism so as to retain power in Khartoum (Malwal 1991: 119–27). So, the ethnic card was extensively played to blunt the rebel threat.

Omar al-Bashir's intention to crush the rebellion on the battlefield received a boost in 1991, when Mengistu was ousted from power by rebels supported by the Sudanese army. Shortly afterwards, Riek Machar and Lam Akol, two key SPLM/A commanders, announced the overthrow of John Garang, whom they accused of dictatorship, abuse of human rights and pursuit of a 'New Sudan' that was at odds with majority opinion in Southern Sudan.

The confrontation between these rebel leaders over leadership of the movement degenerated into ethnic bloodletting, with Dinka and Nuer civilians the main targets. According to Jok Madut Jok and Sharon Hutchinson: 'Both John Garang and Riek Machar reached for the 'ethnic' card – and from there the conflict spiralled downwards into numerous independent warlords, each preying upon one another's civilian populations' (Jok and Hutchinson 1999: 128). Indeed, the predation by these warlords resulted in more fatalities among Southern Sudanese than the attacks by and abuses of the Sudanese army (Amnesty International 2000).

Garang survived the attempt to oust him from the leadership, but at a high price for the unity of the Sudanese. Machar and Akol headed for Khartoum, where they entered into sham peace agreements with Omar al-Bashir. Subsequently, their forces cooperated with the government army so as to defeat the SPLA faction led by Garang. In this way, the government waged a counter-insurgency struggle on the cheap (De Waal 2004). Apart from the many civilian casualties in Southern Sudan as a result of the South-on-South violence, the government army was able to make major military gains on the battlefield and consolidated its 'grip on the oilfields in Western Upper Nile (Unity) state' (D'Agoot 2009: 125). Actually, most of the dirty work of protecting the oilfields by cleansing the surrounding areas of civilians was done by Nuer militias.

In my view, one of the main causes of rebel factionalism, and the associated loss of innocent lives, was the personalised way in which SPLM/A affairs were managed. Although a charismatic visionary, Garang ran the movement mainly on his own, and heavy-handedly. As Malwal has noted, Garang 'demonstrated in such a terribly blatant manner over the years that no one else matters but himself' (Malwal 2005: 45). Moreover, as Young has claimed, 'the ideological orientation of the SPLM/A was designed to promote the personal rule of Garang and to justify the militarist focus of the movement' (Young 2008: 161). In addition, he argues that Garang was averse to the creation of effective institutions, and ensured that the small number of institutions he did create had no power (Young 2008: 165). Unsurprisingly, the high command he formed was merely meant to rubberstamp his decisions (Akol 2001: 209).

The danger for those who challenged Garang could be grave indeed. According to Nyaba, he employed heavy-handed measures against his opponents, many of whom, including Arok Thon Arok, Kerubino Kuanyin Bol, Joseph Oduho and Martin Majier, languished behind bars for long periods (Nyaba 2000: 69). Moreover, he claims that many of Garang's opponents lost their lives on flimsy charges of being against his leadership (Nyaba 2000: 69).

Given this stifling environment, peaceful opposition was difficult and dangerous. It is therefore not totally surprising that disillusioned rebel leaders turned their guns on Garang or sought support from the enemy in Khartoum. However, life in Khartoum was not always easy. Some of those who fled there, among them Riek Machar and Lam Akol, quickly became disillusioned and sought reconciliation with Garang, who was also under enormous military pressure. Undoubtedly, the price of factionalism had been huge for all of them.

Unable to prevail on the battlefield, al-Bashir became more interested in a negotiated settlement. However, the negotiations were far from comprehensive as the two belligerent parties excluded other stakeholders. Malwal has pointed out that 'the two parties to the conflict in Sudan had both become adept in manipulating everything to their very narrow benefit, either as individual leaders or as power seeking organisations' (Malwal 2005: 13).

Towards the end of the 1990s, the negotiations made major progress, culminating in the signing of the CPA in 2005. The rewards for the leaders of the belligerent parties were mouth watering. In particular, the CPA brought huge benefits for Garang (Young 2008). He became the first vice-president of former Sudan as well as president of the government of the southern region. Besides, he retained the position of commander-in-chief of the SPLM/A. His personal power was greatly bolstered but his advancement also generated significant dissent, bitterness and complaints among those who felt excluded. According to Malwal:

> The notion that those who brought this type of … situation about, that peace should be negotiated only between those who are fighting each other, even though the civil war issues concern all the political forces and the citizenry of the state is the major weakness of this peace agreement.
>
> (Malwal 2005: 38)

Predictably, the marginalised people of Darfur, some of whom were part of the SPLM/A, felt let down and took matters into their own hands. They commenced a rebellion that continues to this day, leaving many dead or displaced.

Even within the movement, the manner in which the CPA was negotiated fuelled disunity. A few weeks before the signing of the agreement on 9 January 2005, the SPLM/A experienced another internal struggle, set off by rumours that Garang had ordered the arrest of his deputy, Salva Kiir. Had the SPLM/A commanders not acted quickly to defuse the conflict, the peace talks would probably have unravelled.

During a three-day meeting in Rumbek, the minutes of which were leaked, rebel leaders gathered the courage to accuse their leader of 'arrogance, ethnic favouritism, autocratic decision making, a failure to consult, accepting corruption by those close to him, and favouritism of Dinkas, especially those from his home area of Bor' (Young 2008: 168). Salva Kiir reportedly accused his boss as follows:

> I would also like to say something about rampant corruption in the Movement. At the moment some members of the Movement have formed private companies, bought houses and have huge bank accounts in foreign countries. I wonder what kind of system we are going to establish in South Sudan.
>
> (quoted in De Waal 2014: 345)

The meeting resolved to form committees, which never accomplished their assigned tasks. Garang continued to act as if nothing had happened and instead 'used his increased powers to alienate enemies and critics and began to line up those closest to him to assume highest positions in the governments of Juba and Khartoum' (Young 2008: 169). Salva Kiir was promoted to the rank of lieutenant-general and replaced as the SPLA chief of staff by Garang's son-in-law, Oyai Deng (Young 2008: 169). Then the SPLM National Leadership Council was dissolved.

Tragically, Garang died in a helicopter crash while returning from Uganda, sending shock waves throughout the country, but opening new leadership possibilities in the movement. Salva Kiir replaced him, and assumed all the positions that he had held. This change heralded a new era for SPLM/A, and many South Sudanese hoped that it would be a better one. According to Young, Salva Kiir was 'not autocratic, decisive, or – at least to date – a power monger' (Young 2008: 169). He was perceived as 'a modest, soft-spoken man, almost the polar opposite of the arrogant and charismatic Garang' (Young 2008: 169). Most South Sudanese saw him as the best person to lead Southern Sudan to independence and forge unity among its desperate people.

Initially, Kiir seemed to live up to the expectations of most Southern Sudanese. He reached out to some of the militias that had allied themselves with the Khartoum regime during the war, and signed a deal in January 2006 with Paulino Matiep, a brutal Nuer warlord who wreaked havoc on Nuer civilians

in Unity State and led the South Sudan Defence Force (SSDF). This deal averted a civil war in Southern Sudan (De Waal 2014: 355). Over time, however, Kiir, who had been in the notorious Sudanese security apparatus before defecting to join Garang to found the SPLM/A, behaved more and more like his predecessor. Perhaps, the hopes for a different style of leadership were misplaced, for as Idris explains, 'the military culture that came with the guerrilla movement added to the consolidation of an authoritarian political culture' (Idris 2013: 127).

Increasingly, Kiir placed people loyal to him, especially Dinka from Greater Bahr el Ghazal, in positions of power without regard for equity or the diversity of the country. More disturbingly, the rampant corruption of the war years that he had criticised continued, and actually took on shocking proportions. As in the war years, the former rebel commanders behaved in utterly predatory ways, looting state resources without regard for the public good (Pinaud 2014). Fictitious documents were used by individuals to siphon off billions of US dollars (*Sudan Tribune* 2011). Nonetheless, Kiir continued to talk tough against corruption, just as he had during the Rumbek meeting. For example, he blamed his former colleagues in a leaked letter as follows: 'We fought for freedom, justice, and equality. Many of our friends died to achieve these objectives. When we got to power we forgot what we fought for and began to enrich ourselves at the expense of our people' (Kiir 2013). In reality, no significant action was taken to stamp out corruption and other abuses.

As a result, many people lost trust in the government. Indeed, an opinion study based on focus group discussions conducted across all states in South Sudan and published in 2012 revealed that the majority of participants thought their leaders were taking their country in the wrong direction (Cook and Moro 2012).

Some of the dissent translated into armed rebellion against the government. George Athor, a top commander during the war, founded the South Sudan Democratic Movement/Army (SSDM/A) and fought deadly battles with the SPLA after losing elections during the largely flawed April 2010 polls. In December 2011, he was reportedly killed near the Ugandan border. Like other rebels, the SSDM/A apparently received support from the army of the Khartoum regime (Small Arms Survey 2011).

David Yau Yau, another loser in the April 2010 elections, also took up arms. In 2014, he reached a deal with the government that made him the chief administrator of the Greater Pibor area in Jonglei State. This allowed the government army to concentrate on fighting Riek Machar's rebels, the latest rebel group to confront Salva Kiir's regime. These rebels are drawn mostly from the Nuer ethnic group, which has a history of antagonism towards the Dinka that appears to be worsening. As the Sudd Institute accurately points out, South Sudan's 'splits in one form or another had pitted the Dinka community against that of the Nuer and this political rivalry had gotten worse over the years' (Sudd Institute 2014: 7). The current factionalism is indeed the worst seen in South Sudan.

The first or Anyanya war and the Addis Ababa Agreement

The second war followed a 10-year period of relative peace in Southern Sudan that resulted from the conclusion of the Addis Ababa Peace Agreement in 1972, which ended the 17-year war between the government of Jaafar Nimeiri and the Anyanya rebels, led by Joseph Lagu Yanga. The first war, and the ensuing period of relative peace, shared certain features with, but also differed in significant respects from, the second war and the period that followed the signing of the CPA. Here, the similarities and differences are dwelt on, with the emphasis on the actions of key leaders, among them Joseph Lagu and a prominent Southern Sudanese lawyer and politician, Abel Alier, who headed the government delegation in the talks that led to the Addis Ababa Agreement. Of course, Jaafar Nimeiri also played a vital role in ending the first war as well as in the return to fighting in 1983.

In contrast to the professed aim of the SPLM/A, Anyanya championed the independence of the southern region, whose people were afraid of being dominated by northern Arab and Muslim elites. The rebellion formally started in 1955, a few months prior to Sudan's independence, and ended 17 years later. About 500,000 people died during the war and thousands more were displaced (Peterson 2000: 179).

After many failed attempts to end the war, Jaafar Nimeiri's government struck a peace deal with the Anyanya rebels. The agreement was reached at a time when Nimeiri was in a vulnerable position: by concluding the deal he hoped to survive in power with the backing of the Southern Sudanese, as most Northern Sudanese hated him (Deng 1995). Indeed, the Communists, who had brought him to power, nearly succeeded in toppling his regime in 1971, a year before the Addis Ababa Agreement. After their failed attempt, he purged the Communists thoroughly, leaving himself without a significant support base in the North, since he had already brutally repressed the traditionally powerful sectarian parties, the Umma, Democratic Unionist Party and Islamic Charter.

Nonetheless, the agreement was a significant victory for the Southern Sudanese. It gave them the right to form an autonomous administration, with extensive executive and legislative powers. Moreover, the Southern Sudanese chose their leaders through the ballot while Northern Sudanese were toiling under a one-party dictatorship. Complaints about election results were handled peacefully through a credible court system. Compared to the elections during the post CPA period, these were indeed golden days for democracy.

Because of all the benefits that flowed from the Addis Ababa Agreement, Southern Sudanese threw their weight behind Nimeiri, at least initially. Indeed, Southerner support proved vital for Nimeiri's survival in power at certain points (El-Affendi 1990: 378). For instance, Southern Sudanese enabled Nimeiri to thwart an attempt by a militia organised by the leader of the Umma Party, Sadiq el Mahdi, to seize power in July 1976. Moreover, the agreement enhanced Nimeiri's international standing and he was 'even considered for a Nobel Peace Prize' (Malwal 1982: 17).

Being an opportunistic leader, however, Nimeiri changed course when oil was discovered in 1978 in the present Unity State in South Sudan. His desire to control the oil, and Southerner resistance to his machinations, led him and other Northern political elites to gradually undermine the Addis Ababa Agreement. Southern leaders were told that oil resources 'were of no concern to the Southern administration' (Malwal 1985: 20). Southerners rejected this view and insisted that they had a right to participate in the development of the oil resources and share in the revenues that were expected to begin flowing by the mid-1980s.

The Nimeiri regime subsequently took several steps – including politically renaming oil areas in the South, observing secrecy on oil matters, attempting to redraw the North-South border so that valuable oilfields were incorporated in the North, and proposing to construct an oil refinery in Kosti instead of in the South – to more effectively control the development of oil resources and the expected profits.

Then the Nimeiri government used divide and rule tactics to wear down Southern resistance to his detested oil and other policies. In particular, he played off Alier and Lagu against one another as they struggled for leadership in Southern Sudan. Shortly after the agreement was signed in 1972, Jaafar Nimeiri appointed Alier, then the vice president of the country, to head the provisional high executive council in Juba that was to last for 18 months. This move was not well received by Lagu, who was not consulted in advance, or by other former Anyanya leaders (Lagu 2006: 292). However, Lagu was absorbed into the Sudanese army as a major-general in April 1972.

By allowing Nimeiri to sideline him, Lagu demonstrated a different kind of leadership, at least compared to the rebel leaders who came after him. Indeed, Malwal, writing in 2005, described him as being 'in a class much above our present times' (Malwal 2005: 58). In the days of the SPLM/A, it became the norm for the leader to monopolise all available positions. For example, when the CPA was concluded, Garang took over all the top leadership positions in the Southern and central governments that were slated for South Sudanese candidates.

After the transitional period, Southern Sudan opted for general elections in 1973. Abel Alier was elected by members of the regional assembly as the president of the High Executive Council for a four-year term. With no military experience and limited backing from the Anyanya, Alier recruited the most competent persons to build a democratic political system, which was even praised by the Western press (Lagu 2005: 376). The Regional Assembly played a vital role in checking corruption. For example, members of the Assembly grilled a vice-president of the region over the handling of 30,000 Sudanese pounds meant for resettlement, leading to his dismissal (Lagu 2005: 370). Moreover, with no oil revenues, the region implemented several development projects. These were significant compared to the gloomy situation South Sudanese experienced after the CPA was concluded, despite the huge inflows of oil money into government coffers.

In 1978, the Southern Sudanese again went to the polls to choose their representatives in the Regional Assembly. Joseph Lagu became the president of the High Executive Council. Instead of allowing him to complete his term of office, Alier and his group persuaded Jaafar Nimeiri to force him to step down in 1980.

Apparently aggrieved by the way he was forced out of power, Lagu, a member of a small ethnic group in South Sudan, the Madi, pursued the same divide and rule tactics as his opponent, whom he accused of undermining the Addis Ababa Agreement and institutionalising 'Dinka tribalism' (Lagu 2005: 374). To address the domination of the region by the Dinka, Lagu campaigned for the re-division of the region into three smaller regions, oblivious of the fact that this would abrogate the Addis Ababa Agreement (Lagu 2006). Re-dividing the South was exactly what Jaafar Nimeiri and his new allies in the North wanted. In July 1977, Nimeiri had reached agreement with his arch enemies, the Umma Party head Sadiq el Mahdi and the Muslim Brotherhood leader Dr Hassan el Turabi. Appointed attorney general, el Turabi began the process of Islamising Sudan's laws and undermining the Addis Ababa Agreement.

Alier was put in the difficult position of selling Nimeiri's unpopular policies while also defending the interests of the Southern Sudanese who had voted for him in the elections. He was worried that the politicians he had outmanoeuvred would exploit the difficulties he was facing. That was precisely what the Lagu group was bent on doing. In October 1981, Alier was relieved of his office for opposing Southern Sudan's further re-division of the region. In 1983, Nimeiri went ahead with this re-division, and subsequently imposed *Sharia* or Islamic law over the whole country. In the same year, the war resumed. The newly formed SPLM/A attacked an oil base in Southern Sudan, subsequently bringing all oil activities to a halt. In addition, another prestigious government project, the Jonglei Canal, was attacked and brought to standstill.

Having abrogated the Addis Ababa Agreement, the one significant achievement of his government, Jaafar Nimeiri was forced out of office by a massive civilian demonstration while he was away visiting his strongest supporter, the US, in 1985.

Conclusion

Southern Sudan, which broke away from Sudan on 9 July 2011, has a long history of rebellions against governing regimes. This chapter argues that a major cause of these rebellions is the autocratic way in which the leaders govern their people, in the process generating dissent that often expresses itself as violent conflict. The most recent rebellion in the country, which began in December 2013, was essentially sparked by the attempts of the 'big man' who runs the new nation to suppress the efforts by other key SPLM members to contest the chairmanship of the party. The dispute that followed among them divided the army, which was an amalgamation of groups loyal to particular individuals, and quickly took on deadly ethnic overtones.

Ethnic factionalism has long been exploited by elites to achieve their narrow interests in power. Before the former Sudan split, Northern elites manipulated ethnicity and religion to capture the state and exploit resources for their own benefit and that of their supporters, often drawn from their own ethnic or religious groups. As a result, many people were excluded from participating in the affairs of their country. Some of these, including Southern Sudanese, armed themselves and waged war against the autocratic and militaristic leaders. As the late John Garang made clear, people who were excluded from participation in the governance of their own country would have to struggle to redress the injustice (de Mabior 1996).

Ironically, the rebels who battled on behalf of marginalised peoples frequently adopted the habits of the leaders they rejected and were striving to defeat. One result was that rebel leaders themselves faced armed opposition from others who felt excluded. Garang, who ran the SPLM/A heavy-handedly, weathered several rebellions by his colleagues in the rebel movement. In these internal splits, ethnicity was used extensively to achieve narrow aims, often at the cost of senseless deaths and civilian displacement.

Nonetheless, after many years of fighting, the SPLM/A reached a deal with its enemies in Khartoum, which met with the approval of many Southern Sudanese, who ultimately gained their independent country in 2011. However, independence did not bring peace and development. Instead, the SPLM/A elite got bogged down in bitter recriminations that escalated into armed clashes in December 2013. The hope of building a peaceful and united country will be difficult to achieve if the lust for power by former rebels is not tamed and replaced by a willingness to embrace democratic governance and tolerance for genuine opposition.

Moreover, the leaders of the country could learn from the experience of their predecessors who came to power after the first war, the Anyanya rebellion. During that period, power was not the exclusive preserve of former rebel leaders. Indeed, highly qualified people with no military background played a key role in instituting a largely democratic system, despite interference by the 'big man' in Khartoum. Ultimately, it was he who abrogated the Addis Ababa Agreement, leading to the return to war in 1983.

Notes

1 The term former Sudan refers to Republic of Sudan before the secession of South Sudan.
2 The Dinka are the most numerous ethnic group in the country, followed by the Nuer.

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Part V

Liberation struggles for reform (regime change)



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13 Liberation movements turned governments

The Ugandan experience

George G. Okiror

Introduction

What a liberation movement is or is not may be a matter of ideology. Generally speaking, liberation movements as defined in the African context are associated with the fight for political independence from a coloniser or with a political struggle by a people for emancipation from oppression by an authoritarian or dictatorial leadership. Thus, Africa has witnessed two types of liberation struggle (Melber 2002).

A liberation movement is, as the name suggests, a collective of like-minded persons whose sole objective is to break loose from some kind of bondage, thereby ushering in change that sets people free. Liberation originates from the root word liberty. It is then the process by which a group of people engage the oppressor in the form of a colonial or authoritarian regime, usually through armed struggle, with the ultimate aim of freeing the population from political, economic or sociocultural subordination.

Though Uganda gained independence from Great Britain in 1962 in a seemingly peaceful transfer of political power, Uganda's political teething problems became apparent at just about the same time (Kanyeihamba 2002). This was largely because power was handed to a prime minister, Dr Apollo Milton Obote, who was to serve under a president, King Edward Mutesa.[1] Though the position of president was only ceremonial, a bitter power struggle immediately ensued between king and prime minister, leading to the abolition of kingdoms and the exiling of Mutesa. The Baganda people felt picked upon as a result of these actions. From the outset, Obote had to contend with the seeds of conflict sown at the very time the tools of power were handed to him by the departing colonisers (Kanyeihamba 2002).

In 1971, while Obote was attending the Commonwealth heads of state conference in Singapore, a military coup was mounted by General Idi Amin Dada. What ensued between 1971 and 1979 can only be described as a period of darkness in the history of Uganda. Politically, the country descended from being a fledgling democracy into a brutal dictatorship. The hitherto promising economy, largely Indian-controlled, suffered when the Asians were expelled. Socially, no one group was spared the loss and disappearance of loved ones at the hands of Idi Amin's infamous secret service. By 1979, the fear that gripped the nation,

the poverty and the lack of just about all basic consumer goods, brought the country to a grinding halt. By this time, Ugandans in exile and the international community realised that if nothing was done at the earliest opportunity, Uganda would become a failed state (Olum 2012; Kanyeihamba 2002).

Idi Amin's political escapades were not only internal but also external. After assuming power, he proclaimed that part of western Kenya and the Kagera Basin were really part of Uganda and were to be annexed. As expected, this did not sit well with the leadership in neighbouring Kenya and Tanzania. The Tanzanian president, Mwalimu Julius Nyerere, took the lead in organising opposition to Amin among the Ugandans who had sought asylum in his country. The exiled Ugandan community had also come to the realisation that if nothing was done at this time, there would be no other opportunity to save their loved ones from Amin's dictatorship or to return to their motherland (Olum 2012).

The 1978–79 Liberation War

The 1978–79 war against Amin was agreeable to many as a liberation movement because it united a majority of Ugandans against one common enemy and aimed for regime change from an oppressive government. Second, the Amin dictatorship affected just about everyone: people had either lost loved ones, were on the run for their lives or experienced the general lack of basic goods and services. By 1978–79, Ugandans had been pushed to breaking point by Amin. The Tanzanian People's Defence Forces (TPDF), numbering 40,000–100,000 soldiers equipped with heavy military hardware, and Ugandan exiles in Tanzania and the diaspora[2] took it upon themselves to free the country of Amin's dictatorship (Olum 2012).

The Uganda National Liberation Army (UNLA) comprised the Kikosi Maalum group commanded by General Tito Okello and David Oyite Ojok; the Front for National Salvation (FRONASA) group under Yoweri Museveni's command; and the Save Uganda Movement commanded by Akena p'Ojok, William Omaria and Ateker Ejalu. For their part, Amin's forces were aided by 2,500 troops provided by Muammar Gaddafi and firepower in the form of tanks, armed personnel carriers and MiG 21 bombers. On 10 April 1979, Kampala fell to the liberation forces. After the whole country had been freed, the TPDF stayed on in the country to maintain peace, thereby earning themselves the Swahili name Wakombozi, the liberators. Meanwhile, the Uganda National Liberation Front (UNLF), the political wing of the UNLA, set about organising elections to return the country to civilian rule (Kanyeihamba 2002).

The involvement of a combined force of TPDF and exiled Ugandan forces under the umbrella of UNLA to liberate Uganda shows the extent to which President Nyerere believed in regional peace and that the solutions to African problems lay in Africa. Uganda will always owe the success of its first liberation struggle against an internal enemy to the Tanzanian people. As to whether Tanzanian involvement diminishes the Ugandan character of the liberation war, this cannot be doubted because ousting a ruthless dictator like Amin would not

have been a simple task for Ugandans in exile alone. Some have actually gone on to argue that Tanzania's participation in the liberation war was an act of aggression against Uganda. Whatever the case, Amin's dictatorship in Uganda was brought to an end in 1979 with the help of Tanzania, thereby ending Uganda's first liberation struggle after independence.

Path to civilian rule in Uganda

After the ouster of Idi Amin, the Tanzanians handed over power to President Usuf Lule. Political infighting led to a change in political leadership in Uganda in June 1979 when Godfrey Binaisa took over from Lule. He in turn was replaced on 12 May 1980 by the military commission headed by Paul Muwanga. A three-man presidential commission took over from the military and governed the country until December 1980, when general elections took place, from which Obote emerged victorious. However, because the elections were disputed as fraudulent, Museveni, who had himself competed for the presidency, launched a guerrilla campaign against the Obote II regime (Kanyeihamba 2002). The old bitter political party rivalries and ethnic differences that predated Amin's emergence were reignited.[3]

As the Obote II regime tried to settle into power and implement its agenda of reconstructing the country politically, economically and socially, it could not ignore the 'political bandits',[4] especially after news of armed clashes between government forces and rebels in the bush near Luwero filtered in. Like many another army contending with guerrillas within national borders, human rights abuses by the UNLA, especially in the central region, became commonplace.

As the silent bush war took its toll on the armed forces through frequent hit-and-run attacks and ambushes, cracks began to develop within the UNLA's ranks. With the death of the armed forces chief of staff, David Oyite Ojok, in a helicopter crash on 2 December 1983, the infighting among the generals became ever more apparent, with the older and more seasoned generals complaining of unfairness and favouritism in the promotion of a junior general, Smith Opon Achak,[5] as the new army chief of staff. It was in July 1985 that Generals Tito Okello and Bazilio Okello staged a military coup that sent Obote packing once more into exile (Olum 2012).

The Obote II regime can only be described as brief and riven by power struggles involving many of the groups that had participated in the 1979 war to overthrow Amin. Before he could settle down to run the country and put right the economy that had suffered greatly under Amin, Obote had once again to flee. Thus hopes for civilian rule and democratisation in Uganda were again dashed (Kanyeihamba 2002).

Performance of the first liberation movement

In all fairness, this liberation movement turned government can be assessed in terms of a struggle to regain power from a military dictatorship and return the

country to civilian rule. Though it had insufficient time to get down to running the country, it nonetheless gave Ugandans a respite from military rule and some semblance of peace and security, except in the central region, where Museveni and his guerrilla fighters had gained a foothold (Kanyeihamba 2002).

During the brief interlude the civilian government was in power, Obote reorganised the economy. For example, he jump-started agricultural production – which is the backbone of the economy. Farmer cooperatives received government support and were restored to almost the same position they had held before the Amin era. Consumer goods like sugar and salt, previously rationed or completely unavailable, reappeared. The value of the Uganda shilling was restored, as was consumer confidence. A start was made on rebuilding schools, hospitals and other infrastructure destroyed during the liberation war (Olum 2012).

The fact that elections were held after the ouster of Idi Amin, however disputed they might have been, was a step in the right direction to democratise the country. Given the hopelessness, brutality and fear that Amin had instilled in the citizenry, an opportunity to cast a vote to decide who should govern the country must have been a liberating experience (Kanyeihamba 2002).

On the international scene, normalisation of relations with other countries in the region and further afield made citizens aware that they were part of the world again. Ugandan embassies and foreign missions, closed during the Amin era, reopened and other countries reciprocated by reopening their embassies and missions in Uganda. International travel, business and other cultural exchanges resumed.

An attempt at state-building was also made. Institutions suppressed during the Amin era, such as parliament, the judiciary and the executive were able to thrive again, and the day-to-day running of government by technocrats took root once more (Kanyeihamba 2002).

Weaknesses of the first liberation movement

However, by no means everything the first liberation movement government did went right. For example, the army was notorious for its human rights abuses, including abductions and disappearances, from which people returned – if they returned at all – bearing the scars of torture. This was especially the case in Kampala region, where Andrew Kayiira's Uganda Freedom Movement (UFM)[6] was operating to overthrow Obote's government. Human rights abuses were also reported in the Luwero triangle, where Museveni's guerrilla forces operated. Worse still, army discipline was lacking in many ways, as the army had become a haven for illiterates, misfits and malcontents. This in many ways explains the behaviour of the military towards the civilian population (Olum 2012).

Nepotism was one of the ills noted under the Obote II regime. The armed forces and the civil service were full of people from the greater north. Lucrative government contracts and tenders were dished out to northern tribesmen and the president's close associates. For example, the coffee and cotton export business was in the hands of close friends and relatives.

Attempts at democratisation were jeopardised by election fraud. Moreover, infighting for power among the UNLA/F groups that ousted Amin quickly undermined the positive efforts to foster development and democracy, taking the country back to square one. The rapid succession of political leaders within a period of one year attests to this infighting within the first liberation movement. Before Obote and his team could plan for the reconstruction of the country after years of economic meltdown and mismanagement, they were confronted by dissent and rebellion from within that movement (Kanyeihamba 2002).

Emergence of Museveni and his National Resistance Army/Movement

After seizing power, General Okello invited all groups fighting Obote's government to roundtable discussions in a bid to end the war. While the general's team was busy hosting these discussions with NRA/M delegates in Nairobi after 26 August 1985, Museveni's foot soldiers were advancing towards Kampala. Even though a ceasefire had been agreed, it was never respected. Museveni's bush war was dubbed a liberation struggle, because Museveni and his team believed they were fighting to free Ugandans from human rights abuses by corrupt and dictatorial rulers. According to Museveni, waging a protracted people's war was the only way to involve the whole population (Museveni 1997). By the end of 1985, NRA rebels controlled most of western Uganda. The final onslaught on Kampala started on 17 January 1986 and on the 26 January Okello's six-month hold on power ended. On 29 January, Museveni was sworn into office, thereby marking the culmination of the second liberation struggle in Uganda.

In its formative stages, the National Resistance Movement/National Resistance Army (NRM/NRA) developed a political blueprint, the Ten Point programme (Museveni 1985), for the development of a new Uganda. The programme listed the historical problems that Museveni and his team believed had been the main causes of Uganda's ills since the end of the colonial era. These were generally the same political, economic and social problems that many other African countries had confronted. For each of the problems, the NRM/A provided a solution that they would implement capturing political power. In part, the programme

> clearly spelt out the historical mission of the NRM as [being] that of transforming Uganda's society from a backward state to a modern and progressive one; transforming from a state of anarchy and oppression to a new constitutional and democratic order.
>
> (Museveni 1985)

Reading the NRM's 'political manifesto' while in the bush would surely endear Museveni to any Doubting Thomas as to what the movement's intentions were in waging the war. The Ten Points included the following: (1) There was a need for parliamentary democracy, participatory democracy and a decent

living standard for every Ugandan; (2) Ugandans and other Africans were living in insecurity, as, for example, under the Obote and Amin regimes; (3) One of the major causes of strife in Uganda and Africa was a lack of national unity and there was a need for the elimination of all forms of sectarianism; (4) There was also a need to defend and consolidate national independence; (5) An independent, integrated and a self-sustaining economy was needed; (6) The restoration and improvement of social services was required, as was the rehabilitation of war-ravaged areas; (7) Corruption and misuse of power were to be eliminated; (8) The errors that led to the dislocation of sections of the population needed to be redressed and the plight of salaried workers addressed; (9) There would be cooperation with other African countries to defend human and democratic rights; and (10) A mixed economy strategy would be followed (Museveni 1985).

Critical analysis of NRM performance

With its political agenda clearly laid out, what NRM needed was an opportunity to implement it after capturing political power. In reference to the first point on democracy, President Museveni said that 'one of Africa's biggest problems is leaders who stick to power and do not want to hand over state power' (Museveni 1997). However, after capturing power, promulgating a new constitution and opening up political space for multiparty politics, there has been a change of mind by the person who made this statement and promised in the Ten Point Programme. Today, the constitution that person adopted has been amended to remove presidential term limits and laws have been enacted that curtail individual rights and freedoms and make it impossible to have free and fair elections. The liberation movement rhetoric has completely changed. For example, three decades down the road, President Museveni shows no signs of handing over political power to the next generation of leaders who espouse the ideals of the liberation movement he championed. Instead, the new argument is that 'Africa's problem is not about how long one is in power, but what one can deliver'.[7]

Many of the Ten Points remain to be achieved. For instance, in relation to democracy, ordinary Ugandans have had opportunities to cast their ballots. Each time, though, people have become more and more discontented with election outcomes, as with the most recent presidential and parliamentary elections in 2016. Political representation in the legislature is no longer meaningful, as the assembly has largely become a rubberstamp for an overbearing executive. Legislators are more concerned with their individual survival and relations with the party president than with representing the interests of their constituents. So one thing the liberation movement turned government has failed to give Ugandans is the opportunity to truly democratise the country. Yes, elections are held, but very often they are sham elections whose outcome can be predicted long beforehand. Indeed, as regards the 2016 elections, most election bodies apart from the regional ones faulted the whole process.[8]

In terms of security, the NRM should be applauded for bringing peace and security to the whole country. As compared with past regimes like Idi Amin's, when state-sponsored insecurity and abductions were the order of the day, one can go to just about any part of the country today and be safe. However, the Lord's Resistance Army (LRA)[9] wreaked havoc in northern Uganda and it took decades before relative peace was finally established there. The same can be said of parts of the northeast, which experienced both LRA attacks and Karamojong[10] cattle rustling.

In regard to Uganda's national independence, the NRM has not undertaken major external aggression that would have the effect of jeopardising it. However, the Allied Democratic Front (ADF), a rebel group based in the Congo, has on a number of occasions tried to invade the country across the western border, but the Uganda People's Democratic Forces (UPDF) have been consistently able to repulse the forays to the point of almost wiping out the ADF. The biggest external threat to Uganda, as to other countries in the region, are the al Queda and al Shabaab terror groups,[11] which have long targeted the country on account of the Ugandan army's deployment in Somalia.

The building of an independent and self-sustaining national economy remains largely unfinished business for the NRM government. This is because the economy, including former national assets like the Uganda Commercial Bank and the general banking sector, has been largely handed over to foreign companies. Other examples of such hand-overs include the Uganda Coffee and Cotton Marketing Boards, the Uganda Dairy Corporation and Uganda Posts and Telecommunications (Nasasira 2015).

Despite being the backbone of the country's economy, agriculture continues to be dominated by peasant farmers lacking in the knowledge, skills and capital necessary to revolutionise farming. While the NRM government has had some good ideas about and plans for boosting the agricultural sector, the budgetary allocations for this purpose have been too meagre to achieve meaningful results. Moreover, technical expertise needs boosting in order to offer farmers the required services and support. Unfortunately, the National Agricultural Advisory Services (NAADS)[12] programme has been riddled with corruption, leading the president to suspend its operations in 2015. Other earlier programmes such as *entandikwa*[13] and *bona ba gagawale*[14] did not achieve much either.

Underlying reasons for dismal NRM performance in government

One of the people who fought alongside Museveni during the armed struggle was noted as saying 'When we were fighting, you were eating sausages', meaning it is our turn to enjoy the fruits of our struggles. This line of reasoning was re-echoed during the second presidential candidates' debate on 13 February 2016, when President Museveni said: 'You cannot wish me out of power when my government discovered oil in Uganda under my direct command' (*Daily Monitor* 17 February 2016).

A sense of entitlement tends to breed negative tendencies among leaders of liberation movements. For example, corruption and abuse of office are seen as a quick means to gain personal wealth. The disgruntlement resulting from deprivation of the masses can often spark off the next wave of liberation movements as citizens seek to reappropriate national resources in their own interests (Mohamed Salih 2007).

One reason the NRM government has failed to deliver on its own promises is not because of lack of mechanisms for dealing with corrupt officials and politicians but rather a lack of interest in doing so, perhaps because of this very feeling of entitlement to the benefits of the armed struggle. Second, because of the close-knit relationships between liberation fighters, it becomes more difficult to isolate and punish comrades for their misconduct (Melber 2001; Mohamed Salih 2007).

Another reason liberation movements turned governments fail to deliver is lack of accountability. This needs to be examined on two levels, the leaders and the citizens. From the leaders' point of view, the forceful means by which power is assumed often gives them the attitude that their power derives from the gun and that, consequently, they are not answerable to the larger citizenry but to themselves, that is, the clique that fought. Unfortunately, the liberation struggle leaders often forget that citizens have chosen to accept their movements and support the armed struggle largely because they believe, or are made to believe, that they are being liberated from some assumed or apparent oppression (Melber 2008, 2002).

Citizens shy away from demanding accountability either because they lack a culture of doing so or because of the fear arising from the autocratic nature of the leadership (Heywood 2002). Even where liberation movements metamorphose into 'democratic governments' by allowing some popular participation in decision-making or election of leaders, as in Uganda today, citizens are still in a weak position to demand accountability. The questions still stand as to whether failure by citizens to demand accountability is the result of a weak political culture or the failure by citizens to recognise their rights and responsibilities or because the liberation movement turned government simply does not care to respond to such demands (Melber 2001).

Because of a weak political culture, citizens are generally too apathetic about good governance. For example, they may fail to put pressure on their leaders to account for their actions. As a result, leaders very often act in the knowledge that nobody will bring them to book for their misdeeds (Mohamed Salih 2007; Melber 2001). Apathy in relation to political matters may stem from the fact that citizens' opinions are not considered in larger decision-making processes at the local and/or central government level. Rather than being decision-making partners, citizens are largely implementers of government programmes. As a result of this lack of meaningful citizen involvement in the planning process, a number of failed government projects and programmes litter the countryside, programmes such as the earlier noted *entandikwa*, *bona ba gagawale* and most recently the National Agricultural Advisory Services.

As liberation movements have always gained power through armed struggle, they tend to deal with disgruntled voices and political opposition by using extreme force and the power of the gun whenever necessary. This approach is meant to instil as much fear as possible to deter groups from ever challenging the incumbents. The attitude of the NRM leaders in Uganda towards any opposition is one of daring anyone to try to get in their way. For example, President Museveni has always dared those who threaten to take up arms against his government by saying 'We have the guns and numbers in our soldiers … you risk it and you will see our wrath', and 'you go to the bush, we will find you there and crush you … after all that is what we are good at'.[15]

Another reason liberation movements fail to perform as governments is because, over time, they become preoccupied with regime and power consolidation at the expense of other matters vital to common citizens (Mohamed Salih 2007; Melber 2001). Heavy expenditure on the military and police at the expense of other key sectors has been a defining characteristic of the NRM regime since it came to power. For example, in preparation for the backlash resulting from a contested presidential election in 2016, the Museveni government is believed to have spent billions of dollars on heavy military hardware and teargas to enable the police and army to deter political activists and unarmed civilian protests (Nasasira 2015).

Instead, this money should have been spent on pro-people development programmes such as building and equipping more hospitals for better health delivery, especially as many national hospitals do not have enough beds for patients,[16] nor even sufficient medicines, while doctor-patient ratios are unfavourable, due to the failure to offer attractive salaries to doctors. In some instances, hospitals are physically collapsing as a result of decades of neglect and lack of maintenance. With regard to agriculture, it received Uganda shillings (UGX) 486 billion while the security ministry received UGX 1.5 trillion in the 2015–16 financial year (Nasasira 2015).

Additionally, the preoccupation with holding on to power has led the NRM to embrace an undemocratic culture in Uganda. For example, Museveni and his team have sought to amend the national constitution to entrench themselves in power. Specific examples include the removal of presidential term limits and the enactment of laws that curtail God-given rights and freedoms. Other undemocratic practices include rigging elections at whatever cost and the use of disproportionate force in responding to even the slightest attempts by citizens to demonstrate. These practices go against the very ethos the liberation movement stood for in mounting the liberation struggle (Kanyeihamba 2002).

Liberation movements by their very nature tend to rely on the charisma of a single person – their leader. While the movement has its cadres, none would like to be seen as antagonistic to the founding father figure, since this could have dire consequences. This tendency has worked against the performance of liberation movements-cum-governments, as in the Ugandan case (Olum 2012). Over-reliance on the father figure for counsel on just about everything has led to the neglect of promoting, building and strengthening national institutions, and abuse of them

where they do exist. National institutions established during independence today stand as empty shells and relics of past glory. When such institutions wither, one can only wonder what will happen to a country once its leader is no more or out of power. Leaders come and go, so any nation seeking to be great needs lasting institutions, upon which future leaders can also make their mark. Meanwhile in Uganda, because of lack of institution-building, people run to Museveni to solve all sorts of trivial problems, the most common being land wrangles (Olum 2012).

Following from the above, it can be argued that the lack of institutional checks and balances, as in Uganda under the NRM, is a further reason liberation movements perform poorly as post-liberation governments. The parliament of Uganda and the judiciary are currently a façade. The overbearing nature of the executive, resulting from the excessive powers vested in the executive by the 1995 Constitution, has rendered the other branches of government powerless (Kanyeihamba 2002). For example, Ugandan parliaments since the NRM's coming to power, with the exception of the sixth parliament, have largely been rubberstamp legislatures. This has allowed, for example, the removal of presidential term limits under the constitution and the draconian Public Order Management Act. The fact that the NRM holds over 90 per cent of the seats in the house has given it further freedom to pass laws to its advantage, much to the chagrin of those in opposition (Olum 2012).

Another example of the lack of checks and balances is when the Ugandan government in 1998, acting on Museveni's orders and without consulting parliament, deployed military forces to the Congo in the name of pursuing ADF rebels. This operation was followed by the pillaging of resources by Ugandan generals in cahoots with highly placed government officials. For these criminal acts, the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC) has asked for $10 billion in compensation. Moreover, the International Criminal Court ruled on 19 December 2005 that the DRC's sovereignty had been violated by Uganda and Rwanda (Brosig 2015). These predicaments could perhaps have been avoided had the Ugandan parliament been consulted on the deployment.[17]

It must also be noted that because of the small number of their MPs in the house, the opposition cannot mount the required pressure to meaningfully debate, let alone reverse, the bills coming before them. As a result, opposition members have taken to walking out of parliament as a way of protesting. Thus, a weak and often divided opposition has given the NRM MPs the opportunity to do whatever they please.

Coupled with the above is the NRM's ability to whip into line all its MPs through caucusing whenever an issue of interest is to come before the house. As noted earlier, Museveni as the NRM chairperson allows no dissenting voices or views on positions adopted by the party. Not surprisingly, NRM's position on any issue is usually the view of Museveni.[18] The phenomenon of rebel MPs in Uganda refers to NRM MPs who have dared to challenge the party chair (Olum 2012). For fear of being labelled a 'rebel MP' and the consequences that come with such designation, many NRM MPs would rather not antagonise the chairperson, to the detriment of objective and critical debate within party caucuses.

Moreover, the independence of the judiciary under the NRM government can only be summed up as wanting. On one occasion, when judges attempted to assert their independence in the matter of the Besigye electoral petition in 2012,[19] President Museveni threatened to 'shake up' the judiciary. Such utterances cannot be taken lightly.

A further reason liberation movements turned governments do not function well is because of the boot-licking by the people surrounding the single great leader, people who are intent on securing their own survival. In Uganda and perhaps other countries with similar governments, the president's advisors can at best be termed sycophants. These are usually unwilling, for fear of their safety or of losing their jobs, to call the single leader on his or her errors. This is because voicing such opinions is often seen as going against the liberation leader, who is assumed to be all-knowing and, in some instances, even to be a supreme being. The lack of objective and self-critical views can lead to the failure of the liberation movement-cum-government to deliver on the well-intentioned promises made to the citizenry during the armed struggle (Kanyeihamba 2002).

Upon assuming power as governments, liberation movements may embark on writing constitutions, which, unlike preceding versions, seem democratic, reflecting the popular context in which they came about. However, within a short time the Ugandan constitution has been amended with ease, and to the dismay of many, in order to entrench the liberators in power. A case in point is the amendment of article 105(2) to allow President Museveni to run for the highest political office in perpetuity. Thus, by tinkering with the fundamental law that is intended to differentiate them from their predecessors, liberation movement governments turn the constitution into a façade (Melber 2008; Mohamed Salih 2007).

Cheap popularity gimmicks by the NRM are costing the country's budget a lot. An extremely large local government structure and a bloated civil service, whose original purpose was bringing services to the people, have in themselves hampered service delivery in various ways. The creation of 114 districts (as compared to 32 prior to NRM's accession in 1986) has overstretched financial resources, to the detriment of the new units of administration (Kanyeihamba 2002; Olum 2012). The constant proliferation of districts and the corresponding budgetary allocations to them – inadequate through they be – from just about the same tax base makes little economic sense given the country's GDP. Some of these new districts are not economically viable because they are not home to meaningful economic activities and are thus unable to generate local revenues for their own development.

Most unfortunate of all, the new districts, ostensibly created to bring services closer to the people, are in reality part of a grand scheme to popularise the NRM among the unwitting local population. Second, the new administrative and political vacancies in central and local government are used to reward NRM cadres for their loyal support of the regime. Third, each newly created district has to field two MPs, one directly elected and the other a women's representative. The increase in the number of districts has seen a corresponding increase

in the number of MPs to 485, and the NRM government has seized the opportunity to harvest more MPs for itself. A large local government structure, a bloated civil service and a giant parliament with high levels of corruption and embezzlement of government funds, coupled with a limited resource base, cannot allow for effective service delivery to the common citizens.

In the name of national and regional peace, security and stability and in a bid to generate local and international political prestige, the NRM government has undertaken a number of military operations in the Great Lakes region. Uganda's involvement in Rwanda, the DRC, Somalia and most recently the newly independent South Sudan (Brosig 2015), has cost the country billions of shillings that could otherwise have been used for national development (Mohamed Salih 2007). While it's true no country can peacefully exist in a sea of chaos, issues of regional peace and security should be handled through international and regional bodies such as the United Nations, the African Union and the East African Community. In a similar vein, Uganda must itself desist from unilateral initiatives in the region.

Liberation movements, especially in Africa, seem to have a negative influence on their neighbours. For example, former Libyan President Gaddafi is quoted as telling President Museveni that 'revolutionaries do not fight to hand over power to others'. When one looks at Zimbabwe's President Mugabe, whom most African leaders, including Museveni, admire, his refusal to vacate political office sets a bad example for many other African leaders. Indeed, the removal of presidential term limits to allow incumbents to stay in power for as long as they wish seems to be the new wave of change sweeping across the continent. Looking at Africa today, it can be argued that the rewriting of constitutions and the slew of draconian laws that curtail people's rights and freedoms are attributable to the very liberation movement leaders that Africa at some point cherished and the West heralded as a new and welcome break with the past. While much was expected of such leaders when they assumed political power, the world today looks at most of them with abomination (Heywood 2002; Melber 2008; Mohamed Salih 2007; Olum 2012).

Conclusion

The reasons many liberation movement-cum-governments have failed abysmally to deliver once they are in power are many and varied, depending on the country in question. However, one factor in this failure is the constant selfish desire for power, which unfortunately only ceases with death, as Thomas Hobbes foretold. The struggle for political power among many contenders remains a common occurrence in African countries. The failure of democracy to take root and thus the failure of peaceful transfers of power between leaders can be counted as one of the reasons liberation movement governments continue to flourish on the African continent.

Military struggles were the main mode by which many leaders assumed power in Africa. It has been said that military coups have become an outmoded way of

acquiring political power. However, the failure of peaceful means of assuming and transferring political power, such as free and fair elections, leaves many people in African countries (apart from a few isolated cases) no alternative but to take up arms against those unwilling to relinquish political power. Unfortunately, Africa perhaps has yet to see many more armed 'liberation struggles' because the liberators who assumed power yesterday do not want to relinquish it today.

Notes

1 The king of Buganda, as was stipulated in the independence constitution.
2 Exiled Ugandans had at the Moshi conference united to form the Uganda National Liberation Army to fight Amin.
3 UPC and DP political rivalries also manifested themselves in ethnic and regional terms.
4 Obote's description of Museveni and his fighters.
5 Smith Opon Achak was of Lango descent and a nephew of Obote, while Generals Tito Okello and Bazilio Okello were of Acholi descent.
6 A rebel group in the Buganda region that was fighting alongside Museveni's guerrilla movement.
7 Museveni's remarks during a BBC interview on 23 February 2016.
8 The EU faulted the just concluded elections in Uganda.
9 A notorious rebel group in northern Uganda headed by Joseph Kony.
10 A nomadic group in northeastern Uganda.
11 In July 2010, Kampala experienced terror attacks on crowds watching the screening of the FIFA World Cup final match. The attacks left 74 dead and 70 injured.
12 NAADS was a public-private extension service whose goal is increased market-oriented agricultural production by empowering farmers to demand and control agricultural advisory services.
13 *Entandikwa* is a Baganda word for start-up capital and was a programme through which government attempted to reach out to citizens, but failed.
14 *Bona ba gagawale* is a Baganda expression meaning 'let all get rich', and referred to another failed programme by which government tried to reach out to citizens.
15 Taken from the president's speeches.
16 Mulago Hospital's maternity ward is overflowing with expectant mothers, to the point that some have to sleep under occupied beds.
17 See BBC Timeline on Uganda. Available at www.bbc.com/news/world-africa-14112446.
18 Museveni has always remarked that he is the only one with the necessary vision to lead Uganda.
19 After a high court judgement on the release of detained opposition figures, the court was surrounded 'Black Mambas' (army vehicles), an act one of the justices described as the 'day the courts of Uganda were raped'.

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14 Ethiopia

The quest for transformation under EPRDF

Kassahun Berhanu

Introduction

Ethiopia has experienced three regime changes in the last three decades. The emperor was ousted in 1974 and replaced by a military dictatorship, which attempted to gain legitimacy, even though it was not a constitutionally elected government. The current government, led by the Ethiopian Peoples Revolutionary Democratic Front (EPRDF), seized power in May 1991 following its successful insurgency against military rule. This regime change brought with it changes to both the ideology of the Ethiopian state and its unitary political system. The political landscape, along with state-society relations, were reconfigured through the adoption in principle and practice of ethnic federalism.

A vibrant opposition to imperial rule had unfolded since the 1960s, when the long-entrenched monarchy faced multifaceted resistance from a wide spectrum of societal actors. They made claims and demands for changes ranging from liberal reform to radical transformation of the organisation and *modus operandi* of the state and state-society relations. Organised political groups that surfaced at a later stage had their roots in the Ethiopian Student Movement. These groups, however, differed in their ideological orientation, tactics, strategies and modes of operation. Whereas the Ethiopian Peoples' Revolutionary Party (EPRP), the Ethiopian Democratic Union (EDU) and the All Ethiopian Socialist Movement (AESM) espoused pan-Ethiopian solutions, others like the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF) and the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF) favoured ethno-nationalism. Moreover, while some movements espoused liberal democracy, others subscribed to different variants of Marxism-Leninism.

Established in 1975, TPLF played key roles in the formation of EPRDF in 1989 by bringing together other insurgent movements claiming to represent some of the major ethnic groups in the country. TPLF also subscribed to Marxist-Leninist ideology and held up the vision of transforming the ancient polity's political economy. To this end, it advanced the principle of the right of ethnic groups to self-determination as the cornerstone of its programme, an approach that was fully adopted by EPRDF (Young 1997). In the immediate aftermath of its seizure of power, EPRDF enacted a charter that served as an interim constitution. The charter recognised the sanctity of a multiparty

political system; free and fair competitive elections; a 'free market' economic policy; freedom of speech, assembly and association; and respect for human rights, all of which were to be legally binding following the end of the transitional period in 1995.

With the foregoing as the backdrop, this chapter examines the performance of EPRDF in terms of delivering on its promise to transform the socioeconomic and political landscape by dealing with the root causes of poverty, lack of rights, and inequality and thereby saving the country from the disintegration that had threatened it under military rule. By drawing on analysis of the findings of desk-research, this chapter seeks to draw up a balance sheet of EPRDF's accomplishments and deficiencies since coming to power.

Ethiopian political system: main features

Background

Immediately following the ouster of the military regime, a provisional government came to power and was tasked with providing security and ensuring stability. Subsequently, in July 1991, a conference was convened to establish an interim legislative assembly (Council of Representatives (COR)), a Transitional Government of Ethiopia (TGE), and a charter to serve as an interim constitution (TGE 1991). The transitional period lasted until 1995, when the Federal Democratic Republic of Ethiopia (FDRE) was inaugurated, based on a new constitution (FDRE 1995). As a corollary of these changes, Proclamation No. 7/1992 provided for the formation of national/regional self-governments along ethno-linguistic lines: these became a hallmark of the political system under EPRDF (TGE 1992). The various provisions of the proclamation outlined the structures and tiers of this system, jurisdiction and competence, powers and functions, accountability, and power-sharing arrangements among sub-national governments. In contrast to former policy and practice, the proclamation stipulated that all leading bodies at various levels of government would be purely representative, and that incumbency of leading institutions and offices at federal and state levels would be realised through periodic multiparty elections based on single-member constituencies.

For nearly a decade after 1992, implementation of the decentralisation-cum-devolution initiative was limited to self-governing regions. This was broadened in 2002 by vesting devolved powers and functions in local governments through the District-Level Decentralisation Programme (DLDP), intended to bring government closer to the people (MCB 2002). DLDP empowered local governments by providing block grants as a form of intergovernmental transfer, unimpeded use of own revenue generated, redeployment of skilled and experienced manpower, and autonomy in budget and plan preparation and approval (MCB 2002). The drive to entrench regional and local self-government was also expressed in the establishment of legislative assemblies (councils), executive organs (cabinets) and judicial units in a manner that largely mirrored the

organisation of government at the federal level. Moreover, regional/state governments can promulgate their own constitutions that provide for the formation of local and grassroots administrations. However, in the face of their narrow revenue base resulting from the resource-sharing arrangements enshrined in the federal constitution, sub-national governments are heavily dependent on the federal government for subsidies and other intergovernmental transfers (Gebre-Egziabher and Berhanu 2004). As a result, the federal government, possessing a robust resource base, enjoys significant leverage and influence on policy.

Elections as mainstay of regime legitimacy

Several local and regional/national elections took place between 1992 and 2010. At the time of writing, preparations were under way to embark on a similar exercise in May 2015. EPRDF's move to make elections an important instrument for gaining legitimacy can be viewed as a positive development in a country whose history was bedevilled by the paucity of all-inclusive elections and representative politics. However, the legitimacy of the electoral process remains highly contested, due to its failure to provide a level playing field for all of the parties involved. This problem is compounded by the mode of instituting the electoral commission, which is widely believed to be a client of EPRDF, as attested by the host of irregularities characterising its conduct since its creation.

EPRDF emerged as the overwhelmingly dominant group in parliament during the first national/regional elections at the end of the transition period in 1995. Meles Zenawi, leader of EPRDF, was named prime minister of FDRE, a position he held until his death in 2012. The second elections were conducted in May 2000, during the war with Eritrea, and again culminated in EPRDF's victory. With EPRDF winning an overwhelming majority of seats in the House of Representatives (HPR), the opposition was unable to challenge EPRDF dominance. However, the third national elections in May 2005 were markedly different in several respects. The contestants engaged in unfettered public debate and electoral campaigning, enjoyed access to the media and were able to mobilise their supporters. In short, the campaign proceeded smoothly, without any major shortcomings up to voting day, on 15 May. As the ruling front admitted, the opposition won over 100 HPR seats, including all but one seat on the city council of Addis Ababa. Unfortunately, events took a sharp turn for the worse when the major opposition parties claimed to have won more seats than those officially acknowledged. EPRDF rejected the claim, a move that provoked rioting, a massive government crackdown and considerable bloodletting, following which EPRDF controlled all federal and sub-national legislatures and could form administrations at all levels. In the fourth national and regional elections conducted in May 2010, EPRDF won 99.6 per cent of the seats in federal and regional legislatures (NEB 2010).

Articles 102/1 and 102/2 of the FDRE constitution stipulates that an independent National Election Board (NEB) be established to conduct free and fair elections in an impartial manner and that HPR appoint the members of the

NEB upon the recommendation of the prime minister (FDRE 1995). However, the independence and impartiality of NEB is much disputed. Opposition parties and others assert that NEB is subservient to EPRDF and is an important instrument for maintaining ruling party dominance behind the façade of 'free and fair' elections. Gudina (2000: 188) states: 'Neither the rules of the game of the electoral process were applied in a transparent way nor were there parliamentary democracy and popular governance as … had been hoped for'. The Ethiopian Human Rights Council (EHRCO 2001: 40) and Tronvoll (2000: 20) argue that the appointment of NEB officers by the EPRDF-dominated HPR on the recommendation of the prime minister, the leader of the front, renders NEB's impartiality and independence highly questionable.

Organisation of state power

A brief overview of the organisation of state power at the federal and sub-national levels in post-1991 Ethiopia is provided in this section. The federal government is organised according to the provisions of the constitution, and the formation, organisation and mandate of regional governments, including the lower tiers, follow a similar trajectory. The constitution provides for nine regional states and two autonomous city administrations with devolved powers and functions. As a first step towards entrenching decentralised governance, two levels of parliament were established, the federal and the regional, with further extensions of this principle to local (district) administrations to be made at a later stage. To achieve self-rule, each regional state is empowered to enact its own constitution in a manner that strictly conforms to the intent and spirit of the federal constitution. As regards power-sharing, the federal government is charged with formulating and executing national policies pertaining to finance and investment, defence and security and foreign affairs. All powers not expressly vested in either the federal government or concurrently to both federal and regional entities, fall under the jurisdiction of the regional states (FDRE 1995).

Executive

As in other parliamentary systems, a dual form of executive has been in place post-1991. According to Article 73/2 of the constitution, the leader of the party or coalition with a majority seats in parliament forms the federal executive (FDRE 1995). Without being limited to a fixed tenure, the prime minister is elected from among members of HPR and is vested with executive powers, including nominating federal ministers subject to the approval of HPR. By contrast, the president, who serves as a non-executive titular head of state, is nominated by members of HPR and elected by a two-thirds majority in a joint session of both chambers of parliament. The elected president, if a legislator in either house, must vacate his/her position as deputy, and can serve as head of state for a maximum of two six-year terms. The roles and responsibilities of ministers are specified in Proclamation 41/1993 (TGE 1993a) and include enforcing laws and

policies, preparing and implementing plans and budgets, and entering into international agreements on matters falling under their purview.

Legislature

Whereas the federal legislature is bicameral, comprising the HPR and the House of Federation (HF), regional and sub-regional legislative assemblies, known as councils, are unicameral. The constitution has vested legislatures with major powers like making and implementing laws, endorsing budget proposals and approving the appointment of high-ranking executive officials. Members of the federal, regional, local and grassroots legislative bodies are directly elected for a five-year term by single-member constituencies (regular and special)[1] throughout the country. The HF serves as the 'council of nationalities' and comprises representatives of all ethnic groups, Article 61 of the constitution requiring that each ethnic group be represented by at least one member in the HF, with one additional member for every one million of its population. HF members are elected either by regional councils or by direct vote of the peoples of the regions. In practice, however, regional councils elect members of the HF. This body decides on federal and regional revenue sources, litigation on constitutional matters and the right of ethnic groups to self-determination, and is charged with the upkeep of the constitutional order.

Judiciary

The judicial system is organised into a three-tier hierarchy, namely first instance, high and supreme courts at both federal and regional levels. The constitution provides for the judiciary to operate free of undue intervention and influence in dispensing justice. To ensure judicial independence and integrity, there are legal safeguards concerning the appointment, terms of tenure and removal of judges. As per Articles 81/1 and 81/2, the president and vice-president of the federal supreme court and other federal judges are appointed by the HPR on the recommendation of the prime minister, while a similar procedure is followed at the regional level, where the nomination and appointment of judges is made by the presidents of the regional governments and the regional councils respectively. The judiciary in Ethiopia plays a marginal role in terms of undertaking judicial reviews in order to restrain irregular executive behaviour and action on the basis of constitutional principles. This is because Article 62 of the constitution vests the HF with the power of adjudicating constitutional matters.

Performance evaluation

Taking note of the workings of the major institutions of the Ethiopian political system is worthwhile in order to determine whether EPRDF is living up to its promise to bring about institutional transformation.

The fact is that the executive branch has emerged as a dominant actor. HPR, which is constitutionally empowered to oversee executive behaviour and practice, is noted for its subservience to the whims and wishes of the latter. This is evidenced by the fact that no minister or high-ranking executive officer has been censured in parliament, despite repeated reports of abuse, malpractice and other inadequacies (Berhanu 2005). Legislatures under EPRDF leadership tend to be subservient to the executive, since their role is largely limited to rubberstamping bills proposed by the latter. In actual fact and despite the constitutional provisions regarding parliamentary oversight, the role of parliament remains very limited at best. The major reason for this is the overwhelming presence in parliament of EPRDF members, who accord primacy to party discipline and loyalty, to the detriment of their responsibilities as representatives of the electorate. As a result of this and the prevailing blending of state and party functions, parliament's role as an important pillar of governance and integrity is seriously weakened.

Notwithstanding legal and institutional provisions for an effective and independent judiciary, the record of this branch in dispensing justice and upholding the rule of law is disappointing. It is widely recognised that undue executive intervention in judicial activities has often led to a high turnover of judges and endless adjournments of legal hearings. This situation has severely undermined the credibility of the courts and led to frustration among those seeking legal redress. Contradictory rulings by the different tiers of court have been observed in several politically sensitive cases. For instance, following disturbances in Addis Ababa in April 2001, a federal court granted bail to one of the detained leaders of an opposition party, but the defendant was immediately rearrested on the order of a lower court that claimed jurisdiction in the case (*Addis Tribune* 2001).

Socio-economy and politics under EPRDF

Has EPRDF effected transformation in a manner that positively impacts on different aspects of socioeconomic and political life? An attempt is made in this section to look at economic policy and practice, the civil service, the media, civil society and political parties.

Economic policy and practice

EPRDF's economic policy is the direct antithesis of that of the military regime, which favoured a centrally planned command economy, but with one exception – EPRDF's retention of the military regime's provision for public ownership of land (PMAC 1975). Liberal reforms following the ousting of the military regime ushered in liberal market-oriented policies. These included the abolition of price controls, production quotas and mechanisms to regulate demand and supply.

In the mid-1990s, the Agricultural Development-Led Industrialisation (ADLI) strategy was introduced as the overarching economic policy. It was aimed at promoting economic recovery and rapid growth by improving the performance of smallholder agriculture, which could lead to a marketable

surplus, increased farming incomes, poverty reduction and the production of industrial raw materials (Rahmato 2008). The underlying premise was that the overwhelming majority of the country's population are smallholder farmers and enjoy comparative advantages in abundant land and labour, which offset the scarcity of capital (FDRE 2002a: 4). However, critics doubted the strategy's efficacy, arguing that it tended to focus on land productivity, while the main challenge for Ethiopian agriculture is low labour productivity (Nega 2003). Rahmato (2008) observed changes in agricultural development policy as of 2006, whereby land allocations to local and foreign investors have been facilitated in the hopes of boosting commercial production for both domestic consumption and export. As a consequence, Ethiopia is currently prominent as one of the major sites of transnational land investment (Anseeuw *et al.* 2012).

Berhanu and Poulton (2014) claim that EPRDF has resorted to controlling the commanding heights of the economy in an effort to promote economic prowess, which is deemed crucial to entrenching its political dominance. In line with this, EPRDF has retained all land under the custody of the state as public property. Second, member organisations of EPRDF can establish business syndicates, which are designated as endowments and trusts engaged in profitable economic activities, thereby enjoying privileged access to financial services. They are involved in critical activities such as import and export, distributing chemical fertilisers and pharmaceuticals, sale and purchase of primary and industrial products and providing transport services (Abegaz 2011). These EPRDF-linked syndicates[2] employ tens of thousands of workers and engage in business undertakings that are instrumental in garnering support for the front and consolidating its power both economically and politically. In this connection, it is worth noting that the engagement of political parties in profit-making commercial and industrial activities is prohibited by Articles 27 and 28 of Proclamation No. 46/1993 (TGE 1993b). EPRDF has disregarded such legal restrictions by ensuring its perpetuation in office through a mixture of political control and economic leverage not legally permitted to the opposition.

Civil service

An efficient, professional and merit-based civil service, insulated from undue influence and intervention, is important to the credibility of any political system (FDRE 2002b). It is widely held that the Ethiopian civil service has a poor record in delivering public services, the result of bureaucratic red tape and a paucity of effective mechanisms to ensure accountability and transparency (RLDS/UNECA 2004). This is despite the fact that the current Ethiopian Civil Service Law is based on standard principles and procedures pertaining to modes of operation, integrity and service delivery. The code of conduct governing civil servants requires that public positions should not be used to promote partisan goals and advance personal and sectarian interests. Moreover, the Civil Service Law requires that civil servants report in writing when there is conflict of interest between their regular duties and other engagements (FDRE 2002b).

To ensure rapid transformation, EPRDF recognised the need for a vibrant civil service capable of ensuring social stability and economic recovery. To this end, EPRDF undertook a rigorous examination of the mode of operation of the public sector. Systemic bottlenecks were identified that indicated that the civil service's *modus operandi* was not aligned with the front's envisaged transformative drives. The regime thus launched the Civil Service Reform Programme (CSRP) in 1996, with the aim of creating a fair, transparent, effective and ethical civil service. CSRP was subsequently reinforced by a range of reforms in the areas of justice, tax, ICT, urban management and governance and decentralisation. However, these initiatives proved inadequate on account of the lack of well-coordinated linkages between public sector agencies. Recognising this, the government launched the Public Sector Capacity Building Programme (PSCAP) in the identified priority areas. Ethiopia's development partners, including the World Bank, endorsed this initiative and provided resources for implementing it (MCB 2009).

Despite these initiatives, signs of bureaucratic and political corruption (both grand and petty) grew by leaps and bounds and by 2014 corruption had assumed significant proportions under EPRDF (Gashu 2014). This phenomenon can be partly attributed to new developments associated with the changes in economic policy, specifically the 'free' market orientation, privatisation and deregulation, without adequate safeguards to minimise or prevent abuse and corruption being put in place. This oversight was in part the product of the disarray and confusion characteristic of transitional societies, where institutional stability and effectiveness often lags behind the ousting of the old order and the ushering in of the new. Watchdog institutions like parliament, the courts, the police, etc., expected to fight corruption have become subservient to the ruling front and are hence unable to wage a relentless struggle against malpractices. Besides, the problems persist partly due to the involvement of leading EPRDF members and their clients in various misdeeds. Although the EPRDF-led government has enacted anti-corruption legislation and taken limited punitive measures against perpetrators and their clients,[3] it has failed to deal with the vice in an even-handed manner due to political indifference to the entrenchment of patronage. Consequently, a study on corruption in Ethiopia (IER 2001: 252) has concluded that if a political system lacks the will to curb corrupt practices, it will lack the legitimacy to embark successfully on meaningful transformation.

The media

The media in Ethiopia assumed unprecedented significance following the post-1991 abolition of censorship. To a degree, this led to the weakening of the absolute monopoly of media outlets enjoyed by successive regimes and the proliferation of private media firms (Nega 2000: 21). Nonetheless, the frequent harassment, arrests and fining of journalists, particularly those from the private press, have resulted in the regime's being labelled as one of those in the developing world hostile to freedom of expression. Moreover, according to Cohen

(1994: 26), journalists in public and private media often lack professional training and experience, there are no peer-reviewed reporting mechanisms, and there are no feasible arrangements for observing and ensuring compliance with a code of ethics. These and other deficiencies have contributed to a lack of professionalism and ethical integrity, and have provided the regime with the justification to resort to repressive measures against journalists.

Indeed, following the unrest associated with the outcome of the May 2005 elections, the EPRDF regime took repressive steps against the private print media, virtually reducing it to non-existence, with the exception of those outlets allegedly close politically and ideologically to the front and those that have opted not to take up sensitive political and economic issues in their columns. In sum, it can be argued that the role of the media as agents of transformation in Ethiopia has faced serious setbacks. At the time of writing, the government has initiated legal action against several publishers and editors, thereby prompting the flight of over a dozen journalists and publishers from the country. In this connection, the outcomes of the May 2005 elections have exacerbated a sense of insecurity under the EPRDF regime. Not only was there a post-election government crackdown on opposition media firms, but also a steady shrinking of the public space has been observed, adversely affecting the scope of genuine participation in socioeconomic and political processes. This unfolding state repression is further evidenced by the subsequent promulgation of restrictive legislation such as the Press Law (FDRE 2008), the Anti-Terrorism Law (FDRE 2009a) and the Charities and Societies Law (FDRE 2009b). These pieces of draconian legislation have been subjected to wide-ranging criticism, both internal and external, for disempowering citizens.

Civil society

It is to be recalled that chiefdoms and other traditional power centres were abolished following the revolutionary upsurge that commenced in the mid-1970s. This was reinforced by rendering land public property. In spite of several changes that have taken place since their genesis, the role and mode of operation of Ethiopian traditional voluntary associations has essentially remained unchanged (Berhanu 2007). The advent of modern civil society organisations (CSOs) dates back only to the end of the brief Italian occupation in 1941. In the years that followed, the newly emerging CSOs remained at a nascent stage in terms of capacity, scope, areas of engagement and geographic outreach (Berhanu 2002). During those early days, Ethiopian CSOs were characterised by their small size, ecumenical orientation, foreign origin and focus on limited pressing needs (Berhanu 2002). Between the mid-1970s and mid-1980s, non-governmental organisations (NGOs) proliferated due to a series of major famines. These led to a massive influx of foreign organisations, which encouraged the formation of local counterparts. Because the state could not cope with the unfolding humanitarian crisis, the military regime allowed foreign NGOs to deal with the prevailing threat of drought-induced food insecurity (Rahmato 2002: 106).

Following EPRDF's ascent to power and the opening up of public space, formal CSOs mushroomed in an unprecedented manner. These bodies took the form of professional associations, NGOs and welfare societies. CSOs also widened their geographical outreach and diversified their activities. However, Ethiopian CSOs remained dependent on external support due to the absence of a culture of modern philanthropy in the country. Once liberalisation abated, CSOs were subjected to increased legal and administrative control by the state, culminating in the promulgation of Charities and Societies Law in 2009. This stipulated that local CSOs dependent for 10 per cent or less of their funding from external sources would be classified as Ethiopian Charities and Societies, and thus be eligible to engage in political advocacy and rights-based issues. On the other hand, the bulk of CSOs operating in Ethiopia, both foreign and domestic, receive more than 10 per cent of their funding from non-domestic resources and are required to register as Ethiopian Resident Charities and Societies. These are legally proscribed from engaging in campaigns related to democracy, rule of law, peace-building, conflict prevention and human rights protection.

Political parties

In Ethiopia, party politics are a recent phenomenon, first emerging in the aftermath of the overthrow of imperial rule, when semi-clandestine and clandestine political groups began to appear. Largely characterised by mutual antipathy, they diverged widely in their tactics, strategies and ideological orientation. This trend culminated in the entrenchment of one party rule, epitomised by the advent of the military regime's vanguard party, the Worker's Party of Ethiopia (WPE). Following the demise of military rule, the Transitional Charter recognised the right of citizens to form political parties for the first time in the country's history, and several political parties of varying persuasion were formed. Of these, most put ethnicity at the centre of their programmes, though some did espouse pan-Ethiopianism.

It should be stated that political parties in Ethiopia are constantly in flux due to frequent mergers, splits and even complete disappearance. In the run up to the May 2005 elections, several mergers among opposition parties were attempted, leading to the formation of two major opposition coalitions[4] that played a significant role in the elections. However, these too were affected by the ever-present fragmentation syndrome. On the other hand, a few, such as the Oromo Liberation Front (OLF) and the Ogaden National Liberation Front (ONLF), resorted to armed insurgency in pursuit of the secession of the regions they claimed to represent. Moreover, political organisations such as the Ethiopian Peoples Revolutionary Party (EPRP) and the All Ethiopian Socialist Movement (AESM) operate outside the country, since they are not legally recognised because of their alleged antipathy to EPRDF on several issues.

Overall, EPRDF has managed to prevail as the most powerful actor on the Ethiopian political scene. Built on various ethno-regional organisations, it

controls the four major regions and exerts considerable influence on the remainder.[5] As regards the latter, EPRDF has actively encouraged and supported groups in Ethiopia's peripheral regions[6] in forming their own political organisations in alliance with it. The power to reward clients with power and resources has facilitated EPRDF's quest to entrench itself as the dominant political player. In addition, it is widely alleged that the front co-opts civil servants and members of the urban and rural intelligentsia by enlisting them as members and sympathisers. Various incentives like jobs, training and promotion opportunities and easy access to business licences and land are used as rewards for compliance. Hence, both carrot and stick approaches are employed to facilitate party control and dominance, and according to Abbink (2006: 177), many people from the federal to the grassroots levels owe their positions of power to their loyalty to EPRDF.

Thus, EPRDF's success in controlling political and socioeconomic life lies in its organisational prowess and relative experience in managing party politics, coupled with its grip on the state machinery and the fragmentation of the opposition. This fragmentation is often along ethnic lines, not least because under the post-1991 dispensation members of diverse socio-cultural formations have been induced to think and act on the basis of parochial dispositions, thereby diminishing the possibility of collective action. Major mass organisations such as trade unions, community-based organisations and CSOs have also been affected by this trend, thereby enabling the wielders of power to tighten their grip on Ethiopian society. According to Hagmann (2005), the coexistence of neo-patrimonial and legal-rational domination, institutional instability and patron-client relations stand out as key features of governance in post-1991 Ethiopia. Berhanu (2003) has noted that in spite of the constitutionally protected rights and freedoms to political and associational life, EPRDF has invoked legal pretexts to bar unwelcome individuals and groups from participating in the political process.

Official pledges and solemn declarations aside, the Ethiopian political system tends to have resurrected past practices in the form of neo-patrimonialism and patronage. This has been expedited through the EPRDF-affiliated regional parties, which control the four major regions, and other 'friendly' organisations in the peripheries. In view of this, Aalen (2000) has argued that EPRDF's power structures are characterised by a centralised division of state power, in the sense that the overlaps between the ruling front and government are so pervasive and hazy one cannot meaningfully distinguish between them (Gashu 2014).

Conclusion

The present Ethiopian political system possesses mixed features that affect the quest for socioeconomic and political transformation in one way or other. On one hand, liberal reforms were introduced. On the other, alarming signs are becoming apparent that are reminiscent of past authoritarian practice as EPRDF seeks self-perpetuation at whatever cost.

In an attempt to draw up a fair balance sheet of what has been achieved or not in regard to transformative drives, the following points are worth noting. First, EPRDF was initially favourably disposed to introducing changes to the structures and *modus operandi* of the Ethiopian state by shifting from a centralised a formally decentralised form of government, as expressed in the federal arrangement and associated reforms. It could be stated that federalism, by allowing formal sub-national self-government, has helped preserve Ethiopia's unity by defusing the threat of disintegration that seemed imminent when military rule was on the verge of collapse. Undoubtedly, this shift could have had positive ramifications by meeting the legitimate aspirations of broad sections of society – had it been carried out genuinely and in earnest. Unfortunately, the process of entrenching decentralised governance is increasingly mired in irregularities, manipulations and pretentious semblances that have evoked widespread mistrust and scepticism.

Credible arguments abound that the EPRDF political system is a form of one party rule in a multiparty guise. These rest on EPRDF's firm and overarching control of major aspects of political and socioeconomic life by virtue of its incumbency, rather than the informed consent of broad sections of society. Although EPRDF has facilitated the unprecedented proliferation of political parties, it has also significantly contributed to their impotence by taking advantage of its incumbency to unsparingly weaken and neutralise them. In the final analysis, the prospects for the burgeoning of genuine multiparty politics are seriously impaired. Moreover, EPRDF's commitment to entrenching the rule of law and a robust system of institutional checks and balances as part of its promised transformation project has become increasingly questionable due to its overwhelming executive dominance and frequent recourse to administrative fiat. This is evidenced by the poor performance of major branches of government, including the civil service, which are bedevilled by constraints that affect the capacity- and institution-building endeavours. These deficits are often compounded by undue political interference in the operation of government by EPRDF.

In the first few years that followed the 1991 regime change, many Ethiopians shed the culture of fear in their dealings with the state and power-holders in the belief that EPRDF's pledges to uphold the rule of law and respect human rights would persist. However, as the EPRDF's authoritarianism became more evident, characterised by acts of impunity, citizens began to be cautious in their utterances and other behaviour, taking their cue from their traumatic experiences under the military dictatorship. Caution and fear gained further ground when the regime neutralised the media and CSOs by enacting draconian legislation that had the effect of shrinking the public space. The resurgence of confidence during the preparations for the May 2005 elections was nipped in the bud by the subsequent unpleasantness. As Berhanu (1998: 93) asserts, EPRDF has become increasingly insensitive to the need for building consensus on transformation by nurturing unity of purpose among stakeholders on one hand and facilitating the interplay of diverse legitimate societal interests on the other.

Notes

1 Two types of electoral constituency exist for candidates for the HPR. In regular constituencies, which largely mirror district administration boundaries, one constituency is set aside per 100,000 inhabitants. Special constituencies exist for minority nationalities within regions inhabited by majority ethnic groups.
2 These include the Endowment Fund for the Rehabilitation of Tigray (EFFORT), Ambasel, Dinsho and Wondo, which are controlled by EPRDF-affiliated ruling regional parties in Tigray, Amhara, Oromiya and the Southern Region.
3 Top officials have included an ex-prime minister, an ex-defence minister and an ex-minister of development enterprises and, more recently, top officials in the federal revenue authority and others.
4 The Union of Ethiopian Democratic Forces (UEDF) and the Coalition for Democracy and Unity (CDU).
5 These include the ruling parties in Tigray, Amhara, Oromiya and the Southern Region, namely the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), the Amhara National Democratic Movement (ANDM), the Oromo People's Democratic Organisation (OPDO) and the South Ethiopian Peoples' Democratic Movement (SEPDM).
6 That is, the ruling parties in Afar, Benishangul-Gumuz, Gambella, Harari and Somali.

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15 Liberation struggle for regime change

Somaliland's transition from conflict to civilian government

Michael Walls

Introduction

Somaliland's story is increasingly being told. It is that of a small country that won practical if not recognised autonomy from its southern neighbour after a protracted and bloody civil war. Since the victory of the local insurgent group, the Somali National Movement (SNM) at the start of 1991, Somaliland has seen a transition from interim military administration to civilian government, and then a series of elections for local government, parliament and the presidency. It is a remarkable story, and not least for the role played by the SNM in that transition. The movement was not successful in establishing itself as a viable government – indeed it followed the familiar narrative in which, no longer faced with an enemy to unite it, the movement disintegrated in a welter of clan-based infighting. What is remarkable, though, is that, through a combination of locally legitimate meetings and conferences and sometimes enlightened leadership, this infighting did not deflect Somaliland from an increasingly stable political path.

To understand why that occurred, this chapter examines the process that contributed to it. Essentially, that means looking in some detail at the events between 1981, when SNM was formalised in London, and 1993, when the military administration passed the mantle to a civilian government on schedule and in a national conference convened for the purpose.

The SNM was formed with a strong sense of grievance that only grew more intense as Siad Barre's government became more brutal and repressive in its methods. This consolidated Isaaq solidarity, but the brutality of the Siad regime also gave rise to a sense of principle that was carried through the struggle, and importantly survived into the post-conflict process of reconciliation.

Birth of the SNM (1981)

The first people to use the name 'Somali National Movement' were based in Saudi Arabia, though the group itself was not formally launched until those people travelled to London to meet with Isaaq colleagues there in April 1981 (Drysdale 1994: 136; Laitin and Said S. Samatar 1987: 93; Lewis 1994: 183; Walls 2014: 150). Formed in direct response to the increasingly clan-focused

government of General Mohamed Siad Barre in Mogadishu, the group was diverse, representing a range of ideological positions from the social democratic to the religiously pious.[1] In spite of this diversity, group members shared a more idealistic stance than the pragmatism that was evident among many of their Somali peers, marking a striking commitment from the start to establish a resistance movement that was 'built on Somali cultural values of cooperation rather than coercion; a system which elevates the Somali concept of xeer or inter-family social contract in which no man exercises political power over another except according to established law and custom' (Ahmed I. Samatar 1988: 142). Affirming principles of transparency and consensus, the group launched, in its first year, a monthly newsletter entitled 'Somalia Uncensored', and established a political philosophy that fitted comfortably with the neoliberal norms of the day: a society overseen by a 'minimalist' state, whose primary focus was to ensure a level of stability. This combination of liberal economics and traditional Somali social structure, underpinned by Islamic principles of accountability and law, was in marked contrast to the socialist rhetoric of Siad Barre. Repeated mention was also made of autonomous 'regional and national government', though the SNM did *not* call for secession from Somalia.

This approach was interesting in that, as well as underlining a commitment to the politics of clan and consensus, it also represented a considered attempt to marry tradition to a liberal economic agenda. The commitment to the three spokes of Islam, discursive clan-based custom and liberal economic governance arguably allowed for a more coherent accommodation of historic Somali institutions within a formalised system of representative governance than had been achieved in the Somali Horn to that point. Whether by deliberate act or happy coincidence, it was precisely this arrangement that laid the foundation for the future establishment of the Somaliland state. It is clear that the dominance of the Isaaq clan family[2] was a significant factor in holding this alliance together, but it was not the only factor, and once the threat posed by the Siad regime had abated, so too did the Isaaq alliance, but more follows on that.

The unity and coherence achieved by the SNM in the meantime, though, contrasts strongly with the experience of other Somali insurgent movements. For example, close northern neighbours, the Somali Salvation Front, the Somali Workers' Party and the Somali Democratic Liberation Front, merged (also in 1981) to form the Majerteen-dominated Somali Salvation Democratic Front (SSDF). The SSDF was composed of an even more ideologically diverse group than the SNM, and was never able to formulate a coherent statement of political or social objectives (Ahmed I. Samatar 1988: 143; Lewis 2002: 252).

Escalation: *Uffo* and the Hargeisa Group (1981–2)

With Siad Barre increasingly turning to the very clan structures he had first decried in an effort to prolong his grip on power, he was prone to alarm at even apparently innocent attempts by those outside his kinship groups to improve their lot. When in 1981, a group of returned diaspora members established a

self-help project to upgrade the facilities at Hargeisa Hospital, he became convinced that they posed a threat to his regime. This was in spite of his own lauding of self-help programmes in the early days of his administration: 'If you build a school or a hospital here or construct a canal there by self-help method[s], I consider that to be a constructive contribution to the development and progress of our country' (Mohamed Siad Barre 1979).

Two group members heightened Siad's concerns in the middle of 1981 when they were accused of publishing a newsletter entitled *Uffo*,[3] which complained of corrupt practices and human rights abuses on the part of government officials (Jama Musse Jama 2003: 33). While there is debate over whether the newsletter was in fact their work, the name stuck, and the whole self-help group became known to some as *Uffo*.[4] It is hard to ascertain the degree to which these and later accusations were designed as slurs serving to justify the arrest of group members or whether they were genuine. In a similar vein, group members were also accused of being behind a series of anti-government leaflets signed mysteriously as *Ragga u Dhashay Magaalada* ('Men Born of the City'), and on 26 June 1981, the 21st anniversary of independence from British rule, several members were accused of taking part in a ceremony in which a flag was raised on which four of the five points of the star had been removed. This act was seen as highly provocative, since the Somali five-pointed star had been designed explicitly to advertise the desire for reunification of the five parts of Somalia[5] (Africa Watch 1990: 37 and 264; Jama Musse Jama 2003: 32 and 68–9; Walls 2014: 152–3).

The group's work on the hospital apparently achieved 'spectacular' results and its popularity in Somaliland grew hugely (Jama Mohamed Ghalib 1995: 166). However, such was government paranoia that, between 2 November and the end of 1981, 29 of the 37 group members were arrested one by one for 'subversive activities' (Drysdale 1994: 136). With the accused indicted on 19 February 1982 for a trial scheduled to commence the following day, rumours spread that the ringleaders were to receive the death sentence and students gathered in Hargeisa to protest. A riot broke out, continuing for several days. Soldiers fired on the crowd, killing five and wounding many, while over 200 demonstrators were arrested (Bradbury 2008: 56).

The trial was delayed by nine days as a result of the protests, but once proceedings got under way, they lasted a mere two days. The presiding judge, Lieutenant-Colonel Sharif Shaikuna Maye, ruled that confessions extracted under torture were permissible and denied the accused the right to defend themselves or to call witnesses, allowing them only a few minutes with their counsel. In the end, 14 were sentenced to between 20 years and life, six were handed terms of between three and eight years and the remaining nine were acquitted. After eight months in Hargeisa jail, the 14 handed the harshest sentences were transferred to the notorious Labaatan Jirow prison, near Baydhaabo (about 300 km northeast of Mogadishu). They spent the whole of their eventual eight years in that prison, locked in solitary confinement, a plight alleviated slightly by their practice of tapping out the text of *Anna Karenina* to each other through the cell walls (Bradbury 2008: 56; Drysdale 1994: 136; Jama Musse Jama 2003: 53).

The injustices of the arrests, the trial and the treatment of protestors proved pivotal in consolidating northern antipathy towards the Mogadishu government, with the SNM positioning itself as the flag-bearer of the Isaaq struggle. The anniversary of the protests is still celebrated as a nationalist day in Somaliland, known as *Dhagax Tuur*, meaning 'throwing stones', in memory of the students who demonstrated and the five who lost their lives.

With the trial over, Siad Barre lost little time in stepping up his suppression of those in the north. He introduced emergency regulations, including a new system called *tabeleh*, in which every group of 20 northern households was allocated a local 'leader' with close contacts to the National Security Service (NSS), who was charged with monitoring daily life and reporting any sign of dissent, as well as travel, day-to-day interactions and so on (Africa Watch 1990: 69–71; Lewis 1994: 206).

By that stage, the regime was also active in recruiting Ogaadeeni members of the ethnic Somali but Ethiopia-focused insurgent group, the Western Somali Liberation Front (WSLF), to harass Isaaq pastoralists. His government had also started to arm Dhulbahante and Gadabuursi militias with similar encouragement to use their weapons against members of the Isaaq clans. Emboldened by the February 1982 protests, and incensed at this mounting government-sponsored harassment, a group of elders from several Isaaq clans presented a memorandum to Siad Barre in March complaining about WSLF harassment and discrimination against Isaaq clans in the provision of government services and development investment. This achieved nothing more than to further pique Siad's paranoia, and he responded by having his two most senior Isaaq ministers, foreign affairs and third vice-president, arrested along with sundry others on concocted charges of treason (Eric Hoogland in Metz 1993: 166; Walls 2014: 154–5).

Relocation to Ethiopia and civil war (1982–8)

With opposition to the government growing fast in the north, the SNM saw an opportunity to enter the conflict more actively. The tit-for-tat actions of Ethiopia and Somalia in supporting each other's insurgent groups were helping to exacerbate tensions, and as part of that effort to weaken their Somali rivals, the Ethiopians had offered to support and host both the SSDF and SNM. In February 1982, the SNM accepted that offer and relocated to Ethiopia (Drysdale 1994: 136; Prunier 1995: 6; Richards 2014: 98).

Meanwhile in northern Somalia, unrest was spreading. Where groups like the SNM had until then seemed to represent mainly diaspora interests of limited relevance to pastoralists, Siad's brutality, use of arbitrary arrest and increasingly blatant abuse of clan was steadily driving support to the insurgent groups.

Having shifted its operations to Ethiopia, the SNM began to attract additional regional support, with the Yemeni government providing weapons for 500 SNM members. Taking full advantage of the newly acquired weapons and strategic location, SNM militia mounted a daring raid in January 1983 on Mandheera Central Prison, just off the road between Hargeisa and Berbera. They were able to

free a large number of prisoners, including many political detainees (Bradbury 2008: 61; Maxamed Fadal *et al.* 1999: 18). The government retaliated brutally, bombing all the pastoralist hamlets within 50 kilometres of Mandheera. Siad's paranoia continued to grow, and he had become convinced, in spite of the SNM's formal rejection of the notion, that its insurgency was designed to achieve secession. He told his advisors 'that the Isaaq must be ruled with an iron hand' and declared that if they were unhappy, they should flee (Jama Mohamed Ghalib 1995: 167).

Abuses continued, with rape, previously almost unheard of in Somali society, employed with some frequency as a means of subjugating women and their communities. Summary execution became relatively common and anyone suspected of displaying the slightest sympathy for anti-government rebels was incarcerated. Isaaq livestock was arbitrarily confiscated by government officials, northern villages were burned to the ground and access to vital water points was blocked in a persistent campaign to force the Isaaq clans into submission (Africa Watch 1990; Gardner and El-Bushra 2004: 85–9; Searle 1992). This certainly antagonised many, but rather than cowing the Isaaq population it further alienated them, expanding support for the SNM. Many had indeed left Somalia to escape Siad's actions, finding employment in the UK, the Gulf and the US. But rather than being removed thereby from the picture, they were able to establish effective lines of financial support, remitting funds home in support of the insurgency (Reno 2003: 24).

Faced with an increasingly expensive civil conflict and a disintegrating northern political base, Siad Barre turned to his rival in Ethiopia. Mengistu Haile Mariam was also facing political difficulties of his own, with a growing insurgency in Eritrea. While Mengistu had all but defeated the WSLF in the Somali region (Region 5), Siad's support had been just sufficient to keep the front alive as an irritant, and a drought in 1984 saw the emergence of a splinter group in the form of the Ogaden National Liberation Front (ONLF). While the ONLF had toned down its aim of uniting with Somalia in the light of that country's rapidly deteriorating political situation, it remained determined to win greater autonomy within Ethiopia (de Waal 1991: 347).

Both leaders thus saw value in ending the more costly elements of their rivalry, and commenced talks in Djibouti in January 1986. That process was interrupted when Siad was involved in a life-threatening car accident in May of the same year. While he did eventually recover, the incident both delayed the talks and seemed to exacerbate Siad's sense of panic. When Mengistu suffered a serious military defeat in Afabet, Eritrea, in March 1988, the two leaders became desperate to conclude their negotiations and a deal was struck within a month. Under that agreement, the two sides would immediately withdraw support from insurgent groups targeting the other (de Waal 1991: 347–52; Gilkes 1989; Abdisalam M. Issa-Salwe 1996: 101).

SNM enters Somalia: Hargeisa and Burco razed (1988–91)

With agreement between Somalia and Ethiopia freshly signed in April 1988, the SNM was promptly informed of its expulsion from Ethiopia, presenting it

with a difficult dilemma. Without Ethiopian bases, it would either have to disband as a military force, returning to its role as dispersed diaspora opposition, or else try to seize territory in northern Somalia against the far better equipped and (presumably) waiting Somali army. After weeks of intense debate, the SNM agreed to launch simultaneous make-or-break attacks on the two main Somaliland towns of Hargeisa and Burco in May. While it must surely have seemed obvious to Siad's commanders that such a choice was under discussion, they were caught unawares, and government forces were quickly ejected from Burco and large parts of Hargeisa.

Astonished at the success of the SNM's audacious attacks, the government reacted with a brutality that exceeded even that of its past actions. Reinforcements were hurriedly transported north with orders that the two towns be reclaimed 'by any means necessary' (Abdisalam M. Issa-Salwe 1996: 99). Siad Barre's son-in-law and northern commander, General Mahamed Sayiid Hirsi Moorgan, was to lead the assault. General Moorgan was already infamous for his role in suppressing Isaaq insurrection, and was recorded in a leaked memo early in 1987 detailing 'a campaign of obliteration against the *qurmis*'[6] (Mohamed Barud Ali 2010: 89–98). Even given that reputation, the general's tactics were astonishing in their brutality.

Each town was subjected to a relentless shelling from ground-based artillery and sustained air bombardment in which South African and Zimbabwean mercenaries were joined by Somali pilots, reloading and taking off from Hargeisa airport for bombing sorties. Once that process had been completed, foot soldiers backed by tanks entered each city, with survivors pursued as they attempted to escape and shot or bayoneted to death (Gersony 1990). Buildings in Hargeisa that remained standing after the earlier bombardment were systematically destroyed as ground forces advanced. Somali army video confirms that the destruction was deliberate and methodical, with one meeting of Somali commanders confirming the order that civilians were to be targeted, and that soldiers must 'kill even the wounded'. Soldiers were told 'you must eliminate all. Allow no activity, no life' (see 2'31'' and 3'07'' in Xuseen Cabdillahi Bulhan 2010).

Estimates of the number killed vary hugely, ranging from 5,000 to 60,000, with similarly enormous variations in the numbers displaced (Abdisalam M. Issa-Salwe 1996: 99; Africa Watch 1990: 3; Brons 2001: 203; Drysdale 1994: 137–8; Metz 1993: 51). Whatever the true figures, the deliberate and extensive brutality behind the reconquest of Hargeisa and Burco is well documented, as is the refusal of the Somali government to allow relief agencies to enter the conflict-affected areas for several months afterwards. General Moorgan gained the epithet 'Butcher of Hargeisa' for his part in coordinating the assault, and displacement of civilians was so extensive that Hargeisa was left barely populated, with residents only slowly beginning to return in the years following (de Waal 1998: 133).

For the SNM, the consequences were also extreme. On the one hand, it is estimated that the military action cost it almost half its fighters, but the government's actions also had the effect of finally and irrevocably alienating the great

majority of those living in the northern areas, and emphatically so among the Isaaq (Bradbury 1997: 11). If any moment marked the point at which the sympathies of those in Somaliland turned in favour of secession, this was it. Disillusionment among the non-Isaaq clans also grew, with the Dhulbahante and Hawiye in particular seeing Siad Barre's campaign in the north as no longer directed against the insurgent groups but against whole clans or clan-families, and most particularly the Majerteen and Isaaq. By the end of 1989, the Hawiye-dominated United Somali Congress (USC) had been formed, with assistance from the SNM (Walls *et al*. 2008: 30). This entrenched both government and opposition as explicitly clan-based, but it also undermined many of the customary constraints applied in times of conflict. With the government increasingly desperate to employ whatever tactics it could to cling to power, social norms were systematically discarded. The SNM's previously cited commitment to tradition therefore represented a conscious effort to imbue its struggle with a principled base that stood in contrast to that of the state they were trying to overthrow.

Where Siad had been able to call on the *Soomaaliweyn* dream[7] to bolster his war with Ethiopia, and even to unite Somalis outside of war, this latest shift to a highly politicised form of clan-based social organisation represented the death of any meaningful notion of political union. And for the northern clans in the Isaaq family and among the Majerteen, that sense of disconnection from the dream set the scene for state autonomy that has been played out since in Puntland and, in more extreme form, in Somaliland (Walls 2014: 104, 160, 312–13).

After the massively destructive conflict of 1988, the tide shifted so emphatically against the government that military success turned quickly into state collapse. With the main Somaliland cities destroyed and all but deserted and the population implacably opposed to the government, even a weakened SNM was able to retain control of the countryside. Siad's attentions, at any rate, turned to the south, where the USC and a plethora of other insurgent groups were challenging for power in and around Mogadishu.

From early 1990, the SNM embarked on a series of overtures to non-Isaaq clans residing within the borders of the old British protectorate of Somaliland. By the time the Siad administration fell in January 1991, the SNM was experiencing some success in ending fighting in the north with a series of peace agreements, the process of which is the subject of the next section.

Inter-clan links, commitment to reconciliation and independence (1990–1)

Understanding the SNM experience in government requires an understanding not just of the conflict that preceded it, but also of the sequence of peace conferences that followed its conclusion. In some respects, the SNM's military success was followed by a failure in peace that is typical of insurgent struggles in many places both on the African continent and beyond. Yet there are also notable differences from the common narrative: where many insurgent groups

cling to power once in government, the SNM leadership allowed a transition that led from military to civilian rule without a return to full-scale conflict. There were arguably elements of benevolence in that process, but as in any such circumstance, goodwill must be understood alongside many very divergent motivations.

A series of some 38 meetings and conferences were held around Somaliland between 1990 and 1997 that established what one might refer to as a remarkably stable political settlement, which was enshrined in a codified constitution and political system, and which persists today (Laws 2012; Walls 2014: 231). It was that increasingly formalised system of nation-state governance that permitted the transition just described, and to understand the end of the SNM, one must examine the process of peace-building.

While the SNM was clearly dominated by leaders from the Isaaq clan-family, it had seen varying levels of linkage with non-Isaaq clans. From the early days, periodic efforts were made to include non-Isaaq members in the central committee. Most of these were Hawiye individuals, though positions were also allowed for Gadabuursi and Majerteen representatives. After the first election of Axmed Maxamed Maxamuud Siilaanyo as SNM chair in 1984, the number of non-Isaaq members expanded significantly when seven Hawiye members were added. It was that close alliance between some Hawiye and the Isaaq leadership of the SNM that saw sometimes difficult, but generally warm relations continue between the SNM and USC up until the point when a USC faction entered Mogadishu in contravention of an agreement it had made earlier with the SNM (Walls *et al.* 2008: 30).

Although links with the Hawiye were important, they resided predominantly in areas that did not border Isaaq territory, and if peace was to be sustained, agreement was needed with neighbouring clans, most particularly the Gadabuursi in the west and the Harti (Dhulbahante and Warsangeli) in the east. Helpfully, the preeminent Dhulbahante leader, Garaad Abdiqani, had already made overtures to the SNM. He had long expressed sympathy with the SNM cause, even approaching the front at one point and asking to be permitted to join as a Dhulbahante member. That request was declined but the approach opened a communication channel for later talks (Bradbury 2008: 79).

The Dhulbahante had been a part of the MOD alliance that formed the core of Siad Barre's clan support, the initials MOD representing the Mareehaan, Ogadeen and Dhulbahante clans (Laitin and Said S. Samatar 1987: 92–4; Lewis 1989: 574). The *garaad*'s support for the SNM was therefore remarkable and also important in the meetings that followed. Talks between the Dhulbahante and SNM started in 1990 and continued in the town of Oog after the fall of the Mogadishu government at the start of 1991, at which point both parties agreed to participate in a conference in the port city of Berbera in late February 1991.

Meanwhile, in one of the final acts of the northern war in January 1991, SNM forces had pursued retreating government troops to the small western town of Dilla, where they fought a ferocious battle in which the SNM were eventual victors. Having defeated the government there, the SNM group entered the main

Gadabuursi city of Borama. However, believing that the Gadabuursi were ready to accept SNM's military success, the group withdrew its units quickly in order to allow discussions to take place without the shadow of occupation. A brief initial meeting won Gadabuursi agreement to attend the same Berbera meeting as the Dhulbahante had committed to. Bilateral talks between the SNM and Gadabuursi were then scheduled to continue afterwards (Renders 2006).

In line with its early commitment to returning to 'Somali cultural values of cooperation rather than coercion', the SNM had committed to emphasising that its fight was not with other clans, but with the government of Siad Barre. The inter-clan talks of 1990 and 1991 were seen explicitly as an expression of that commitment (Walls 2014: 164–5). While those who had previously been affiliated with the Mogadishu government were not always trusting of SNM intentions, the movement's actions in that period confirmed the integrity of the commitment.

The Berbera conference had been held successfully in February 1991, formally extending the peace agreement to the Iise and Warsangeli clans in the west and east respectively. But where that and earlier meetings had focused on agreeing to the cessation of hostilities, the next step was to organise a major conference with a focus on future clan relations and governance more generally. With that aim in mind, a 'Grand Brotherhood Conference of the Northern Clans' (*Shiirweynaha Walaalaynta Beelaha Waqooyiga*) was scheduled to take place in Burco, to be funded by the SNM, as Berbera had been, drawing heavily on the resources of diaspora networks. Having been largely destroyed in the 1988 bombardment, conference facilities had to be hurriedly prepared, but the symbolism of a major reconciliation conference in one of the towns devastated by Siad Barre was potent (Renders 2006; Richards 2014: 101–3).

The conference started on 27 April 1991 with a meeting of elders representing all of the major clans residing within the borders of the previous British protectorate, including the non-Isaaq groups. The elders' meeting took eight days and was followed by a meeting of the SNM central committee, whose role it was to debate and then adjust, reject or endorse the elders' recommendations. The elders agreed on six points, the most notable by far being the establishment of a Somaliland government, fully autonomous from Mogadishu. Since 1988, public opinion in the territory had fallen solidly behind this move, but it was still not SNM policy. Indeed, Article 6 of the SNM's constitution still committed the group to 'preserving Somalia's territorial integrity' and the SNM leadership remained opposed to independence (Compagnon 1990: 32).

However, the atmosphere outside the conference in Burco was tense, with crowds having gathered from throughout Somaliland to witness events. Many were armed, and the overwhelming sentiment was not only in favour of independence, but the threat of violence should the decision go any other way was plainly evident to all in attendance. Neither was this sentiment confined to the Isaaq clans: the Gadabuursi had previously agreed to promote the establishment of a separate Somaliland state, and although the Dhulbahante were divided, most of their senior *garaads* were also behind the move (Walls 2014: 166–7).

Consequently, when the central committee came to review the elders' resolution, it felt compelled to support it. Indeed, concerned that the original wording was open to misinterpretation, the committee strengthened it, declaring that Somaliland would revert to the sovereign status it held at independence from Britain on 26 June 1960, with SNM chair Abdirahmaan Ahmed Ali Tuur assuming the role of interim president (Walls *et al.* 2008: 34–8).

SNM splits reassure non-Isaaq clans (1992)

With Somaliland's independence declared, the internationally unrecognised country experienced a period of optimism, economic growth and stability. However, it was not long before rifts began to appear in SNM ranks. Large numbers of young fighters remained armed, yet had little to occupy their time and squabbles began to break out. The problem was particularly severe in Burco, where youth from the Isaaq clans Habar Yoonis and Habar Jeclo fought for a week in February 1992, with an estimated 300 fatalities (Bradbury 2008: 89).

In this case, senior leaders from the Gadabuursi and Dhulbahante clans along with the SNM's own *guurti* stepped in to mediate, and were able to end the fighting. However, renewed conflict erupted a few weeks later in Berbera, again between rival Isaaq clan groups. The basis of the Berbera conflict was far more serious than that in Burco, as the dispute was over control of the port as a key national asset. Desperately short of cash, the government had attempted to take control of revenues generated from the port, but the clan in whose territory the port lay, the Habar Awal (Iise Muuse sub-clan), resented the demand. President Tuur exacerbated the clan dimension by first deploying to seize control of the port a military group that was dominated by another Habar Awal sub-clan (the Sacad Muuse). They refused to fight their kin, forcing the president to deploy a militia primarily drawn from his own Habar Yoonis clan. What had started as a classic political dispute over state control of assets had quickly turned into a clan conflict involving erstwhile SNM allies. Fighting continued for some six months, before an alliance supporting the Sacad Muuse drove the president's forces away. This defeat exacerbated the nascent government's cash crisis and created a political one, as the SNM alliance splintered.

But the president's political crisis had another remarkable impact on Somaliland's sense of coherence. One of the abiding fears of the non-Isaaq clans in the north was (and remains) the possibility that the Isaaq clans might form a coherent alliance that would then dominate Somaliland politics at the expense of the others. The fighting in Burco and Berbera effectively reassured many among the Gadabuursi, Dhulbahante and the Iise and Warsangeli that Isaaq unity remained unlikely. Paradoxically, the disintegration of the Isaaq project that was the SNM provided impetus to Somaliland as an independent nation.

Once again, resolution to the Berbera conflict relied heavily on the intervention of non-Isaaq clan elders. This time, many groups tried to mediate, with limited success, but eventually a series of meetings between the various factions, and involving a high-level delegation from the Gadabuursi, resulted in an Iise

Muuse agreement that the government would assume control of Berbera port on condition that other facilities, including Hargeisa's airport, would similarly be taken over by the state (WSP International 2005: 62).

Having played a significant role in resolving this difficult issue, the Gadabuursi elders then persuaded all the clans of the need for another meeting to formalise the reconciliation and to advance the agenda towards wider national political reconciliation. A further major meeting was therefore organised to be held in the Isaaq town of Sheekh, in the middle of Somaliland.

Sheekh and Borama conferences and the transition to civilian rule (1992–3)

By this stage there was a clear cycle emerging in which conflict was resolved through talks focused solely on finding an agreement for a ceasefire. These were then followed soon afterwards by a wider series of meetings with a focus on more distant objectives: first, on the basis for sustained peace between specific clans, and then, finally, on governance for the future.

The Sheekh conference was scheduled for November 1992, but where the Berbera and Burco events had been hosted by a strong SNM, the movement was now so riven by internal rivalries that it was unable to undertake the same responsibility. Sheekh therefore marked the institutionalisation of the group of elders who had by then become known as the *guurti*. The SNM had incorporated a committee of elders known by the same name in 1989. They were originally a loose group in the tradition of Somali mediatory councils: convened when the need arose and drawing on those respected men available at the time. Numbers therefore fluctuated, as did the role of the group. At times, the SNM's *guurti* was primarily concerned with raising funds by maintaining links with diaspora Somalis. At others, they were responsible for mediating internal SNM conflicts (Renders 2006: 185–6). At this time, of course, the members were drawn exclusively from Isaaq clans, but from 1991 the SNM had involved non-Isaaq members in order to facilitate peace talks.

With the SNM-led government unable to organise the Sheekh conference, it was this broader *guurti* that stepped up to the challenge. The Dhulbahante *garaad*, Abdiqani, sent a delegation led by respected elder, Mahamed Ali Shiire, to join Gadabuursi and Isaaq members. A chairing committee (*shirguddoon*) was convened to organise the conference, with members drawn from each of the largest northern clans, to be chaired by the respected Isaaq elder Haaji Abdi Huseen 'Waraabe'. The conference proved successful, establishing the principle that clans must henceforth take responsibility for ensuring security in their own areas. This approach had been used in the past, but the Sheekh conference established it as a general principle where it had previously been used only on a piecemeal basis where appropriate (Walls *et al.* 2008: 48; Walls 2014: 175–6).

With the SNM administration's interim term due to expire in May 1993, there was an immediate need to move on from Sheekh and to convene another conference to discuss future governance arrangements. The success of the *guurti*

in Sheekh made them the obvious choice to organise another grand conference, and the centrality of the Gadabuursi elders saw them entrusted with the task of hosting it. Scheduling the conference for the start of 1993, they determined that it would be held in the Gadabuursi town of Borama. It was not a given that SNM members would accept this role for a newly invigorated *guurti*, let alone under the leadership of the Gadabuursi. However, by lending his support to the arrangement, it was the president himself who legitimated it. In so doing, he both consolidated the inter-clan peace and laid the foundation for his own removal from power.

With little time between the conclusion of the Sheekh meeting in late 1992 and the scheduled start of the Borama conference in January 1993, preparations were frantic. Fundraising was intensive, accommodation arranged and the venue – Sheekh Ali Jowhar School on what was then the edge of Borama town – was prepared. One-hundred-and-fifty official delegates were joined by between 700 and 1,000 others, who crowded into every available space. The declared objective of the conference was nothing less than to determine the 'destiny' of Somaliland (Walls *et al.* 2008: 49–54).

The conference lasted four months and, after keen debate on many critical issues, produced two agreements: the 'Somaliland Communities' Security and Peace Charter' (*Axdiga Nabadgaladyada ee Beelaha Soomaaliland*), more commonly known simply as the 'Peace Charter'; and the 'National Charter' (*Axdi Qarameed*), which was effectively an interim national constitution. Delegates concluded by electing a new government, with Mahamed Haaji Ibraahim Igaal as president (Drysdale 1994: 143).

Conclusion

In the space of three years, Somaliland had moved from a devastating conflict, established an interim government and then transferred power to a civilian administration within the originally agreed timeframe. That period had seen the SNM victorious then riven by conflict, yet its achievement in shifting, however painfully, from the deep divisions of 1991 to broad, cross-clan agreement on a new constitution was remarkable. Rather than clinging to power at all costs, and at the expense of the people and territory it had fought so hard for, it had been persuaded to step aside.

In some respects, it would be fair to suggest that the SNM's ultimate success in enabling this transition, even while it disintegrated, resulted from a sequence of events that was highly specific to the time and place. But that is no more than is the case in any such instance. In fact, as serious as the conflicts and disagreements were, there was a very deliberate cycle of events that helped the process along.

Small, bilateral meetings were employed first to agree on the basis for a ceasefire between clan groupings. These were then followed by larger conferences designed to deal with more complex concerns, to involve larger numbers of clans and to address issues of longer-term relevance. The titles given to the

conferences betray the deliberation behind this sequence. The Berbera conference held in February 1991 was called simply a 'brotherhood conference' (*shirka walaalaynta*), while the Burco conference was designated a 'grand conference' (*shirweynaha*), with the suffix 'weyne', or big, indicated its elevated status.

This chapter was not written to offer a comparative analysis of events in Somaliland in the north against those elsewhere in the Somali Horn of Africa. However, a brief reflection in that direction is instructive in order to illustrate the importance of the sequence just described. Successive national and federal conferences in Arta, Eldoret/Mbagathi, Mogadishu, etc. have attempted to find agreement on a Somali-wide governance system with local grievances to be addressed at a later stage. The Somaliland case illustrates the folly of that approach: it reverses precisely the sequence that was successful in Somaliland. And it is a folly that is evidenced by the serial failure of 'grand' reconciliation conferences in southern areas. Perhaps the more recent southern return to regional state-building is a step in the right direction, as negotiations are at least located closer to the communities most affected.

In the final analysis, the SNM showed Southall's contention to be correct: it did indeed prove to be 'a disappointment not only to [its] many sympathisers internationally but above all, to the majority of people over whom [it] [ruled]' (Southall 2013: 1). But that tells only a small part of the story. Through an ultimately felicitous combination of good fortune, enlightened action and social cohesion, the SNM achieved that most remarkable thing: having won the war, it stepped aside in a timely manner and so enabled the establishment of viable civilian rule.

Notes

1 Some commentators have argued that the SNM incorporated a significant Islamist agenda, but while conservative Islam was useful as the basis for a call to unity and justice, there is little evidence that this orientation ever truly represented the views of more than a minority (Prunier 1990: 109; Renders 2006: 163–4).

2 The Isaaq are not, as sometimes represented, a single 'clan', as later events were to illustrate so emphatically. Rather they are a group of related northern clans who sometimes unite and sometimes fight. Consequently, the term 'clan family', employed for the same reason by Lewis, is preferred as more accurate (see Lewis 1961: 4). In addition to those who constitute the Isaaq family, the main clan groupings who live within the borders of the old British protectorate are the Iise and Gadabuursi in the west and the Harti pairing of Dhulbahante and Warsangeli in the east. The most numerous of the Harti group are the Majerteen, who live predominantly in what is today called Puntland, bordering Somaliland to the east.

3 The Somali word *uffo* refers to a wind that often precedes rain (Maxamed Fadal *et al.* 1999: 18; Somali Partner Academicians 2000).

4 The same group is also referred to as the 'Hargeisa Group', a name which is now memorialised in the central hospital they were formed to rehabilitate, known today as Hargeisa Group Hospital.

5 These five territories were the colonial areas of the Northern Frontier District of Kenya, Somali Ethiopia (the Haud and Ogadeen), and the French, British and Italian Somalilands (the French now being Djibouti). Of those, only the British and Italian

colonial territories did unite, so the use of a five-pointed star amounted to an unashamed reminder of unfinished business.

6 *Qurmis* means 'rotten', and was frequently used by the Siad regime to refer to the Isaaq (Walls 2014: 160).

7 *Soomaaliweyn* means 'greater Somalia'. This was the dream embodied in the five-pointed star: the reunification of the five Somali territories previously mentioned.

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16 Between the devil and the deep blue sea

The birth and breakdown of Somali Armed movements, 1976–99

Mohamed Haji Ingiriis

Introduction

One of the peculiar moments in the Somali conflicts – a theme that has received little consideration in the current literature on state collapse – is the 1970s emergence of the armed opposition movements that challenged the clan-military regime of Major-General Mohamed Siad Barre. Although they shared similarities with other movements in Africa, the Somali armed movements were a new phenomenon. The formation of the movements was precipitated by the regime, increasingly identified with Siad Barre's clan coalition of the Mareehaan, Ogaadeen and Dhulbahante.

Academic literature on the liberation forces in Somalia reveals little about the rise and fall of the Somali armed opposition groups. Thus, serious scholars of the Horn have often posed the legitimate question of why the Somali liberation forces disappeared.[1]

The history of the main Somali armed opposition groups – the United Somali Congress (USC), the Somali National Movement (SNM) and the Somali Salvation Democratic Front (SSDF) – is cloaked in cloud and controversy. Compagnon (1990: 29–54) nicely narrates the early story of the SNM and the SSDF, especially their acute power rivalry in the 1980s. His work was important in predicting what would be restored of them as soon as Siad Barre left the scene. Later, Compagnon (1992: 502–30, 1998: 73–89) and Djama (1992: 147–52) presented case studies emphasising the military mobilisations and political resources of the post-Siad Barre armed groups. These otherwise diagnostic accounts, however, omitted the diachronic background and performance of these movements, by neglecting their failures and fall. Other studies (Bongartz 1991; Prunier 1990: 107–20; Samatar 1990: 78–87) of the armed movements were aimed either at explaining the state's collapse or at attributing that collapse to them (Mahadalla 1998: 163–70). New studies have shifted the focus on the armed movements to the formation of new states in post-Siad Barre Somalia. Duffield's (2013: 1–29) most recent study and an earlier study by Fox (1999: 1–34) have traced the state-building projects of the SNM and SSDF. Most importantly, Duffield and Fox have discussed the disparity between North and South Somalia as regards the post-Barre political configuration and the distinct state-building strategies each has pursued.

The prevailing assumptions in the existing literature revolve around two propositions: (1) that the armed groups led Somalia into 'uncivil war', and (2) that the war was triggered by only men at arms (e.g. Samatar 1987: 871–90). Fitzgibbon (1982) went so far as to call the SNM 'malcontents and paid agents'. It is in this spirit that Sheikh-Abdi suggested as far back as 1980 that, since the sole strategy of the armed movements was 'to sow division and discord along clan lines', Somalia was headed for a major disaster from which it might never recover (1980: 51–2).

This chapter challenges these assumptions and argues that, aside from the movements' rivalries and institutional flaws, the Siad Barre regime created the conditions that forced the armed movements to fall.

Drawing on extensive interviews and never-before-used sources, this chapter offers the first comprehensive reappraisal of the formation, fall and failure of the armed opposition movements, and is important in a number of other ways. First, it offers an explanation of why the state collapsed and could not be renovated, and second, of why these movements provided no alternative government after Siad Barre's regime was overthrown in 1991.

Resurgence of armed opposition movements

The Somali uncivil war (begun in 1972, but ongoing since 1977) mutated into clan-based war in 1991 after the collapse of the Siad Barre regime.[2] The genre and 'genesis of the Somali civil war' (Kusow 1994: 31–46) is often a hotly contested topic in Somali studies, but the main facts and figures about and from the war cannot be invalidated. After a brief democratic interlude following independence (1960–69), Somalia descended into dictatorship following the military coup of 21 October 1969. Lacking legitimacy in the eyes of the public, the military junta led by Siad Barre began a major political purge at the outset and soon established an authoritarian state. For more than two decades, he ruled through a system whereby first his clan, then his sub-clan and finally his extended family enriched themselves at the expense of the Somali state. Internal clan support and patron-client relationships with allied clans enabled Siad Barre to keep armed opposition movements at bay and long sustain his rule. The contradictions inherent in such a political configuration and dispensation were disguised as the balancing of state and clan. This was an incongruous stance for Siad Barre, who declared when he ascended to power the banning of clanism in Somali social and political life, and yet went on to rely on his clan and sub-clan to consolidate his power (Makinda 1991: 115).[3]

The formation of the armed opposition movements was a direct response to the clanisation (and later criminalisation) of the state, specifically Barre's manipulation of clanism and unleashing state terror against certain clans and communities. Three phases are evident in the development of the movements: (1) 1976–81 saw the emergence of the first movements: the Somali Democratic Action Front (SODAF) in 1976, the Somali Salvation Front (SSF) in 1979, and two more groups, the Democratic Front for the Liberation

of Somalia (DFLS) and the Somali Workers Party (SWP), with all of them merging to form the SSDF; (2) 1981–89 witnessed the formation of the SNM and the USC, as well as the Somali Democratic Movement (SDM) and the Somali Patriotic Movement (SPM); and (3) 1990 onwards marked the proliferation of movements inasmuch as each sub-clan was affiliated with a certain opposition movement on the eve of Barre's fall (Cairo Declaration Document 1997; Press Statement 1992; Report 1991; Mission Report 1991; Silyano 1991; SSDF 1989, 1982; UNHCR 2002; UNOSOM 1994; Ururka Dhagdahagaag Waddanka Soomaaliyeed 1991; USC Document 1989; Warqadda Koowaad n.d.). Led by Omar Hassan Mohamoud ('Omar Istarliin'), an erstwhile and beloved mayor of Mogadishu, the formation of SODAF, the first movement, was initiated in Kenya, but was finalised in Ethiopia. Financial and military assistance was sought from the Arab world, and even Iran and Israel, to unseat Siad Barre, moves that created much anxiety in the Siad Barre regime (Halgan 1978: 17).

After its subsequent merger with SSF, SODAF (even if it soon disappeared) remained in the minds of the public as defining not only the SSF but also the ensuing SSDF. Initially powerful both economically and militarily, SSDF drew support from the regional allies of both the US and Soviet Union. Formed in Nairobi with the approval and assistance of President Jomo Kenyatta and his vice-president, Daniel Arap Moi, the SSDF soon moved to Ethiopia and set up a military base there. The deal behind this move was negotiated between Moi and Mengistu Haile Mariam. It was scarcely surprising that the SSDF came to serve Somali interests less than Ethiopian and Kenyan interests, a fact proven on the battle front. In summer of 1982, Ethiopian forces, guided by SSDF militias, captured Balanballe and Goldogob, Somali border towns, in an attempt to force Siad Barre to renounce his claims to the Somali region in Ethiopia. The invasion provided the Siad Barre regime with a good opportunity to claim more economic aid and weapons from the West (Somali Government 1983).

Assortment of armed opposition movements

The first military operation by a Somali opposition movement was launched in October 1979 from Ethiopia and almost all armed opposition movements subsequently sought sanctuary in that country, since there was no safe base in Somalia. By 1988, Siad Barre himself was seeking Ethiopian support after renouncing his territorial claims in Ethiopia (Caddow 2001: 145; Dualeh 1994: 69 and 113; *Indian Ocean Newsletter* 1988: 2). This stratagem by opposition movements is mistakenly assumed to have caused their subsequent proliferation. However, this phenomenon clearly stemmed from internal rivalry within SSDF, specifically authoritarian tendencies of Colonel Abdullahi Yusuf Ahmed, an uncompromising clan commander, who overthrew the original SSDF leader, Mustafe Haji Nur, a former BBC Somali Service broadcaster, (s)elected by a majority of the members. Abdullahi Yusuf's move was unacceptable to those members and led to the fragmentation of the movement.[4]

The political system used by Abdullahi Yusuf to rule the SSDF was not so dissimilar to the structure upon which Siad Barre's regime was based. Throughout postcolonial Somalia, serious clan chauvinism and clan dominance developed. This policy, adopted by both Siad Barre and the SSDF, forced other Somali clans to choose between two options: accept rule by either the Daarood/Mareehaan or by the Daarood/Majeerteen. With Abdullahi Yusuf as its leader, the SSDF was dominated by the Daarood/Majeerteen/Omar Mohamoud, and was purged of its most prominent members from other Somali clans, notably the Hawiye and Isaaq.[5] To add insult to injury, two senior members of the movement were assassinated on 19 October 1984, allegedly by Abdullahi Yusuf. They were Abukar Haji Mohamed Hussein 'Iikar', the son of the eloquent Somali Youth League (SYL) leader, and Abdirahman Aideed Ahmed, former associates of Siad Barre who had defected. Their companion, Abdi Muhumad Amiin, a popular poet, was badly wounded on the narrow streets of Didirdhabe (*Africa Confidential* 1984: 7; *Indian Ocean Newsletter* 1984: 6; *Indian Ocean Newsletter* 1985: 7).[6]

With many members leaving the movement, the SSDF definitely became a (sub-) clan forum for a small clique, so weak that it could not carry out further military operations. The reason the SSDF so soon failed as a movement – it surrendered to Siad Barre in 1985 – was that most of the Majeerteen/Mohamoud Saleebaan clan members, constituting the bulk of the movement, were part of Siad Barre's clan-military dictatorship right from the beginning.[7] Mengistu was infuriated by the surrender of the SSDF fighters. Taking advantage of this event, Siad Barre negotiated a deal with the clan elders of the minority Majeerteen clans – notably Reer Mohamoud and Reer Bi'iidyahan – to set up militias funded by the regime to fight against the Hawiye/Habar Gidir (mainly the Sa'ad and the Saleebaan). The Hawiye/Habar Gidir/Saleebaan members, who had initially allied with the SSDF, were now surrounded by SSDF remnants until Mengistu's forces came to their rescue. Compounding this serious internal crisis was the fact that after Mengistu detained Abdullahi Yusuf, his sub-clansmen, first Hassan Ali Mire and later Mohamed Abshir Walde fought over who had the right to assume the SSDF leadership.

Explosion of armed opposition movements

As the SSDF was unravelling as an active armed opposition movement, the SNM – formed on 6 April 1981 in London by exiles hailing from Northern Somalia (present-day Somaliland) – decided not to join the SSDF as had previously been expected (Lewis 1998: 177–220; Samatar 1997: 21–48). Within a year, the SNM moved to Ethiopia and set up a military base against all the odds.[8] However, a similar tendency of power contestation – though not as violent as in SSDF – also emerged within SNM. Coups and countercoups led to the unseating of the civilian authorities in the movement and then within the military wing. BBC correspondent Yoonis Ali Nuur, who visited the Somali armed movements in Ethiopia in the 1980s and interviewed their leaders, found

that this acute internal rivalry had paralysed the movements.[9] Since they could not resolve their own political disputes, they seemed ill-equipped to bring Somalia the political stability it desperately needed. Indeed, on the eve of the SNM's formation, the rumour was already circulating that SNM membership was based on birth, not on shared political beliefs.

Given that the SSDF had surrendered and the SNM had been weakened after its May 1988 attempt to disrupt the regime's savage bombardment of Hargeisa ('Hargeisa Holocaust') and had earlier locked its gates to many Hawiye clan members, a new opposition movement – the United Somali Congress (USC) – was formed in Rome by Hawiye exiles on 12 January 1989. The political and military objectives of the new movement – toppling Siad Barre – were not so distinctive, but its institutional structure was unique. Whereas the SSDF had been a purely military movement and the SNM consisted of military and civilian wings (although both had begun as guerrilla movements), USC comprised civilian (political and economic) wings and a single powerful military wing. USC was born with vigour and vitality as an armed movement, and was intent on succeeding where others had failed. No movement on its own was capable of ousting Siad Barre, and some relied on external support, while others never had enough resources. Each movement was only seeking to be the one that most weakened the regime. With General Mohamed Farah Aideed as its military leader, USC celebrated victory after victory and soon conquered an area from the central regions to Mogadishu's northwest suburbs. However, it needed more than military victory to succeed politically.

The defection of Colonel Ahmed Omar Jees from the 26th Northern Military Sector in June 1989, followed by the Daarood/Ogaadeen/Awlyahan mutinies in Kismaayo led by Lieutenant-Colonel Bashiir Ali Salaad 'Bashiir Bililiqo' resulted in the formation of the SPM, first aided by the SNM and then by the USC (*Africa Confidential* 1989: 2–4; *Indian Ocean Newsletter* 1989: 4). Yet even if they provided some logistical support to one another, the armed movements failed to unite their forces, let alone their leadership. There were plenty of efforts to merge all into a single powerful movement. In October 1990, SNM, USC and SPM met in Mustahiil, just across the border, and agreed to share power once they had seized the Somali state. Mohamed Farah Jimale, a senior USC member, noted the existence of written rules and regulations for the rule of Somalia once Siad Barre had been forced to leave.[10] However, these guidelines were not as clear as they seemed, and as Compagnon noted: 'No evidence has been produced yet to indicate that the competing fronts are ready to share power tomorrow' (1990: 40).

USC and the Mogadishu uprising

In 1990, the resistance war came to Mogadishu. On 26 January 1991, USC unseated the Siad Barre regime after a fortnight of house-to-house, hand-to-hand fighting in Mogadishu that began on 30 December 1990. So sudden was the new political reconfiguration that Ali Mahdi Mohamed, a former

parliamentarian-turned-hotelier and a USC financier, was proclaimed president on 29 January 1991. The elders who chose Ali Mahdi did not consult the USC military wing led by General Aideed and the SNM beforehand. Infuriated at being overlooked, Aideed rebuffed Ali Mahdi as president (*Focus on Africa* 1991) and called for an all-inclusive conference of the SNM, USC and SPM in order to begin negotiations about forming a new government. Having spent many turbulent years in the bush, the armed movements – of which the USC was by 1991 the most powerful – had acquired a culture of violence like that pursued and practised by Siad Barre, a culture in which military solutions took precedence over any other kind. This culture implied crushing dissent and accomplishing political missions by force of arms. As Verhoeven reminds us: 'Intra-elite conflicts are universal, but when violence is an accepted part of politics and rivalries develop between actors who share control of the coercive apparatus, power struggles are explosive' (2002: 274). Thus since Ali Mahdi had assumed the presidency without consent, Aideed would unilaterally attempt to oust him. Between November 1991 and March 1992 political – but projected as personal or clan – warfare raged between the two leaders, each supported by USC militias that had fought alongside one another during the uprising.

Although the initial statements and available documents of all the armed movements were replete with lofty words such as 'democracy' and 'justice',[11] never was an attempt made to translate them into action. Stunning statements were issued, but no concrete political programmes were put in place, a procedure which signalled that the objective was to seize the state without really reshaping it. This was further illustrated by the rivalries over state spoils between and among the leaders of the armed movements, thereby adding fuel to the fire. Compagnon, who worked in the French embassy in Somalia in the early 1980s, clairvoyantly commented that these movements could hardly agree on a single proposal for a political solution applicable to all Somalis in the event the dictatorship was toppled (1990: 40). The situation was further complicated by Siad Barre's having turned the uprising against his rule into conflict between the Hawiye and the Daarood, thereby leaving the capital vulnerable to random violence. A report by the Inter-NGO for Somalia (UK) following a visit to that country in 1991 noted the consequences of Siad Barre's arming of his fellow clansmen to counter the uprising (Report 1991). Both the USC and SNM were also tainted by this legacy.

Inspired by the USC conquest of Mogadishu, the SNM – which was ruling the rural areas of the then Northwest – crept up on the urban centres and seized the main town of Hargeisa. However, how the USC tried to govern was different from how the SNM (and even later the revamped SSDF) sought to govern. Whereas the SNM struggled to control its liberated areas, the USC tried to rule all of the territories under the jurisdiction of the (now defunct) Somali Republic. This was indeed why the subsequent USC infighting was so much more disruptive. Besides internal infighting, the USC and its leaders who took control of the capital were constrained by sociopolitical processes and the nature of the society they represented, not to mention the institutional flaws in

their movement. When Ali Mahdi was again nominated president during the first round of the Djibouti Reconciliation Conference in June and again in July 1991 in the second round of talks, General Aideed refused to recognise the outcome even though his envoy Omar Haashi Aden was among its signatories, and vowed to fight on. As Prunier had noted earlier, the movement leaders were not acting alone, but following 'the feelings of their people' (1990: 120).

Lack of political agreement gave rise to fragmentation of the armed movements and the almost countless proliferation of political factions in the country.[12] Two observations gleaned from primary sources help to explain the multiplication of the movements: use of the political movement (1) as a political platform for obtaining state spoils and (2) to promote and protect personal or clan/community interests in the absence of the state.[13] The defunct SSDF was revived in February 1991 under General Mohamed Abshir Muse, a former police commissioner in postcolonial Somalia, seeking thereby to enhance his chances of political office (War-Torn Society Project 1998a: 5). Numerous other armed and unarmed movements followed suit, sometimes allying themselves with the bigger movements. The two USC camps of Ali Mahdi and Aideed came to lead two opposing alliances (which did not, however, include SNM). Initially named the Manifesto Group and the Mustahiil Group, they were later dubbed the Somali National Alliance (SNA) and the Somali Salvation Alliance (SSA), also known as Group 12 (SSA comprised 12 factions). In character, these alliances matched the nature of their claims to national legitimacy, with Aideed's camp more or less aggressive in its political and military approach, whereas Ali Mahdi's was more or less defensive. This was also in large measure because Aideed's group had a more military background than Ali Mahdi's political factions. By 1997, 27 political factions were evident, indicating that forming a faction had become profitable.[14] Tables 16.1, 16.2 and 16.3 below show how normal a movement's shifts between camps had become.

Controlling and curbing violence

The post-Siad Barre political movements lacked the experience to administer their liberated areas and establish governments. Most importantly, they could hardly escape the anarchy and chaos so common in the Somali context after 1991, and so dissimilar to other African experiences. The only political game every member of the political factions understood was the rules and regulations left behind by the ousted regime. Because violence was institutionalised by Siad Barre and became the accepted mode after 1991, it was impossible for any movement to smooth transition to peace and democracy. Democracy could hardly be constituted immediately – and even ultimately – given the anarchy and hostility among civilians left by the departed regime. To reinstate peace where it had been unknown for decades was no easy venture. The uncivil wars had tarnished the lives of millions of Somalis, and the absence of the rule of law and of resources essential for the restoration of normality made conditions very difficult to bear. Three months after Siad Barre's fall, SNM authorities reported

Table 16.1 Somali National Alliance (SNA)

Movements	*Leaders*	*Associated Clans*
USC/SNA*	General Mohamed Farah Aideed	Hawiye/Habar Gidir, Hawiye/ Gugundhabe, Hawiye/Sheekhaal
SPM/SNA	Colonel Ahmed Omar Jees	Daarood/Ogaadeen/Mohamed Subeer
SDM/SNA	Colonel Mohamed Nur Aliyow	Digil and Mirifle
SSNM/SNA**	Colonel Abdi Warsame Isaak	Dir/Gaadsan and Dir/Biyamaal
SNU/SNA***	Omar Mungaani Aweys	Banaadiri and Bravanese
SAMO/ SNA****	Sheikh Jama Haji Hussein	Jareer/Bantu

Notes

* General Aideed's leadership was challenged in June 1995 by Osman Hassan Ali, his right-hand man who claimed the position weeks before Aideed nominated himself for the Somali presidency on 15 July 1995. Aideed continued to lead USC/SNA1 and Aato USC/SNA2 (Himilo 1995a: 3, 1995b: 3). Table 16.2 shows additional movements that joined his government.

** Southern Somali National Movement (SSNM). Colonel Abdi Warsame Isaak later defected from Aideed's to Ali Mahdi's camp and was immediately replaced by Abdikarin Sheikh Yusuf 'Arabeeto', who was killed by US airstrikes on the Aideed group conference on 12 July 1993 and subsequently replaced by his brother Abdiaziz Sheikh Yusuf.

*** Somali National Union (SNU), unarmed movement.

**** Somali African Muki Organisation (SAMO), unarmed movement.

dire economic conditions in the north on account of the destruction of infrastructure in their liberated territory.[15]

Reconstituting a state and building a peaceful society were not as straightforward as USC and SNM assumed. Controlling a post-conflict country is a daunting and terrifying task. The massive number of firearms in civilian hands thwarted efforts to bring about peace and rule of law. One reason, for instance, USC leaders could not control violence was the lack of clear differentiation between armed militias and the civilians who had joined the movement on the eve of the Mogadishu uprising. An armed militiaman could turn into a civilian and vice versa at any time, anywhere, even though many armed men distinguished themselves – and many civilians viewed them – as *libaax* (lion) or *libaaxyada* (lions). Unlike a conventional reserve, these

Table 16.2 Aideed-allied movements/factions

Movements	*Leaders*	*Associated Clans*
SNM	Abdirahman Ahmed Ali 'Tuur'	Isaaq/Garhajis
United Somali Front (USF)	Abdirahman Dualeh Ali	Dir/Iise
Somali Democratic Alliance (SDA)	Mohamed Farah Abdillahi 'Hasharo'	Dir/Gadabiirsi

Table 16.3 Somali Salvation Alliance

Movements	*Leaders*	*Associated Clans*
USC/SSA	Mohamed Qanyare Afrah	Hawiye/Abgaal and Hawiye/Murusade
USF	Abdirahman Dualeh Ali	Dir/Iise
SDM/SSA*	Abdi Muse Mayow	Digil and Mirifle
SSNM/SSA	Colonel Abdi Warsame Isaak, later Abdullahi Sheikh Ismail	Dir/Gaadsan and Dir/Biimaal
SPM/SSA	General Aden Gabyow	Daarood/Ogaadeen/Awlyahan
SNU/SSA	Mohamed Raajis Mohamed	Banaadiri and Bravanese
SAMO/SSA	Mohamed Ramadan Arbow	Jareer/Bantu
SDA	Mohamed Farah Abdullahi 'Hasharo'	Dir/Gadabiirsi
SNDU/SSA**	Ali Ismail Abdi 'Giir'	Daarood/Leelkase
SNF/SSA***	General Omar Haji Mohamed Masalle	Daarood/Mareehaan
USP/SSA****	Mohamed Abdi Haashi	Daarood/Dhulbahante
SSDF/SSA	General Mohamed Abshir Muse	Daarood/Majeerteen

Notes
* Somali Democratic Movement (SDM). Additionally, a new movement called USC/PM's Abdullahi Ossoble Siad was also allied with the SSA.
** Somali National Democratic Union (SNDU).
*** Somali National Front (SNF).
**** United Somali Party (USP).

militias were 'called up to fight and then can demobilise back to civilian life' (Vinci 2006: 83). The newly nominated President Ali Mahdi attempted internal disarmament, including of the Mogadishu populace, with his ragtag *Ashaamud* or *Shaalaleey* army comprising former militias, but absent political stability backed by a negotiated settlement, such disarmament could not succeed.

Apart from controlling the violence, state re-formation demanded the imposition of coercive control over the bellicose clans armed to the teeth. This was a prerequisite for state institutions to develop and for establishing the rule of law. However, Djama (1992: 152) claimed that in Northern Somalia in 1991 '*la violence pourrait s'avérer rentable pour certaines factions en ce qu'elle génère – à travers la mobilisation de l'aide international*' (violence could be profitable for some factions in that it generates [income] – through the mobilisation of the international aid). Yet violence did not serve the interests of the SNM, let alone the USC authorities, as they fought to seize control of the whole central state system. Indeed, the severity and extent of violence in 1991 Mogadishu led French scholar Gérard Prunier to trace the roots of the problem as far back as 1842 in his study '*Segmentarité et violence dans l'espace Somali, 1840–1992*' (Segmentation and Violence among the Somali, 1840–1992) (Prunier 1997: 379–401).

Trajectory of state-building

Partly because of the lack of external backing and a genuine local alliance, the USC was unsuccessful in establishing security and putting the rule of law in place. Two further salient issues necessary for establishing peace and stability in such a setting were (1) ending military combat operations, and (2) rehabilitating war veterans. However, the militias lacked demobilisation plans and ways to diffuse distrust and build confidence among clans and communities so that they would surrender to the new authorities were not adequately contemplated. Fear and suspicion were rampant. It was feared a new Siad Barre – or Siad Barre himself – would return to the scene.

For those Isaaq civilians still reminded of Siad Barre's state terror, their financiers in the diaspora advocated secession to at least heal psychologically the wounds left by their agonies and ordeals. Propelled by their memories of their horrible experiences under the Siad Barre regime, Somalilanders (s)elected Abdirahman Tuur, a mild, chain-smoking, former senior diplomat, as president. Within two years, he was replaced by Mohamed Haji Ibrahim Egaal, an old hand in post-colonial Somali politics and the last civilian prime minister before Siad Barre's coup. He was chosen by traditional clan elders to lead Somaliland, a decision that infuriated Tuur and led him to join General Aideed's government in Mogadishu. Unlike the SNM, where the movement constituted the highest political authority and clan elders the highest traditional, traditional leaders were not incorporated into the USC's political structure. A contemporary SNM video clip reveals how the smooth transfer of power was secured with the collaboration of the non-Isaaq clans (Iise, Gadabuursi, Warsangeli and Dhulbahante) inhabiting Somaliland.[16] Soon after reconciling the clans by drawing on customary systems, traditional elders were able at the Boorame conference to replace Tuur with Egaal. Free of personal or clan considerations, their decision was political.

By appointing Egaal, the elders calculated that they would achieve two objectives. First, Egaal had been the leader of independent Somaliland before it merged with Somalia and, as such, was expected to easily attract international recognition. Second, as the last legitimate leader of Somalia before Siad Barre's rule, he was seen as someone who could unite Somalia in case the secession did not materialise. Egaal's initial speeches confirm these observations. In 1993, he declared Somaliland would never be independent from Somalia, but in the late 1990s he had concluded that the Somalis could live apart from each other by forming separate states. The latter point was vehemently condemned by both those who anointed him and those who opposed him. The change of leadership from Egaal to Tuur revealed interesting traits in contemporary Somali politics. When Tuur was president of Somaliland, Egaal opposed the Somaliland project. A year after he was dismissed, Tuur reversed his earlier position, insisting that Somaliland secession be undone. In response, Egaal vowed in an interview with the BBC that Somaliland was 'irreversible'. This case indicates how far the culture of political opportunism – so predominant during the Siad Barre regime – influenced and shaped post-1991 Somalia(s).

The reality that there were no civilian police in place resulted in chaos in both Northern and Southern Somalia.[17] Other movements in Africa did not encounter this institutional challenge. On the eve of their dictatorial military regime changes in the 1990s, there were functional police forces in Ethiopia, Uganda, Rwanda, even Liberia and Sierra Leone. By contrast, well before their victory, the USC leaders had failed to provide a degree of security and administration in the areas the movement controlled. Unlike USC, SNM was a state unto itself but even it only succeeded in achieving a stable political system and security in its liberated areas after it transferred power to the civilian leadership of Egaal in May 1993. Political stability finally came to Somaliland in mid-1997 when Egaal was re-approved as leader by clan elders.[18] Yet for much of its long struggle, SNM, although it was a 'state-builder' (Duffield 2013: 11) politico-military movement, never operated as 'an authority'.[19] However, the USC hardly achieved even the status of state-builder.

The armed opposition movements were more constrained by the legacies of the Siad Barre regime than they would have been had the regime left the scene earlier. During the 1980s, the regime played rural clans against one another. As Kivimäki pointed out:

> The manipulation by the dictatorial government of the identitive structure towards a more antagonistic direction played thus an important role in increasing violence and the number of casualties in Somalia, and to some degree the assistance that the international community provided by economically strengthening the state contributed to the same result.
>
> (2001: 26)

However, the regime and opposition movements were similar in the eyes of the Somali public. The following tale bespeaks the condemnatory attitudes towards both. A Somali man was run over by a group of camels. Badly injured, he was asked by his fellows about which camel hurt him least. The man replied that he saw no camel to which he could be grateful. This was the case with the Siad Barre regime and the armed movements that toppled him. Yet there does exist a *cause* and a *consequence*. The regime was the cause of conflict, the armed movements the consequence of Siadist culture (Ingiriis 2012: 63–94).

Conclusion

Why did the USC fail where the SNM succeeded in restoring law and order? Some scholars suggest the explanation lies in the colonial power configuration and political composition of North and South Somalia under British and Italian authorities (Fox 1999: 1–34; Kivimäki 2001: 24; Searle 1992: 23–32; see Prunier 2012: 35–49 for similar but more forceful point). By and large, Somaliland's experience of choosing civil politics over violence has been well explored (Bradbury, Abokor and Yusuf 2003: 455–78; see also Adam 1994: 21–38; Reno 2003). However, the circumstances encountered by USC authorities in Mogadishu

quite differed from those their SNM counterparts faced in Hargeisa. The political objective of the former was to rule over all Somalia and the latter to liberate Northwest Somalia (former British Somaliland, present-day Somaliland Republic), and both of them were associated with Hawiye and Isaaq clan-groups respectively. Once the clan card was evoked, they experienced difficulty in controlling all the clans and constituting a central authority. Inasmuch as each movement was seen as representative of a separate clan or clans, the question was which clan had the right to rule, a fundamental question that still challenges the central Somali government in Mogadishu in its efforts to reach out to distant regions. So Somalia slid into unprecedented fragmentation, with each clan demanding its own mini-state authority.

The armed movements were significant and can be traced to contemporary Somali conflicts and what went wrong in post-Siad Barre Somalia. The performance of one movement varied from that of the next. As soon as the Siad Barre regime collapsed, USC, SNM and the less powerful SPM emerged as the only dominant factions. While their success in war was stellar, their political achievements were poor. Never did they attempt to establish an administration in their liberated territories before the conquest of Mogadishu. Only after Siad Barre was ousted did they rush to form governments, a partial government by the USC, a separate government by the SNM and no-government the SPM. Although the SNM made a singular attempt to impose a form of stable state on the rural Northern areas well before 1991, it was not successful until much later. One should remember also that it was the only armed movement in the north, and did not face a major challenge from a comparable faction.

USC's sudden military victory in January 1991 was unparalleled, but the movement's attempts at state-building resulted in failure. Three issues thwarted the reconstitution of the state: (1) widespread anarchy and chaos caused by the lack of central authority, (2) secession of Somaliland as an independent state, and (3) Ali Mahdi's unilateral declaration of a government. Thus military victory could not be matched by the re-formation of a stable state. These issues aside, past USC institutional flaws stood in the way of a new power-sharing formula within the movement. What was required beyond that was state renovation and innovative institution-building – in other words, substantive reconfiguration of the political state. Before the USC could contemplate such innovations, power was contested by the two powerful leaders emerging as representatives of the two different wings of the movement.

Ahmed Mohamed Mohamoud 'Siilaanyo', erstwhile SNM leader, seemed to understand this when he wrote in 1991 that the armed opposition movements who overthrew the Siad Barre regime – basically the USC and SNM – had to reinvent the postcolonial state. He warned that

> if we are to build a nation state again, on the ashes of the destruction and disintegration left by Siad Barre, and build it on firmer fou[n]dations this time, we should, perhaps, take a little time to ponder over it.
>
> (Silyano 1991: 3)

This advice was hard to follow, especially where no armed movement had governed the regions it had liberated before Siad Barre's fall. The SNM ruled mostly rural areas and, to some extent, urban centres for more than two years (1988–91) and USC controlled most of the central regions for close to a year (1990–1991). However, neither created a civil administration in its liberated territories. Had they worked together before, they might have managed to reconstitute former state institutions.[20]

Notes

1 I am indebted to Professor M.A. Mohamed Salih for posing this question to me at the National Liberation Movements as Government research conference hosted by the Nordic Africa Institute, Uppsala, 6–7 October 2014.
2 Available at: 'biloowga dagaalka soomaaliya', www.youtube.com/watch?v=C7px LIGURPU (between min. 00:00–04:34).
3 Bakonyi pointed out that '[t]he clan only exists through the way people make use of it as a source of organising and ordering their social lives' (2009: 436).
4 Interviews with Omar Salaad Elmi, London, 13 June 2014; Colonel Abdulkadir Mohamed Warsame Galbeyte 'Ex', telephone, 31 July 2014; Mohamed Jili'ow Teenis, telephone, 1 July 2014.
5 Interview with Ahmed Salaad Kulmiye, telephone, 2 June 2014.
6 Interviews with Ahmed Salaad Kulmiye, telephone, 2 June 2014; Yoonis Ali Nuur, London, 27 May 2014.
7 Interview with Omar Wardheere, email, 23 April 2013.
8 'Somali National Movement', www.youtube.com/watch?v=XWosiLB6YNg (between min. 00:01–09:25).
9 Interview with Yoonis Ali Nuur, London, 27 May 2014.
10 Interview with Mohamed Farah Jimale, VOA Somali, 19 October 2009.
11 Warqadda Koowaad, Baaqa Ururka SDM; United Somali Congress (USC) Political Programme; SSDF pamphlet titled, 'The Somali Salvation Democratic Front (SSDF), Questions Answered II 1989'; Somali Salvation Democratic Front, 'The Political, Economic, and Social Program', *Midnimo* (Addis Ababa), January 1982, 9–12.
12 Cassanelli observed well before Siad Barre's fall that 'virtually every region and clan had produced an anti-Barre movement' (1996: 22). Along the same lines, Little argued: 'It is not surprising that recent political factions drew much of their support from the clan structure, since the Siyad Barre regime reinforced "clanism" by strategically manipulating one group against another' (1996: 113). A good summary of the 1990s multiplication of political movements is provided in Vinci (2006: 75–90).
13 Oral information from A.W.A., 26 January 2015; 'S.P.M., U.S.C., & S.D.M.', Joint Statement, 4 March 1992.
14 Cairo Declaration on Somalia (Somali Political Leaders), 22 December 1997, UN Doc. S/1997/1000 (1997); Declaration of National Pledges and Commitments, adopted on 3 January 1997, by the High-Level Consultative Meeting of Somali Political Movements, Held at Sodere, Ethiopia, 1997.
15 Ururka Dhaqdhaqaaqa Waddanka Soomaaliyeed (Somali National Movement), Erigavo, 3 April 1991.
16 'Cabdiraxmaan Axmed Cali (Tuur) khudbadii uu ka jeediyey shirkii Boorama', www.youtube.com/watch?v=rFZPtWTYYN4 (between min. 00:17–19:43).
17 Interview with General Osman Haji Omar 'Falco', telephone, 19 June 2014.
18 Cf. War-Torn Society Project, 'Report on Mission to Somaliland', 17–27 January 1998; Radio Hargeisa in Somali (BBC Summary 16 November 1996), 'Somaliland President Pardons, Releases 669 POWs'.

19 'New Issues in Refugee Research', UNHCR, Geneva, 2002. 7.
20 For example, elsewhere some regional movements met additional socio-legal requirements. Bakonyi and Kirsti Stuvøy reported that the Eritrean People's Liberation Front (EPLF) 'established a legal system and provided health services to the civilian population in Eritrea' (2005: 379 n.38).

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